

AN ADULT FANTASY NOVEL

THE MIDWIFE OF THE DROWNED MOON

Every stillness has a body.



T. K. ARVEN

The Midwife of the Drowned Moon

An original adult fantasy novel

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Part I

Chapter 01 — The Body That Weathered

Tavia braced one boot against the recovery sledge and pulled until the lake gave up the fisher's hand.

Mud sealed the rest of him to the exposed inlet. It had the black shine and sour mineral breath of earth that had never expected air. Lake Veyl had fallen six arm-lengths in nine days, leaving boats tilted beside their moorings and white fish gasping in the channels. Above the mudflat, half Dunmere watched from the burial quay without speaking.

"Again," Tavia told the two netters on the rope.

They leaned back. The body came free by degrees: wrist, shoulder, cheek, then a chest armored in lakeweed. Silt released him with a sound like a boot dragged from porridge. One netter retched over his sleeve. The other, a girl named Reska who had hauled eel pots since childhood, stared at the dead man's knees.

Tavia saw them too.

Old Malven Dorr had gone missing three mornings ago. He had been sixty-one, broad in the belly, with a thumb flattened by a capstan and a healed burn down one shin. Tavia knew because she had set the thumb, dressed the burn, and delivered two of his children. Yet the knees beneath his soaked trousers looked a hundred years old. Their joints bulged beneath paper skin. His feet had curled inward. Silver-black lines climbed from his ankles in branching channels no wider than thread.

"Cover him," she said.

Reska found the sailcloth. Crown Keeper Sillan stepped off the quay before she could spread it.

His blue coat had stayed clean despite the mud. Four keepers followed him, each wearing the crescent badge of Veyl Lock and each careful to remain on the plank path laid for their boots. Sillan's smooth face carried the grave patience officials used when they hoped a tradeswoman would spare them the labor of threatening her.

"Master Dorr drowned," he said.

"He is dead in the lake," Tavia answered. "Those facts touch. They do not yet marry."

A few people on the quay shifted. Malven's widow, Tessa, gripped the rail with both hands. Tavia wished she had stayed home. Kin deserved a washed body, a quiet room, and truth given at the pace the lungs could bear. Public truth arrived like a dropped stone.

Sillan glanced at the fisher's face. "He went out alone during a lowering. His skiff turned up beyond Hook Point. Certify the drowning and let his family bury him."

Tavia crouched. Her stiff left knee objected, then settled into its familiar ache. She pressed two fingers beneath Malven's jaw. No bruising from rope or net. She turned his head and found pale froth dried in one nostril, but almost no water drained when she rolled him. A man who drowned in cold Veyl usually carried the lake home in his lungs.

She opened one eyelid. The white had yellowed. Fine wrinkles radiated from the corner, deeper than any she remembered. Three days could soften a corpse, swell it, bleach it, feed small mouths. Three days could not spend forty years from the joints outward.

"Where did you find the skiff?" she asked Reska.

"North of the old saint post."

"Anchor down?"

"Gone. Rope cut clean."

Sillan's boot scraped the plank. "A recovery does not require an inquest."

"It requires that I name what happened to the body." Tavia lifted Malven's left hand. The nails had thickened and split. Beneath the wrist, a narrow burn made two silver-edged punctures. "Did your people draw him from a channel?"

"No."

"Did anyone fit a line to him?"

"No."

The answer came too quickly. Tavia laid the hand down and looked toward the lock road. Veyl Lock stood beyond a fold of basalt, hidden from town, but the lowering showed everywhere. Wet marks striped the pilings. Rush beds lay flat in the sun. The lake's ordinary breathing had been replaced by a measured drain westward to grain canals whose owners had never smelled Dunmere's mud.

Tessa called from the quay, "Tavia?"

That one word carried a wife's request and warning. Do not soften it. Do not make it worse to punish the keepers. Bring him back as himself.

Tavia drew the cloth over Malven's face. "I need the preparation room."

Sillan stepped into her path. "The Crown requires a finding before noon."

"The Crown may wait until I have opened his chest."

A murmur passed along the quay. Sillan lowered his voice. "Ordinary drowning. Exposure during recovery. You can write both without lying."

"Not on this body."

His gaze rested on her long enough to feel like a hand. Eight years earlier another keeper had stood on this quay and explained that opening Veyl Lock could

not be delayed for one missing skiff. Jeren's boat had come back in boards. His body had taken eleven days. Tavia had learned then how cleanly an official could divide a death from the order that caused it.

She nodded to Reska. Together they hauled the sledge toward the mortuary ramp. Behind them Sillan said nothing. Silence from a Crown keeper rarely meant surrender.

The preparation room occupied the lowest floor of Tavia's house, where limewashed walls kept summer heat from the dead. She barred the street door, lit two fish-oil lamps, and asked Reska to fetch Tessa's sister. No widow should identify a husband alone, and no young netter needed to watch the cutting.

Once the room emptied, Tavia stripped Malven's wet clothes. Sand collected in the seams, too coarse for the inlet where they had found him. Red grit from the lock road lodged beneath his belt. Someone had moved him or he had entered the lake farther west.

His weathered body yielded its history reluctantly. The belly had begun to green, as expected after three days. Fly eggs clustered at the lips, proving exposure before immersion. Yet the hips had thinned as if illness had eaten months from him. His shoulders remained those of the man who had carried smoked-eel baskets at dawn. Age had not crossed him evenly. It had entered through the marks at his wrists and ankles, traveled along branching burns, and spent itself in bone.

Tavia set out her narrow knife. She named each change aloud, as custom required.

"Skin loosened at the joints. Nails thickened. Bone enlarged. Teeth worn after death or near it. Silver burns, four limbs. Water in the throat, little in the chest."

Her voice sounded too loud under the low beams.

The first cut released blood dark as plum skin. Dead blood did not startle her. The smell did. Beneath rot and lakewater lay the sharp mineral scent of a struck coin. She separated the ribs and found the lungs mottled but light. Malven had breathed water only at the end, perhaps after whatever had ruined his bones.

Around his heart, a translucent film clung to the sac. It caught lamplight in small fixed stars.

Tavia stopped breathing.

Grandmother Ossa had once shown her a scrap of paleshell hidden inside a birthing box. It had looked like an eggshell held against night, black at one angle and full of lights at another. Ossa called it grief made useful, then spat into the stove and refused to explain. Crown law had taken the old lake-midwife tools before Tavia's apprenticeship ended. Most stories went with them.

She touched the film with horn tweezers. Cold bit through the handle. Malven's heart shifted once beneath her hand.

Tavia dropped the tweezers.

The organ did not beat again. A dead body often settled under a knife. Trapped air moved. Tendons tightened. She had corrected frightened apprentices for calling those motions hauntings.

Still, her own pulse climbed.

A knock struck the barred door. "By order of Veyl Lock," Sillan called. "Open."

Tavia covered the chest with linen. "The family has not finished viewing."

"You dismissed the family."

"So your man at the alley says."

Metal touched the latch. The keeper had brought authority shaped for breaking wood.

Tavia crossed to the writing shelf. Three certification slips waited beneath a stone: drowning, uncertain death, Crown inquiry. The third would surrender Malven to the keepers. The first would bury the evidence. She chose the second and wrote in her blunt mortuary hand.

CAUSE NOT CONSISTENT WITH ORDINARY DROWNING. ACCELERATED JOINT WEATHERING. CHANNEL BURNS. EXAMINATION INCOMPLETE.

She sanded the ink, pressed her trade seal into black wax, and opened the door wide enough to pass the sheet through.

Sillan read it. A vein moved beside his mouth. "You understand what uncertain death requires."

"An inquest with family witness."

"It permits removal to the lock infirmary."

"Not before the widow sees my findings."

"You are making a local tragedy into something else."

"No. Something else made Malven into a local tragedy."

The keeper behind Sillan looked away. He was younger than Reska, with cracked skin around his badge where metal polish had burned him. Sillan folded the slip once.

"The lake is low. People panic when tradesmen invent causes."

"Then you should be grateful I have invented none."

He studied the room over her shoulder. Tavia stood broad enough in the doorway to block his view. She had no weapon except a narrow knife, a bone saw, and the fact that Dunmere watched how officials treated its dead.

Sillan handed the certificate back. "Complete it by evening."

"I will complete what the body allows."

His smile held no warmth. "Then listen carefully."

The keepers withdrew. Their boots crossed the quay in measured knocks. Tavia

waited until the sound faded before barring the door again.

At noon Tessa came with her sister. Tavia showed them Malven's hands first, then his feet, then the marks. She did not expose the opened chest. Tessa touched the flattened thumb and said, "He complained his boots pinched."

"When?"

"Yesterday week. After he hauled two barrels for the lock store."

"What barrels?"

"Water, he said. He laughed because the Crown paid a copper to carry water beside a lake." Tessa swallowed. "He came home tired. The next morning his hair had white in it. He thought lime dust caught there."

"Did he receive a token? A permit? Any paper?"

Tessa shook her head, then reached beneath her collar. A thin silver flake hung on cord. "This caught in his cuff."

Tavia took it without touching bare metal. One edge had been cut into a shallow channel. Dried blood darkened the groove.

Tessa's sister whispered, "What does it mean?"

Tavia carried the wrapped flake to the lamp and turned it with her horn tweezers. Three stamped letters showed beneath the blood: VLK. Below them, scratches made a number too damaged to read. The groove along the edge had held something finer than rope, perhaps silver wire. She had seen a similar fitting only once, when Jeren's body came home with a Crown measuring clasp hooked through his coat. The keeper had called it debris from the gate.

"What did he say about the barrels?" Tavia asked.

Tessa wiped her mouth with the back of one hand. "That they came from Bellhaven sealed in straw. Lock men set them beside the old saint post. Malven carried each one onto a sled, then took them down the west ramp. They paid him not to ask why lakewater needed a lid."

"Was the water clear?"

"He said it held its surface even when the barrel tipped. He thought that funny."

Stillwater. Tavia had heard the word used for palace medicine and winter fruit, always as though cleverness had defeated time. Merchants sold pears kept crisp from harvest to thaw. Crown surgeons could pause bleeding until a wound reached Bellhaven. Nobody in Dunmere knew where the rot or blood went while the pear stayed young and the soldier stayed alive. Grandmother Ossa had answered the question once: Nothing leaves the world merely because a rich man shuts his eyes.

A basin stood beside the washing slab. Tavia filled it, lowered the wrapped flake until waxed cloth touched the surface, and watched. Ripples flattened around the packet. At the far edge, a sprig of mourning fennel browned from green to black in three breaths.

Tessa's sister made a warding sign.

"Do not," Tavia said sharply. "Look instead." She lifted the packet. The water moved again, but the fennel remained dead. "The metal held a trace of whatever passed through Malven. It stopped change here and sent the cost into the nearest living thing."

"Fennel isn't living like a man."

"It lived enough to pay." Tavia set the basin away from all three women. "Malven paid more."

She returned to the table and examined the soles of his feet. Fine red grit pressed deep into the calluses, but a clean crescent crossed each heel where straps had held them above ground. Whoever used the silver lines had bound him in a frame. The thought came with such precision that she wished it had not.

"I don't know yet." Tavia made herself say the whole truth. "His body received years it had not lived. The marks carried them in. The lake killed him after, or someone put him into it."

Tessa gripped the table. Her sister caught her elbow.

"Can you prove that?"

"I can prove what changed. I cannot yet name who sent it."

Outside, a basin bell rang once. Dunmere used one note for falling water, two for fire, a running peal for lock failure. This solitary strike had no civic meaning. Another bell answered from a house uphill, then stopped.

Tavia wrapped the silver flake in waxed cloth. "Did Malven fish near the saint post?"

"Not since the lowering. He said something had begun knocking under the mud."

"What kind of knocking?"

Tessa looked toward the floor as though it might answer. "Like a second heart."

By late afternoon, heat drew bubbles from the mudflat. Tavia left Malven sewn and washed under his own sheet, locked the evidence box, and walked the drained inlet with her recovery hook over one shoulder. She told herself she sought the place where he had entered the water. This remained true, though not complete.

Children had already tested the mud and been chased off by their parents. Their footprints ended where the ground changed from brown silt to black clay. Beyond that line, small dead fish shone like tossed coins. Tavia planted her hook ahead of each step and followed the old shoreline toward the saint post.

The post had fallen. Its carved face lay downward, exposing a back scored with three shallow curves. Ossa had drawn those curves in flour when teaching forbidden birthing notes, then swept them away before Tavia could ask why.

Farther out, a ridge broke the mud's flatness. Tavia scraped it with the hook.

Stone appeared, black and fitted, descending at an angle beneath the lakebed.

She cleared another edge with her boot. Then another.

The drowned steps ran west beneath waterlogged clay, broad enough for two people carrying something between them. Rush roots veiled their sides. On the third tread she found a handhold worn smooth at the height of her knee. This had not served fishermen. People had gone down here often, bearing weight.

A bubble rose from a crack and burst against her boot. Cold air breathed through the gap.

Tavia crouched and drove the recovery hook into the opening. Its iron tip struck stone, slid, then touched something that yielded like taut skin.

A pulse traveled up the ash shaft.

She nearly released it. The second pulse arrived slower than her own heart and powerful enough to ache in her palm. Mud around the steps trembled. Across Dunmere, every open bowl of water dimpled at once.

From the quay Sillan shouted her name.

Tavia pulled the hook free. Silver frost filmed its iron curve. She wrapped the head in her apron and climbed toward town without answering him.

Night came pale. Since childhood, darkness had thinned year by year until true black existed only in deep cupboards and beneath shut boats. Tavia waited while Crown lanterns moved along the quay and Keeper Sillan posted two men outside the mortuary. She sat beside Malven with Ossa's birthing box on her knees.

Inside lay rope, a horn lamp, wax, a bladder of air, and a strip of cloth embroidered with three curved marks. No miracle waited there. Only tools made by hands that had expected another pair of hands to use them.

Tavia cut sixty arm-lengths of recovery rope from her best coil. She packed a pry bar, the silver flake, and a skin of drinking water. Last came her grandmother's song, not an object and not safe. She practiced the first note against closed teeth until the table's water cup shivered.

A keeper coughed outside. Tavia opened the drain hatch beneath the washing slab, lowered the coil into the alley channel, and followed it down on her belly. Her left knee caught once. Lime scraped her palms. She emerged behind the smokehouse smelling of soap and old blood.

The mudflat reflected a weak moon, with drowned pilings casting broken bars across it. At its center, the exposed stair made a darker cut through the silvered clay.

Tavia tied the rope around her waist and went back after dark with rope and her grandmother's forbidden song.

Chapter 02 — Orders at the Quiet Dam

Oren Kest lay flat on the spillway lip and felt Veyl Lock kick beneath his ribs.

The stone rose once, barely a finger's breadth, then settled. Water on the eastern face stood black and smooth thirty feet above him. On the western face, the grain canal ran low between silvered gates. A quiet dam should have carried weight without motion. This one breathed against its hinges.

"Again in twelve counts," said Keeper Haro beside him.

Oren counted through the stone. At eleven, a deep impact struck from below. Lime dust jumped from a seam. The iron dog under Haro's boot gave a small answering ring.

"That makes nine since sunset," Haro said.

"Ten. You missed the one while changing watch." Oren pushed himself upright. Cold from the masonry had entered his elbows. "How far did you lower the lake?"

"Six arm-lengths at Dunmere gauge."

"The schedule allowed four."

Haro's mouth tightened. "Bellhaven requested another two for the western wheat."

"Bellhaven requests what the east can be made to lose."

The remark earned him a quick look. Dam-riders could question mechanism, weather, horseflesh, and route. They were not expected to question the direction of hunger.

Oren descended the inspection ladder. Lanternlight caught the lock's working parts one at a time: wet chain, green bronze gear, oak balance beam, silver channels laid into stone like healed scars. A keeper turned a wheel above. The gate should have answered with a smooth adjustment. Instead its lower edge shuddered and drove a pressure pulse through the chamber.

Something struck from beneath.

Not driftwood. Driftwood battered without rhythm. These blows came in pairs, followed by a long gathering stillness. Oren had tracked men who knocked coded warnings from inside collapsed mines. The pattern below the gate lacked human spacing, yet it carried intention enough to trouble him.

He reached the lowest platform. Water breathed through a cracked mortar joint and gathered around his boots. White grains floated on it.

"Paleshell?" he asked.

Haro came down more slowly. "Scale from the dosing trough."

"The trough sits two levels up."

"Runoff finds a route."

“Not uphill.”

Oren crouched without touching the grains. Powdered paleshell activated in water could suspend bleeding, rot, fever, or the settling of a damaged wall. Every keeper knew the public lesson: chosen change paused here, harmless matter elsewhere carried the burden. Fruit blackened so a wound stayed closed. Timber split so a bridge held through flood. The sums appeared clean on Crown ledgers.

His daughter’s life appeared in those sums too.

A lock clerk called from above. “Rider Kest. Palace packet.”

Oren climbed. The clerk waited under the winch roof with two objects on a tray. One carried the Regent’s black wax. The other fit within Oren’s palm: a blue ceramic hospice token stamped with a child’s room number and the week’s date.

Enna had lived three hours since he last held one.

He picked up the token first. Its glaze felt warm from the courier’s coat. A crescent punched through one corner allowed patients to thread tokens as calendars, though Enna called hers a necklace made of stolen Tuesdays. Eleven years old, she had accumulated less than nine years of waking. The marrow fever waited inside her bones whenever physicians released the stilling for meals, examinations, and supervised mornings.

On the reverse, a nurse had written in grease pencil: ATE HALF BROTH. WALKED SOUTH GALLERY. ASKED WHETHER GEESE DREAM.

The question belonged to their last morning together. Enna had watched palace geese land on the hospice pond and complained that no creature should be allowed so much noise while sick children slept. When Oren pointed out that she had not been asleep, she told him this proved her public spirit. Then her knees buckled. A physician caught her before Oren crossed the room.

They had laid her on a copper-framed bed and asked whether he authorized another week of suspension. The marrow fever had consumed platelets faster than ordinary tonics could replace them. Without stillwater, the physician estimated months, perhaps a year if Enna survived winter infections. With weekly renewal, they offered time for a cure not yet discovered.

Oren had signed.

An attendant brought a glass basin. The physician sang one held note over water clouded with paleshell. Enna’s bruises stopped spreading. Her fever ceased climbing. Across the room, a basket of green apples wrinkled and collapsed as the first counterweight accepted the displaced change. Oren watched the fruit and believed he had witnessed an honest price.

Later renewals happened behind a screen. The physician explained that plant matter saturated too quickly for long suspensions and that authorized clinical reservoirs carried the burden instead. Oren had asked what filled a clinical reservoir. The answer came in language about distributed capacity, regulated

channels, and Crown-certified tolerance. Enna woke before he could ask again and demanded a goose feather for her token cord.

Now Vennel's hidden hand gave those phrases fingers and skin.

Oren turned the ceramic disk over. Enna's room number had been stamped crookedly. She would notice. She noticed each small fault in the machinery built to preserve her, perhaps because everyone around her spoke as if gratitude required blindness.

He promised the token, silently and without right, that he would return before her next waking. Then he tucked it beneath his collar.

Oren read the line twice.

Captain Belden entered from the gatehouse, fastening his coat. He commanded the eastern dam-riders and wore lack of sleep as if it proved rank. "Good week?"

"She walked."

"Then the system holds."

Oren closed his fingers around the hospice token. "Something below the gate disagrees."

Belden glanced at Haro. "Fish, pressure, old rock. Choose a noun that doesn't delay the canal."

"The lake has been lowered beyond schedule. Paleshell lies below the dosing level. The gate moves under load."

"Then inspect it."

"That is what I am doing."

"Do it without alarming Dunmere." Belden lifted the sealed packet from the tray. "The Regent has supplied a more immediate noun."

Before opening it, Oren walked to the register room. The lock's records occupied a narrow chamber protected from spray by tarred felt. Every gate movement, paleshell dose, hiring chit, breakage, and irregular sound should have entered the daily books. Ink created responsibility, which explained why powerful men preferred spoken corrections.

Clerk Vennel sat at the sloped desk, pressing sand over a fresh page. His right sleeve hid his hand. Oren noticed the concealment because Vennel usually displayed his rings when speaking to riders.

"Bring me the paleshell register," Oren said.

"The captain has closed it for quarterly count."

"Then open it for a damaged gate."

Vennel looked toward Belden. The captain had remained outside, but his presence filled the doorway more thoroughly than a body.

"Page ninety-four has gone to Bellhaven," the clerk said.

"Registers do not travel. Copies travel."

"A correction required the original."

Oren held out his hand. "Show me ninety-three and ninety-five."

Vennel fetched the book from a locked cabinet. He set it down gently, like a man placing a sleeping infant between wolves. The binding had swollen from damp. Page ninety-three listed ordinary doses for western grain silos and a Bellhaven surgical reserve. A torn stub followed. Page ninety-five began with a delivery of four sealed barrels from Ward Seven, received eleven days earlier.

Oren read the entry again. "Ward Seven is not a shell mill."

"I copy labels."

"What did the barrels hold?"

"Stillwater reserve."

"Counterweight named?"

Vennel's hidden hand moved under the desk. "Page ninety-four carried the routing detail."

The missing sheet had been cut close to the stitching with a sharp blade. No accidental tear left such a patient edge. Oren touched the paper stub. A faint red grit adhered to it, the same basalt dust used on the west service ramp.

"Who unloaded the barrels?"

"Local labor."

"Names."

"On the missing page."

"Convenient."

Vennel's gaze hardened. "Dam-riders follow routes. They do not audit medical channels."

Oren had heard the boundary before. Each Crown trade kept its own small square of knowledge and called the darkness around it order. A rider carried sealed loads. A clerk copied labels. A physician selected a dose. Harm could cross the kingdom without meeting a person who admitted to understanding the whole journey.

"Show me your hand," he said.

The clerk did not move.

Oren reached across the desk and pulled back the sleeve. Two fingertips had aged gray and ridged. A silver-edged burn crossed the wrist.

Vennel jerked free. "Leak from a tally tube."

"Where did the change go?"

"Authorized counterweight."

"Name it."

"I don't know."

For the first time, fear made the answer believable.

Captain Belden opened the door. "Enough."

Oren shut the register. "A page is missing. Four barrels arrived from a ward that does not appear on eastern supply lists. Your clerk carries channel burns."

"My clerk spilled treated water. Page ninety-four went west for correction. If your mechanism fails, report the mechanism."

"Someone has already corrected the report."

Belden's expression flattened. "Read the packet."

They took it to the map room. Seven bronze pins marked the locks from Veyl to Sea Gate. Blue cord showed surface canals; black cord traced the underground Nightcourse known mostly through old surveys. Under Veyl, the black line ended in a circle that later cartographers labeled SEALED STRATA.

Oren broke Sere Valec's wax.

The document bore three signatures from offices that rarely agreed quickly: Regent, Royal Physician, Keeper-General. Its heading read RECOVERY ORDER: LUNAR BIOLOGICAL MATERIAL. The language beneath avoided the old words moonbrood and mooncalf until the final paragraph.

Any living specimen emerging in the Lake Veyl basin was to be secured unharmed where practicable. Shell fragments, shed membrane, blood, and contaminated water belonged to the Crown. Witnesses could be detained. Local obstruction permitted proportionate force, including entry into private homes and seizure of boats. If transfer toward the Nightcourse began, the ranking rider could use lethal force against human carriers.

The last line had been added in Sere's narrow hand.

DO NOT DAMAGE THE BROOD UNLESS PASSAGE BECOMES OTHERWISE CERTAIN.

Belden waited. "Now you have your noun."

"A living moonbrood." Oren looked at the black line beneath Lake Veyl. "The Crown teaches that none survived the first locks."

"The Crown teaches what prevents lake cults from breaking dams."

"You knew to expect this?"

"I knew the bells might change."

"What bells?"

As if summoned by the question, a note traveled through the water. It entered the map room through stone rather than air. One basin bell rang in the yard. A second answered from the keeper kitchens. Soon every open vessel in Veyl Lock

sounded against its shelf.

Belden crossed to the window. "Hatching signal."

Oren folded the recovery order along its existing creases. "How long?"

"Old manuals say the drowned-moon eclipse closes twenty-three days after shell fracture."

"And if the brood reaches the Nightcourse?"

"It moves west. Each quiet lock loses its harvesting frame. Reservoirs rise. Grain canals fail. Bellhaven's lower basin may flood."

"The old manuals say all that?"

"They say enough."

More knowledge divided into offices. More darkness named order.

Oren set Enna's token beside the black cord. Palace physicians renewed her stilling through channels supplied by the locks. If the lock network failed, marrow fever would resume its work. He knew the shape of that danger: pain behind her knees, bruises flowering without touch, blood that refused to thicken. He did not know the shape of the weathering that paid for each paused week. Until Vennel's hand, he had not forced himself to ask.

Belden tapped Dunmere on the map. "Take six riders. Search the inlet, mortuary, boat sheds, and old burial cuts. Keeper Sillan sent word that the lake midwife refused an ordinary-drowning certificate. She found channel burns on a fisher."

"Name?"

"Tavia Sorn."

Oren knew the name. Her husband had died during an opening eight years ago. The incident report described unavoidable loss under authorized release. He had carried the report east after a clerk corrected the gate time in the margin.

"Was the fisher used with the barrels?" he asked.

Belden's patience thinned. "The body concerns Sillan. The specimen concerns you."

"If both carry the same channel trace, they concern one order."

"You have a daughter in Crown hospice, Kest."

Oren looked up.

Belden did not smile. "I mean only that you understand what a broken stilling costs. Recover the brood and the locks remain sound. Wander into clerks' questions and someone less careful may take your route."

The threat came dressed as confidence. Oren had delivered enough orders to recognize the tailoring.

He slid Enna's token onto the leather cord around his neck. "Six riders. A gate

mechanic too.”

“You need speed, not tools.”

“If something under Veyl can move this much stone, I need a person who knows which hinge will kill us.”

Belden allowed it with a shrug. “Captain Letha Marr is sending a squad east from Bellhaven. You retain command until she arrives.”

Outside, the paired impacts began again. Eleven counts. Strike. A pause deep enough to feel deliberate. Strike.

Oren chose riders who could swim and who did not strike villagers for answering slowly. He rejected Pell, who treated every closed door as an insult, and chose quiet Senna despite Belden’s dislike of her mother’s burial songs. He selected Liof as mechanic, though the woman was only nineteen, because she could hear a cracked pin through running water. The remaining three knew reed channels better than formal roads. Oren made each rider repeat the order’s distinction between securing a living creature and punishing a human carrier. None looked comfortable. Good. Comfort made force arrive too easily. They packed short ropes, hook poles, two crossbows sealed against rain, and blankets meant for wrapping a living specimen. Nobody said what shape the blankets expected.

Haro met Oren in the stable passage. “You should see the lower gauge before you go.”

They descended to a shaft behind the east wall. Its brass needle measured pressure from the buried channel. The needle had bent past its highest mark and scratched a new crescent into the dial.

“Started after the fourth barrel,” Haro said.

“Why wasn’t this reported?”

“It was. Page went missing.”

“You saw the laborers?”

“Three from Dunmere. Two left walking. The older fisher needed carrying.”

Malven Dorr. Oren did not need the name spoken.

“What happened to the contents?”

“Keepers poured them through the harvesting frame. Water stayed clear. Afterward the lake level fell faster, and the knocks began.”

A harvesting frame stripped movement and change from whatever crossed it, storing that power in stillwater routed west. If a living egg lay below, the lowering had not merely exposed it. The Crown had drawn against it.

“Counterweight?” Oren asked.

Haro looked toward the wall. “The laborers stood in silver foot clamps. Sillan said the clamps grounded pressure.”

“They grounded it into bodies.”

“One man aged. Sillan put him in a skiff and said the lake would make the report simple.”

The gate struck below them. Mortar cracked across the gauge housing.

Oren seized Haro’s coat and pulled him away as brass screws spat from the wall. Water burst through the seam, then stopped in midair. Droplets hung between stone and floor, perfectly round.

Upstairs, a keeper had activated the emergency stilling.

Haro stared at the suspended spray. “Where did they send that?”

A horse screamed in the stable. One of the old geldings collapsed as every joint in its forelegs swelled at once.

Oren ran to it. The animal thrashed against the straw, young eyes wide above ruined knees. A silver floor channel ended beneath its stall.

“Cut the note!” he shouted.

The emergency singer stopped. Water completed its fall. The leak struck the floor. The gelding’s legs did not recover. Suspended pressure had moved into living bone, and ending the stilling could not return what the counterweight had already received.

Oren knelt until the animal quieted. Then he ordered Haro to end its pain. He did not let the keepers call the death necessary.

Before midnight, six riders assembled under the east arch. Rain had begun, fine enough to grease basalt without filling the lake. The stable smelled of wet leather, frightened horses, and the bitter powder keepers scattered over blood. Liof checked every saddle buckle herself. Belden handed Oren a copy of the sealed order and kept the original.

From the high Crown road, Dunmere showed as a scatter of lamps beside an immense black absence. Lowered water had widened the shore by hundreds of paces. In the inlet, lanterns moved near the exposed mud, though Keeper Sillan’s message claimed the site secured.

Oren could have sounded the warning horn. Three notes would wake the reeve, clear the shore, and tell any carrier that riders approached. It would also give Tavia Sorn time to hide whatever she had found.

Enna’s token rested warm against his chest. The order’s final line remained in his pocket. Behind him, Veyl Lock took another blow from below.

He raised one hand and chose speed over warning the town.

The riders descended toward Dunmere before dawn, six dark shapes slipping down the rain-slick road.

Chapter 03 — Under Veylwater

Tavia fed rope through her palms and lowered herself past the point where the drowned steps lost moonlight.

Cold pressed close. The stair descended between fitted basalt walls sweating after generations underwater. Above, Lake Veyl's exposed inlet narrowed to a pale crooked mouth. Below, her horn lamp found one tread, then another, each worn in the middle by feet the Crown claimed had never walked there.

She tested every step with the recovery hook. Mud disguised cracks. Rush roots dangled from the ceiling and brushed her jaw like wet hair. Ossa's embroidered cloth rode inside Tavia's coat, three curved marks against her chest.

At the twelfth tread, the walls closed around her shoulders. She turned sideways, keeping her stiff left knee downhill. A midwife learned early that pride could turn a manageable passage into a body no one could extract. She measured the opening, her breath, and the route back before moving deeper.

Something knocked below.

The pulse passed through stone and hook shaft. It did not match her heart. This rhythm paused too long, gathered strength, then pushed outward as though testing a shell.

"I hear you," Tavia whispered.

The next pulse loosened grit from the ceiling.

Her lamp showed a carved hand beside the stair. Five fingers spread around a small oval. Another hand appeared lower, then another, each cut by a different carver. Some hands bore scars. One lacked two fingers. These belonged to working people, not saints polished smooth by worship.

Tavia cleared slime from the first oval with her thumb. Inside, a curled creature had four fin-limbs and a long body wrapped around itself. Lines ran from the creature toward the carved hands, not away. The figures held no spears. They guided its head toward a channel descending west.

Crown school tablets showed Saint Orra pinning a serpent beneath one foot.

Here Orra knelt with both palms open.

A second panel continued around the bend. Tavia cleaned it with lakewater and the edge of her sleeve. Three midwives lowered a sling while townspeople above managed ropes. Nobody wore a crown or stood apart. One figure held a bowl beneath the egg; carved lines showed water overflowing into planted beds where reeds bent under sudden growth. The counterweight had not been hidden. Plants took strain, water warmed, tools cracked, and attendants changed positions before any one body carried too much.

Farther down, damage obscured the sequence. Chisel marks had removed faces

and cut Crown crescents over open hands. Newer mortar filled labels beneath the carvings. Tavia dug at one patch with her knife until old lettering emerged: NAME THE WEIGHT BEFORE YOU MOVE IT.

Ossa used those words at human births. She made every person in a room name what they held: shoulders, lamp, water, fear, the laboring woman's left leg. As a young apprentice, Tavia had thought the ritual needless. Then a father fainted while gripping a rope and nearly pulled his wife from the birthing stool. Unnamed weight still fell somewhere.

Tavia followed another carved instruction. A moonbrood emerged into a water cradle while attendants opened a western gate. Its tail remained curled near the shell; its head faced a current. No one dragged it. Guidance meant making the necessary road possible and keeping hands ready when the body chose movement.

At the panel's bottom, twenty-three small moons diminished toward darkness. The last showed a fin touching a wave cut with salt crystals. Someone had gouged that image deepest, trying to erase the destination. Crystals still glittered in the cuts.

A rusted nail projected from newer masonry. Blue thread clung beneath its head, preserved by cold. Crown workers had once stretched cloth across the carvings before flooding the stair, hiding the old lesson without spending labor to destroy all of it.

Tavia wound the thread around one finger. Ossa might have walked here before the final closure, or learned from someone who had. The old woman's refusal to explain now looked less like secrecy and more like terror shaped by raids, fines, and confiscated tools. Tavia wished for five minutes at her kitchen table, and resented the dead for keeping their answers where hands could not reach.

The discovery struck harder than wonder. Trades could be stolen by changing the pictures used to remember them. Lake midwives had not merely washed the drowned and delivered children near water. They had attended another kind of birth.

A loose tread shifted beneath Tavia. Her boot dropped. She caught the rope before her knee folded, slammed one shoulder into stone, and hung above a shaft of black water. The lamp swung from her wrist. Its flame bent but held.

She found a ledge with her toe and breathed until pain narrowed to a known line. Nothing tore. The knee would swell later. Later had to earn its turn.

The hole beneath the tread breathed cold mist. Her recovery hook reached no bottom. Yet the rope continued past her into darkness, its free end tugged by a current below.

Tavia wedged the pry bar across the stair, retied her line around it, and descended through the gap. Stone scraped her back. She entered water to the waist, then chest. The cold stole a breath before she could bargain with it.

Her lamp floated inside an oiled bladder. She bit its loop between her teeth and followed the wall with one hand. The passage ran level now. Grooves beneath her fingers formed a sequence: open hand, curled creature, three waves, open hand. Each repetition ended with a notch cut deep enough to grip.

A recovery route, she thought. Or a birth passage built by people who expected the attendant to cross in darkness.

Water rose to her chin. The ceiling dipped. Tavia filled the air bladder from her own breath, held it against her mouth, and went under.

Silence changed underwater. Every small movement entered her bones. Rope rasping stone sounded like distant sawing. The buried pulse spread through her teeth. On the second beat, light flickered behind the wall, not white but deep blue, tracing narrow silver channels.

She understood Malven's burns with sudden bodily certainty. Silver had carried change through him the way these lines carried pressure through stone.

The channel widened before her air failed. Tavia surfaced into a chamber with a low domed roof. She coughed quietly, though nobody stood to hear. Her lamp revealed a circular ledge and seven outlets blocked with masonry. Six had been faced in newer brick. The westernmost opening retained a stone lip carved with flowing fins.

At the chamber's center, a black shape broke the water.

Tavia pulled herself onto the ledge. The object looked at first like a boulder lacquered by depth. Then constellations shifted under its surface. No reflection caused them. Points of light drifted in curved lines, vanishing near a broad crack and appearing elsewhere.

A pearl-black egg, longer than Tavia from crown to heel, lay tilted inside a silver harvesting frame.

Four hooked arms clamped its middle. Tubes ran from the frame into the chamber walls. Where metal touched shell, frost had spread in feathered burns. The lake lowering had exposed the upper quarter of the egg and shifted its weight against one arm. A crack opened there, fine as a hair but fresh.

The pulse came again.

Every tube brightened. Water around the frame went smooth. Tavia's lamp flame stopped moving. At the chamber edge, an old wooden offering cup split in half as violently displaced pressure found a counterweight.

The frame harvested the egg's movement. Each attempt to hatch entered silver channels and went elsewhere. Malven's ruined joints, the browned fennel, perhaps western stores she could not see, all belonged to one concealed arithmetic.

Tavia stepped into the water.

Cold reached her thighs. The egg's surface had no warmth, yet her palms prickled before touching it. She approached the cracked side and laid one hand

against shell.

A body answered.

Not with words. Tavia felt a long spine folded beyond comfort, four limbs pressing in turns, gills opening against fluid that had begun to sour. The hatchling's heart beat too slowly. Around it, the frame tightened whenever it moved.

"You're caught," she said. "That much we share."

The egg kicked beneath her hand. Silver light raced up the nearest arm. Somewhere beyond the chamber, stone groaned.

Tavia searched the frame. Each clamp hinged around a central ring stamped with the Regent dynasty's crescent. An older mechanism lay beneath: stone cradles shaped to hold without closing, channels meant to receive lakewater, handgrips positioned for several attendants. Crown builders had bolted extraction arms onto a birthing place.

Her pry bar fitted between one silver hook and the shell. She leaned carefully. Nothing moved except pain in her knee.

The hatchling struck again. The bar snapped free. Stillness seized the water around her legs. Her trousers stopped rippling. The suspension climbed toward her hips with numbing pressure.

Across the chamber, a line of ancient reed mats blackened and collapsed. They paid for a few seconds of trapped motion. When the mats saturated, the stilling reached farther. Rock dust streamed from one blocked outlet.

Tavia pulled away before the channel could choose her body.

She climbed onto the ledge and studied the carvings by lamp. Seven attendants surrounded an egg. Three held ropes. One poured changing water through a cut shell. Another bent over the creature's head with lines emerging from her mouth.

Three lines.

Ossa had forbidden the song after Jeren died. "No use calling what the locks will kill," she had said. Tavia had mistaken grief for superstition. Perhaps Ossa had known exactly what answered.

Tavia took out the embroidered strip. The marks matched the carved lines: low, rising, low again. Not melody. Instruction shaped for pressure.

She hummed the first note.

The chamber pushed back. Water tightened around her ankles, and her teeth ached. The egg's pulse stumbled.

"Too high," she told herself.

Ossa's old voice returned from a winter kitchen: Do not sing prettily at a laboring body. Give it somewhere to put the breath.

Tavia lowered the note until it vibrated in her sternum. The water accepted it. Blue light eased along the silver channels, no longer racing.

She found the second note by feeling for the egg's heartbeat and rising just above it. The hatchling moved once. Instead of striking the frame, it turned toward her voice.

The third note dropped beneath hearing. Tavia shaped it with throat and ribs, a pressure more than sound. Her lamp trembled. Frost withdrew from a handspan of shell.

The three-note song did not break the stilling. It gave the trapped movement a route inside the egg, allowing the hatchling to uncurl without feeding the silver arms. Calming carried a cost too. Tavia's jaw cramped. Blood warmed one nostril. Each repetition borrowed pressure from her chest and spent it through the chamber water.

She sang again while studying the clamps.

The oldest stone cradle had hand releases beneath the waterline. Crown bolts pinned them shut. Tavia dove, located the first by touch, and looped rope through its grip. The line ran over the pry bar and back to her waist. She surfaced, sang three notes, and leaned.

Stone shifted half an inch.

The silver hook followed because its bolt crossed the old release. A gap opened beside the shell.

Tavia moved to the next grip. Her cold fingers fumbled the knot twice. She imagined explaining haste to a dead patient and forced herself to tie it properly. Pull, sing, rest. The second release moved. The egg rolled against the cradle, and the crack widened with a noise small enough to terrify her.

Dark fluid seeped out. It shimmered with moving points, thicker than lakewater.

Tavia smelled iron and salt.

A moonbrood belonged to saltwater at the far end of the kingdom. This one had developed in a mountain lake above seven sealed gates. Its body carried a journey before taking its first breath.

She pressed waxed cloth over the crack. The shell's cold drew heat through her palm. Blue veins appeared beneath her skin, mapping the silver channels outside. Tavia snatched her hand away, but the marks remained.

The hatchling quieted.

"Not dead," she said, because the chamber offered no reassurance.

A slow pulse answered.

The third clamp had bent under the lake lowering. Its release would not turn. Tavia wedged her pry bar beneath the Crown bolt and used the old cradle as a fulcrum. Metal protested. The harvesting frame responded by activating every silver line.

Water froze into stillness without becoming ice. The movement of her lungs

slowed. Pressure she should have felt as pain vanished from her shoulder and reappeared in the wall, where a carved attendant's stone face aged into powder. The magic suspended Tavia's strain and transferred it into the image of the trade that had once served here.

"No," she gasped.

She released the bar. Motion returned to her arm with doubled force. Muscle spasmed from wrist to neck. The carved face remained gone.

Stillwater never restored its counterweight.

Tavia wrapped rope around the bent arm instead. She led the line through two stone handgrips, making a hauling system meant for several midwives. Alone, she could multiply force but not erase its cost. The rope would fray. Her palms would tear. The old grips might break. Those prices had names.

She planted both feet against the cradle and pulled while singing.

The first note steadied the hatchling. The second directed its body away from the clamp. On the third, the creature pushed from within.

Rope burned Tavia's palms. The bent silver arm rose. A scale of shell peeled from beneath it and struck the water. At once the chamber's surface turned mirror-flat. Tavia's shoulder pain vanished.

Beyond the blocked eastern outlet, something living screamed.

She stopped singing. The stilling released. Pain returned to her shoulder. The distant scream ended.

Paleshell dust on the frame had used her held note to activate. She understood now why Ossa's song had been criminalized: the same human breath could guide a birth or power a theft, depending on what metal waited in the water.

Tavia wiped blood from her nose. "We do this without letting the frame hear."

She could not prevent sound from entering water. She could change where she sang.

The old carvings showed attendants pressing their brows to stone. Tavia knelt and placed her mouth against a handgrip beneath the surface. She sounded the notes through basalt. The cradle carried them directly into the egg while the surrounding water received only a dull vibration.

The hatchling followed.

Tavia pulled. Rope fibers broke one by one against her palms. The creature shifted inside its shell, lending force at the precise instant the third note fell. Silver scraped pearl-black surface. The bent hook lifted clear.

A fourth clamp remained near the egg's lower end. This one had no Crown bolt. The lake lowering had cracked its stone hinge. Tavia touched it and found the weight already poised to fall outward. She cut the retaining wire with her mortuary knife.

The frame opened.

The egg rolled into the old cradle. Water surged around it, carrying dark birth fluid through carved channels that had waited 162 years. Each of the seven blocked outlets rang at a different pitch. The western opening answered deepest.

Cold light flooded Tavia's palms. The rope burns filled with blue, not healing but marking every place her skin had paid friction. Lines traveled from her hands to wrists, then stopped. She felt the hatchling's heartbeat through them, alongside her own.

A section of shell lifted and settled.

"Not yet," Tavia whispered.

The creature had begun hatching. Ossa's cloth carried another pattern along its hem: twenty-three tiny knots followed by an open loop. Tavia had counted them as a child. Now the meaning arrived without mysticism. The drowned-moon eclipse had already begun dimming the sky. Twenty-three days measured the distance between first crack and hardened gills. The final loop opened toward the sea.

She said it aloud so the cost could not hide inside wonder. "Twenty-three days."

Tavia counted backward through roads she barely knew. Even with open canals, a barge took longer than that to reach the coast. Beneath the kingdom, the buried river might run faster, but seven Crown locks sealed it. A deadline did not make her chosen. It merely made delay another named danger.

The egg turned in its cradle. A fin pressed against the crack, translucent and starred. Then it withdrew.

Above the chamber, faint impacts entered the stair. Boots on stone. Crown riders or Sillan's keepers had found her rope.

Tavia gathered the line and worked it beneath the egg, building a sling. She could not carry such weight up the narrow shaft. The western channel offered the only route large enough, but brick sealed its throat. First she needed Ila, a boatwright, and a vessel that could hold water where no ordinary boat fit.

The egg pulsed through her marked palms.

This time the pressure did not remain in the chamber. It entered the old channels, passed through stone and lakewater, and struck every open basin above.

One bell rang in Dunmere. Another answered at Veyl Lock. Then every basin bell around Lake Veyl began to ring.

Chapter 04 — The Regent's Borrowed Face

Sere Valec listened to two mothers argue over a grain chit while the bowl beside her throne refused to ripple.

Morning wind entered through the high shutters. Tapestries stirred. Candle flames leaned east. The water remained a perfect silver disk inside black stone, unchanged since servants set it down thirty-five years ago.

The older mother had six people under her roof and a mill injury that kept one son from work. The younger had twins and a dead husband's canal allotment disputed by his brother. Each possessed documents bearing valid seals. Neither document could create wheat.

"Divide the household claim until harvest," Sere told the grain magistrate. "Issue the mill family four chits and the canal household three. The disputed allotment remains attached to the children, not the uncle."

The younger woman began thanking her. Sere raised one finger. "Your gratitude feeds no one. Report any clerk who asks coin to honor this ruling."

A scribe recorded the order. The women backed away beneath painted scenes of abundant fields.

Sere kept the unchanged bowl at her right hand because visitors noticed it without admitting they had. Its surface made a promise: in this room, disorder stopped. Fever could pause. Grain could resist mold. A kingdom could hold shape against flood, hunger, and succession.

Only fools mistook promises for free goods.

A keeper entered before the next petitioner reached the speaking tile. Mud stained his knees. He crossed the audience chamber, knelt, and whispered to the master of petitions. The master's face lost its ceremonial vacancy.

"Your Grace," he said. "Basin bells have sounded from Lake Veyl to Bell Lock."

No court musician moved. Even the mothers stopped near the doors.

Sere placed her fingertips against the bowl's cool rim. "Clear the chamber. Grain petitions resume at second bell. Keep every claimant's position."

Officials began moving. She watched which advisers tried to leave first. Three always fled toward private information before receiving public instructions. Sere named them and ordered them to remain.

Within four minutes, the throne room held only ministers, physicians, lock officers, and Captain Letha Marr from the lower-gate watch. Servants closed the shutters. The wind vanished. Water in ordinary drinking cups settled slowly. The unchanged bowl had never acknowledged the disturbance.

Keeper-General Vos unfolded a damp message. "Veyl reports the hatching signal. The eastern harvesting frame lost contact at the third pulse. Rider Oren

Kest has gone to Dunmere under recovery authority.”

“Living confirmation?”

“None yet.”

“Then call it an egg until it moves.”

Royal Physician Edran stepped close enough for only Sere to hear. “Your renewal cannot wait through council.”

A thin pressure had begun behind her eyes. At the base of her right thumb, skin tightened over a joint that remembered sixty-seven years despite her face showing thirty-two. The weekly stilling had reached its limit during the audience.

“Five minutes,” she said.

“Two.”

Sere dismissed everyone except Edran and her chamber secretary. Behind the throne, a narrow door opened into the stilling room. No gold ornamented it. White tile, copper drains, two chairs, and silver channels made the place resemble a small surgery because honesty sometimes survived in rooms no public eye entered.

Edran poured water from a sealed flask into a shallow glass dish. Paleshell clouded it like ground pearl. The silver line beneath Sere’s chair ran through the wall, down palace foundations, and into Weathering Ward Seven.

“Current routing?” she asked.

“Ninety-six registered capacities. Eighteen juvenile, none carrying your primary age channel this week.”

“None carrying more than tolerance?”

“Tolerance follows the medical table.”

“That did not answer me.”

Edran met her eyes. “Three adults approach saturation. We can move your line before the next renewal.”

“Move it now.”

“The transfer requires a fresh route. Delay raises the chance of visible return during council.”

A visible return meant thirty-five years reaching for her body at once. It could begin with skin, bone, fever, or the scar tissue left by the assassin’s knife. The system did not choose elegance. It moved deferred change along prepared metal toward a living counterweight strong enough to receive it.

Sere removed her rings. “Which process goes where?”

Edran knew she required the words. “Your next seven days of aging and recurrence of wasting fever will be suspended. The fever load routes to preserved livestock tissue in the south vault until saturation. Age-related cellular change

routes among twelve adult Ward Seven residents below threshold. One resident bears less than eleven months equivalent."

"Twelve people, named on the private ledger."

"Yes."

"Not children."

"Not for this renewal."

The qualification entered her like a needle. Sere had inherited a smaller ward and expanded it during famine years, when allowing the Regent's fever to return would have thrown the grain command into a succession fight. First prisoners received shortened sentences for service. Then debtors accepted family payments. Later ministers found people without anyone powerful enough to demand a receipt.

She had ended the use of children for her personal channel. Other medical assignments remained.

"Begin," she said.

Edran sounded one held note.

The dish went still. Pain behind Sere's eyes stopped climbing. Her thumb eased. Across echo-distance, silver carried those changes into named bodies and butchered tissue. Nothing vanished. The kingdom's medicine had never violated that law, only its public accounting.

A new ache entered her left hip and disappeared before she could locate it fully. Somewhere in Ward Seven, another person's bones accepted what hers refused.

The chamber secretary watched the floor.

"Look at me," Sere said.

He obeyed reluctantly.

"Write that twelve adult residents received the age channel. Seal their names in my medical ledger."

"Yes, Your Grace."

"If any exceeds table tolerance, Edran reports directly."

Edran removed the dish. Its water began moving, but the week remained suspended. "You could reduce the burden by permitting natural aging between audiences."

"And let every border governor calculate weakness from my face?"

"Medicine is not policy."

"In this palace, it became policy before either of us held office."

Sere replaced her rings. The face in the polished cabinet showed smooth cheeks, black hair threaded with no gray, and eyes old enough to distrust both. She did not call the image youth. Youth had not buried a sister, rationed grain

through three failures, or ordered bodies entered into hidden ledgers.

Council reconvened around a flood map.

Engineers had modeled two outcomes. In the first, Crown riders recovered the egg before it reached Veyl Lock. Grain canals lost one week's flow. Dunmere endured shortages but no major flood. In the second, a moonbrood entered the Nightcourse and broke locks out of sequence. The lower Bellhaven basin filled above second-story windows. Tens of thousands required movement uphill through streets built for carts, not panic.

Captain Letha planted one broad hand on the map. "Begin evacuation staging now."

Treasury Minister Caldryn recoiled. "On the strength of bells?"

"On the strength of water being heavier than disbelief."

Sere liked Letha for sentences that did work. "How many can the lower watch move in three days?"

"Eight thousand if grain barges carry people. Five if merchants contest the quays. Less if the palace archives claim priority."

"The archives have flood protocols."

"So do children in the dye quarter. Theirs involve drowning."

Nobody spoke to a Regent that way unless usefulness had accumulated enough interest.

Sere studied the contour marks. Bellhaven's population clustered where locks had made land valuable: mills, dye works, grain depots, cheap rooms on old silt. An evacuation order would empty factories during harvest intake, freeze trade, and trigger flight from towns not in danger. Grain prices would rise before water did. Western governors might close roads to refugees. Broad warning could kill through hunger even if Oren recovered the egg by noon.

"How certain is sequential failure?" she asked Keeper-General Vos.

"Unknown. Old records conflict."

"Because?"

"Records from the first closure describe a guide route later removed from official plans."

"Removed physically or from ink?"

Vos hesitated. "Both, perhaps."

Sere felt anger sharpen, not at the answer but at inherited ignorance disguised as tradition. Her ancestors had altered reliefs, burned midwife songs, and classified lock maps so thoroughly that the present government could not distinguish engineering from theology.

"Find the unaltered plans," she said. "Open sealed Orra holdings if needed."

Caldrin frowned. "Saint Orra's chapter will object."

"They may object while carrying boxes."

Letha remained over the map. "And evacuation?"

"Prepare without proclamation. Inventory carts, open hill storehouses, clear flood stairs, and inspect warning bells. Do not move the lower wards yet."

"That buys capacity, not time."

"It buys both if done without panic."

"It spends the residents' time without their consent."

Sere looked at her. "If I order sixty-three thousand people uphill and the egg is recovered tomorrow, western grain spoils on stalled barges. Prices triple. Children die in towns whose names never reach this room. Their consent will not make them fed."

Letha's jaw worked once. "Then let them know what risk they carry."

"Knowledge without a workable route creates crush deaths."

This argument had no clean side. Sere had learned to distrust advisers who found one.

She ordered the lower-basin census brought from archives. Clerks arrived carrying six stitched books and a street board marked with wooden counters. Letha moved the counters by district while Caldren recited capacities: hill storehouses, public stairs, barges, carts, infirmary beds. Each number depended on another number refusing to fail.

The dye quarter held nine thousand people below the first flood mark. Its eastern stairs narrowed beside a retaining wall currently kept from settling by structural stillwater. If the lock network failed, the wall's deferred cracks might return while people climbed. The mill district could evacuate by canal, but its barges also carried three weeks of capital grain. Palace Heights had room and elevation, yet its gates admitted only residents bearing stamped household tablets.

"Remove tablet checks during flood movement," Letha said.

Caldren objected. "Then anyone can enter the palace store zone."

"Anyone with water behind them should."

Sere marked the change herself. "Flood command supersedes household privilege. Put that in the sealed drill orders."

Letha gave the smallest nod.

Another counter represented the fever hospice. Patients under stilling could not simply be carried across echo-distance without rerouting their channels. Enna Kest and forty-two others depended on active lines. Moving them uphill might break suspension; leaving them risked inundation.

"Prepare ordinary treatment kits beside every suspended patient," Sere told

Edran. "Bandages, fever bark, clotting moss, clean water. Assume release."

"Some will die if moved."

"Some die if they remain."

"We can reinforce the hospice with more stillwater."

"From where?"

Edran looked down at Ward Seven on the map.

"No," Sere said. "Not to preserve a building while its counterweights sit below flood level."

The room quieted. Her moral boundaries often impressed people who did not ask how far inside those boundaries she had already permitted suffering.

Sere remembered the Ash Winter, twenty-two years earlier, when ice sealed western canals and three governors hoarded seed grain. She had requisitioned barges, arrested two governors, and stilled the capital stores against mold. Apples, timbers, and slaughtered cattle carried the first months of displaced rot. When those failed, physicians proposed prisoners. Sere approved volunteers with sentence reductions. By spring, the definition of volunteer had widened without returning to her desk.

Thousands survived. Forty-seven original counterweights died. Both facts belonged in the same history, though palace murals showed only barges arriving through snow.

"Open the old North Rise kitchens," she said. "Stock them quietly for twenty thousand meals. Use current grain, not preserved reserve."

Caldrin blinked. "That much movement cannot remain quiet."

"Call it vermin inspection and roof repair. Rumor may notice flour. Rumor need not receive a flood date."

"You plan as if you expect failure."

"I govern as if expectation has no weight against water."

She divided tasks. Letha received authority to clear stairs under the cover of fire inspection. Caldrin would release contingency grain if prices rose more than one fifth. Vos would reinforce Hush and Red Step while avoiding visible troop trains. Edran would prepare trauma wards without drawing on new human counterweights.

"Can you do that?" Sere asked him.

"For forty-eight hours with fruit, timber, and animal tissue."

"After?"

"Living capacity becomes necessary if injuries exceed forecast."

Named source, named counterweight. The arithmetic remained monstrous even when spoken plainly.

A second courier arrived from Veyl Lock. His report confirmed movement below the gate, a missing paleshell register page, and a lake midwife named Tavia Sorn obstructing examination of a weathered corpse. Oren had departed with six riders.

Sere knew Kest's file. Competent. Slow to violence. Daughter in palace hospice. He would obey because the lock network held Enna's fever still.

She wrote an amendment to the recovery order.

SECURE THE EGG AND ANY LIVING BROOD. PRESERVE THE MIDWIFE FOR QUESTIONING. IF THE BROOD ENTERS A LOCK, CLEAR LOWER SLUICES BEFORE MOVING THE MAIN GATE.

Vos read the last instruction. "That procedure comes from prohibited lake-midwife records."

"It also appears in the oldest engineering appendix."

"Opening lower sluices may reveal the buried course."

"The course will reveal itself more violently if pressure chooses the hour."

Sere sealed the amendment. "Send by fast relay."

Then she opened a second sheet without the council seal.

Saint Orra maintained the kingdom's only paleshell grinder large enough to process a whole brood. Publicly it ground relic fragments for emergency medicine. The machine had last received fresh shell eighty-one years ago.

Sere addressed the private order to Orra's prior and Royal Mechanist Faul.

She had inspected the grinder once, at nineteen, before court instructors learned to protect heirs from useful ugliness. The chamber smelled of wet chalk. Millstones taller than a person sat around a drain carved as an open mouth. Guides described the last moonbrood as a monster whose shell had saved generations. A maintenance ledger recorded hooks, blood loss, and the hours the creature survived after restraint. No line called the process mercy.

Fresh paleshell from that killing still powered portions of the palace network eighty-one years later. One butchered migration had funded thousands of paused fevers, preserved harvests, unchanged faces, and hidden wards. Destroying the next brood could extend those systems. It would also renew the choice that had made every later crime administratively possible.

Sere did not tell herself contingency carried no intention. Preparing a blade made its use easier. Failing to prepare could leave Bellhaven under water. She wrote with the same hand that had allocated grain and human aging, unable to separate ruler from beneficiary.

INSPECT THE GRINDER. REPLACE CORRODED TEETH. PREPARE A WATER-FED RESTRAINT FRAME. THIS IS CONTINGENCY, NOT AUTHORIZATION TO KILL.

Her secretary blotted the words. "Should the council receive a copy?"

"No."

"Keeper-General Vos?"

"No."

The secretary's gaze flickered toward the unchanged bowl visible through the open door.

Sere added, "Record its existence in my sealed succession packet. Hidden from the council does not mean erased."

That distinction mattered to her. It would not matter to a creature in the grinder.

By noon, reports spread beyond bells. Water bowls had rung in villages as far west as Bellhaven. Sleepers woke remembering rain inside rooms with dry roofs. At Veyl, the buried channel pressure exceeded its gauge. Dunmere's inlet exposed old masonry.

Edran brought a narrower medical projection. "If the moonbrood survives and drinks from active stillwater, stored changes may return toward their sources."

"Evidence?"

"Accounts from the first closure. Buildings aged in minutes. Preserved grain fermented. Old wounds reopened."

"Human channels?"

"Unknown."

Sere touched the map where Ward Seven lay beneath the dye quarter. Ninety-six bodies. Eighteen children. Beyond them, other wards and informal assignments not counted in any public budget. If stored age returned to her source, thirty-five years might kill her. If it returned to those who had received it, they might weather faster. The old records offered no mercy, only uncertainty.

"Could the brood be guided around the reservoirs?" she asked.

"Perhaps by old songs."

"Songs we outlawed."

"Your grandfather outlawed them."

"And I maintained the law."

She did not use ancestry to dilute responsibility.

Captain Letha returned with stair-clearing estimates. Sere approved labor payments from palace emergency funds, then rejected the captain's renewed request for public evacuation.

"Give me living confirmation," she said. "One credible sighting. One shell measurement. Then we move districts by elevation."

"By then the roads narrow."

"They narrow now if rumor reaches them first. Place watch captains at each rise and prepare."

Letha bowed without agreement.

After council dispersed, Sere stood alone beside the throne. The unchanged bowl reflected her borrowed face without distortion. Servants had laid a fresh petitioner list on the chair: mill claims, canal injuries, a western town asking permission to eat seed grain. Governance did not pause because an old life cycle returned beneath a lake.

She dipped one finger into the bowl. Water clung without running down her skin.

A line appeared across the back of her hand.

It deepened from smooth flesh into a narrow age crease. Another branched beside it. For one breath, the hand matched the years she had lived.

Far below, silver channels brightened. The stillwater took hold, erased the lines, and sent those seven days of change toward twelve named residents in Ward Seven.

Sere watched until her borrowed skin lay smooth again.

Chapter 05 — A Boat for the Unborn Night

Ila Venn opened her boat-shed doors, saw the pearl-black egg on Tavia's mortuary sledge, and said, "That will not fit any boat I own."

"Then build smaller doors." Tavia leaned against the hauling rope, wet to the ribs and shaking from cold. "Quickly."

Dawn had not yet cleared the basalt ridge. Basin bells still trembled around Dunmere. Tavia had brought the egg up through the old birthing shaft by flooding the stone cradle, guiding it into a maintenance trough, and letting the lowered lake carry most of the weight. The final hundred paces across mud had demanded rope, a door used as a skid, and every curse Ossa had forbidden in a birth room.

Ila looked past her toward the quay. "Crown lanterns on the north road."

"I know."

"You brought it through town?"

"Along the eel drains."

"That explains the fishwives praying into their aprons."

The egg shifted. Moving lights under its shell gathered near the crack.

Ila's broad face lost its humor. She closed the doors and dropped the bar. Boat ribs hung from rafters overhead. Half-finished punts crowded the walls. At the shed's center rested a funeral skiff built from black alder, narrow enough for a burial channel and hinged in three sections so grieving families could carry it uphill.

Tavia put both marked palms against the shell. Cold light brightened in her rope burns. The creature's heart struck once, slow but stronger than before.

"What happened to your hands?" Ila asked.

"The frame drew movement from the egg. I opened it. The shell marked where the rope took skin."

"That answer has too many impossible nouns."

"Touch here."

Ila approached as she would a warped keel, suspicious of every claimed measurement. Tavia guided her hand to the shell's uncracked side. A fin moved beneath it. Ila jerked back, then returned her palm deliberately.

"Living," she said.

"Yes."

"How much time?"

"Twenty-three days to saltwater."

"Across the kingdom."

"Under it, if the Nightcourse opens."

Ila studied Tavia rather than the egg. "Your evidence?"

Tavia showed her the blue palm lines, the silver flake from Malven, and Ossa's embroidered cloth. She described the midwife carvings, the Crown frame, and the blocked western channel. Ila interrupted whenever a fact tried to dress itself as legend.

"You saw a road?"

"A watercourse."

"Open?"

"Blocked out of the chamber, open somewhere beyond."

"You know it reaches sea?"

"The carvings show salt. Crown silver runs west along it."

"So you know old hands believed it reached sea."

"Yes."

"Better." Ila touched the egg again. "And this body wants that route?"

"When the western channel moved, they turned toward it."

Ila nodded. Belief did not enter her decision. Weight, pulse, and direction did.

Hooves sounded on the upper street.

Tavia moved toward the door. Ila caught her coat. "If you lead them away, they search here next because I am your oldest friend and Crown riders can read a town directory."

"Then what?"

"Then we make your impossible patient portable."

The egg could not travel dry. Its crack leaked dark birth fluid whenever exposed to air. Tavia had wrapped it in wet funeral linen, but the fabric already warmed. A proper cradle needed enough water to cover the lower shell, room for hatching limbs, and a shape narrow enough for reed channels and old tunnels.

Ila walked around the funeral skiff. "This folds because dead people do not object to hinges."

"Living ones do."

"We line them."

She kicked open a cabinet and threw Tavia a roll of waxed sailcloth. Together they removed the skiff's bier boards, padded each bronze hinge with wool, and sealed seams using hot pitch. Ila cut two side ribs lower so the egg could settle without rolling. Tavia filled cloth bladders at the rain barrel and arranged them as shock cushions.

Every alteration changed what the boat could bear. Ila named each compromise

aloud.

"Lower gunwale loses stiffness."

"Add crossing rope."

"More rope blocks the forward fin."

"Leave two handspans here."

"Water weight doubles the load."

"Spread it over three skids."

The work resembled turning a bed for a difficult labor. Nothing fit twice. Bodies altered the plan by occupying it.

Ila made Tavia sit while pitch heated. She unwrapped the marked palms and hissed through her teeth. Blue light pooled in each torn line, cold enough to stiffen the surrounding fingers.

"You cannot haul with these."

"I just did."

"That describes the injury, not the cure."

From a drawer Ila took fishskin, clean lint, and alder salve. She dressed the palms without covering the blue marks completely. Tavia flexed each finger. Pain remained sharp but useful. No tendon damage. She could tie knots if she let rope cross the heel of the hand rather than the torn center.

"What does the light do?" Ila asked.

"Connects me to the heartbeat. Perhaps to the channels."

"Perhaps gets people killed when it shines through a glove."

Ila rubbed charcoal into the outer bandages. Practical concealment, not shame. Tavia held on to that difference.

They needed water. The shed's rain barrel held too little, and ordinary lakewater from the inlet carried silt that could clog the hatchling's gills. Ila opened a covered sump beneath the floor where spring seepage stayed clear. She tasted it first, then filled a horn cup and left it under lamplight. The surface changed with each vibration from the egg. No unnatural stillness caught it.

"Safe enough to begin," Tavia said.

"Beginning has become an expensive word today."

Using a hand pump, they raised springwater into three stitched bladders. Each bladder hung from a separate cradle section so one tear could not empty the whole basin. Tavia placed warmed stones beneath the aft lining. The egg carried mountain cold, but a hatching body could lose heat through the crack. She tested shell temperature against her inner wrist the way she tested bathwater for a newborn.

Ila cut inspection holes in the sailcloth. "Four limbs, you said."

"Four fins. Long body."

"How long?"

"Folded inside an egg longer than me."

"So when it comes out, we discover our careful boat fits the shell and not the patient."

Tavia looked at the hanging ribs. "Make the side ropes releasable under load."

"That risks spreading."

"Cross-brace from below. If the body lengthens, we drop both gunwales and let the basin widen."

Ila altered the plan, muttering about customers who changed dimensions after delivery. She fitted bone toggles that Tavia could release one-handed. The skiff's three folding sections gained another use: they could open flat into a shallow floating pen or close around a smaller body for narrow passages.

Tavia tested each toggle three times. On the second run, the aft brace jammed. Ila shaved it. On the third, a hinge pin caught the lining. They wrapped it in greased leather. Haste did not excuse leaving a known failure inside a boat.

A faint tapping came from the shell. Tavia answered with the lowest note of Ossa's song, keeping her mouth against the egg so the paleshell fragment could not activate through the shed water. The hatchling settled. Ila watched the bladders, the reeds in a caulking bucket, and Tavia's hands.

"No transfer?" she asked.

"None I can see. Sound traveled through shell, not loose water."

"Then write that into your instructions before someone sings beside a reservoir and ages a village."

Tavia found chalk and marked the inside of the forward board: SONG THROUGH SHELL OR STONE. NEVER THROUGH SILVERED WATER.

A fist struck the outer door.

"Crown inspection," called Keeper Sillan.

Ila did not pause over the auger. "We open when the pitch sets."

"Open now."

"Then your boots stick to my floor and I charge the lock."

Tavia pressed against the door's shadow. Through a knothole she saw Sillan and two keepers. Riders passed behind them toward the mortuary, blue coats dark with rain. Their leader sat straight in the saddle and watched exits rather than windows.

Oren Kest, she guessed. The recovery order had grown a face.

Sillan struck the door again. "We are searching for stolen Crown material."

Ila called back, "I have three bent nails and a beam full of rot. Name what the Crown recognizes as its own."

One keeper almost smiled.

Inside the cradle, the egg pulsed. Tools rang on their hooks.

Sillan went silent. Tavia felt his attention cross the boards.

Ila began hammering a rivet, loudly and without need. "Hear that? Work. Rare sound at the lock, I'm told."

Boots moved around the shed.

Tavia crouched beside the skiff. The pitch remained soft. If they launched now, hot seams could open and leak. If they waited, Sillan would find the reed-channel door behind stacked planks.

A tap sounded beneath the floor. Then another. The egg answered with a slow pressure wave.

Ila's eyes narrowed. "Old water under us?"

"Nightcourse branch, perhaps."

"Does it reach Veyl Lock?"

"Everything here reaches the lock."

"That is not what I asked."

"I don't know."

Ila set down the hammer. "Good. Keep saying that when you don't."

They rigged the cradle-boat beneath the sledge. By loosening two pins, the funeral skiff folded around the egg in three padded sections. Once carried to water, it could open and lock rigid. Ila had designed the hinges for families without enough strong arms to bear a coffin. Grief's tool now held an unborn night.

Outside, a rider ordered the south lane closed.

Tavia tied a midwife's chest knot around the shell. "Come as far as the inlet. Then go back."

"No."

"Salo needs you. Dunmere needs boats if the lake returns."

"Salo can bake without me for a week and complain for ten years." Ila threaded the launch rope. "Dunmere may need someone who knows what you have started."

"What I started?"

"You opened the frame."

"It was killing them."

"I agree with the opening. Do not hide its weight inside grammar."

Tavia pulled the knot tighter. The words hurt because they sounded like her own trade.

Ila continued, quieter. "If you take this creature west, Crown canals may fail.

Veyl Lock may open. Our smokehouses flood. My shed goes first. Salo's oven sits two steps above summer water. People who never saw your carvings will pay."

"I can hide the egg in the upper caves."

"For twenty-three days?"

"They die there."

"And if you surrender it?"

Tavia pictured the silver arms tightening whenever the body moved. "The Crown harvests them."

"Then name the choice."

Tavia rested her forehead against cold shell. "I take a living body toward the sea. I may bring water through Dunmere to do it. I do not know how many houses pay."

"Better than calling the lake angry." Ila lifted the forward handle. "Now name what you will do about those houses."

"Warn them before any gate opens. Clear lower channels. Move those who cannot climb."

"By yourself?"

The lie in Tavia had always claimed one pair of hands could stay innocent by refusing work too large for them. Malven's body had shown where that refusal ended: larger hands worked unseen.

"With everyone we can convince," she said.

Ila nodded once. "Then I come until we find people to send back with instructions."

A board scraped outside. Sillan's keeper had found the rear stack.

They lifted.

The loaded cradle weighed less than the egg alone because shallow water rose through grates under the shed and took part of it. Ila kicked free the concealed channel door. Reeds showed beyond, silver in dawn light.

Sillan shouted at the front. An axe struck near the bar.

Tavia and Ila carried the folded skiff down two wet rails. At the channel edge they pulled the hinge pins. Three sections opened, sailcloth lining settling into a continuous basin. Water rushed in. The egg floated low, cradled by black alder and wool.

A shell fragment loosened near the crack. Tavia caught it before it touched the channel. Even that thumb-sized piece stilled ripples around her hand. On the bank, cut reeds yellowed as they received the suspended decay.

She wrapped the fragment and placed it beside Malven's silver flake. No unnamed magic. Shell held stolen stillness; reeds paid when it woke.

The shed door split.

Ila shoved with a pole. Tavia steadied the egg while the cradle-boat slid between reeds barely wider than its lowered gunwales. Behind them, keepers entered the empty shed and overturned benches.

One rider reached the bank. Tavia saw the same straight-backed man from the lane. He could have loosed an arrow. Instead he judged water depth, current, and distance, searching for a safe intercept.

Their eyes met through reeds.

Ila opened the mill bypass with one pull. Current took the cradle sideways into a channel hidden under rush mats. Tavia ducked as willow branches closed above them.

The folded cradle-boat slid into the reed channel while riders searched the shed.

Chapter 06 — The Road Beneath the Lake

Oren found the boat shed empty and the pitch still soft enough to keep his fingerprint.

A funeral bier lay disassembled beside the stove. Black alder shavings curled on the floor. Three trails of water crossed toward a rear wall that appeared solid until Liof found wet reed pollen beneath the lowest plank.

“Channel door,” she said. “Opened outward.”

Keeper Sillan kicked a bench. “I told you she had Crown material.”

“You told me she had a body and an attitude.” Oren crouched beside a cut hinge pin. “How long ago?”

“Minutes.”

The pitch skin had set but remained warm below. Tavia and Ila had worked quickly without abandoning care. Greased leather wrapped every sharp edge. A bone toggle left on the floor had been carved to release under load. Whoever designed the vessel expected its passenger to change shape.

Oren looked through the reed door. The hidden channel ran south beneath woven rush mats, away from the Crown road.

Sillan drew his sword. “We take the lane and cut them off.”

“With horses through spring mud?”

“The south lane reaches the mill race.”

“The channel does not.” Oren pointed at watermarks on the posts. “It turns west below the smokehouses. They are heading onto the drained lakebed.”

Sillan’s face reddened. “You saw them.”

“I saw two women in a low craft. No clean shot.”

“You had authority against carriers.”

“I had reeds, townspeople, and an unknown living target. Your preference for missed arrows does not revise my order.”

Oren told two riders to hold the town exits without entering homes. He took Liof, Senna, and the three others down the burial slope. Sillan tried to join them. Oren left him command of the shed search, where his damage could remain among furniture.

Rain stopped as they reached the mudflat. Hooves sank to the fetlocks. Oren dismounted and led his mare, Ash, by the bridle. The exposed lakebed disguised every depth beneath one dull sheen. Fresh water from the reed channel cut a path toward a line of stones just visible above silt.

Senna brushed mud from the first marker. A carved eye emerged.

“Funeral track,” she said. “My mother sang over this road before the final burial boats were banned.”

Oren studied the line. Stones crossed the old inlet westward, then curved toward Veyl Lock. The Crown map showed no road here. Local dead had once traveled beneath ordinary lake level, which meant processions used it during deliberate lowerings or before the lock raised Veyl permanently.

“Tavia knows where it goes,” Liof said.

“She knows where old carvings claim it goes.”

“Difference matters less if she is ahead of us.”

They led the horses single file. The track supported weight better than surrounding mud, though silt concealed broken sections. Oren used a spear butt before each step. Behind them, Dunmere bells stopped ringing one by one. Ahead, Veyl Lock stood beyond basalt, its towers hidden but its pressure audible through the ground.

A cradle skid had scraped one marker. Black pitch dotted the edge. Tavia and Ila had dragged the vessel out of the channel here, folded it enough to cross mud, then reopened it where a shallow current covered the road.

Oren imagined the labor. Two women, one damaged knee listed in Sillan’s report, an egg heavy enough to mark stone. They were not fleeing blindly. They were following infrastructure older than his maps.

The track dipped. Water reached the horses’ knees. Liof paused beside a cluster of bubbles.

“Gas?” she asked.

Oren smelled minerals, not rot. “Pressure. Give it room.”

He marked the spot with a reed pole and led around it. Twenty paces farther, another vent breathed through silt. These aligned with the buried Nightcourse. Water below sought release after the lake lowering and the egg’s movement.

A shout came from behind.

Young Rider Mera had ignored the marked route to pass Senna. Her mare’s forelegs vanished through a skin of mud. The animal pitched sideways. Mera fell clear, landed once on her shoulder, and broke through beside it.

Silt swallowed her to the waist.

Oren dropped Ash’s reins and ran back on the stones. “Do not struggle.”

Mera struggled. Mud rose to her ribs.

Her mare thrashed in a separate hole, opening the crust. Steam burst between them. A pressure vent had hollowed the lakebed from below. Thin mud covered a shaft of rising water.

“Ropes,” Oren ordered. “Two anchors, wide.”

Senna drove hook poles between funeral stones. Liof looped a line around

Oren's waist. He lay flat to spread his weight and crawled toward Mera.

The ground bucked beneath his chest.

Hot mineral water broke through near his left hand. It carried white paleshell grains. Motion around the vent slowed as the powder activated against silver traces in the old road. Mud hung in the spray.

Mera stopped sinking.

For one hopeful breath, stillwater held her.

Then Senna screamed. The pressure routed along a buried silver channel into her braced ankle. Her boot twisted as joints took the vent's suspended force.

"Break the note!" Oren shouted.

Nobody sang. The held pitch came from Veyl Lock, carried through stone.

Liof struck the nearest silver seam with the back of her axe. Once, twice. Metal split. The suspended mud fell. Mera dropped to her armpits, but Senna's ankle stopped deforming.

"Keep her breathing," Oren said.

He slid a loop across the mud. Mera caught it with one hand. Her other arm hung useless from the fall.

"Under your shoulders."

"I can't."

"You can with one. Feed it behind your neck."

She obeyed, sobbing without noise. Oren advanced until the crust bowed beneath his ribs. He reached her wrist.

A deeper pulse struck. The vent widened. Mera's mare vanished to the shoulder, eyes rolling white.

Oren had seconds to choose. Pulling the rider might collapse the stone supporting him. Retreat preserved pursuit and command. The recovery order named the moonbrood as priority over delay.

He closed his hand around Mera.

"Haul."

Five riders leaned into the rope. Mud resisted like flesh around a birth. Mera emerged inch by inch, coat left behind, one boot gone. Oren pushed her onto the nearest stone before the crust beneath him opened.

Water took him to the chest.

The rope around his waist snapped tight. Pain crossed his lower ribs. He found no footing. Beneath his boots, current ran west hard enough to pull.

Liof crawled close and drove a hooked pole under his arm. "On three."

"Do not count. Pull when the vent breathes out."

They felt the next pressure gathering. As water dropped for an instant, the riders hauled. Oren came free with both boots and half the lakebed inside his coat.

Mera lay on the track. Her shoulder had dislocated forward. Tavia Sorn might have known a gentler reduction. Oren knew field method.

He checked blood flow at the wrist, braced the arm, and told Mera exactly what would happen. "Pain now. Less damage after."

She bit a folded strap. Oren guided the joint until it seated with a heavy shift. Mera screamed into leather.

Senna's ankle had swollen, but bones seemed aligned. The stilling had transferred strain into ligaments and cartilage before Liof broke the channel. Ending magic did not reverse the received injury.

The trapped mare cried from the vent.

Oren crawled back with ropes. They saved the animal too, though it cost another quarter hour and three cut lines. When she reached stone, one foreleg dragged. Liof splinted it with funeral markers already loose from age, apologizing to Senna's ancestors while she worked.

Before anyone moved, Oren made them account for bodies and equipment. Mera could feel all five fingers but could not lift the injured arm. Senna's toes remained warm inside the cut boot. Oren's ribs hurt where the rope had stopped him, though each breath entered fully. Pell had burned both palms on the anchor line and tried to hide them.

"Hands," Oren said.

"They work."

"Show me."

Pell opened them. Mud filled two raw grooves. Oren rinsed the injuries with boiled water from a saddle flask and wrapped them. A rider who concealed damage became unreliable at the exact moment others depended on him. Oren had learned that on winter roads and still failed to apply it to doubts.

Liof knelt at the broken silver seam. "This line isn't part of any current lock plan."

She scraped mud with her axe and revealed three narrow channels braided around one wider groove. Tool marks differed. The broad channel belonged to old builders; the three narrow cuts had been added from above and packed with paleshell mortar.

"Old route carried pressure toward the lock," she said. "Crown lines tap it sideways."

"Toward what?"

"One east to Dunmere. One north under keeper farmland. The third goes west with us."

Oren followed the east line with his gaze. Malven had stood in clamps near the lake. The vent's stilling had found Senna through a road seam. Silver did not care about rank, intent, or innocence. It found prepared pathways and available matter.

"Could Tavia have caused this by freeing the egg?" Pell asked.

"She changed the pressure," Liof said. "The lowering cracked the bed first. Harvest lines gave it places to hurt people."

"So both."

Oren appreciated the answer because blame shared between causes remained harder to use as a weapon. "Record both."

His field book had stayed dry inside waxed cloth. He wrote the time, location, named injuries, dead horse at the lock, missing register page, and broken silver route. Belden would prefer a short report stating pursuit delayed by terrain. Oren wrote long enough that no later clerk could make Mera's fall look like weather.

Senna watched him. "You didn't write reports like that when Jeren Sorn died."

The question found an old opening.

"I wrote that his skiff failed to clear the release zone."

"My mother said the lock opened ahead of the posted bell."

"It did."

"Your report?"

"Carried a corrected time when it reached Bellhaven."

"Who corrected it?"

"Keeper command."

"You signed."

Oren's name remained beneath the altered margin. He could say he had not controlled the gate, that wheat fields downstream needed the scheduled flow, that riders existed to carry findings rather than adjudicate them. Every sentence would describe procedure accurately and responsibility falsely.

"Yes," he said.

Senna's face held no triumph. "Tavia knows?"

"I don't know."

"Tell her before asking trust."

"I am not asking trust. I am ordered to recover her patient."

"That avoids less than you think."

Mera shivered despite the mild rain. Oren covered her with his coat. The talk could not repair Jeren, and confession offered no useful shelter from exposure. Still, Senna had forced the name back into the route.

They examined the vent before leaving. Mineral water cooled quickly in a

shallow basin. Paleshell grains settled into a crescent along the west edge. A dead beetle floated there without sinking while a nearby reed aged from green to brittle brown. Residual stilling held the beetle's final collapse and transferred decay into the plant.

Oren scooped both water and grains into a glass evidence tube, then sealed it with wax. "No bare contact."

Liof marked the vent with crossed poles and tied blue cloth high enough for townspeople to see after water returned. "There will be more."

"How many?"

"Every place the old course presses against a Crown tap."

That could mean dozens between Dunmere and the lock. Pursuit now carried danger outward. Horses striking vents might activate channels, injure villagers, or break the road before the moonbrood reached it.

Oren considered sending a warning to Sillan. The keeper had already placed one dead laborer in the lake. Yet Dunmere needed the locations. He wrote a second note to the reeve directly: KEEP PEOPLE AND STOCK OFF EXPOSED LAKEBED. MARK BUBBLES. DO NOT SING NEAR SILVER OR WHITE GRAIN. He gave it to the riders taking Mera back and ordered delivery by hand.

"Crown secrecy?" Pell asked.

"Does not fill collapsed lungs."

"Belden will call it unauthorized alarm."

"Then he can spell Mera's name while disciplining me."

Rain began again.

Mera said, "Leave me with the mare. Keep after them."

Oren looked west. The cradle's scrape marks faded under rising water. Every minute widened Tavia's lead. Every minute also brought Veyl Lock closer to structural failure.

"Two riders take Mera and Senna back," he said.

Senna objected. "I can ride."

"You cannot stand."

"The order permits losses."

"So does every order written far from mud." Oren tightened her splint. "I do not."

The words came too absolute. He had accepted losses before, including Jeren Sorn under an authorized gate opening. Clean reports turned individual bodies into route conditions. He had not protested because delay might have damaged a grain canal.

Mera watched him. "Captain Belden will count the time."

"He should learn numbers attached to names."

Oren redistributed supplies. Two riders built a drag litter from cloaks and spear shafts. The injured mare could hobble behind. When they started east, Mera gripped Oren's sleeve.

"I left the stone because I wanted to be first through town."

"Remember that longer than the pain."

She released him.

Only Liof and Rider Pell remained for pursuit. Pell had followed despite Oren's earlier rejection by attaching himself to Sillan's town detail, then slipping after the group. Oren considered sending him back. Three people offered better odds if the road failed again; Pell's impatience offered worse ones.

"You step where I step," Oren told him. "Not beside. Not ahead."

Pell nodded, chastened for perhaps the length of one breath.

They resumed west at walking pace. Rising water erased the track behind them. Veyl Lock's towers appeared above a basalt shoulder, less than three miles away.

"Could she mean to break it?" Liof asked.

"If she wanted wilderness, she would have taken high trails. This road leads to the lower lock chamber."

"Why carry the egg toward the Crown's strongest gate?"

"Because the buried river runs through it."

Senna had left Oren a charcoal copy of the funeral marker sequence before turning back. As he walked, he compared each symbol against the old survey in his field book. Eye, open hand, folded fin, westward wave. Crown maps retained the eye as a gauge mark and erased the rest. The symbols did not decorate a road. They gave operating instructions to people moving a living body under water.

At one widened platform, shallow sockets showed where six carriers had once braced poles. A spill groove led safely away from the path into reed beds. Later builders had filled the groove with silver and redirected it north toward keeper farms. Tavia's route followed old risk-sharing infrastructure; Crown alterations concentrated pressure into whatever counterweights officials controlled.

Liof measured the platform with her stride. "Her folding boat can rest here without leaving water."

"Which means she may know more stations ahead."

"Or she reads the road as she goes."

That possibility troubled Oren more. A fanatic followed doctrine past contrary evidence. A practitioner adapted. Tavia had built warning words into her vessel, chosen a route with resting places, and avoided firing riders who stood within arrow range. None made her plan safe, but all made the recovery order's phrase reckless carrier feel deliberately blind.

He unfolded the copied recovery order. Sere's amendment had reached him by rider at Dunmere: clear lower sluices before moving the main gate. The Regent knew a passage might occur. She had not included that knowledge in the original order.

A patch of sailcloth snagged on a stone ahead. Oren lifted it. Charcoal writing crossed the inner side: SONG THROUGH SHELL OR STONE. NEVER THROUGH SILVERED WATER.

Tavia had marked a warning for herself or anyone handling the cradle. It matched what Oren saw at the pressure vent. A held note through silvered water activated paleshell and sent motion into the nearest available body.

"She understands the transfer," he said.

Liof read the cloth. "Better than our keepers."

"Do not make her harmless because she is informed."

"I didn't."

Oren folded the scrap into his pocket. Tavia intended a migration route. She also expected people to survive near it. Those aims could conflict without either being false.

They found the place where the cradle left the funeral track. Two parallel skids climbed a low mud ridge toward an abandoned service culvert. Water flowed out of it, though the surface canal above remained nearly dry. The Nightcourse pressed upward through old masonry.

Pell drew his crossbow. "We can reach the culvert first on horseback."

"Ground won't hold."

"It held their boat."

"A floating cradle spreads weight. Your horse does not."

Pell mounted anyway.

Oren caught his bridle. "Down."

A sound like a deep inhalation moved under the lakebed.

Ash reared. Stone rose beneath her hind feet. The funeral track lifted in a long ridge, throwing water aside. Oren kept hold of the bridle as the mare came down on ground that had not occupied that height a moment earlier.

Cracks raced west toward Veyl Lock, splitting the buried marker line and spilling trapped bubbles from ancient joints. Through them shone blue-white pressure from the buried river.

The Nightcourse lifted the road under his horse.

Chapter 07 — When the First Lock Broke

The egg split as Tavia and Ila dragged the cradle-boat beneath Veyl Lock's eastern arch.

A crack ran from crown to lower curve. Dark fluid flooded the sailcloth basin. The creature inside drove one fin through shell, translucent as river ice and patterned with moving stars.

"Stop pulling," Tavia said.

Above them, keepers shouted from the gate gallery. The buried Nightcourse had lifted the approach road and cracked the lower chamber wall. Water poured through new seams. Every few breaths, pressure struck the main gate hard enough to shake lime from the arch.

Ila set the tow rope around a bollard. "This seems a poor room for a birth."

"Most birth rooms become poor once labor starts."

The cradle rocked. Tavia climbed in beside the egg, water rising above her knees. Her bandaged palms lit through charcoal as she spread them on the shell. Heartbeat filled her hands: slow, powerful, then suddenly quick.

A second fracture opened. One black shell plate lifted. Beneath it lay a narrow head with sealed eyes and folded gills. The mooncalf pushed, slipped in their own fluid, and struck the opposite side of the egg.

Silver answered from the gate.

Lines in the floor brightened. Veyl Lock's harvesting frame descended from the gallery on four chains, a vast cousin to the mechanism Tavia had opened below the lake. Its curved arms reached toward the cradle. Paleshell slurry poured through channels around them.

"Move the boat," Tavia said.

Ila heaved on the rope. The cradle shifted one yard, then stopped as water turned glassy around its hull. First movement from the hatching had activated the frame. The mooncalf's kick hung unfinished. Ila's rope went rigid in mid-swing.

Across the chamber, an oak stair accepted the displaced strain. Its steps twisted, aged, and burst into splinters.

"Cut the slurry!" Tavia shouted to the keepers.

Nobody obeyed. Keeper Haro appeared above, one hand gripping a cracked rail. "Crown mechanism. Stand clear."

"It is drawing from the hatchling."

"That keeps the gate stable."

"It sends their movement somewhere else."

Haro looked toward the western wall. He knew.

The egg shifted again. Silver light traveled outward. In a keeper stall beyond the chamber, something heavy collapsed with a wet crack.

Tavia put her mouth against shell and sang the first low note. Sound entered the egg without crossing loose water. The hatchling turned toward it. She rose to the second note, offering direction. On the third she pressed both hands beside the crack and guided rather than pulled.

A head emerged.

The creature had no horns, no human expression, no sign of legend's judgment. Soft scales covered a blunt brow. Their four-lobed mouth opened and closed in the water. Gills unfurled along the neck, red at first, then translucent. Starlight moved beneath the skin in slow currents.

Only the head and one fin had escaped. The silver frame tightened. Suspended motion held the rest of the body inside shell.

Tavia felt pressure accumulating in her wrists. The cold-light marks linked her to the creature's trapped movement. If she sang through water, the frame would use her note. If she stopped, the mooncalf might suffocate before the next contraction.

"Open the cradle sides," she told Ila.

"Water will spill."

"Let it."

Ila released the bone toggles. Both gunwales dropped outward. Birth fluid and springwater spread across the floor. As the basin widened, the egg rolled away from one silver arm.

The hatchling pushed again. Another plate fell free.

Tavia caught the long body as it uncoiled. The mooncalf came out tail first after the shoulders, a dangerous turn in any species. Their second forward fin remained trapped beneath a band of shell. Tavia slid one arm along the slick flank, found the folded limb, and eased it toward the opening.

"Follow the body," she whispered. "Do not invent a better shape."

The fin cleared. The mooncalf spilled into the opened cradle, eel-long and heavier than a child, four fin-limbs beating water in different directions. Their eyes opened black, with no visible white. Moving constellations brightened along their spine.

Tavia counted breaths by gill movement. One. A pause. Two. Too slow.

She rubbed the chest where it joined the neck. The skin held mountain cold. She cleared membrane from the mouth with two fingers and turned the head toward fresh inflow from a wall seam.

Three.

The creature bit her thumb without teeth, a hard reflexive clamp. Ila laughed once from relief.

"Strong enough to insult you," she said.

"Then strong enough for a name."

Tavia remembered Ossa translating one old word while gutting eels: breath below water. "Nhal."

The name held no title, no promise, no claim that the creature had come for humans. It gave Tavia something to call a body while keeping it alive.

"Nhal," Ila repeated.

Tavia checked the new body from head to tail before allowing wonder any room. Four fins opened fully. The rear left limb lagged but answered touch. Gills showed no tears. A soft seam remained along the belly where yolk vessels had closed. Shell edges had scraped one flank without piercing it. She named each finding to Ila, who wrote them in chalk on the cradle board. A patient deserved a record before becoming anyone's symbol.

At the sound, the mooncalf turned toward the low eastern current, then twisted west. Their whole body strained toward the gate.

The harvesting frame drank that movement.

Nhal froze mid-turn. Silver around the chamber flared. A suspended gate chain stopped rattling. The change debt traveled outward, looking for counterweights through every prepared line.

On the gallery, Keeper Haro's hair whitened at one temple.

A younger keeper dropped as his right knee folded sideways.

"Stop the note!" Tavia shouted.

"It comes from the lock choir," Haro called. "Automatic under breach."

"Then flood their room." Ila seized an axe.

"Too far," Tavia said. "Find the mill bypass. If moving water crosses the singing trough, it may dilute the paleshell."

Ila looked toward the western service door. "That bypass runs to Dunmere."

"Yes."

"Opening it warns the town with water."

"And clears pressure away from them."

Ila took the axe and went.

Boots struck the eastern approach. Tavia heard riders before she saw them. Oren Kest entered beneath the cracked arch leading a mud-covered mare. Liof and Pell followed on foot. Oren took in the opened cradle, Nhal trapped in stillness, injured keepers, and descending silver arms.

"By recovery order," he called, "release the moonbrood and step away."

Tavia kept one hand on Nhal's chest. "Release them to what?"

“Crown custody.”

“The frame is Crown custody.”

Oren’s gaze tracked Haro’s white temple and the fallen keeper’s knee. “Liof, stop the choir.”

The mechanic ran for the upper stair, found it destroyed, and began climbing the maintenance lattice.

Pell raised his crossbow toward Tavia.

Oren pushed the bow down. “No shot into the cradle.”

“She is refusing.”

“The target moves behind her.”

Nhal did not move. That frightened Tavia more than weapons. Their gills had slowed to shallow ripples. Suspended first motion accumulated as debt in the frame.

“Your order says living,” she told Oren. “Watch them stop.”

“Step away and let my mechanic work.”

“Your mechanic understands a frame built to steal from this body?”

“Better than you understand lock collapse.”

The main gate took another impact. Masonry cracked above Oren. He shifted without looking, pulling Pell out of falling stone’s path. His body read danger before rank.

Tavia said, “Lower sluices first.”

Haro leaned over the gallery. “They are sealed under Crown plate.”

“Old hand releases sit beneath the east apron.”

“You cannot know that.”

“I saw the birthing chamber. The same open-hand marks lead here.”

Oren drew Sere’s amended order from his coat. Water had blurred the seal but not the line. “The Regent gives the same sequence.”

Tavia stared. “Then she knows what this place once did.”

“She knows the engineering risk.”

“And still sends a recovery order.”

A groan traveled through the western wall. Every argument became smaller beside it.

Oren crossed halfway to the cradle. “If we open the main gate against blocked lower channels, pressure lifts the lock foundations. Dunmere gets the lake at once. Clear the sluices, then surrender the animal.”

“Nhal.”

“What?”

“Their name.”

His eyes rested on the mooncalf. “Clear the sluices, then surrender Nhal.”

Tavia heard no respect in the concession, but attention had begun.

The injured keeper on the gallery cried out. His knee continued aging in small increments as Nhal’s stored movement sought release. Tavia could not wait for agreement.

“Open the east apron,” she said. “I will keep the song off the water.”

Oren gestured to Liof, who had reached the upper wheel. “Choir first.”

Liof hacked through the leather bellows feeding air to the singing pipes. The held note faltered. Water around Nhal loosened.

Movement returned all at once.

Nhal lashed their tail. The cradle spun. Tavia struck a dropped gunwale and nearly fell. The silver frame took the surge before the song fully died. A channel in the western wall flashed white.

Far away, a bell rang from Dunmere.

Tavia felt rot travel through the palm marks, not into her but past her. Something in town had received the movement. Timber, fruit, animal, person, she could not name it.

“Every second inside this frame spends somewhere,” she said.

Oren’s jaw tightened. “Then help me end it.”

They reached the east apron together. Water covered the carved hand marks. Four iron plates had been bolted over them. Oren and Pell took the upper bolts while Tavia searched below by touch. Her fingers found old grips clogged with silt.

“Six releases,” she said. “Paired.”

“Main chamber plans show four.” Oren pulled a bolt.

“Main chamber plans lie.”

“I am beginning to notice.”

Liof dropped from the lattice and joined them. She examined the plate. “New iron pins cross old stone levers. We remove all at once or the remaining two take full pressure.”

“Tools?”

“Not enough time.”

Oren looked at Pell’s crossbow. “Steel prod.”

Pell recoiled. “It ruins the weapon.”

“Good. Then you cannot aim it at the midwife.”

They stripped the bow and used its prod as a pry bar. Tavia threaded cradle rope through lower grips. Oren tied a rider’s load hitch. His knot held efficiently but

would seize under strain.

"Wrong knot," she said.

"It holds."

"We need it to release." She retied it despite bleeding bandages. "Holding forever kills as surely as opening early."

Above them, Haro organized able keepers around the manual wheels. His injured men remained on the gallery because the destroyed stair trapped them.

"Lower sluice one ready," Liof called.

Tavia braced at the first rope. Oren took the second. Pell and a keeper held the paired levers.

"On the low note," Tavia said.

"You said no singing through water," Oren replied.

"I sing into stone."

She put her mouth against the apron and sounded the first note. Basalt carried it. Nhal answered from the cradle with a body-length shiver. The old handgrips moved.

"Now."

They hauled. Iron pins tore free. The first pair of lower sluices opened six inches.

Water hit them at knee height and knocked Pell down. Oren caught his coat. Mud, shell chips, and dead reeds rushed into the drainage channel. Pressure in the main chamber dropped enough for the gate to settle one finger's breadth.

"Second pair," Tavia said.

The next grips lay deeper. She submerged to reach them. Current pulled at her stiff knee. Through murky water she saw silver lines crossing old carved channels and followed them to a cluster of Crown valves.

One valve routed east toward Dunmere.

The mill bypass remained closed. Ila had not reached it yet.

Tavia surfaced. "If we open the second pair before the bypass, east pressure goes into town."

Oren looked toward the service door where Ila had vanished. "How long?"

"No count I trust."

A horn sounded outside. Crown reinforcements had reached the upper road.

Pell said, "We have more hands."

"We have more weapons," Oren answered. "Hands depend on orders."

He climbed the gallery lattice to intercept them. Tavia returned to Nhal.

The mooncalf moved weakly inside the cradle. The first sluice opening had reduced frame draw, but silver hooks still tracked each fin. Tavia covered Nhal's

eyes with wet cloth. Many newborn animals calmed in darkness. Nhal pushed their brow into her wrist and breathed against the cold-light lines.

A sensation passed through her, not a message: pressure west, heat caught in water, hunger sharp enough to convulse. Nhal sensed the lock's stored change. The frame smelled like food to a body built to release what had been trapped.

"Not yet," Tavia murmured. "That meal bites back."

Nhal opened their four-lobed mouth against a silver channel.

Tavia pulled them away. A drop of stillwater touched their tongue. The chamber lurched.

Rot returned toward its source. In the keeper store, preserved ropes aged and snapped. A barrel of apples fermented hard enough to burst its lid. The harvesting frame shook as old motion came home through its own channels.

Nhal convulsed.

Tavia held the long body without trying to stop every movement. Gills flared. Stars under the scales scattered, then gathered. The sip had strengthened the tail but hurt the gut.

"Source and counterweight," she said aloud for Ossa, for Ila, for herself. "Stored rot from the keeper stores. Ropes and fruit receive it back. Nhal carries the release through their body."

Naming did not make pain fair. It stopped her from calling it miracle.

From the gallery Oren shouted, "Reinforcements holding upper level. Belden wants the cradle seized."

"Does he want the gate standing?"

"He assumes both."

"He can assume from underwater."

Oren almost smiled, then a new crack opened beside Haro.

The gallery tilted. Two keepers slid toward the broken rail. Oren caught one. The other grabbed a chain attached to the harvesting frame.

His weight pulled a silver arm down onto Nhal.

The hook struck just behind the forward fins. Nhal screamed through water. The sound carried no human grief, only pressure so intense Tavia's teeth rang.

She cut the chain with Ila's axe. It took three blows. The keeper fell into the chamber when the chain parted. Oren jumped after him.

Both vanished beneath turbulent water.

Tavia passed Nhal's restraint rope to Liof and dove. Oren had reached the keeper, but a loose gate chain wrapped his boot. Tavia followed the links to a snag under fallen timber. Her knife could not cut iron. She wedged the axe handle, levered once, and freed enough slack for Oren to pull out.

They surfaced with the keeper between them.

Oren coughed. "You should be holding the animal."

"You were a body closer to drowning."

He accepted the rebuke and began rescue breathing. The keeper vomited water after four compressions.

A deep rushing sound came from the service passage.

Ila returned soaked, carrying a red mill flag. "Bypass open. Mill race is running backward. Salo has the high bell."

"Town warned?" Tavia asked.

"Every house below the smoke stairs. Fishwives are clearing reed dams. The miller threatened me with an invoice."

Ila had not merely opened water. She had given Dunmere a route, a signal, and named work.

"Second sluices," Tavia said.

They moved as one group now: Tavia at stone grips, Liof on pins, Ila and Pell hauling rope, Haro's keepers turning wheels above. Oren stood between them and Belden's reinforcements with his sword sheathed and the recovery order in hand.

The second pair opened.

Water surged through the mill bypass. Far east, warning bells changed rhythm as Dunmere's channels filled. The lock floor dropped beneath Tavia's boots. Pressure no longer sought living joints through the east silver line; moving water carried it into emptied mill races and sacrificial reed beds. Reeds tore out. Mud walls collapsed. People had cleared those places first.

"Third pair," Liof called.

These releases had fused. Crown iron and old stone moved as one corroded mass. The main gate bowed inward. Nhal thrashed harder, responding to the western current now audible beyond it.

Tavia examined the final mechanism. "The frame braces across the release bar."

Oren came down from the gallery. "Can we cut it?"

"Not before the gate fails."

"Then move Nhal clear and let the frame hold."

"The frame will keep drawing. The final sluices remain shut."

A choice narrowed around them. Break the silver harvesting works and release Nhal's accumulated first motion into the lock. Preserve the works and let pressure take the foundations, Dunmere, and the mooncalf.

Tavia touched Nhal's brow. The creature turned west.

"I cannot break the frame," she said. "But they can."

Oren looked at the soft-bodied hatchling. "That hook nearly tore them."

"They drank one drop and returned rot through the store. The frame is full of stored movement."

"You want the animal to feed on it."

"I want to guide one bite. No more."

"Where does the change return?"

"To the frame, the lock, and every source it has held. We clear people first."

Oren looked upward. The gallery held six injured keepers and Belden's fresh squad. Seizing Nhal remained possible if he used those hands. Instead he shouted evacuation orders.

"Upper chamber out. East stairs only. Leave gear."

Belden's voice answered from above. "Kest, secure the specimen."

"Gate failure imminent."

"Then secure it before withdrawal."

Oren looked at Tavia. "How long do you need?"

"Enough to sing three notes."

He turned back. "You heard the structural warning. Clear the gallery."

That choice did not make him ally. It made him responsible for the people in reach.

Keepers carried the injured east. Ila checked each lower walkway. Liof opened animal stalls and cut tether ropes. Pell, his crossbow ruined, lifted the keeper Tavia and Oren had pulled from the water.

Tavia refilled the cradle from clean wall seepage. Nhal's gills steadied. She removed the cloth from their eyes and guided their head toward the frame's central silver ring.

"Only what blocks the road," she whispered.

She sang the first note into Nhal's shell fragment, held against the creature's brow. The sound traveled through bone and scale.

Nhal fixed on the silver ring.

The second note rose. Tavia felt the western current beneath the lock, a road compressed into pressure. She gave that direction through her marked palms.

On the third note, Nhal bit.

Stillwater entered them as white fire.

The mooncalf's body arched. Stars under their scales blazed. The silver frame tried to suspend the bite, but Nhal drank the suspension itself. Stored first motion released toward every source.

Chains leaped off wheels. The bowed gate moved the inches it had been denied.

Cracks raced backward through Crown mortar. Preserved beams weathered to their true age and fell, but evacuated galleries held no bodies beneath them. West of the frame, a row of grain casks split as fermentation resumed. Eastward, reeds flattened in the emptied mill race.

Nhal convulsed once. Tavia kept both hands on them and sang the low note without letting loose water carry it.

“Now!” Liof shouted.

The mooncalf lashed their tail into the silver frame.

The central ring broke.

Four arms recoiled. One tore free and smashed the final release bar. The third pair of lower sluices opened together.

Water found the proper sequence.

It rushed through six lower passages before pressing the main gate. The lock foundations settled instead of lifting. Old Nightcourse masonry shed Crown plaster. The western channel opened black and deep beneath the gate.

Then the main gate began to rise.

Not safely. Too much stored pressure waited behind 162 years of closure. The opening surge climbed the eastern apron and struck the Crown road. Horses ran loose uphill. Belden’s supply wagon overturned. On the western side, harvesting sheds collapsed as their silver supports received returned age.

Tavia and Ila held the cradle between them. Oren reached the tow rope as water took their feet. For three breaths, all three carried Nhal’s weight.

A keeper cried from the lower gallery. Haro remained trapped behind a fallen beam.

Oren released the cradle rope.

Pell shouted, “The specimen!”

Oren swam toward Haro.

Tavia saw his decision clearly. Nhal lay within reach, barely restrained after the frame broke. Oren chose the keeper under timber instead.

Ila pulled the cradle toward the opening channel. “Admire him later.”

They freed the final side ropes. Nhal slid from the boat into moving water. For one instant the hatchling circled Tavia’s legs, cold body brushing her marked palms. Then the western current caught them.

Tavia seized the cradle painter. “Keep it. We will need the basin.”

Together she and Ila folded the damaged sides inward while wading. The boat rode low but remained intact.

Behind them, Oren levered the beam off Haro with Liof’s help. Floodwater carried all three toward the east stairs. Belden’s squad threw lines despite their

captain's shouted demand to close the gate.

Closing had become impossible. The broken frame jammed the upper track. Water tore its silver channels from the walls and exposed older carvings beneath: open hands, westward fins, six lower streams beneath one gate.

Veyl Lock's harvesting works folded into the surge. Silver tubes whipped loose. Stored changes traveled back through them. A keeper roof sagged to its honest age. Timbers in the Crown road split where years of structural stalling had postponed rot. The flood damaged what hidden transfers had preserved, not random matter, though random bodies still stood near those sources.

Tavia saw one supply driver swept from a wagon. Ila caught him with the pole. A horse struck the wall and went under. No song or right intention could make the break bloodless.

The main surge passed.

Water remained high but directional. It flowed into the black western opening, no longer battering every wall. Nhal hovered at its threshold, gills working fast. The hatchling's scales had dimmed after drinking the frame. Scales behind the forward fins remained blanched from pressure but unbroken.

Tavia approached through waist-deep water. "Can you move?"

Nhal answered with one pulse. It traveled through her palms and out into the channel.

The mooncalf swam west.

First awkwardly, fins striking stone. Then the current lifted their long body. Moving constellations gathered along the spine and disappeared into darkness.

Ila stood beside Tavia with the half-folded cradle. "Dunmere?"

High bells continued from the east. Three warning peals, pause, three again. Salo's signal meant people had reached smoke-stair elevation. Lower sheds would flood. Houses might. The town remained alive enough to ring.

Oren emerged from the east stair carrying Haro over one shoulder. He set the keeper down, checked breathing, then looked toward the channel where Nhal had gone.

Belden came behind him with drawn sword. "You let it pass."

"I removed people from a failing structure."

"You disobeyed direct recovery."

Oren did not defend himself. Water around his boots carried paleshell dust west.

A pressure note returned from the Nightcourse.

Veyl's basin bell rang once above the ruined lock. Farther west, beyond rock and towns none of them could see, another lock answered. Then another, each note lower and delayed by distance.

Nhal entered the newly opened Nightcourse, and the western locks answered

one by one.

Part II

Chapter 08 — The Market of Spoiled Hours

Tavia held Nhal's gills open while Ila stole a handcart from a Red Step tannery.

They had surfaced through a drainage arch below the town after two days inside the Nightcourse. Nhal lay cramped in the opened cradle-boat, sides extended flat across wet cobbles. Underground current had carried them west faster than any surface barge, but the water between Veyl and Hush had tasted of lime and old metal. Near Red Step it turned purple from dye runoff.

Nhal's gills worked too quickly. Dark residue clung between translucent folds.

"Not stealing," Ila said as she rolled the cart from under a rack of hides. "Borrowing during a medical inconvenience."

"Leave coin."

"I have."

"How much?"

"Enough to insult a generous tanner and delight a dishonest one."

Together they folded the cradle around Nhal and lifted it onto the cart. Tavia poured their last clean bladder across the mooncalf's gills. Stars along the spine steadied but remained dim. They needed food, fresh water, and a larger vessel before returning underground.

Above the tannery roofs, striped awnings filled Red Step's lower square. Bells rang without civic pattern. Hawkers shouted prices that fell each minute. Ila read the painted gate sign and swore.

The Spoiled Hours had arrived.

Tavia knew the traveling market by reputation. Counterweight goods saturated with displaced change could not enter respectable town exchanges, so brokers gathered them under temporary licenses. Poor households bought winter fuel that might age to dust before spring. Healers bought cloth carrying dormant fevers because it cost less than clean linen. Everyone pretended risk became consent when the price sat low enough.

"We can find a water cart there," Ila said.

"We can also find Crown informers."

"Clean water first. Informers after."

They covered Nhal with damp sailcloth and entered the crowd.

Time behaved badly under the awnings. A woman bought six bright pears. Before the seller finished counting copper, one fruit wrinkled in her hand and split around black pulp. She demanded replacement. The seller pointed to a board

reading SATURATION UNKNOWN, PRICE FINAL.

At the next stall, house beams rested on trestles. Their cut ends looked new, but powder sifted from them whenever a shadow crossed. A laborer tested one with his knife. The blade entered sound wood at noon side and dry rot at sunset side.

"Roof repair?" Tavia asked him.

"Flood brace. Needs to last a week."

"It may not last an hour."

"Clean alder costs six times."

He bought two beams.

The choice did not become foolish because danger showed plainly. His house might flood without braces. Poverty forced people to compare immediate collapse against deferred collapse, then let merchants call the result preference.

Nhal shifted under the cloth. The market's accumulated change called to them as heat.

Tavia pressed both marked palms against the cradle. Hunger traveled through the cold-light lines: rot held in fruit, fever caught in cloth, strain banked inside timber, fermentation prevented in sealed jars. Every stall smelled like food to a body meant to release the world's withheld changes.

"Keep moving," she whispered.

A vendor sold saturated fruit from baskets packed in ice. Grapes shriveled while buyers tasted them. Plums went hard as stones, then softened to liquid. Labels named original orchards, transfer dates, and expected failure windows, though half the ink had run.

Tavia picked up one apple with a cloth. A silver puncture scar marked its stem. "What did this receive?"

The vendor, an old man with skin weathered in patches, shrugged. "Orchard rot. Growers still the trees through blight, send the burden into culled fruit, sell the fruit here. Sometimes a little storage age."

"Which orchard?"

"Label says North Rell."

The apple looked twenty minutes from collapse. North Rell's trees remained healthy because their blight and natural decay had been pushed into goods carried miles away. When the goods saturated, poor buyers held the failure.

"Water cart?" Ila asked.

"Third row by the clock seller. Do not buy the blue wheels. Those carry metal fatigue."

The old man noticed the shape beneath their cloth. His gaze sharpened, then moved away. Mercy or calculation, Tavia could not tell.

They passed weathered laborers unloading dangerous stock. One young woman had an old person's hands and a smooth face. A silver routing scar crossed her throat. She carried fever cloth with tongs while her supervisor wore gloves and stood uphill from runoff.

Tavia stopped. "How much change has she received?"

The supervisor said, "Employment matter."

"To her body."

"She signed tolerance."

The worker gave Tavia a tired glance. "I signed for two months' rent. Don't improve me where the boss can hear."

Tavia lowered her voice. "Any numbness?"

"Three fingers. Comes and goes."

"Not if bone weathering caused it. Find House care."

"House of Last Change wants records. Boss keeps the assignment slip."

The supervisor stepped forward. Ila placed a caulking mallet on the cart between them.

"We are shopping," she said.

They moved before help became another cost charged to the worker.

A bell clanged at the center aisle. Market attendants carried in a man on a door, shouting for room. His left side looked forty years older than his right. Gray hair divided his scalp at the middle; one hand had curled with swollen joints while the other still gripped a porter's hook.

Tavia intercepted them. "What failed?"

"Cloth bale," one attendant said. "Marked skin-rash burden. Split when he lifted it."

"Skin rash does not age bone."

The supervisor from the fever stall tried to turn away. Ila blocked him with the cart.

Tavia knelt beside the porter. Breath shallow, pulse rapid, no silver burn visible on the chest. She cut his shirt and found a routing plate strapped beneath his left arm. Three wires linked it to a warehouse permit seal.

"He carried the building's counterweight," she said.

The porter managed, "Bonus work."

"What change did they name?"

"Beam settling. One shift only."

Above the nearest warehouse, a roofline remained unnaturally straight despite rotten supports. When the cloth bale saturated, structural age had sought the

permit's living route and entered the man.

"Take off the plate," Ila said.

"Not yet." Tavia felt the roof's tension through the cold marks in her palms. "Breaking the line may return collapse to the warehouse at full speed. Clear everyone beneath it first."

Market attendants hesitated. Goods represented debts and meals. Tavia stood and pointed to each task. "You, ring collapse warning. You, empty the west stall. Move without running. Ila, loosen straps but leave wire attached."

Specific work overcame disbelief. Bells changed from market time to danger. Sellers dragged baskets into the lane. Buyers carried the injured porter beyond the marked fall line.

Only then did Tavia cut the first wire.

The roof dropped a handspan. Dust burst from windows. She cut the second. Two beams split, but empty floor received them. With the third wire severed, the warehouse settled into its true crooked shape and stopped.

The porter screamed as pressure ceased entering his left side. Received age remained: gray hair, enlarged knuckles, weakness. Tavia checked his pupils and grip. "You need ordinary rest, food, and a bone physician. No stillwater. Another transfer could push the strain into heart or spine."

"Who pays while I rest?"

Nobody answered.

Tavia looked at the supervisor. "His permit held your warehouse."

"He signed."

"For one shift and named beam settling. Your plate carried years of deferred structure."

"Complain to license court."

Ila lifted the man's account box from his belt and found three Crown chits. "We'll begin damages here."

The crowd closed around the supervisor. Not a riot, not yet. Witnesses asked to see permit plates. Workers unfastened collars and wrist bands, comparing stamped burdens with actual injuries. A seller of fever cloth discovered her license routed saturation into two undocumented porters. She sat down among her wares and began to cry.

Tavia could not remain to organize them. Crown pursuit pressed nearer. Leaving felt like repeating the same abandonment she condemned.

She took a chalk board from the collapsed stall and wrote: NAME THE SUSPENDED CHANGE. NAME ITS SOURCE. NAME THE COUNTERWEIGHT. DO NOT CUT A STRUCTURAL LINE BEFORE CLEARING ITS SOURCE. HOUSE CARE WEST HILL.

The young woman with old hands added beneath it: COPY EVERY ASSIGNMENT

BEFORE THE BOSS TAKES IT.

Others began making copies on wrapping paper.

Ila touched Tavia's shoulder. "You wanted many hands."

"I wanted trained ones."

"Training often begins because someone has already been hurt."

They pushed on. At a stall of cheap medicines, stoppered bottles kept fever bark fresh by sending fermentation into cages of mushrooms. Most mushrooms had liquefied. One bottle sweated silver around its neck, searching for another counterweight. Tavia warned the seller to bury it in dry sand, never pour it into a drain.

A row of children sold broken counterweight goods by weight. They wore no shoes because leather near the stock weathered unpredictably. Ila bought all the clean wax they carried and made the stall keeper pay them directly. One child pointed at the covered cradle.

"Big fish?"

"New patient," Tavia said.

"Does it pay?"

"Not in coin."

"Bad patient."

The child's judgment carried more sense than the merchant claims around them.

The water cart had blue wheels.

Its seller promised the fatigue remained cosmetic. Ila lifted one axle, listened, and pushed a knife into a hairline crack. The hub crumbled around the blade.

"Cosmetic," she said. "If one dislikes wheels."

A second cart carried a clean frame but a saturated canvas tank. The cloth sweated yellow liquid that smelled of old fever. A third had belonged to dyers and retained violet stains without active silver trace. Ila bought the frame. Tavia traded two shell-free bronze buckles for a new waxed tank from another stall.

They transferred the cradle aboard behind a screen of rolled carpets. Fresh water came from a public pump beyond the market boundary. Tavia tested it with a changing-water bowl before letting Nhal drink.

A man in a saffron coat watched from the clock seller's stall.

He approached holding a sealed glass tube. "You have shed membrane."

Tavia kept one hand beneath the sailcloth on Nhal's neck. "Many creatures shed."

"None make every clock in Spoiled Hours lose the same second."

Around them, sellers wound mechanisms, compared shadows, and argued. A

hundred clock hands had indeed jumped.

The man smiled. "I deal in medical material. Fresh moonbrood membrane could buy you a clean cart, provisions, permits to Orra, perhaps passage to the coast."

"What would you do with it?"

"Analyze regenerative properties."

"Name the change and counterweight."

His smile narrowed. "Membrane may suspend tissue death. Laboratory animals receive transferred decay."

"Then prisoners after animals saturate."

"I did not say that."

"You stopped before saying it."

The merchant showed her the glass tube. A strip of translucent material inside carried tiny moving lights. He already possessed membrane, likely from the cracked egg or Veyl runoff.

Nhal sensed it. Their head rose beneath the cloth.

"Sell me the rest," he said. "If Crown agents find you, they take creature and evidence without payment."

Ila leaned close. "If you know agents are near, you are already charging for information."

"Information carries risk."

"So does having your wrist broken by a boatwright."

Tavia touched Ila's arm. "No." To the merchant she said, "The membrane belongs to the body that shed it. Fragments already separated may still carry stilling. Keep yours out of water and away from held notes."

"You refuse enough coin to save towns."

"I refuse to fund a second harvesting frame."

His gaze moved toward the market entrance. Two Crown agents in plain gray coats had begun speaking to stall keepers. Behind them, Red Step watchmen lowered chain barriers across three streets.

The saffron merchant stepped back. "Then my information becomes free. East gate closed. Canal gate next."

He vanished between clock cases.

Ila gripped the cart handles. "Dye canals."

"Water is contaminated."

"Streets will contain crossbows."

Nhal shuddered beneath the cloth. Hunger sharpened as market runoff gathered downhill. Purple water carried juice from spoiled fruit, preservative brine, paleshell

dust, and sloughed change from every stall.

Tavia chose the least safe route she could still guide. "Canals, but keep Nhal above runoff."

They pushed into the third row. Agents shouted behind them. Sellers reacted according to experience: some blocked aisles to protect customers, others pointed eagerly at the wet cart. A beam stall collapsed when its owner tried to move stock. Powder filled the lane.

Tavia and Ila turned through fruit baskets. Wheels crushed plums already brown with borrowed rot. Juice ran toward the dye gutters.

A watchman seized the cart rail. Tavia struck his wrist with her recovery hook, enough to release grip without breaking bone. Ila rammed a wheel over his boot.

"Medical inconvenience," she called behind them.

The canal gate began descending.

They needed ten more yards. Tavia pulled while Ila pushed. Her stiff knee sent pain up the thigh. Nhal's weight shifted downhill, stretching cradle ropes.

A bolt hit the cart frame. Another pierced the water tank. Clean water streamed onto cobbles.

Nhal smelled the runoff.

The mooncalf tore through the sailcloth and dropped their head into the purple gutter.

"No." Tavia caught the neck, but Nhal had already swallowed.

Stored change entered them.

Their scales blazed white. The gutter cleared around their mouth. Saturated fruit across the market plumped for one impossible breath as borrowed rot left it.

Then the debt traveled home.

Far northeast, beyond Red Step's walls, North Rell orchard received the blight and decay it had displaced. Tavia could not see the trees, but the transfer moved through her marked palms: silver channels warming under roads, root cells collapsing, preserved branches meeting their true age. Workers near those sources would face falling limbs and spoiled harvest without warning.

In the market, the old vendor's apples became crisp. A buyer laughed until Tavia shouted, "Do not eat them. Change is moving."

Nhal convulsed on the cart. Purple water erupted from their gills. Fruit labels whipped through the air toward the east as pressure followed its source.

The canal gate jammed halfway down. Returned metal fatigue struck its stillwater-preserved chain. One link aged through and snapped.

Ila dragged the cart under. A gray-coated agent followed, reaching for Nhal's tail. Tavia released one cradle toggle. The side panel dropped into canal water between them. The agent stumbled over it and fell without going under.

They entered the dye canal.

Violet water reached the axles. Ila jumped onto the rear board and poled. Tavia held Nhal's head in the leaking clean-water tank, flushing contaminated gills with what remained. Each breath rasped.

"Name it," Ila said, breathless.

"Orchard rot and blight returned northeast. Gate-chain fatigue returned here. Nhal carried both. They are hurting."

"Can you stop the return?"

"No. Only limit the drink."

The answer cut through hope. Nhal did not cure stolen change. They sent it back, consequences included.

Crown agents ran along both banks. Dye workers opened sluice boards ahead, whether from sympathy or desire to keep pursuit out of their vats. Blue, red, and yellow currents divided around the cart. Ila chose yellow because its channel ran deepest.

A low bridge approached. They folded the cradle sides while moving. Nhal lay along the cart tank, longer than before, fins tucked. The bridge scraped sailcloth but not scales.

Behind them, the gray coats commandeered a punt.

Tavia searched the banks for an exit. Painted symbols marked vats, drains, and fire stairs. One sign showed an open hand over a mineral spring.

An old woman sat beneath it selling maps printed on fishskin. She watched the cart emerge from yellow dye and raised a gate pole.

"This way if you prefer not to be arrested," she called.

Ila steered into a drainage cut barely wider than the wheels. The map seller dropped a screen of drying cloth across the entrance. Crown agents passed on the main canal, cursing the dye.

The cut ended beneath her stall. Tavia and Ila pulled the cart into darkness among rolled charts.

Nhal's convulsions eased. Their gills remained stained purple. Tavia changed the water and checked each fold for burns. No tissue had torn, but the stars beneath the scales moved erratically. She counted thirty breaths, felt the belly for hardening, and smelled each outflow for blood. The hatchling pressed one fin over her wrist, holding contact until the cold lights in her palms slowed to match their pulse.

The map seller descended a ladder. She had one clouded eye and fingers stained with six colors.

"You fed a mooncalf from Spoiled Hours," she said.

"They fed themselves before I could stop it."

"Same debt, less flattering sentence."

Tavia looked at her sharply.

The woman pointed to the cold-light palms. "Old trade marks. Haven't seen those outside reliefs."

"You know the Nightcourse?"

"I know maps people paid to erase." She unrolled a hill chart west of Red Step. "Your creature needs clean water and someone who treats returned change without pushing it into another body."

"Where?"

A narrow path climbed from dye canals toward warm springs. The map seller tapped a whitewashed square above them.

"The House of Last Change," she said, while pursuit boots sounded faintly above the hidden stall.

Chapter 09 — A Hunter in the Weathering Ward

Oren pried a blue paving brick from Red Step's Crown depot and found a silver channel warm enough to blister rain.

It ran beneath the floor toward the former dye quarter, away from every public stillwater store marked on his map. Agents around him searched seized market carts for moonbrood traces. Captain Belden had arrived from Veyl with thirty riders, a dry uniform, and orders to pretend the broken lock had resulted from sabotage rather than a living passage.

"Contaminated runoff went west," an agent reported. "Dye workers lost the cart in lower canals."

Belden pointed toward three street exits. "Sweep uphill. Kest, take north drains."

Oren showed him the exposed silver. "This line carried the market release."

"Then mark it for engineers."

"It leaves the depot outside the registered route."

"Your assignment remains recovery."

The heat under Oren's fingers pulsed once. Somewhere north, stored change moved through a body or building.

"I can follow it faster than questioning dye vats," he said.

Belden gave him Liof and two agents, more to supervise than assist. Oren replaced the brick loosely so another investigator could find it, then traced the channel with a compass needle. Silver pulled the needle sideways under alleys, through an abandoned washhouse, and beneath a wall painted with old indigo hands.

The route ended at a brick infirmary whose windows had been filled from inside.

No sign named it. The front door carried a Crown hygiene seal and three locks. A drain at street level released warm water smelling of fever bark, urine, and wet coins.

Liof knelt beside the threshold. "Channel splits inside. Many branches."

One agent checked his list. "Quarantine store. We wait for medical authority."

A knock sounded behind the bricked window.

Three quick strikes. Pause. Two.

Oren knocked the same pattern on the door.

A child's voice answered, "If you're delivering age, use the side chute. We have enough."

The agent went pale.

Oren broke the first lock with his sword pommel. Liof opened the other two using a wire and professional contempt. Warm air pushed out when the door moved. It carried no epidemic stink. It smelled of too many people washed in too little clean water.

Inside, a narrow corridor sloped underground. Silver lines ran along both walls at shoulder height, branching through numbered doors. Some glowed. Every branch ended in a metal cuff, chair, bed frame, or floor plate.

A woman sat in the first room with one young arm and one old. The aged hand rested in a basin because swollen knuckles would not close. Across from her, a ledger clerk recorded pulse and tolerance without meeting her eyes.

"What facility is this?" Oren asked.

The clerk reached for a bell cord.

Liof cut it. "Poor answer."

People emerged from rooms. A man with cataracts under black hair. A pregnant woman whose belly showed ordinary time while her face had weathered decades. Two children supporting an elder who turned out, by voice, to be younger than either. Some wore prisoner gray, others debtor brown, many whatever clothes they had entered in.

Oren counted doors until the corridor turned. More continued beyond sight.

A painted board read REGISTERED CAPACITY: 96. JUVENILE: 18. AVAILABLE ROUTES: 71.

Weathering Ward Seven.

A nurse named Dema arrived from the lower corridor with sleeves rolled above silver burns. She demanded Oren wash before examining anyone and did not change her tone when he showed the Crown badge. That insistence encouraged him more than obedience would have.

"You opened an external door during route activity," she said. "Now close nothing until I inspect pressure."

"Who commands here?"

"Change does. I negotiate."

Dema led them through the first turn. The ward had been built as a dye workshop; old drainage gutters still ran between beds. Crown renovations laid silver along every gutter and converted washing basins into transfer troughs. Residents slept beside routing plates numbered by process rather than person.

At plate F-12, three adults carried fever heat from palace clinics. Water cloths covered their chests. One woman's skin burned while her core temperature measured low, a mismatch Dema attributed to repeated transfers arriving faster than bodies could regulate them. At plate R-03, two men coughed black rot dust whenever distant grain stores received stilling. Neither had worked with grain.

"Treatment?" Oren asked.

"Fluids, food, ordinary fever bark, splints, lung wash," Dema said. "Stillwater would only move their burden into another resident."

"Can routes be paused?"

"Medical office can pause them for six hours. They refuse unless capacity falls below table."

Oren looked at the woman under water cloths. "This falls below any table I recognize."

"The table measures survival, not suffering."

Children occupied the former color-mixing room because its south wall received weak daylight through roof glass. Eighteen narrow beds matched the board's count. Four stood empty, not because residents had left, Dema explained, but because those children could still walk and worked kitchen rotation. Chalk drawings covered the floor between silver lines. Most showed houses with smoke, trees with uneven branches, and people whose two hands matched.

One small boy sorted buttons while a routing cuff aged the hair above his left ear. Dema checked circulation and inserted wool beneath the metal. "He carries cosmetic age from a magistrate's scar treatment."

Oren stopped. "A scar."

"Public-facing office," the ledger clerk offered behind them.

The boy looked up. "Must be a very important cheek."

Another child had no visible weathering until she tried to stand. Her hips moved with an elder's caution. Bone age hid beneath young skin, allowing inspectors to call her load moderate.

"How many died here last year?" Oren asked.

Dema answered before the clerk could. "Nine registered. Two after transfer to unclaimed-remains service, so the official number says seven."

"Families notified?"

"Where records permit."

"Where they do not?"

"Bodies go to medical teaching or lime burial."

The old funeral custom required every visible change named before burial. Ward residents could disappear under a category that named only exhausted capacity.

Liof touched a wall line with the back of one fingernail. "If the moonbrood releases debt, what happens here?"

Dema considered rather than offering comfort. "Some incoming changes return toward beneficiaries and sources. Some loads already altered resident bodies and remain. Channel recoil may injure everyone attached. I would disconnect them, but

abrupt release could collapse buildings or reopen hemorrhage before sources evacuate.”

“So the ward cannot simply open its cuffs.”

“Not safely. Safety has been designed to require continued captivity.”

Oren understood the structure because it resembled a lock. Make downstream lives depend on a gate, then call any challenge reckless.

He had seen the name on the missing Veyl page and Sere’s medical maps. He had let himself imagine a warehouse of fruit, animal tissue, perhaps volunteers under clinical supervision. The human mind defended obedience by furnishing locked rooms with abstractions.

A boy sat on a wheeled stool near the ward kitchen, peeling a turnip with hands shaped by old bone. His spine curved beneath a patched shirt. He looked twelve.

“You’re a rider,” he said.

“Oren Kest.”

“Condolences.”

“Your name?”

“Perrin Doss. Mine is shorter, so I win.”

Dry humor did not soften what the silver had done to his fingers. Oren crouched without touching him. “How long have you been here?”

“Depends whether you count my years or someone else’s. Four calendar years.”

“What change do you carry?”

“Bone aging mostly. Sometimes fever bruises. Once hiccups for three days, but that may have been soup.”

The ledger clerk found enough courage to speak. “Residents receive regulated loads in exchange for debt relief, sentence credit, or dependent support.”

Perrin shaved a strip from the turnip. “I was twelve when I signed. Conveniently, I remain twelve for contracts while my spine explores retirement.”

“You signed?” Oren asked.

“My mother put a thumbprint on something. She could not read. Clerk said I would sort medical linen.”

The clerk retreated behind his ledger.

Oren took out Enna’s hospice token before deciding to. Ceramic blue lay against his muddy glove.

Perrin’s knife stopped.

The boy’s gaze fixed on the punched crescent and seven tiny notches around Enna’s room stamp. Recognition crossed his face, followed by caution too practiced for a child.

"You know this pattern," Oren said.

Perrin resumed peeling. "Palace hospice."

"Which route?"

"Many routes use blue."

"You looked at the notches."

"I like holes."

Oren moved the token closer. "My daughter receives marrow-fever stilling."

Something closed behind Perrin's eyes. He did not reveal the link. "Then she should ask what pays."

"I am asking."

"Here?" Perrin glanced down the branching corridor. "Very advanced of you."

The answer landed because Oren had earned it.

A pressure wave traveled through the silver walls. Several residents cried out at once. The woman in the first room clutched her young shoulder while age spread another inch along the arm. Perrin's fingers tightened until the turnip split.

"What transfer?" Oren demanded.

The clerk checked a dial. "Market channel rebound. Structural and agricultural return. Temporary."

"Source?"

"Red Step depot network."

"Beneficiary?"

"Multiple coded accounts."

"Counterweights?"

The clerk gestured helplessly at the rooms.

Oren followed the strongest branch to a records office. The door carried a medical seal. He broke it.

Rows of assignment strips hung from wire spindles, one for each resident. Every strip named age, tolerance, intake date, and beneficiary code. Names appeared only for the people receiving change. Those whose bodies remained young, unrotted, uncollapsed, or unfevered hid behind letters and numbers.

PERRIN DOSS. JUVENILE. PRIMARY BURDEN: OSSEOUS AGING. BENEFICIARY: PH-11-MF-07.

Oren's token carried room eleven, marrow fever, route seven.

He looked back toward Perrin. The boy had remained outside the office. The connection lay close enough to touch, but Oren lacked a code key and the timeline forbade certainty his fear wanted to seize. Many hospice children might share route notation.

He read other strips.

MARA VENN, AGE 29. STRUCTURAL SETTLING. BENEFICIARY: PH-NORTH RETAINING WALL.

JOR SIL, AGE 8. HEMORRHAGE AND CELLULAR AGE. BENEFICIARY: RS-PRIVATE MEDICAL.

NEDA CAL, AGE 54. FERMENTATION, ROT, FEVER. BENEFICIARY: PALACE FOOD AND CLINICAL RESERVE.

The system joined palace health, buildings, grain, and private clients inside one hidden population. Ethical stillwater required replaceable counterweights and limits. Crown medicine used bodies after fruit, timber, and animals saturated because living tissue carried repeated loads longer.

A side ledger priced each burden. Cosmetic age earned the ward two copper a week, structural settling five, marrow fever eight. Residents received a fraction after food, guards, medical observation, and burial reserve were deducted. Perrin's account showed debt increasing despite four years of service because the ward charged him for splints and a wheeled stool.

Oren turned pages until he found outbound reports. They praised utilization, low escape risk, and improved routing efficiency. Pain appeared only as tolerance variance. Death became capacity closure. No column counted mornings lost, hands unable to close, or children forgetting how their parents looked.

Dema stood behind him. "Copies go to palace medicine every month."

"So Sere knows."

"The Regent's seal authorizes the ward total. Whether she reads individual strips, ask her."

Oren would not let distance grant ignorance automatically. Nor would he invent direct knowledge where paper did not prove it. The seal established policy. The strips established bodies. Responsibility connected them even if no ruler had pronounced Perrin's name.

Liof stood in the doorway. "My aunt disappeared into debtor service."

"Name?"

"Ressa."

They searched the strips. Ressa's record ended two years earlier with CAPACITY EXHAUSTED, REMAINS RELEASED WITHOUT CLAIMANT.

Liof read the line once and walked out before grief could become evidence for watching agents.

Oren found the master beneficiary key locked beneath the desk. Its drawer required two official seals. One belonged to Ward Seven's physician, absent during market closure. Belden or Sere held authority for the other.

He could not open it without destroying the box and announcing exactly what he

had taken. So he copied one assignment strip instead: Perrin's. He laid thin paper over it and rubbed charcoal across the raised letters. The beneficiary code emerged in reverse.

Perrin watched from the corridor. "Planning to rescue one person?"

"I don't know who the code names."

"Yes, you do. You just haven't admitted the size of knowing."

Oren folded the copy. "Why not tell me?"

"Because riders take people toward whatever they love and call the road necessary."

Enna's face entered his mind, annoyed by geese, bruises held still beneath her skin. He had ridden toward Dunmere prepared to use force because preserving her life made every intervening body look like terrain.

"What do you want?" he asked.

"A rear door that opens."

"After that?"

"A sky without bricks would be ambitious."

Boots filled the entrance corridor.

Captain Belden arrived with Royal Physician Mael, six agents, and a sealing crew carrying mortar boards. He looked at the broken records door, the gathered residents, and Oren's open hand around Enna's token.

"You exceeded route," Belden said.

"You concealed a human counterweight ward."

"I concealed nothing assigned to your office."

"Malven Dorr died through a line supplied here. Senna's ankle took pressure on a route your register removed. Children carry palace medicine."

Physician Mael stepped forward. "Residents have contracts and tolerance schedules."

"Perrin was twelve."

"Dependent consent permits juvenile assignment under hardship statute."

Perrin called from the kitchen, "I consent to the physician eating my turnip."

Nobody laughed except Liof, once.

Belden lowered his voice. "The market incident has exposed a route. Seal the facility until channels stabilize."

"Seal records?" Oren asked.

"Seal the building."

"With residents inside."

"Opening external doors during a rebound risks uncontrolled transfer into Red

Step. Medical staff will remain.”

Mael looked surprised by the final sentence, which meant staff had not volunteered.

Oren walked to the front threshold. The sealing crew already laid brick across the door, leaving a food hatch. Outside air narrowed strip by strip.

“Where is the emergency exit?” he asked the ward clerk.

“Rear laundry court.”

Belden said, “It remains locked.”

“For fire?”

“Fire can be stilled.”

“Into whom?”

Belden’s silence gave the answer.

A new pulse hit. Somewhere in the ward a child screamed. Silver channels flared around a door marked J-14. Mael ran toward it, proving at least that his training could overcome policy when pain had a voice.

Oren moved the other direction.

Belden caught his arm. “Your daughter’s suspension depends on this network.”

“I know.”

“Then do not pretend destroying routes leaves your hands clean.”

“I am opening a fire door.”

“You are compromising quarantine during active rebound.”

“Name the disease.”

Belden tightened his grip. “Secrecy prevents riot, seizure of medical stores, and uncontrolled line cutting. You saw a warehouse collapse in the market. Imagine that across Bellhaven.”

The argument held truth. Exposing or cutting channels without clearing sources could kill people. Keeping residents bricked inside so the system survived also killed them, slowly and usefully.

Oren removed Belden’s hand. “Then guards control the rear court. Door stays open.”

“That is not your order.”

“No. It is my consequence.”

He did not draw a weapon. He walked away while Belden decided whether to arrest him in front of ninety-six witnesses.

The laundry court lay behind two iron doors. One had rusted shut. Liof found tools. Perrin directed them to a maintenance wheel hidden behind stacked sheets.

“Turn left,” he said.

Liof tried. "Jammed."

"Everyone says that before using both hands."

Oren and Liof turned together. The wheel moved. Old latches withdrew from the rear door with a series of knocks.

Sunlight entered the weathering ward.

Residents did not rush out. Years of locked routes had taught them every opening might conceal another assignment. Perrin rolled his stool to the threshold and put one aged hand into sun.

"Still there," he said.

Belden reached the laundry court. Agents filled the passage behind him.

"I can arrest you," he told Oren.

"Yes."

"Then why are you still holding the Crown copy of the recovery order?"

Because Oren had not yet found a way to keep Enna alive outside the system. Because Tavia's mooncalf could release the channels violently and kill ward residents along with beneficiaries. Because pursuit remained the only route toward the creature changing all these sums.

"I continue the assignment," he said. "The rear door remains open under guard. No resident removed by force. No record burned."

Belden looked at the gathered faces. Arrest here could turn concealed capacity into witnesses. "One hour of court access. Then medical seal."

"Four."

"Two."

Oren accepted two because it moved air now. Compromise tasted worse when measured against bodies, but refusing it would close the door immediately.

Perrin said, "Heroic. We have negotiated sunlight."

"I am not your hero."

"Good. Heroes never copy the useful paper."

The boy's gaze dropped to Oren's pocket.

Oren left water, two agents he trusted least little, and written orders naming every resident as a protected witness. He could not know whether Belden would honor them after pursuit resumed. He knew only that the rear door stood open when he departed.

At the depot, Ash waited beside Liof's horse. Crown reports placed Tavia and Ila on the west hill road with a water cart. The House of Last Change lay above them.

Oren mounted. Enna's token rested against his chest. Perrin's copied code waited in his inner pocket, separate from the official recovery order.

He continued the pursuit carrying a copied assignment strip.

Chapter 10 — House of Last Change

Nhal struck the bottom of the cradle-boat hard enough to throw black water over Tavia's wrists.

She caught the mooncalf behind the forward fins and nearly lost them again. Their body had gone rigid from throat to tail, each translucent scale holding a pinprick of cold light. The borrowed handcart jumped beneath the folded skiff. Ila shouldered it uphill while the wheels ground into the mineral road.

"Keep their head in," Tavia said.

"I am keeping everything in that can be kept." Ila leaned her whole weight against the cart. "Where is the holy house?"

White buildings climbed the hillside above them, broad-windowed and plain, with steam lying over the roofs. No silver glimmer showed along the walls. People crossed between infirmaries carrying laundry, kettles, splints, and baskets of root vegetables. At the nearest doorway, an old woman rang a copper handbell once.

A young man in a boiled linen apron came running. He saw Nhal and stopped for only a breath.

"Warm pool," he called over his shoulder. "Lower surgery room. Bring every clean cloth we have."

"Brother Caun?" Tavia asked.

"Today." He seized the cart rail beside Ila. "What did they drink?"

"Runoff at Red Step. Stillwater carrying orchard rot, timber strain, cloth fever, probably more. It went back east when they drank, but some stayed in them."

Caun did not ask whether she believed that. "How long ago?"

"Half a day. The spasms began after sunset."

Together they drove the cart beneath a whitewashed arch. Warm mineral air pressed against Tavia's face. Nhal convulsed again, tail whipping a crack through one of the funeral skiff's ribs. Tavia kept her scarred palms under their jaw until the movement passed.

The lower room held a stone pool fed by a spring pipe. Attendants shoved a trestle aside and swept floating herb bundles from the water. Caun tested the pool with his bare arm, then directed the cart down a ramp until the cradle-boat floated free.

"No stillwater," he said. "Not even for pain. If anyone brings a silver vial through that door, break the vial outside and send the fool to me."

One attendant nodded and ran. Another helped Ila unfold the skiff's cracked side. Tavia climbed into the pool without removing her boots. Warmth struck the rope burns in her palms, and pain opened cleanly through both hands.

Nhal rolled. Their gills worked too fast. Black threads clouded the water around them, not blood but change made briefly visible: rot feathering like mold, a shudder of heat, the dry sound of timber splitting where no timber stood.

"That belongs elsewhere," Caun said.

"Orchard east of Red Step for the rot. A roof beam somewhere for the strain. Fever could belong to anyone who handled the cloth before it saturated."

"Then we do not move it again." He pointed to the mooncalf's throat. "We help the body pass what it can, and we name what it cannot."

He ordered salt in measured handfuls, cool spring water through the gills, and strips of wet linen beneath the fin joints. Nothing vanished. The heat entered the pool and raised steam. Rot blackened three herb bundles, which Caun removed with tongs and laid in a marked clay tray. A spasm traveled from Nhal into the cradle-boat and split another old rib rather than entering a patient down the hall.

Tavia understood the choice. The skiff paid in wood already dead. The herbs paid in leaves grown for medicine. The room accepted the heat. No prepared channel reached for a child beyond the wall.

"Again," Caun said when Nhal's gills caught.

Tavia sang three low notes into the water. The first steadied their head against her palms. The second passed through the stone pool and made every copper basin in the room tremble. On the third, Nhal released a rope of silver-black mucus. It smelled of bruised apples and hot lime.

Their body softened.

Ila sat down abruptly on the ramp. "If the next stage smells like a tannery, I resign from moon work."

"Your resignation may be entered after the patient stops dying," Caun said.

That earned half a laugh from her. Tavia had no room for one. She kept two fingers over the fine pulse below Nhal's jaw and counted until it slowed.

Only then did Caun look at her hands. "Now you."

"They need watching."

"So do you. You have burned through the skin twice and ground road dirt into it."

"I know what my hands look like."

"Excellent. It shortens the consultation."

He sat her on the ramp beside Ila and washed each palm with boiled water. The burns from Veyl Lock traced pale ropes through older scars. Several cracks had opened during the climb. Caun used no numbing vial. He picked out grit with a bone needle, packed the deepest splits with honey and ground yarrow, and wrapped her hands loosely enough to preserve movement.

Pain remained where it belonged. Tavia found that almost restful.

Caun made her walk the infirmary before he allowed her near the records. The House had no single ward for the hopeless and no polished room for those able to pay. A mason with a crushed foot lay beside a canal assessor coughing blood into a clay cup. Two women took turns holding a feverish laundress upright while an attendant changed the wet bedding beneath her. By the western window, a boy practiced bending a leg newly freed from a splint. His mother counted each attempt and wrote the count on the wall slate.

"You show visitors this on purpose," Tavia said.

"We show ourselves." Caun checked the mason's toes for warmth. "Secrecy begins as kindness more often than people admit. Someone says the wound will upset the family. Someone else says the dead should look peaceful. Soon the cost has vanished from every room except the one where a stranger pays it."

At a tiled stove, an attendant boiled cloth stained with Nhal's black discharge. Heat killed what could spread. The fire consumed alder billets brought from a managed grove, and smoke left through an ordinary chimney. Caun named each cost when Tavia asked: wood, labor, water, the attendant's sleepless hour. None traveled through silver toward an absent body.

One patient asked for stillwater while they passed. His broken pelvis had shifted during the cart ride, and his voice came thin through clenched teeth. Caun knelt where the man could see him.

"I can give willow bark, set the bone, and stay," he said. "I cannot put your pain into someone you will never meet."

The man cursed him. Caun accepted the curse, called for three more hands, and began arranging straps for the setting.

Tavia helped despite her bandages. Her palms paid for the grip, the attendants paid with effort, and the patient paid most of all. They did not call the division fair. They only kept it visible. When the bone settled, the man's shout rang through every clean corridor in the House. Nobody closed a door to hide it.

Across the pool, Nhal drifted within the cradle-boat. Their scales dimmed from hard starlight to the softer gleam of fish under deep water. Each breath still carried a tremor, but the tremor no longer seized the entire body.

"How do you record this?" Tavia asked.

Caun tied off the second bandage. "Precisely."

He led them upstairs once Nhal could be moved. The House kept its records in a long room beside the communal kitchen. Shelves held paper rolls, bound ledgers, slates, jars of shed teeth, locks of hair, tumor stones, and splints labeled with dates. Steam from soup kettles mingled with the scent of ink.

No clerk hid the patients behind codes. A board listed births, fevers, broken bones, recoveries, and deaths from the previous week. Beside each entry appeared the treatment, the bodily change observed, and the material spent.

Three names had small black circles beside them. Nobody had softened those deaths into a word like passing.

Caun opened a fresh page.

"Patient: Nhal," he said.

Tavia watched his pen. "Moonbrood. Newly hatched."

"Source of injury?"

"Stored change taken from runoff at the Spoiled Hours. Orchard decay, structural strain, fever, unknown lesser transfers."

"Counterweights used here?"

She glanced toward the lower room. "Dead skiff timber. Cut herbs. Water heated by released fever. Nothing living by design."

His pen scratched across the page. "Outcome?"

"Alive. Uncertain."

He wrote that too.

At the far end of the table, Ila had found a ledger of fever treatments. She turned pages with the care of a boatwright checking thin planks. "You keep failures where anyone can read them."

"A failure buried in a cupboard comes back dressed as confidence," Caun said.

Tavia moved beside Ila. One page described marrow fever in a child of ten. No stilling had been used. The treatment listed broth, marrow-supporting herbs, sterile drainage, transfused blood from six named adults, and months of weakness. The child had survived. Two pages later another child had died under the same protocol.

The House had preserved both names.

Oren's sick daughter existed only as a hospice token in Tavia's knowledge, a small weight he carried against his orders. She did not yet know the illness. Still, she marked the page with a strip of reed paper. A method that admitted death differed from a promise funded by an unseen body.

Caun returned carrying a shallow stone dish. Water in it clouded when he placed the dish near Nhal's side.

"Their gill edges have begun to pearl," he said. "Not harden. Not yet."

Tavia looked up. "You know the sign?"

"We kept fragments of the old lake-midwife records after the Crown burned the eastern houses. Most people here thought they described a ritual calendar. I thought so yesterday."

He brought out a narrow book made from stitched fishskin. Its drawings showed a hatchling at several stages: soft gills, pearled rims, closed gill fans, then a still body on dry salt. A column of notches ran beside the images.

Tavia counted them twice. "Twenty-three."

"Days from shell-break to the end of the drowned-moon eclipse." Caun touched the newest notch he had added. "Your patient hatched at Veyl on Day 2 of your flight. By our reckoning, today gives you until Day 23. After that, their gills harden. The sea change cannot begin."

The deadline entered her body like a tightened cord. She had known they were moving toward danger. She had not known the danger possessed a date.

"How far?" Ila asked.

"By Crown road, under ordinary water, less than eighteen days. Neither condition applies."

Caun crossed to a locked cabinet. Instead of silver, the lock used three wooden pegs set at different depths. He opened it and removed a broad route ledger wrapped in oiled cloth.

The cover showed seven circles connected by a wavering line.

"Old service routes," he said. "Spring chambers, burial stairs, channels the lock builders sealed or renamed. Some entries predate the Crown. I can read the House marks. Your songs may tell us which waterways remain alive."

Tavia did not reach for it. "You said us."

"I did."

"This is not sanctuary work."

"It became sanctuary work when a living patient arrived carrying half a market's stolen decay."

Ila closed the fever ledger. Her hands rested flat on its cover. "Then we need more than a route. Every lock that opens sends water into somebody's kitchen."

Tavia heard the turn before Ila spoke it. They had worked together too long for surprise to hide inside politeness.

"You want to go back," she said.

"I want Dunmere to clear its lower channels before the next surge. I want Red Step to stop piling carts along a flood stair. I want every town east of Bellhaven to hear what happened at Veyl from someone who stood there." Ila's voice roughened, but it did not weaken. "Following you west lets me mend one boat. Going east might move a hundred."

Nhal stirred in the cradle beside them. The damaged skiff creaked under their weight.

Tavia wanted to say no. Ila knew flood marks, hull balance, the bad habits of lock keepers, and when Tavia's stubbornness had crossed into stupidity. Wanting her close did not make the eastward work smaller.

"Salo will call you a fool," Tavia said.

"He married me with current knowledge."

"The Crown road will be watched."

"So I take the funeral tracks. You taught half this kingdom to ignore them."

Caun spread a blank sheet beside the ledger. Together they listed the first instructions: clear lower sluices before any main gate moved; mark roof heights in lime; keep children and immobile patients above the second flood stair; use bells in sequences rather than a single alarm; place no one beneath old masonry when stored strain returned. Ila added which boat designs could survive falling water and which would roll.

They named who might listen in Dunmere, Red Step, and the hamlets between. Tavia refused "local hands" until each line carried a person. Costs without names had built the weathering wards.

Near dusk, Ila repacked her tools. She left the collapsible cradle-boat, her narrow adze, and the blue cord she used for measuring ribs.

"Bring the cord back," she told Tavia. "The adze can find its own prospects."

Their embrace hurt Tavia's palms and her stiff knee and something farther in. Ila smelled of road mud, alder shavings, and the sharp soap used in the House kitchens.

"Day 23," Ila murmured beside her ear. "Do not make me organize all those fools for nothing."

"I won't."

"That sounded like a promise made by someone who has met no fools."

Ila went east under the first dim stars, carrying copies of the sluice instructions in an oilskin tube.

Caun barred the outer arch after her. Tavia returned to the lower infirmary and sat beside Nhal. Their pulse remained uneven but present. On the table, the old route ledger waited unopened beyond its first page.

Hoofbeats came up the mineral road after full dark.

No alarm bell sounded. Sanctuary custom allowed any injured person to reach the arch before judgment. Tavia rose, hands throbbing inside fresh cloth, and took Ila's adze.

Through the broad infirmary window she saw a single rider dismount beneath the copper bell. Oren Kest looked smaller without a troop behind him. Mud blackened his coat. One cheek carried a fresh cut. He removed the short lock-blade from his belt, set it on the threshold, and stepped back.

Then he unbuckled his longer weapon.

Oren placed it beside the first and raised both empty hands. Brother Caun opened the viewing slot but not the door.

Outside the infirmary, beneath the House's record of every life it had failed to preserve, the Crown's hunter waited with empty hands. Above him, a painted

sanctuary rule said that any armed visitor lays down his weapon before asking shelter. Oren had obeyed it. Tavia tightened her grip on the adze and watched Caun lift the bar.

Chapter 11 — The Map in a Midwife's Hands

Tavia set Oren's lock-blade on the table between them and kept its edge pointed toward the wall.

Morning had not yet reached the House's lower windows. Four lamps lit the record room, their wicks turned low to spare oil. Oren sat on a backless bench with his empty hands visible. Caun stood at the door. Sanctuary custom had admitted the hunter, fed him, searched him, and refused to decide whether he deserved any of those things.

Nhal rested in the adjoining mineral pool. Through the open doorway came the irregular tap of their tail against the cradle-boat.

"Begin with the ward," Tavia said.

Oren looked at the wrapped burns on her palms before meeting her eyes. "Red Step depot carried a silver channel beneath its north wall. I followed it into a sealed dye quarter. Ninety-six people lived inside. Eighteen children."

Caun's face changed at the numbers, not dramatically, but enough for Tavia to see that he would remember each one.

"What did the channel carry?" she asked.

"Change taken from Crown treatments. Age. Fever. Bone strain. Bleeding. The residents had assignment marks keyed to beneficiaries elsewhere." Oren drew a folded strip from inside his shirt and placed it beside the blade. "I copied this before my superior sealed the ward."

The paper held columns of numbers and tiny hooked marks cut by a keeper's stencil. Several entries had been overwritten until the fibers shone thin. Tavia did not touch it yet.

"Sealed how?"

"Doors barred. Food left for six days. No messengers permitted."

"And after six days?"

A muscle moved in Oren's cheek. "No order addressed after."

"You opened a rear door."

His gaze sharpened. "Who told you?"

"You came here without your riders. Either you murdered them all, or you did something the Crown dislikes more than murder."

Caun made a small sound that might have objected to the logic. Oren only nodded.

"I delayed the sealing," he said. "Some residents got out. I don't know how many. The keeper captain saw me."

"Then why keep following us?"

"Because breaking the locks without sequence will bury lower Bellhaven. Because the thing in your pool draws stored change toward itself. Because my daughter receives stilling care from the same system I found under Red Step." Each answer came clipped, as though he had inspected it for hidden leverage before releasing it. "And because you have no complete map."

Tavia slid the weapon farther from him. "That last one sounds like a man asking to be useful."

"I am."

"Useful men have drowned more people than useless ones."

"I know."

His agreement unsettled her more than a defense would have.

She picked up the assignment strip. Silver dust clung to the creases. The first column named ward rooms by number. The second carried dates. A third paired each resident with a beneficiary code, then divided transferred change into units: marrow heat, years of bone wear, scar closure, suspended bleeding. A child's line bore thirty-seven renewal cuts.

"Do you know these people?" Tavia asked.

"One. Perrin. He recognized the pattern on Enna's hospice token. He wouldn't tell me more."

The name pulled at the page she had marked in the House ledger. "What illness does Enna have?"

Oren did not ask how she knew the token belonged to his daughter. "Marrow fever."

Caun moved from the doorway. "We have treated it."

Hope crossed Oren's face with such naked force that Tavia almost looked away. It vanished behind discipline a breath later.

"Successfully?"

"Sometimes," Caun said. "Not cleanly. Not without danger, pain, and months of care. Our ledger keeps both survivors and dead."

"She has no months without stilling."

"Perhaps not. I will not offer a promise purchased from a child under Red Step."

Oren's fingers closed against his knees. He did not challenge Caun. That restraint earned him no forgiveness, but Tavia placed it among the facts.

"Your order called Nhal a living paleshell source," she said. "Did you know what that meant?"

"Not when I received it."

"You knew the Crown wanted them alive."

"I believed restraint offered more chances to prevent a flood than killing did."

"And Saint Orra?"

This time his silence lasted.

Caun shut the record-room door.

"The sealed command mentioned a grinder," Oren said. "Preparation only. I told myself it meant processing old shell."

"Did the order say old?"

"No."

The taps from the mineral pool ceased. Tavia turned toward the doorway until Nhal's tail struck wood again.

A clean order transferred responsibility upward. Oren had carried that belief in the set of his shoulders from Dunmere to Veyl Lock. Now it sat poorly on him, like a coat taken from a dead man.

"Sanctuary gives you a bed," she said. "It gives you food and ordinary care. It does not give you our route."

"Then ask what buys it."

"Nothing buys it. You may earn the chance to stand near the decision."

Oren glanced at his blade. "By doing what?"

"For now, by answering everything."

They questioned him until the lamps guttered. He named the riders, depot clerks, keeper captains, road stations, and sealed orders he could recall. Where memory failed, he said so. Tavia made him distinguish what he had read from what he had assumed. Caun copied the assignment strip without translating its beneficiary marks. They would not attach innocent names to uncertain codes.

When daylight grayed the windows, Nhal called from the pool.

The sound entered through water pipes as pressure rather than voice. Ink rippled in the wells. Oren stood before he could decide not to, then stopped with both hands lifted away from the table.

Tavia watched him hear the animal he had pursued. Fear passed through him. So did recognition.

"Their gills are failing by degrees," she said. "Day 23 ends the chance of sea change. If they die here, the stored water stays stored until it breaks elsewhere."

"If they reach the sea?"

"Night changes. Tides change. Dreams, according to the old records. I know what happens to Nhal. I don't know every consequence for us."

"Good," Oren said quietly.

"Why good?"

"Because everyone who gave me an order knew every consequence before it happened."

Caun brought the old route ledger from its cabinet.

They moved to the kitchen's longest table after breakfast. Patients and attendants had cleared it, though several stayed along the walls to witness. The House did not make secret plans easily. Caun unwrapped the fishskin ledger. Oren laid his keeper road maps beside it. Tavia contributed Ila's blue measuring cord and a basin of water wide enough to hold the old pages' reflection without wetting them.

The ledger did not resemble a Crown map. It measured routes in breaths held underwater, bell intervals, rope lengths, and the time needed to carry a laboring body between warm pools. Seven circles ran east to west. Between them, branching channels had been drawn in inks made from soot, shell, and powdered root.

Caun named the Seven Locks in order: Veyl, Hush, Red Step, Bell, White Root, Orra, Sea Gate.

Oren touched each corresponding mark on the modern chart. "Hush holds the drinking reservoirs for six canal towns. Red Step supports the market terraces and two grain mills. Bell carries the western wall of the capital. White Root feeds the underground cisterns. Orra controls the pilgrimage island. Sea Gate holds salt surge outside the lower basin."

"And Veyl carried Dunmere until it didn't," Tavia said.

"Yes."

She laid the blue cord over the old line. It passed beneath each circle rather than stopping at it. The Crown roads followed the lock tops. The older route ran under foundations, surfaced in side pools, and reentered channels that modern maps omitted.

"Nightcourse," Caun said. "Not one river. A sequence of birthing reaches."

The word birthing had become decoration in later copies. Tavia could see how. Anyone accustomed to gates thought a route required force. Anyone who had delivered a child knew the body opened by stages, with pauses that mattered as much as pressure.

She placed seven cups along the table to represent the lock basins. Kitchen workers filled them from a kettle. Between each, she laid folded strips of cloth for lower channels. Oren supplied wooden spoons as gate arms.

"At Veyl, opening the lower sluices first saved the town from the direct surge," she said. "Not the Crown road. Not the harvesting works. Bodies and houses."

Oren tipped the first cup. Water crossed the cloth into the second without knocking it over.

"If Hush stays shut," he said, "the upper pressure piles against its old eastern wall. That wall sends strain into the drinking reservoir."

"What receives the strain now?"

"Prepared timber beneath three keeper houses, until it saturates. After that, whatever the silver channels reach."

Caun marked the counterweight beside Hush. They did the same for Red Step's mill brakes, Bell's foundation piers, White Root's reservoir masonry, Orra's pilgrim halls, and Sea Gate's salt doors. Every lock suspended motion and structural failure. Every suspension had been routed somewhere that could break instead.

Tavia refused the word manageable whenever Oren used it without a noun. "Manageable for whom?"

He answered each time. Sometimes the answer shamed him. Sometimes it shamed all of them.

By midday, the cups had soaked the table. Their first three attempts flooded the flour chest below it. A kitchen worker moved the chest and told them any plan unable to survive a wet floor did not deserve a kingdom.

On the fourth attempt, Tavia held the first spoon while Caun cleared the cloth channel. Oren delayed the second cup until the first had dropped below a charcoal mark. Water passed east to west in pulses.

"Sequence," Tavia said. "Not smashing."

"Each lower channel needs clearing before its main gate moves," Oren replied. "Each settlement needs warning. Keepers must know the pressure from the previous reach before they open theirs."

"And someone must stand there who can refuse if the people below have not moved."

Caun began a separate list for messengers, bells, boats, high rooms, immobile patients, and livestock paths. No names filled the leadership lines yet. Tavia left them blank rather than writing towns as though stone possessed hands.

The old ledger held another puzzle near Orra. A full-page relief sketch showed a woman waist-deep in water, one palm against a moonbrood's jaw. The creature curved through a side passage beside the sixth lock. Later ink had covered the passage with a spear shaft and altered the woman's guiding hand into a fist.

Oren fetched a printed pilgrimage image from the House library. In the Crown version, Saint Orra stood over a pinned beast. Chisel marks rendered the side passage as decorative waves.

"A guide-channel," Caun said, reading the old label.

Tavia traced it without touching the fragile page. The guide-channel ran behind the lock chamber, bypassed a grinding room marked with toothed circles, and rejoined the Nightcourse below Orra.

"They carved it out of the story," she said.

"They plastered over parts of the real wall too," Oren said. "I guarded the Orra procession five years ago. The west relief sounded hollow when the crowd struck it with blessing rods."

The grinder command returned to the table between them.

Nhal swam into the kitchen pool fed by the spring pipes. Their head rose beside Tavia's elbow, gills still trembling. They pressed their jaw against the underside of the table. Water in all seven cups began to quiver.

The pulse moved from Veyl's cup toward Hush, stopped, then pressed again. Nhal could sense the blocked course through stone and distance. Their hunger supplied force. It supplied no judgment about who lived below the gates.

Tavia rested her wrapped hand on the tabletop above their head.

"We do not let them choose alone," she said.

Oren considered the soaked map. "Nor me."

"Especially not you."

A dry edge entered his expression, almost humor. "Conditional trust continues to inspire."

"You don't have conditional trust. You have supervised usefulness."

Caun assigned Oren a pallet near the outer arch, where he could not reach Nhal without passing two staffed rooms. Oren accepted. He offered keeper ciphers for road notices and the signal patterns used to close lock causeways. In return, Tavia allowed him to see the copied route lines, not the original ledger.

Before she trusted even those copies, she took him to the House's upper cistern. The route ledger showed an old spring outlet beneath the herb terraces, while Oren's Crown chart labeled the same space as solid hill. Caun stayed with Nhal. Tavia carried the copied page under her coat and made Oren walk ahead where she could see his hands.

Rain had begun, slight and cold. Patients had laid crushed eggshell along the path for grip. The cistern occupied a limewashed chamber open on one side to the valley. A stone lip divided drinking water from the hotter surgical spring. Neither pool held silver.

Oren knelt beside the west wall and brushed moss from three plugged holes. "Keeper drains. Older than the current road."

"The ledger calls them breathing mouths."

"A builder's name for pressure relief. Crown engineers stopped using it after the lock code standardized."

Tavia gave him Ila's blue cord. "Show me what the standard improved."

He measured from the cistern lip to the central plug, then paced the wall. His left boot found a hollow place under the paving. Together they lifted two slabs with an iron hook borrowed from the herb shed. Below ran a narrow stone channel furred with white mineral scale.

Water moved west in darkness.

Tavia lowered her bandaged fingers close enough to feel the cool draft. The

channel's pulse arrived in pairs, unlike Nhal's three-note rhythm. "Where does it go?"

"Into an abandoned feed above Bell basin, if the old grade held. The House spring would once have joined a side channel near Hush."

"Would opening it flood the infirmary?"

Oren studied the mineral lines. "Clearing it all at once might drain the surgical pool. A partial opening could carry a signal, but someone would have to watch the cistern level and replace what leaves."

There lay the kind of answer she needed. Not yes. Not safe. A named risk, a body assigned to watch it, and water visibly spent.

She made him remove only the smallest plug. Scale broke with a brittle sound. A thread of warm water entered the hidden channel. Steam rose from the opening, drifted west, and vanished beneath the terrace.

Far below them, Nhal answered through the pipes.

The pressure note shook droplets from the roof tiles. Oren put one palm to the floor. His face tightened as the vibration entered bone.

"That can travel farther than a bell," he said.

"A bell tells people to obey whoever rings it. A song can carry instructions only if people learn what the notes mean."

"Then every lock needs listeners as well as keepers."

A woman from the infirmary had followed them on crutches. She wore a fresh amputation wrap below one knee and carried a slate under her arm. "Every plan made in a map room eventually needs somebody in the rain," she said. "Write down who."

Tavia handed her the chalk.

The woman drew three columns on the slate: person, task, cost. Under the House spring she wrote her own name, Merra Vos, then added watch cistern level and risk loss of surgical water. Tavia had not asked her to volunteer. That mattered. So did Merra's right to cross out the line later.

They returned to the kitchen with the slate and changed the planning sheet. Each proposed opening now required a watcher, a messenger, a person responsible for the downstream flood stairs, and a named material counterweight where stilling remained. No task could hide behind a town's name. Blank spaces multiplied faster than assignments.

Oren did not complain that the method slowed them. He added a fifth column for authority to stop. Beside every lock he wrote that the downstream lead could delay the sequence if evacuation failed.

"The Crown will call that mutiny," he said.

"What do you call it?"

His chalk paused. "A command clean enough to survive the person who gave it."

Their plan remained more holes than cloth. Ila could carry instructions east. Caun knew House contacts west of Bellhaven. Oren could identify lock mechanisms and keeper loyalties. Tavia could read Nhal's body and the old birthing measures. Merra and the watching patients knew what institutional promises looked like from a bed. None could clear seven towns alone.

By evening they had one decision: travel toward White Roots, where the old ledger marked spring chambers connected to the Nightcourse. From there, messengers could reach surface roads without using Crown gates. Before moving, they would copy instructions for controlled release and send them by every House traveler willing to risk the roads.

A bell rang at the outer arch.

Not the single note for a patient. Three fast strokes announced a Crown notice.

Caun went out and returned with a wet broadside nailed to a board. The courier had not waited. Red wax carried Sere Valec's seal above a woodcut of black water swallowing houses.

Tavia read the first lines standing beside the seven cups.

The Regent named Nhal a dangerous harvested creature. She promised grain and safe passage to anyone who reported the party. Oren's name appeared under a charge of desertion. Brother Caun and the House received warning against sheltering enemies of public order.

Then the proclamation named Tavia Sorn of Dunmere.

It did not call her a midwife. It called her a thief of Crown property, a breaker of locks, and a child-killer who intended to drown Bellhaven's lower wards before the eclipse ended.

Outside, someone at the sanctuary gate began reading the accusation aloud to the gathering road.

Chapter 12 — The Regent Opens the Granaries

Sere cut the blue cord on the first granary seal while refugees were still climbing Bellhaven's eastern flood stairs.

Rain streaked the counting-yard tiles. Below the covered gallery, six thousand sacks stood behind alder doors marked for winter reserve. Grain assessors waited with wax tablets held under their coats. Beyond the yard gate, people from Veyl basin pressed shoulder to shoulder, wet from three days on the road. Some carried children. Others carried lock permits, broken tools, cages of hens, or nothing.

The master of stores offered Sere a ceremonial knife. She ignored it and used the small iron blade from his desk.

"Open the north and lime yards," she said. "Issue one seven-day household measure to every arrival, resident or not. Stamp no debt against it."

The master swallowed. "Regent, the winter account permits only citizens of Bell district."

"Then today's account will acquire a larger idea of Bell district."

She cut the second seal. Captain Letha Marr relayed the order to the gate watch. Chains lifted. Store workers rolled back the doors, and the smell of dry rye entered the rainy yard.

The crowd did not cheer. Hungry people who had spent years beneath Crown permits knew better than to mistake an opened door for ownership. They watched the scales.

Sere watched them watch.

"Weights on public tables," she told the assessors. "One clerk from the stores, one from the lower ward, one chosen by the refugee line. Replace any damp sack in full."

A council secretary leaned near her. "Choosing from the line may slow distribution."

"Fraud will slow it more."

Within an hour, measures passed beneath the gallery in a steady rhythm. A cooper from Hush took the third scale position and caught a store clerk resting two fingers on the balance arm. Letha removed the clerk without spectacle. At Sere's order, kitchen crews set up kettles along the south wall so the weakest did not have to trade raw grain for fuel.

Competence calmed a crowd faster than banners. Sere had learned that during the river famine, long before continuous stilling left her face younger than the people who remembered it.

She moved from table to table. A mother with a split lip demanded grain for a son who had lost his permit in the Veyl surge. Sere handed the measure over

herself. A miller warned that open stores would invite hoarding. She ordered mills to post their grind fees and placed Crown buyers at the market bridges with enough grain to undercut any seller who doubled a price.

By noon the cost of rye had fallen from panic levels. Bread lines formed without crushing. Rainwater ran brown with chaff toward Bell Lock.

Price did not stay low because a regent wished it. Three river factors closed their private sheds as soon as the Crown measures began, intending to sell after the public yards emptied. Sere crossed the grain quarter on foot and found their porters fastening tarred cloth over doors marked with false quarantine signs.

She asked the nearest porter what sickness lay inside.

"Meal mite, Majesty."

A few refugees along the wall laughed. Meal mite left a sweet dust that any mill child knew. None showed under the door.

"Open it," Sere said.

The factor emerged from the office wearing mourning gray and an expression prepared for insult. "My stores pose a public hazard. I closed them for Bellhaven's protection."

"How much rye?"

"Private accounts do not fall under emergency disclosure until the third scarcity bell."

Sere held out her hand. The harbor secretary placed a chalk tally in it. "The first bell rang when Veyl broke. The second rang when six thousand refugees crossed our stair. I can ring the third now, or you can open your books."

He opened them.

The three sheds contained enough grain to supply the east squares for nine days. Some sacks had already been sold on paper four times, each buyer expecting scarcity to raise the value before anyone demanded delivery.

Sere did not confiscate the stock. Confiscation would send every hidden merchant cellar deeper underground. She fixed a purchase price above the previous month's rate and below that morning's panic rate, payable in hard copper rather than future Crown notes. Refusal meant public auction under the scarcity code. Compliance preserved a narrow profit.

"You reward them," one refugee said from the wall.

Sere turned. The speaker carried a sleeping girl inside a coat too large for either of them.

"I pay them enough that the next owner opens before I find him," Sere said. "I also publish every name."

The factor paled. In Bellhaven, reputation could cost longer than a fine.

Clerks copied the ledgers onto boards outside the sheds. Porters stripped away

the false signs. When the doors opened, stale dust rolled into the street and people saw how much food had waited behind them.

At the public grain stores, another problem had formed. Families sold portions of their free measure to pay for shelter, then joined the distribution line again. Store assessors wanted to brand their permits and refuse them.

"They need roofs as well as bread," Sere said. "Open the empty ropewalks without rent. Put guards at the doors to keep landlords from claiming them. Give each household a clay token when grain is issued, then let them rejoin tomorrow rather than pretending seven days of hunger can be solved in one weighing."

"Some will trade the token," the assessor warned.

"Some always trade. Design for people, not for obedient marks on a page."

She ordered market cooks paid per full kettle rather than per ladle, removing the profit in thin soup. Bakers received public flour only after posting loaf weight. Dung collectors gained temporary rights to fuel yards so wet families could heat pots without breaking shelter beams. Every correction cost copper, labor, or authority. Sere named each source in the margin of the order.

A boy fainted beside the fourth scale. The crowd opened around him without instruction. Sere knelt while a healer checked his breath. Hunger, chill, and fear had taken strength from him; no stillwater had touched the collapse. Broth, dry wool, and his mother's arms supplied what could be supplied. What could not be restored remained visible in his narrow wrists.

When he woke, he stared at Sere's unlined face.

"Are you Saint Orra?" he asked.

His mother flinched.

"No," Sere said. "I am the person who should have opened these doors yesterday."

She stood before the answer could turn into absolution.

No ceremony could hold the eastern gate clear. Sere assigned two empty dye halls as shelter, opened public bath furnaces, and ordered healers released from court service for three days. She denied a request to put the most exhausted refugees under motion stilling.

"Use cots, broth, dry cloth, and hands," she said. "A delayed collapse must land somewhere."

The physician who had proposed it lowered his eyes. He knew where.

Sere knew too.

A tremor touched her left thumb. The skin above the joint blurred, showing an instant of age before the palace channel corrected it. Somewhere under the former dye quarter, a prepared body received the stiffness that should have entered hers. Her thumb steadied. The stranger's joint did not.

She closed her hand around the wet gallery rail.

Saving bodies in the yard did not absolve the rooms below them. Neither did exposing those rooms feed the people now waiting in rain. A ruler who confused moral cleanliness with action could kill as efficiently as any flood.

That belief had built much of her reign. It had also become the shelter behind which she avoided looking down.

"The Council waits," her secretary said.

"Let it learn patience. First the barges."

Bellhaven's east basin held forty-three broad grain barges, twelve medicine punts, and nine deep-draft archive carriers. Refugees had already begun offering coin for deck passage west. Lock watchmen kept them behind rope lines.

Sere boarded the harbor office without an escort fanfare. Water maps covered one wall. Colored pegs showed craft, cargo, and crew. She moved the reserve pegs with her own hand.

"Twenty grain boats for public milling and shelter kitchens," she said. "Eight to distribute seed above the second flood mark. Six medicine punts remain mobile."

Letha stood across the map table in her rain-darkened watch coat. "And evacuation?"

"Prepare passenger rails on the remaining grain hulls. No boarding yet."

"The lower wards have sixty-three thousand with the heights included. Remaining grain hulls will not carry a tenth."

"Evacuation includes roads, roofs, and high warehouses, Captain. Barges carry those who cannot climb."

Letha's mouth stayed level. "Which barges?"

The question held no insubordination, only a demand for a number.

Sere shifted nine black pegs to the protected west quay. "Archive carriers stay under palace control. Two grain hulls join them."

A harbor clerk looked up. "For what cargo?"

"Palace archives, seed records, lock plans, and the sealed stillwater stock."

Letha tapped the two diverted grain pegs. "Those hulls each hold four hundred people in river weather."

"They also hold the legal memory required to distribute land and food after a flood. The stillwater stock can stop fire, bleeding, or a failing wall during evacuation."

"If it has counterweights."

"It will."

Sere did not say where. Letha did not pretend the omission meant nothing.

A shout rose from the quay. Three refugees had climbed the boarding ropes, one

carrying a man whose legs dragged. Watchmen moved toward them with staves.

"No striking," Letha ordered through the window. She went down herself.

Sere remained beside the map. She had preserved tax rolls after the north-quay fire twenty years ago; without them, three districts had spent a winter fighting over grain claims. Records possessed bodily consequences. Yet the black pegs looked like a small dark fleet fleeing before people who could not.

She moved one grain hull back to public use.

Only one.

The Council received her in a chamber above the harbor, where bowls placed at each chair showed ordinary rainwater gathering dust and temperature. Sere's own water had been changed before she arrived. A servant rotated it often enough to imitate change.

Reports began with Veyl. The first lock's harvesting frame had broken beyond repair. Hush pressure climbed. Red Step's saturated-goods market had scattered through dye canals. House of Last Change had admitted Tavia Sorn and the mooncalf.

"Name," Sere said.

The intelligence keeper frowned. "Regent?"

"The creature has one."

"Locals call it Nhal."

Granting the animal a name did not grant Tavia's account truth. Refusing the name merely advertised fear.

"Continue."

A glassmaker's orchard east of Red Step had aged seventeen years in one afternoon after Nhal drank runoff. Roof beams in a Crown depot cracked along stresses suspended over the previous decade. Fever returned to four textile workers whose symptoms had been transferred into saturated cloth. One died. Three remained alive.

Ward Seven had also been moved. After Oren Kest opened its rear door beneath Red Step's dye quarter, the Crown transferred the registered residents under guard to Bellhaven's older receiving infirmary. The assignment number, silver routes, and locked-door rules traveled with them. Four adult residents died during the first channel failures. Ninety-two living bodies, including all eighteen registered children, now occupied cots below the capital's flood mark.

The finance minister pressed both hands to the table. "It returns the storage to origin."

"Not storage," said the chief stiller. "Change. The water held instructions through prepared channels. The animal reopened them."

"Then destroy the channels."

"Breaking silver without draining it releases what it carries."

Sere looked toward the city below. Bellhaven glittered with more prepared silver than any place in Avelune. Channels ran beneath hospitals, granaries, bridges, breweries, foundries, and the palace itself. Thirty-five years of her aging followed routes into Ward Seven by repeated renewals. If Nhal drank the main Bell channel, stored change could return to every source at once.

Age would enter her first as an accumulation, not a natural year at a time. Fermentation would leap through grain and beer. Deferred cracks would finish crossing walls. Wounds held shut by treatment could open. Fires paused in chimney stone could remember burning.

"Every western lock receives double keeper strength," she said. "Remove portable paleshell. Drain ethical stores into their declared timber and fruit counterweights before the creature reaches them. Living assignments remain connected."

Several councilors looked relieved by the distinction. Sere heard what she had said. Objects could receive their accumulated debts now because their destruction harmed property. Living counterweights would remain burdened because releasing them endangered beneficiaries with names powerful enough to enter this room.

"Increase the guard around the weathering wards," she added. "No resident moves without physician approval."

The chief stiller cleared his throat. "Ward Seven has reported channel failure."

Silence tightened around the table.

"Define failure."

"Three north-wall conduits cracked after the Veyl pulse. Assignment pressure shifted into fewer routes. Renewals remain possible, but the residents are weathering faster."

"How many deaths?"

"Since dawn, four."

"Children?"

He consulted no paper. "None. The four were adults."

Sere looked at the ordinary water in the nearest council bowl. A thread of dust turned slowly on its surface. She imagined ordering all palace stilling ended. Her thirty-five years would return in hours or minutes; the physician could not predict which. More important to the Council, old repairs throughout the palace might fail with her. Authority would fracture while roads filled with refugees and the locks came under assault.

Those facts remained true. So did the dead child.

"Reduce ceremonial stilling first," she said. "Audience flowers, banquet food, fountain temperature, fabric preservation. Route each release into the objects of

origin."

The chief stiller blinked. "That saves little channel capacity."

"Then stop wasting little amounts."

"Your personal renewal is due tonight."

Sere's left thumb trembled again. A faint brown spot surfaced near the nail, then faded as the channel took it.

"Renew it."

Anset brought the renewal basin after dark. He mixed a thumb measure of ground paleshell into water drawn from Sere's unchanged chamber pipe and held the activating note until the surface took on a silver skin. Two physicians recorded her pulse, the brown spot near her nail, the ache in her spine, and the hours since her last sleep. Naming the suspended changes did not cleanse the act. It only prevented the palace from calling them nothing.

When Sere immersed both hands, cold entered the joints first. The stiffness left her thumb. Fatigue withdrew from behind her eyes. The small mark vanished. Above the basin, seven channel needles moved toward Ward Seven assignments.

"Recipient pressure rising," Anset said.

A physician read the coded board. Three registered bodies took her joint age, skin change, and fatigue. Prepared silver carried each burden under the dye quarter. Sere required the codes spoken aloud and copied into her private book. She did not ask for names. The registry withheld them by design, and she had preserved that design through six reforms.

The note ended. Water warmed around her young-looking hands. Somewhere below, three people paid in bone, skin, and sleep.

No one spoke.

"Use my registered assignments only," she continued. "Do not spread the load into unassigned ward rooms."

The order could keep extra children untouched tonight. It could not make the registered bodies voluntary. She knew the difference and issued it anyway.

After the Council, Sere went below the palace to the channel observatory. Silver tubes entered through black brick and met above a measuring basin. Each tube carried suspended change as a tremor, warmth, discoloration, or note. Bell Lock's main line pulsed hard enough to ring the clamps.

Stiller Anset, who had served her since the assassination year, showed her the western pressure chart. "Nhal's Veyl pulse continues propagating. If Bell basin receives a direct drink, we cannot predict the rebound."

"Can we isolate the main line?"

"Not while the city uses stilling. We could test closure in sections."

"A drill."

Anset hesitated. "Closing a district channel returns current suspended processes to their sources. Even briefly."

"At natural speed if the debt remains small."

"For recent workings. Older holdings may jump."

"Then we need to know which before Tavia Sorn brings the animal under our wall."

She walked along the measuring basin. A scale showed motion held in mill wheels during maintenance, another heat withheld from grain-store fires, another bleeding diverted from court surgery. Counterweight boards named timber stacks, spoiled fruit vaults, livestock, and ward assignments. The system could not be described as one crime because it had been built from thousands of choices, some merciful, some venal, many both.

Sere had always counted complexity as a defense against simple judgment. Complexity did not stop a body from aging in a locked room.

Anset adjusted a valve. Silver water in the basin went still. In a distant mill, a wheel would have stopped while prepared brake timber accepted its motion. The timber would crack sooner. If that timber saturated, a living channel might take the strain.

"How narrow can the test be?" Sere asked.

"One street. Half a bell."

"Insufficient. Panic will not stay within one street when the real failure comes."

By dusk she stood on the palace's lower balcony to address Bellhaven. Refugees filled the east squares. Residents crowded roofs and bridges. Grain smoke rose from public kettles opened under her order.

She promised shelter, controlled prices, working hospitals, and evacuation readiness. Every promise had an order beneath it, a store opened, a worker assigned, or a boat moved. She offered no empty assurance that Bellhaven could not flood.

"The city will practice what danger may require," she told them. "Work captains will mark high routes. Healers will prepare ordinary treatment. Keepers will test Bell Lock's district channels so no hidden failure surprises us."

Below, people shifted at the word test.

Sere gave them the hour, the bell sequence, and the instruction to extinguish open flames beforehand. She ordered wages paid for interrupted work. She ordered ward physicians present at every counterweight chamber. She ordered the lower flood stairs cleared of market stalls.

Then she returned inside and signed the final page.

At first light, Bellhaven would conduct a citywide stilling drill around Bell Lock.

Chapter 13 — The Stillness at Bellhaven

Oren held the cart wheel off the paving while Tavia pulled a child's shoe from beneath it.

The east causeway had narrowed to a corridor of bodies. Refugees moved toward Bellhaven's grain yards while city workers dragged market stalls away from flood stairs. Above them, keeper crews painted white height marks across brick walls. The first drill bell had not sounded, but every face had begun listening for it.

"Got it," Tavia said.

She passed the shoe to a girl perched on her father's shoulders. Oren lowered the wheel carefully. The cradle-boat rode under a cover of wet funeral cloth, its three folded sections braced on a brewer's handcart. Nhal lay within shallow spring water. Their heat pressed through the cloth like a banked stove.

Brother Caun walked behind with a medicine basket and House papers naming them as a fever-transfer party. The papers would survive one inspection if the guard read the seal rather than the names. Sere's proclamation hung from every blue-tiled arch.

A fresh broadside showed Tavia with teeth like a river saw. Someone had drawn a midwife's cord around the woodcut's neck.

"Flattering," Caun murmured.

Tavia kept her hood low. "Mine has better shoulders."

Oren found no humor in the gate watch ahead. Captain Letha Marr's lower-gate officers checked carts entering the outer basin and sent wheeled traffic into three lanes. One lane led to shelter. Another led to quarantine. The third, marked with a silver circle, served stilling supplies and Crown personnel.

He took the third.

"You no longer have a uniform," Tavia said under her breath.

"The people who obey uniforms mostly remember posture."

He walked as though the cart belonged wherever he put it. At the barrier, a young watchman saw his keeper boots, the Crown stitch holes on his coat, and the old road authority in his face.

"Channel destination?" the watchman asked.

"Former dye quarter. Main Bell feed."

"No transfers permitted during the drill."

"This cart carries the means to survive one."

The watchman looked toward his sergeant. Oren moved before permission could harden into refusal. The barrier lifted for an outbound grain wagon, and he slid the cart through its shadow.

They entered Bellhaven on the first bell.

Sound rolled from the palace height and struck the lower basin in layers. Mill bells answered. Street keepers shouted the drill order: extinguish flame, halt wheels, sit where marked, do not touch silver, await release.

People obeyed unevenly. Bakers shoveled embers from ovens into sand. Canal workers locked capstans. A barber kept cutting until his customer seized his wrist. Children climbed flood stairs for a better view. Refugees who had never practiced a city stilling crouched whenever anyone in blue told them to.

Oren guided the cart west along a drainage lane where no official checkpoint should have stood. Two ward officers blocked it anyway.

"House papers," one said.

Caun produced them. A second bell began before the officer finished reading.

The city's held note rose beneath it.

Stillers stationed at Bell Lock sustained a single tone through copper speaking pipes. Paleshell water entered the main silver network. The effect crossed the street as a line no eye could see.

A falling raindrop stopped against Oren's cheek.

Not all rain. One drop, caught where a prepared channel selected motion around the gate lane. It hung cold on his skin without running. Beside him, a cart horse froze halfway through a breath. Its ribs remained expanded. Harness leather ceased creaking. Across the drainage lane, a mill wheel held while water climbed motionless against its paddles.

The ward officer's paper stopped fluttering.

Oren could move because the drill exempted human bodies in marked transit lanes. The stilling had selected machines, fire, water hazards, and recent injuries. Silver channels carried each suspended change outward.

A timber stack in the assessment yard took the mill wheel's strain. Boards bent and cracked. Barrels of bruised pears received halted fermentation from the breweries and collapsed into brown froth. In a brick room behind the officers, living assignments took what objects could not hold: reopened wounds, joint stress, fever, age.

The officer finished reading. "Former dye quarter closed. Take the north shelter road."

"Our patient cannot climb," Oren said.

"Then wait. Half a bell."

Under the funeral cloth, Nhal struck the boat once.

The frozen horse's eye rolled toward the sound though its body could not follow. A silver line set into the gutter brightened.

"We leave now," Tavia said.

The officer reached for the cloth. Oren caught his wrist without drawing a weapon.

Recognition widened the man's eyes. "Kest."

Caun overturned his medicine basket. Clay jars broke across the paving. Vinegar, honey, and bitterroot flooded the officer's boots. Tavia shoved the cart between them. Oren released the wrist and ran.

A whistle sounded behind him. The frozen rain remained against his cheek as he pulled the cart into an alley.

Bellhaven under stilling felt like a city interrupted while drowning. Oven flame held blue and flat beneath sand. A mason's dropped hammer hung a finger's width above stone where a worksite channel had caught it. Blood stopped midway down a butcher's cut thumb. The man stared at the red bead with relief he had not purchased knowingly.

Far below, someone else began bleeding for him.

Oren knew the dye quarter's rear routes from patrol years. He chose a laundry stair, crossed a roofed canal, and cut through a cooperage whose workers sat beside motionless hoops. The handcart barely fit. Nhal's tail beat faster with each silver gutter they crossed.

"They smell the store," Tavia said.

"Bell's main channel lies under us."

"How much?"

"Two centuries of repairs. Thirty-five years of palace holdings. Recent drill motion. More than the market runoff."

"Then get us away from it."

The shortest western route passed above Ward Seven. Oren turned north instead.

A squad entered the far end of the cooperage. Blue coats. Drawn hook-staves. His former service had taught him exactly how quickly six officers could close a room.

"Back stair," he said.

Caun kicked open a slatted door. Tavia pulled the cart while Oren dropped storage hoops across the passage. Stilled metal refused to roll. The hoops hung against one another in an impossible tilted stack until officers struck the marked exclusion line. Then ordinary weight returned. Iron crashed down and filled the doorway.

The party gained one street.

Third bell.

The drill narrowed. Main transit lanes lost their exemptions in sequence. Oren felt the change reach his old knee scar, a small injury from winter pursuit years

ago. Pain vanished. The scar's stiffness flowed into a prepared channel.

He stopped.

"Why?" Caun demanded.

"Human injuries have entered the test."

Tavia swore. Her bandaged palms had relaxed. The burns no longer pulled when she gripped the cart.

"Mine too," she said. "Where did they put it?"

The answer came from beneath their feet.

A child screamed underground.

Not one cry. Several, separated by brick and channel noise. The sound rose through drain grates along with air that smelled of lime, old fever, and wet metal.

Oren looked at the sealed door ahead. No sign named the weathering ward. Blue paint marked the building as an abandoned dye store. He had opened its rear exit days earlier. Someone had barred it again.

Nhal rammed the cradle-boat wall. Cold light burned through the funeral cloth.

"We cannot take them near that channel," Tavia said.

Another scream came up. Oren saw Enna's weekly room in the palace hospice, clean and quiet, her mornings portioned into hours. He saw Perrin's bent fingers on the ward cot. A clean route west lay two streets away. The ward door stood here.

"Then you go around," he said.

"No."

"Tavia."

"I said supervised usefulness, not solitary stupidity. Caun, get the cloth off."

They dragged the cart into an enclosed loading yard. Oren used the heel of his hand on the old dye-store latch. Crown keepers had reinforced the door with a silver pin. Under the drill, the pin's metal resisted bending by sending strain into the ward network.

He struck it anyway.

Pain left his palm each time and traveled below. A child paid for his blows.

Oren lowered the hammer.

"Counterweight," Tavia said. She pointed to a stack of obsolete dye beams beside the wall. "Can you reroute the pin into those?"

"Without a stiller?"

"You know locks. Give me a mechanism, not permission."

The silver pin connected through a wall plate. Oren pried off the cover and found three channel teeth: source, selected change, recipient. He pulled the recipient tooth from the ward line with cloth around his fingers. The active note made the

silver burn cold. Caun wedged a beam against the plate while Oren drove the loose tooth into rotten wood.

"Now," he said.

Tavia swung Ila's adze.

The pin bent. The beam accepted the strain, split along its length, and shed a bloom of blue rot. No scream answered below.

They opened the door.

Weathering heat struck Oren's face. Ward Seven's main corridor held rows of cots beneath cracked silver channels. Adults and children lay twisted under changes the city had suspended: swollen joints, opened incisions, fever flush, sudden age. One woman had gray hair on only the left half of her head. A boy's arm shook with the motion of some distant mill.

Physicians moved among them with basins too small for the work. Crown guards clustered at the front entrance, protecting the channel room rather than helping patients.

Perrin Doss stood at the rear door with a pry bar. His spine curved more sharply than before.

"You took your time," he told Oren.

"How many can move?"

"More if the city stops practicing on us."

Tavia entered carrying Nhal's forward weight. Caun and Oren supported the cracked cradle-boat. Every silver conduit in the corridor brightened. Nhal opened their mouth and pulled water from the basin through the air in a trembling rope.

"Don't let them drink," Oren said.

"I know."

Tavia sang one note. Nhal thrashed. The note steadied their gills but did not turn their head from the channel heat.

A physician ran toward them. "Get that animal out!"

"Release your living assignments first," Caun said.

"During an active drill? Every selected injury would return at once."

"It will return if they drink. Choose how."

The fourth bell should have ended the test.

Instead, the held note deepened.

Someone at Bell Lock had extended the stilling.

Silver light raced through the ward walls. The city above fell quieter. More motion, heat, wounds, and structural strain entered the network. Perrin dropped the pry bar as his hands contracted. A little girl on the nearest cot aged across the face in three breaths, cheeks hollowing while the palace or hospital source

remained unchanged.

Oren lifted her. She weighed almost nothing.

"Rear yard," he told Perrin. "Anyone walking goes now. Caun, mark those who need carrying."

Guards at the front finally understood the creature had entered. They pushed through the physicians with hook-staves leveled.

Nhal struck the channel wall.

Brick cracked. A silver pipe broke. Stillwater poured in a bright sheet across the floor.

The mooncalf drank.

Tavia's song became a shout inside the pressure wave. She caught Nhal around the throat, but their body pulled forward with strength born from the very store hurting them. Silver water entered their mouth. Constellations blazed under their scales.

Oren felt his knee injury return. Not gradually. Eight winters of withheld ache drove through the joint and nearly dropped him. The frozen raindrop on his cheek fell. Across Bellhaven, the stilling broke.

Deferred motion returned first.

Mill wheels jumped through half a turn with accumulated force. One tore free of its axle and crossed a work yard in a spray of spokes. Hammers completed interrupted falls. Canal capstans spun. The stilled cart horse outside finished its breath, screamed, and bolted through a rope barrier.

Fire followed. Ovens coughed out the heat held beneath sand. A grain-kitchen flue ignited where soot had accepted years of paused sparks. Brewery vats erupted as fermentation leaped forward. The air filled with sour yeast and smoke.

Then bodies remembered.

The butcher's cut opened. Old surgical seams bled. Recently set bones shifted against splints. Fever returned to source patients while ward residents convulsed under the debt routed through them. Some weathering reversed by a measure. Much did not. Change already lived in damaged bone and could not be called back like a clerk from a room.

The ward floor bucked.

Bell Lock took the network's released pressure. Water struck its eastern gate below the city. Foundation strain returned to piers under the western wall. Lime dust poured from the ceiling.

"Children out!" Oren shouted.

He carried the aged girl into the rear yard and set her in a laundry cart. Perrin led three younger children by a cord around his waist because his hands would not close. Caun and two ward physicians lifted a cot through the broken door.

Tavia remained inside with Nhal.

Oren turned back. A falling ceiling tile struck her right shoulder and drove her to one knee. She did not release the mooncalf. Their tail whipped through cots. Water spiraled from the broken main pipe into their mouth.

"They will drink the whole line," a physician cried.

Tavia changed the song.

The first note went low enough to tremble in Oren's teeth. The second caught Nhal between gulps. On the third, she forced their head against her chest and covered the gills with both bandaged palms.

"Not all," she told them. "You do not take what you cannot carry."

Nhal had no human words to understand. Their body knew pressure, heartbeat, hunger. Tavia gave them those. She slowed her own breath against their jaw. She released one gill at a time.

The mooncalf spat a stream of silver water onto the floor.

Where it struck, old dye brick aged into powder. The building paid structural years returned from the city's channels. Tavia dragged Nhal toward the rear door as the powder spread.

Oren went in for them. A guard lunged with a hook-staff. He caught the shaft, drove its end into the wall, and used the guard's momentum to send him across a cot. Killing would not clear the room faster. Oren kicked the hook away.

Together he and Tavia hauled Nhal outside. Her right arm hung close to her body. The shoulder moved, but bruising had already darkened beneath her collar.

"Cart," she gasped.

The cradle-boat had lost one wheel in the floor heave. Caun ripped the folding braces free. They carried Nhal in the boat's central basin between them while Perrin organized the ward children into pairs.

Eighteen children had been registered. Oren counted seventeen in the yard.

"One missing," he said.

Perrin pointed upward. "Lio Mar. Channel room. They took him to receive overflow."

The front corridor had begun collapsing. Oren could see the channel-room door through dust, closed behind the Crown guards. Bell Lock surged again. Water boomed under the street.

Tavia read his decision. "Go. We move the others to the flood stair."

"If the west wall fails, don't wait."

"I never wait when men tell me to."

He entered through a window.

The channel room held silver manifolds around a central chair. Lio Mar had been

strapped into it. He looked seven, perhaps eight, though weathering had lengthened his bones unevenly. A guard worked the release buckles while another tried to close the broken main valve.

"Help me," the first guard said.

Oren cut the straps. The child's skin carried branching channel burns. The chair had taken recent drill overflow and poured it into him: halted bleeding from city clinics, fatigue from watch officers, the first minutes of Sere's renewed age.

The valve guard shouted that pressure had reversed.

A silver tube tore loose. Oren threw himself over Lio. Water sliced across his coat and struck the chair. The metal aged black, buckled, and collapsed beneath them.

Lio breathed once against Oren's neck.

"Can you hold on?" Oren asked.

Small arms closed around him.

He climbed through the window as the channel ceiling came down.

Outside, Bellhaven had begun moving in terror. People fled uphill without waiting for instructions. Grain carts overturned in narrow streets. Some flood stairs held because workers had cleared them. Others remained blocked by private storage, locked gates, or families trying to carry everything at once.

The first rear-yard laundry cart had made it only twenty paces. A brewery door burst across the lane and spilled hot, foaming mash around its wheels. Fermentation suspended during years of summer heat returned to the vats in one violent minute. The sour flood reached Perrin's knees. Two children fell.

Oren put Lio into Caun's arms and waded back. The mash carried no stillwater now. It could burn skin, drown a small body, and shove wreckage through the street with ordinary force. He caught the younger child by her coat and lifted her onto a windowsill. Perrin hauled the other up by the cord around his waist.

"Not the main stair," Oren said. "Use the blue doors."

A row of laundries opened along the north wall, each with upper galleries joined for carrying wet cloth above street mud. Their ground doors had been painted blue for the drill. He kicked the first latch until a laundress inside removed the bar.

She saw the children in weathering smocks and tried to close it again.

Perrin planted his pry bar across the jamb. "Your city used us before breakfast. You can lend us a staircase after."

The woman looked at his bent hands. She opened the door.

They moved the ward children through a room full of stalled washing tubs. Change had returned unevenly here. Cloth from a palace infirmary shed fever heat into one tub, turning water hot enough to steam. Linen used at a court funeral decomposed into gray pulp. Ordinary shirts remained wet shirts. The laundresses

marked the dangerous tubs with broken chair legs rather than asking magic to hold them again.

On the upper gallery, a seamstress pressed both hands over an incision that had reopened along her belly. Her neighbor kept pressure with folded cloth. Oren stopped long enough to knot a broad bandage around them.

"Clinic?" the neighbor asked.

"West stair has healers. Do not take the canal bridge."

He could give direction. He could not give certainty. A wall groaned across the lane, and everyone crouched while old foundation cracks completed their travel through brick. Dust filled the gallery. The building stayed up.

At the far laundry, fire blocked the connecting walkway. A held spark had returned inside a drying rack. Flames climbed oiled wood toward roof cloth. Caun started to turn the children back.

"No time," Tavia called from below.

She had brought Nhal's basin alongside the gallery on a loading hoist. Her bruised shoulder shook with the effort. The mooncalf sensed the fire's deferred heat through silver nails left in the rack and opened their mouth.

"Not that," Tavia told them.

Nhal drank a thread before she covered their jaw. Heat vanished from one burning crosspiece and entered a prepared nail. The transfer searched for an old counterweight route, found none, and returned toward the rack. The wood blackened, then flared twice as high. Nhal gained one bright pulse beneath the scales and convulsed against the basin.

Magic had bought them no passage. Oren took an ax from the wall, cut the walkway ropes, and dropped the burning section into the flooded lane. The gap left six feet of open air between galleries.

"We jump?" Perrin asked.

"You cross a door."

Oren and Caun laid the narrow laundry door over the gap. It bowed under the first adult. They sent children one at a time, crawling. A ward physician crossed last with the aged girl tied against her back. Below, hot mash and runoff carried the burning walkway west.

A mill wheel came through the end wall before they reached the stair.

Its axle had failed under returned strain. The wheel rolled across a courtyard, crushed a rain tank, and struck the gallery supports. Timber lurched. Oren had time to push Perrin toward the far landing before the floor dropped beneath him.

He caught a hanging sheet. Wet cloth tore through his fingers until a lower knot held. His boots swung above the courtyard. Lio cried out from Caun's arms.

Tavia braced the blue measuring cord around a roof post and threw its free end.

Ila's boat cord reached Oren at chest height. He wrapped it around his wrist. Tavia hauled with her left arm while Caun anchored her waist. Her injured right shoulder could not take weight.

Oren climbed hand over hand. The old knee scar burned, but no channel accepted it now. His body kept the pain.

When he rolled onto the landing, Tavia checked his palms. "Skin only."

"I had reached that conclusion."

"You look surprised to still own your injuries."

"Out of practice."

The exchange cost one breath, no more. They descended into a cooper's yard where ordinary rain had begun knocking fermentation foam flat. From there the west flood stair lay visible beyond a junction crowded with watch officers.

Captain Letha stood at the junction above Ward Seven, directing refugees away from a cracked wall. She saw Oren emerge with Lio. Her watch raised weapons.

"There are children in the rear yard," Oren said. "Eighteen registered. Seventeen came out that way. This is the last."

Letha looked past him toward the weathered residents. The hidden ward had opened onto a public street. Hundreds saw the children. They saw bodies carrying their paused wounds and young faces altered by palace years.

"My orders name you deserter," she said.

"Then arrest me after the wall falls."

A section of parapet dropped into the junction. Letha shoved two civilians clear. Stone shattered where they had stood.

"West flood stair," she told her officers. "Move the ward children first."

She had not defected. She had chosen the next body in danger.

Oren gave Lio to Caun at the stair. Perrin refused help until every younger child had climbed above the first white mark. Tavia stood halfway up with Nhal's basin braced against her good shoulder. The mooncalf shuddered, overloaded by stored change. Each convulsion sent small returns outward: rust racing across a gate hinge, bruises darkening on source bodies, fruit collapsing in market baskets.

"Can they travel?" Oren asked.

"They can die here or travel," Tavia said. "Lift the left brace."

The inner palace gates began closing.

High above the smoke, Sere Valec stood on the western gate gallery in a pale rain cloak. Distance did not conceal her unchanged face. She saw the opened ward. Oren knew because she gripped the rail and looked down for three full breaths.

Tavia raised her head. For an instant the two women held sight across the

damaged city.

Sere gave an order.

Chains hauled the inner gates shut, protecting palace height and the archive quay. Refugees still climbing from the lower basin found iron leaves closing ahead of them. The crowd roared.

Captain Letha looked up at her regent. Something in her face hardened.

Bell Lock sounded below, not a bell but a gate beam cracking under returned strain.

"West," Oren said. "Service spillway. Now."

He led the party along the flood stair while Letha's officers kept the junction open. Caun carried Lio. Perrin and the ward children moved among adults who had once crossed streets without knowing they existed. Tavia guided Nhal's breathing with two notes, saving the third whenever the mooncalf turned toward a silver channel.

At the western wall, the service spillway had begun pouring into an old cart tunnel. Oren broke its maintenance latch with a paving stone. Water took the door and opened a route beyond the city.

They passed through waist-deep current. Tavia slipped once when her stiff left knee failed; Oren caught the basin rather than her, and she caught herself with the uninjured arm. Behind them, Bellhaven's mills lurched, roofs shed tile, wounded people cried out, and the grain quarter steamed with sudden fermentation.

No spell had erased the stored years. Nhal had returned them to walls, food, fire, and bodies that originally shed them. Ward residents kept damage already grown into them. The city paid both old debt and present panic.

Oren reached the western embankment as daylight weakened under smoke. He turned long enough to count the children coming through. Eighteen.

Tavia and Caun carried Nhal into the rain beyond the wall. Perrin followed with the copied assignment strip tucked against his chest. Behind them Bellhaven stood damaged, loud, and awake, while Bell Lock drove a dark surge west along the Nightcourse.

Chapter 14 — What Oren Refused to Take

The last ward cart had not cleared the reed bridge when Crown riders came over the Bellhaven embankment.

Oren heard eight horses before he saw them. Fast pace, light baggage, iron-shod on wet stone. Pursuit riders. He shoved the cart's rear wheel over the bridge lip while Perrin pulled from the front with a rope around his waist.

"Keep west," Oren told him. "The House refuge lies beyond the lime kilns. Merra knows the sign."

Perrin's weathered hands could barely close around the rope. "And you?"

"Making another road."

The boy looked past him toward Tavia, Caun, and Nhal's damaged cradle-boat. Understanding flattened his mouth.

"That usually means someone with a weapon has decided he understands roads better than the people using them."

"Today it means the cart moves now."

Perrin gave one sharp whistle. The ward residents leaned together. Their wheels crossed onto the western towpath, where Merra Vos waited with the eighteen children and three laundry workers from Bellhaven. The group vanished behind reed screens as the first riders entered sight.

Tavia had already folded the cradle-boat into its narrow carrying shape. Nhal lay in the central section with wet cloth over their gills. Their scales flickered from the change swallowed under the city. Brother Caun lifted the forward handle. Tavia took the rear with her good arm.

"We need the lower track," Oren said.

"We need Nhal in water," Tavia answered. "They have been breathing through cloth for half a mile."

"Riders first."

"Body first. That remains true even when riders arrive."

She turned toward a drainage pond beside the road. Oren nearly argued, then saw Nhal's gills catching at the edges. He followed.

They lowered the basin into brown rainwater as horses splashed off the embankment. Nhal opened their gill fans and drew one ragged breath. The pond held no silver, only silt, insect larvae, and road salt. Their breathing cost the water a little warmth. Nothing living elsewhere took the strain.

The riders spread into a crescent.

Lieutenant Senna rode at the center. She had served under Oren for six years, first as a lock-road scout and later as his second at Veyl. Her left boot carried a

repaired buckle he had once mended with fishing wire during a winter patrol. She wore her helmet pushed back, rain running off the nose guard.

"Oren," she called.

He moved between the horses and the pond. His blade remained tied inside the bedroll. Drawing it would teach every mount to fear his hands.

"Lieutenant."

"The Regent offers terms."

"I read her last terms on a wall."

Senna glanced toward the reed bridge. She had seen the ward carts. Her riders had too. None pursued them yet.

"My order concerns the mooncalf," she said. "Not those people."

"Those people concern the mooncalf."

"Everything concerns everything when you need an excuse."

Tavia knelt in the pond with Nhal's jaw across her thigh. Caun checked the channels burns along their gills. Neither tried to hide the animal. After Bellhaven, concealment had become a poor joke.

Senna took a sealed packet from her coat. "This came from the palace hospice."

Oren recognized Enna's weekly paper before he saw the token mark. The hospice used blue rag fiber, expensive enough not to tear under stilling damp. His body stepped forward. Training stopped the movement after one pace.

"Open it," Senna said.

"You. Slowly."

She broke the seal and held up a physician's order. Rain darkened the margins.

"Enna Kest remains under Crown protection," she read. "Her marrow fever will be stilled for the full eclipse period, without interruption or reassignment, upon recovery of the living paleshell source."

The language struck harder than a threat. A threat could be resisted. This offered Enna's safety in the form he had spent years obeying to preserve.

"Whose assignment takes the renewal?" he asked.

Senna lowered the page. "I don't have that part."

"You saw the ward."

"I saw a city breaking around an animal your party brought into its main channel."

"You saw the children."

Her reins tightened. The mare beneath her lifted its head.

"Give up Nhal," Senna said. "You go to trial, not execution. The midwife receives the same. Brother Caun returns to his House. Enna keeps her treatment."

"And the ward child linked to her?"

"I don't know that claim has proof."

"Then ask the Crown to name the counterweight before you offer me the bargain."

One rider shifted toward the pond. Oren marked the movement, the horse's line, the muddy bank, the loose saddle girth. He knew each person in the crescent. Fenn had two sons above Hush. Rala sang badly on night watches. Young Osk had nearly drowned in the Veyl pressure vent because urgency had placed him on bad ground. Orders had made them dangerous without making them strangers.

"You taught us to finish the recovery before asking who failed," Senna said.

"I taught you wrong."

"Convenient timing."

"Late timing. Not convenient."

Nhal stirred. Water pushed outward from the pond in low rings. The horses felt it through their hooves. Ears flattened across the line.

Oren kept his voice low. "Take your riders off the wet ground."

Senna heard the warning as maneuver. "Last offer."

Tavia rose in the pond. Her right shoulder remained close to her ribs, bruised from Bellhaven. "If you want the patient, you enter the water without hooks."

Two riders laughed. Senna did not.

"Tavia Sorn," she said. "By order of Regent Valec, surrender Crown property."

"Nhal has a heartbeat. Your order has wax."

"Wax can feed a child when it seals a grain release."

"Then use it for that."

Oren saw Senna decide. Her right hand opened, palm down.

The riders moved.

He did not draw the blade. He snatched the blue measuring cord from the cradle-boat and looped it around the nearest horse's bridle cheek. One pull turned the animal away from Nhal. The rider struck at him with the flat of a short sword. Oren ducked and released before the bit cut the horse's mouth.

Caun flung two jars from his medicine basket. They broke under the second pair of horses. Bitterroot oil spread across wet stone. The smell made the animals shy, harmless but sharp.

Tavia drove Ila's adze into a rotten drainage board. Pond water tore through the opening and crossed the road. Nhal's pressure pulse moved with it.

Every mount jumped.

Senna stayed seated. She brought her mare around and reached for Oren with a

hooked arresting staff. He caught the shaft under one arm. She released it rather than be pulled from the saddle, drew her blade, and cut for his hand.

Steel opened Oren's left forearm from wrist toward elbow.

Heat came first. Blood followed, bright against his soaked sleeve. No stillwater closed the wound. His body paid in blood and grip.

Senna saw the cut and hesitated.

Oren used that breath to seize her bridle near the bit. He turned the mare toward the pond, not into it. The animal sidestepped. Senna lost her line on Tavia.

"Stand down," he told her.

"You first."

Behind them, Fenn had reached Nhal's basin. Tavia met his hook with the wooden adze haft. Her injured shoulder buckled. The hook caught the funeral cloth and dragged it from Nhal's gills.

The mooncalf screamed through water.

Pressure struck the road. Not magic aimed as a weapon, only animal panic carried through the pond. Horses went to their knees. Riders fell into mud. The old drainage wall cracked and released a second rush toward the western ditch.

Oren dropped beside Senna's mare and cut the saddle's front cinch.

The saddle rolled. Senna slid into reeds without the horse falling on her. Oren moved down the line, not toward bodies but tack. One girth cut. One bridle stripped. A buckle opened with his right hand while blood from the left made every grip uncertain.

Rala came at him on foot. He blocked her sword arm with his shoulder and shoved her into a patch of soft sedge. She surfaced cursing, alive and uncut.

Young Osk drew a Crown horn from his belt.

Oren slapped it aside before the boy could blow. The horn landed on the road. He put his boot over it, then looked at Osk.

"Take your horse and leave."

"You attacked an officer."

"I disabled her saddle. Learn the difference while you still can."

Osk's fear fought his training. At last he backed toward his mount.

Caun reached Oren and wrapped the forearm above the cut with a strip torn from his own apron. "You will lose the hand if you keep pulling tack."

"Noted."

"That word has never healed anyone."

The fight thinned as riders lost their mounts. Horses without saddles moved toward higher grass. Those still bridled would not cross the pressure ripples around Nhal. Senna regained her feet, mud streaked across one side of her face.

She could have called for arrows. She had two archers. Oren saw her look at Tavia bent over the mooncalf, Caun binding a deserter's arm, and the rider horses milling between every clear shot.

"Fall back," Senna ordered.

Fenn objected. "Lieutenant, they are four."

"And you have no seat, no clean line, and a drainage surge behind you. Fall back."

Discipline took them where force could not. Riders gathered loose reins and helped one another stand. No body remained facedown in the pond. One mare limped from a scraped knee; Oren noted it and hated the necessity without pretending necessity made no wound.

Senna retrieved the hospice paper. Water had blurred the physician's signature.

"Enna will learn you refused," she said.

"Tell her what I refused. Tell her a child in Ward Seven would pay for every hour you offered."

"You don't know that."

"Neither do you. That should have stopped you."

She folded the page along its old crease. "The Regent will not offer again."

"Then she has learned one useful thing."

Senna mounted bareback. Before turning, she looked at his bleeding arm.

"You could still come with us. Not the animal. You."

Oren thought of Enna awake for only a few allotted hours each week. He thought of the House ledger that kept both survivors and dead. He wanted the clean room, the blue paper, the certainty of another renewal. Want did not change who paid.

"No," he said.

The riders withdrew east, leading the mounts whose tack Oren had cut. Their pace could not support immediate pursuit. One scraped mare refused to follow. She stood in the drainage verge with blood running below the knee and her reins tangled under a foreleg.

Oren waited until the last blue coat disappeared behind the reed bridge. Then his knees weakened. Caun caught his good arm before he struck the stone.

"Sit," the Brother said.

"Horse first."

"Your arm is open."

"Her reins will break the leg if she falls."

Tavia went to the mare before either man could continue. She approached from the visible side, speaking in the same low cadence she used when a frightened patient needed hands near the body. The animal showed white around its eye but

let her cut the trapped rein.

Oren joined her. His left hand no longer closed fully. With the right, he felt along the mare's cannon bone. No break. A flap of skin had peeled back below the joint, ugly but shallow.

"Clean water," he said.

Caun stared at him, then handed over the travel flask. "I have begun to resent how often your stubbornness reaches a medically defensible conclusion."

They flushed grit from the scrape and packed it with the last of the House honey. Oren cut a broad strip from an abandoned saddlecloth for a wrap. No stillwater moved the mare's pain into another animal. She held the injured leg clear until Tavia released her, then limped east after the riders.

Only after the horse left did Oren sit on a drainage stone. Caun opened the temporary wrap around his arm.

The cut along his left forearm had missed the main artery but split muscle near the wrist. Caun flushed it with the water remaining in a second flask. Oren held still while Tavia pressed clean cloth into the wound.

"This will scar badly," Caun said.

"It can join the collection."

"You have used all available dry humor. Save your strength."

Caun stitched without stillwater. Each pass hurt. The pain entered no horse, no prisoner, no hidden room. Oren counted the needle strokes and kept his hand open when the muscle tried to curl it shut.

A distant horn sounded from the Bellhaven road. Three short calls marked delayed pursuit, not retreat. Senna would reach the next keeper house, claim fresh saddles, and send word ahead. Cutting tack had purchased hours rather than safety.

Tavia tied the final dressing. "Enna's safety."

He looked at her.

"You could have taken it," she said. "Not a trick. Not a lie. They would probably have kept her stilled."

"Yes."

"And someone else would have carried the fever."

"Yes."

Nhal rested in the repaired pond channel, weakened but calmer. Their pressure song traveled west through the drainage water. The Crown bargain had copied the same shape as the ward: preserve the named child, hide the other body, call the result mercy.

Oren remembered Enna at seven, before the hospice, holding a dead sparrow in both palms. He had told her the bird felt nothing now. She had asked who felt the

missing instead. Even then she had distrusted an answer that made cost disappear.

Later, when marrow fever took her strength, he had begun answering every hard question with another treatment day. He learned the hospice bells, the permitted visiting hours, the foods she could swallow, the lies physicians used when her blood counts worsened. He did not ask which body received the fever because asking threatened the only arrangement that kept her voice in the room.

Senna's paper had offered that arrangement again with cleaner seals. His refusal did not make Enna safe. It exposed her to a failing system and to a disease the House treated without promises. He could not turn the choice into virtue merely because the alternative carried hidden harm.

"If they stop her renewal because of me," he said, "the fever returns to her body."

Tavia rinsed blood from her fingers. "Yes."

"You are supposed to say I chose correctly."

"I am a midwife, not a festival judge. You refused to buy her hours with an unnamed child. That does not make the fever kind."

Caun finished packing his needle. "House records may give her another treatment path. They do not guarantee survival."

The plain statement hurt more than reassurance and gave Oren more to stand on.

He flexed his fingers once. Pain pulled through the stitches.

"I am no longer asking you for conditional trust," he said.

Tavia looked at him across the pond. "What are you asking?"

"Nothing. Tell me the work. I decide whether I can do it. You decide whether I stay near you."

"That sounds inconvenient."

"I am told late timing often does."

For the first time since Dunmere, she smiled at him without anger underneath it. The expression passed quickly.

They repaired what pursuit had damaged. Caun splinted the cradle-boat's cracked carrying bar. Tavia rewrapped Nhal's gills. Oren gathered the cut tack and hung it visibly on the bridge rail so later travelers would not blame thieves hiding nearby.

He also inspected every abandoned piece for a usable buckle. Two could repair the cradle brace. One fit the strap that held their water jars. Work returned scale to the afternoon: a strap, a knot, a distance possible before dark.

Young Osk's dropped horn remained in the mud.

Oren picked it up. The mouthpiece carried a shallow dent, but the tube had not

cracked. His own insignia still marked the brass. He washed it in the pond and tied it to his pack.

"Why keep that?" Caun asked.

"Keeper signals carry farther than my voice."

"It also identifies you to every Crown post."

"They already know my name."

He left his Crown horn intact because a tool did not inherit the order last blown through it.

Tavia chose a submerged service path west of the road. They carried Nhal between them, Caun forward and Tavia beside the mooncalf's head. Oren took the lighter packs one-handed. Blood seeped through his bandage but did not soak it.

The service path crossed three abandoned keeper cuts. At each one, Oren stopped to read the water marks and found recent scratches where villagers had cleared branches ahead of the Bell surge. Ila's instructions had traveled faster than they had. Someone had painted a lime arrow toward high ground. Another hand had listed two farm names responsible for the next drainage grate.

No heroic order had produced those marks. People who expected water had chosen work before certainty. Oren added the hour of Bellhaven's surge beneath the second arrow using a charcoal stub. His left fingers could not hold it, so he wrote with the right. The letters leaned badly and remained legible.

At the third cut, they heard Senna's replacement horses on the upper road. The reeds concealed the party only while nobody broke them. Nhal's tail began to beat against the basin. Tavia put her brow to their wet jaw and breathed until the rhythm slowed. The mooncalf's stored change stayed in their body. No channel opened. No distant stranger bought their quiet.

Dusk settled under the drowned-moon eclipse. Ahead, pale ridges lifted through the road's broken surface. At first Oren mistook them for limestone. Then one flexed under the paving and split a stone from below.

White roots broke the road surface ahead, wet with underground light.

Part III

Chapter 15 — Beneath the White Roots

Tavia went down on her stiff knee and put her ear to the root that had split the road.

Cold traveled through the white wood in three uneven pulses. Nhal answered from the cradle basin behind her. Their throat made no audible sound, yet grit hopped along the paving.

"It hears them," Brother Caun said.

"They," Tavia corrected.

"The root."

Oren scanned the dark road behind them. His stitched left forearm rode in a sling made from torn saddlecloth. "Whichever one hears, pursuit will reach this rise before we settle the grammar."

The largest root had lifted a wedge of stone, exposing a black opening beneath the causeway. Mineral air breathed from it. Tavia slid her hand into the gap and felt moving water three feet below.

Caun unwrapped the old route ledger. In fading ink, a forked mark lay west of Bellhaven beside the words lower forest entrance, open during brood passage.

"No door," Tavia said.

"Trees rarely install them," Caun replied.

They widened the break with Ila's adze and a keeper pry bar Oren had taken from Ward Seven. No magic spared the work. Oren levered one-handed. Caun hauled loose stone. Tavia's right shoulder objected whenever she lifted above the waist, so she cut packed reed and let the men take weight. Nhal waited in pond water while their gills slowed under wet cloth.

The opening admitted the folded cradle-boat by inches.

Oren lowered himself first on the blue measuring cord. He reported a ledge, deep water, and root columns thick enough to carry a house. Tavia followed with Nhal's head end while Caun controlled the tail. The mooncalf entered darkness without struggling.

Once all four stood below, Caun pulled a dead reed mat across the road gap. Hoofbeats passed overhead before they had moved twenty yards. Mud fell through the mat. No rider stopped.

The cavern opened around them.

Blind trunks rose from islands of pale clay. Their bark held no color until Nhal breathed; then dim silver ran upward through every branch. The canopy

disappeared into stone. Warm mineral springs crossed beneath colder Nightcourse water in separate currents, one clear enough to reveal white roots descending beyond sight.

Tavia had worked in drowned alder groves where branches caught the dead by their clothes. These trees held no leaves and needed no sky. Their roots braided around the underground river as fingers supported a laboring back.

She caught herself making the place kind in her mind. Roots did not consent to carry roads. Wood could pay a cost without choosing it.

"What feeds them?" she asked.

Caun knelt at a spring lip. "Lime, heat, flood silt from the Nightcourse. Old records say moonbrood shed light here during migration. Two stopped passages left the forest starving."

He touched a branch no thicker than cord. It crumbled into white meal.

Nhal lifted their head. Constellations moved under the scales. They gave one pressure note.

The nearest white roots brightened.

Light raced away through the forest faster than walking. A distant spring answered with a ring against stone. Another reply came from behind them, eastward, faint but distinct.

Oren put his good hand on a trunk. "Bell?"

"Not the gate," Tavia said. "Water connected to it."

She sang the lowest note of Ossa's birthing song.

The root under her palm carried vibration without air. White light opened through its grain, crossed a braid above the river, and vanished west. Three breaths later, the cavern returned the note from farther ahead.

Tavia sang the second. Nhal's gills widened. Water level rose a finger around their basin, drawn by pressure rather than created. The increase came from the adjacent spring and lowered that pool by the same measure.

On the third note, the forest answered from both directions.

Not words. No human message waited inside the wood. The root network carried intervals, force, and timing. Tavia could distinguish her three-note song because she knew the pressure spaces between notes. A keeper at another lock might learn the same pattern.

"Again," Caun said.

She repeated it while he walked west along the bank. Oren remained east with one hand against a second trunk. The first note reached both. The second lost strength at a broken root bridge. The third divided at a spring junction and returned in two echoes.

They marked the failure on the ledger.

For the next hours, the party moved between listening pools. Nhal swam where channels ran deep enough. At dry passages, they rode in the cradle-boat between poles. Tavia tested the song at every junction. Caun mapped which roots reached surface springs. Oren measured delay with his pulse and translated it into keeper bell counts.

The system required living listeners. Pressure could not clear a sluice, carry a patient upstairs, or refuse an unsafe order. Still, it could let distant people hear whether a previous reach had opened.

At the first surface shaft, Caun found stone steps ending beneath a round cover. The ledger named a herb terrace two miles south of Hush's western canal. He climbed high enough to smell rain and returned with a scrap of red-dyed wool caught under the lid.

"House marker," he said. "Our herb sellers use that path. A messenger can surface there."

The second shaft opened near a lime quarry above Red Step. The third led into a burial chamber outside Bellhaven's western wall. Recent footprints crossed its lowest stair. Escaped residents had used it after the city broke.

Caun placed a House chalk mark beside each route. "From here, messages reach three lock districts without Crown road posts. Farther west, the forest branches toward White Root Lock and Orra."

"Who carries them?" Tavia asked.

"House travelers. Patients able to walk. Herb crews."

"Names."

Caun studied her. "I do not know who has reached each entrance."

"Then we have routes, not messengers."

They tested what a messenger would actually have to do. Caun climbed the Bell burial shaft with a slate while Tavia remained at the listening pool. Oren walked west to the next root junction. Nhal stayed between them in clean water.

Tavia sent the three notes. Caun answered by striking the stone cover once, opening it, and striking twice. Oren reported the pattern reached his junction as four weak pulses because a split root doubled the middle beat.

"A person could hear open as closed," he said.

They changed the signal. Three notes called listeners. A long pressure held afterward meant do not act. Two short beats gave the all-clear only after the next lock's named watcher answered. Any broken rhythm required waiting and a surface messenger.

Caun returned with mud on his knees. "The burial shaft opens from below only if someone removed the funeral stones above. Bellhaven mourners did. That exit may close whenever a family uses the chamber."

Tavia wrote the limit beside the route. A line on parchment had suggested permanent access. A body climbing it found stone, custom, and other people's dead.

At the next branch, the cradle-boat would not pass between two trunks. They unfolded one side, moved Nhal into the wider basin, and carried each wooden section separately across a root shelf. Ila's repaired brace split under the mooncalf's weight. The old funeral wood paid in a crack rather than shifting strain through silver. Caun bound it with red House cord, reducing the basin's depth.

"One more narrowing like that," Tavia said, "and Nhal swims while we carry lumber."

"If the water stays deep," Oren replied.

They measured it. The western channel reached Tavia's waist at the center and dropped without warning beside the root wall. Her stiff knee slipped on mineral clay. Oren caught the blue cord with his good hand; his injured arm stayed tight against his ribs. Nhal circled back and pressed under Tavia's chest until she regained footing.

The mooncalf had not rescued her from a chosen destiny. They had felt a struggling body in water and supplied buoyancy. Tavia scratched a depth warning into the route copy.

By the time they reached a warm pool under a trunk wider than Dunmere's recovery shed, every clean line in Caun's map carried corrections: blocked, seasonal, coffin stair, deep edge, weak root, one person at a time. Those limits made the route more useful, not less hopeful.

Caun changed Oren's dressing. The cut had seeped but showed no fever streak. Tavia rested her bruised shoulder and checked Nhal's gills. Pearling had advanced along the rear edges.

Day 11, by Caun's count. Twelve remained.

A map spread across Tavia's knees. Seven lock circles faced her like mouths stitched shut. They had evidence, routes, a song, and people angry enough to act. Those pieces could become a plan. They could also become another clean diagram that spent bodies hidden below its ink.

"I don't know how to make this large without making it cruel," she said.

Caun paused over the bandage knot. Oren did not offer comfort.

Tavia touched Veyl's circle. "At the first lock, I knew Ila stood at the mill race. I knew where the keepers were. I knew which road would flood, and we still hurt people. At Bellhaven, we entered one ward to save children and brought Nhal to the main channel. The whole city paid."

"Sere ordered the drill," Oren said.

"Nhal drank. I brought them."

"Yes."

His agreement had the same hard use as Caun's records. It did not shift the cost elsewhere.

"If we tell seven towns to open," she continued, "somebody will say evacuation is ready when it is not. Somebody will call a district empty because the poor left no permits. Somebody unable to walk will remain below a white mark. Collective action can conceal an individual body as easily as a Crown ledger can."

Oren moved the map from her knees to the flat stone between them.

"Then name who stands at each lock," he said.

"We don't know enough people."

"Name the role until a person accepts it. One leader for lower sluices. One for high routes. One for clinics and immobile residents. One with authority to stop the gate. Write the empty place where everyone can see it."

"A role can hide the body too."

"Then require the person to speak their own name through the roots before opening."

Caun tore blank pages from his travel book. They made a sheet for each lock. Veyl already had eastern names: Ila for town warning, Dunmere miller Senn for lower flow, two keepers who had survived the broken frame. Hush remained mostly blank. Red Step gained Merra's House contact if she consented. Bell required Letha or another watch captain, not a palace title. White Root would need people they had not met. Orra and Sea Gate waited empty.

Tavia wrote each lock in full. Beneath it she listed bodies often erased from evacuation counts: children, prisoners, hospice patients, people without permits, workers below ground, the dead awaiting burial, animals confined in yards. Dead bodies could not be saved, but floodwater still carried them into drinking channels. Her trade did not let death excuse neglect.

Oren added stable crews and lock keepers stationed inside gate housings. Caun added surgical patients who could not be moved without bleeding. None wrote everyone.

"When a name comes," Tavia said, "the person may refuse."

"Yes," Oren replied.

"No Crown seal makes acceptance for them."

"Yes."

"If one lock cannot clear, the others wait."

His jaw tightened at the risk to Nhal's deadline. "As long as waiting does not make the eventual break worse. We state the pressure limit in advance."

That answer kept necessity from pretending patience had no end. Tavia wrote it down.

They sent the first message east through the root network. Three notes called

for listening. Oren struck a keeper interval against stone to mark Bellhaven. Tavia repeated the birthing pattern, then Caun sent a House rhythm used to request medical aid. The root carried pressure toward known spring exits. Human messengers would have to supply meaning.

An answer came after a long wait.

Three notes, clumsy and too fast, returned from the east.

Someone had heard.

Nhal rose in the pool until their jaw rested against the root. Light moved through the cavern forest. For several breaths their hunger eased, fed not by stillwater but by clean Nightcourse pressure. Water left the eastern spring, passed across their gills, and continued west. No counterweight received hidden change.

Then a different sensation entered the wood.

Tavia's left wrist began to ache. The pain did not belong to her old injuries. It tightened with the small, frantic rhythm of a child's pulse. Along the nearest root, silver light bruised purple and faded.

Caun touched the same trunk. "Bellhaven."

Nhal recoiled. The ache sharpened through Tavia's bones: growth forced too fast, joints burdened by an adult's suspended years, channel burns under thin skin.

The roots carried the sensation without removing it from its source. Somewhere east, a ward child still hurt. The forest made distance unable to hide the hurt.

Oren opened the blank Bell sheet and set it beside the purpled wood.

Chapter 16 — The Child Who Paid for a Princess

Oren held Enna's hospice token over the listening pool until its silver notch touched the water.

A faint line brightened beneath the surface. It ran from the token to the copied assignment strip laid on a root shelf, then stopped under a cluster of hooked marks he had failed to read at Red Step.

"Again," Tavia said.

She sang the first of the three notes into the pool. White roots around them carried the pressure east and west. The water trembled against the token. One hook on the assignment strip darkened as its silver residue released a trace of stored bone strain.

Oren lifted the paper before the transfer could complete. The strain returned to the strip's brittle fibers and curled one corner. No living body received it.

Brother Caun leaned over the markings. "The first hook identifies source treatment. The second identifies recipient class."

"And the third?" Oren asked.

"Renewal sequence, perhaps."

Oren had copied the strip in haste under Ward Seven. Every line named a counterweight room, a date, and a beneficiary code. Perrin's row showed thirty-seven renewal cuts. Enna's token carried the same thirty-seventh cut along its silver edge, small enough to pass as decoration.

He set the token beside the row. The marks aligned.

Not proof yet. A conclusion he wanted to avoid could make coincidence look precise. He measured the cuts with Ila's blue cord. Tavia counted intervals. Caun compared the House's old stillwater notation. All three measures matched.

"Enna," Oren said.

Her name entered the cavern and did not change anything. Water kept moving under the roots. Nhal circled the deeper pool nearby, their scales dim after Bellhaven.

The beneficiary mark on Enna's hospice token matched Perrin's assignment.

Oren had thought knowledge would arrive like injury. Instead it behaved like a lock gate settling into its housing, quiet because the violence had already happened upstream.

"You knew the system," Tavia said.

"Not the person."

"Your body cares about the difference."

His injured left arm throbbed inside its dressing. "Yes."

A signal struck through the eastern root.

Three notes, uneven. Then the House rhythm for medical passage. Caun answered on a hollow trunk. Pressure returned twice, paused, and came again with a scrape of stone from the Bell burial shaft.

Oren gathered the assignment strip and token. Tavia moved Nhal into the cradle-boat's center basin while Caun took his medicine pack. They reached the shaft junction as the cover above opened.

Merra Vos descended first on her crutches.

Mud streaked her fresh amputation wrap. Behind her came ward residents in pairs, carrying bundles and rolled testimony sheets. Perrin Doss climbed backward down the steepest section because his spine would not bend safely toward the wall. He used both elbows when his hands failed.

"I told you the House refuge had a western exit," he said when Oren reached up to help.

"You omitted that it involved a burial shaft."

"The dead complained less than the road guards."

Eighteen children had left Bellhaven. Fourteen came into the cavern. Merra reported that the youngest four remained at the refuge with two physicians and families from the laundry lane. The adults had divided as well. Those able to travel west carried evidence. Those needing sustained care stayed where surface kitchens could reach them.

No one called the separation clean. Families had chosen under pursuit.

Perrin saw the token in Oren's hand.

Dry humor left his face.

"You worked it out."

Oren held the token beside the copied strip. "Say it."

"You have the marks."

"Say what they mean."

Perrin sat on a low root. His knees clicked as he lowered himself. "Room Seven-North, bed twelve. Perrin Doss. Primary counterweight for beneficiary Kest-Eleven, palace hospice. Marrow suspension. Secondary burden for age and scar work when the main channels overflow."

Caun drew breath through his nose.

"How long?" Oren asked.

"Five years."

"Enna entered hospice four years and eight months ago."

"They prepared me early."

The words tilted the cavern.

Oren crouched until he and Perrin held the same eye level. The boy's face looked twelve in its quickness and older in the skin around the mouth. His hands resembled a laborer's at seventy. One shoulder sat higher where repeated bone strain had changed the spine.

"Tell me each renewal," Oren said.

Tavia made a warning sound. "He can choose whether to."

"Yes." Oren forced his voice lower. "Perrin, will you tell me?"

The boy considered him. "If Caun writes it. Not you."

Caun opened a blank ledger.

They moved to a dry chamber where mineral light ran through the roots. Ward residents gathered near enough to correct dates. Tavia kept Nhal in the adjacent pool, within sight but outside the narrow room.

Perrin began with the first preparation. Crown physicians had set silver crescents against his ribs and activated them before Enna received treatment. He spent three days vomiting marrow heat his body had never produced. A nurse told him he had helped a deserving child.

The second renewal aged two fingers. The third brought pain into his hips. During the seventh, Enna's fever rose despite stilling; physicians increased the note and Perrin's left wrist fused partly closed.

Oren remembered that week. Enna had been conscious for three full afternoons. They played stones on her coverlet. He had praised the new dose.

Perrin described the twelfth renewal, when a channel fault sent Enna's suspended fever through three children before settling mainly on him. One child died. The ward ledger called it recipient instability.

At seventeen, his spine began curving. At twenty-four, adult age from a palace overflow entered his jaw and loosened two teeth. At thirty-one, physicians moved him to North Twelve because the shorter channel reduced loss.

"Loss of what?" Oren asked.

"Treatment effect. Not us."

Caun wrote the exact phrase.

The thirty-seventh renewal had occurred the night Sere opened the grain stores. Enna's marrow heat, bleeding risk, and fatigue moved through prepared silver into Perrin. At the same time, palace age overflow reached his room. His hands contracted during Bellhaven's drill because the cracked channels concentrated both burdens.

"Did Enna ever know?" Oren asked.

"Not my name. Hospice patients get told counterweights are livestock or saturated timber. Some treatments still use those. Hers stopped after the first month."

Oren pressed the token into his good palm until its edge hurt.

"I brought this every week," he said. "I thought it proved she remained under care."

"It did prove that."

"It also recorded what happened to you."

"Yes."

Perrin's lack of accusation opened more space for guilt, not less.

"You didn't make the channels," the boy said. "You didn't assign me."

Oren stood so quickly the root shelf struck his injured arm.

"Do not comfort me."

The room went still.

Perrin's eyebrows rose. "I wasn't."

"You were making the part I did smaller. I accepted treatment without asking who paid. I enforced the roads and sealed orders that kept these wards hidden. I entered Ward Seven only because pursuit led me there."

"I know."

"Then do not carry my judgment too."

Anger entered Perrin's face, welcome and young. "You don't get to tell me what I carry."

Oren stopped.

The correction landed exactly where it should.

"No," he said. "I don't."

Perrin rubbed his fused wrist. "I can decide you did less than Sere and more than nothing. That doesn't absolve you. It counts."

"All right."

"You say that as if counting hurts."

"It has begun to."

Merra laughed once from the wall. The sound held no kindness, but it eased the room enough for Caun to continue writing.

One testimony opened others. A woman named Dasa received wound closure from palace guards and carried scars that split anew each month. An undocumented canal family had taken fermentation sickness from Crown breweries. Two brothers shared the suspended collapse of an archive stair; one now walked with a twisted pelvis. Merra's amputated leg had carried structural strain from a ministerial house until the bone died.

Proof required more than wounds. Sere's officials could call every altered body disease, poverty, or performance. Oren spread the assignment strip beside three

hospice tokens carried by residents who had served palace patients. Each token bore a pattern of edge cuts. Each counterweight row repeated that pattern in reverse.

He taught the room how to read the notation. A long cut named the district channel. Two shallow cuts marked treatment class. Hook direction identified whether a body gave or received change. Crown clerks had made the code complicated enough to discourage casual reading, not to hide from another clerk.

"Say that again," Merra said.

"The code assumes anyone qualified to read it already approves."

"No. The useful part. Show us so we don't need you."

Oren placed his good forefinger on Dasa's row. "Long mark here, Bell palace. Paired shallow marks, wound closure. Hook opens toward recipient, which means this bed takes the change. The final cuts count renewals."

Dasa counted fourteen. Her scars had split fourteen times.

Caun copied the key onto separate cards. Ward residents paired up and decoded one another's rows. They caught two errors in Oren's first translation. A hook he called age transfer actually marked structural strain. One date he read as winter used the palace's old flood-year calendar and fell in spring.

Being corrected steadied him. Proof that depended on his authority would remain vulnerable to his failure. Proof others could test might outlive him.

Perrin laid Enna's token on the shelf. "Show them this one."

"You don't owe the room another account," Oren said.

"I know. Show them."

The boy explained the alignment himself. He pressed the thirty-seventh edge cut against his row. Under warm spring water, silver residue joined across the paper and token. Tavia gave one low note, not enough to activate a transfer. The line glowed, revealing the channel match, then faded.

They repeated the test with a false pairing. No line formed.

"A Crown stiller may say the glow comes from Nhal," Caun warned.

"Then record a test without them," Tavia said.

She led Nhal two root chambers away. Their pressure receded. Oren warmed fresh water over Caun's travel lamp and immersed the marks without a held note. The silver remained dull, but rubbed charcoal caught identical cuts on paper. Mechanical fit confirmed what magic had shown.

Next they tested source direction. Dasa consented to wetting one old channel scar at her wrist. A grain of silver rose from the skin and drifted toward her assignment row. Oren kept the hospice tokens outside the basin so no route could connect. The grain held a trace of scar tension. Clay received it, cracked, and ended the movement. Dasa's wound did not open.

Caun labeled the broken bowl as counterweight evidence. "The change transferred from residual silver in Dasa's scar into prepared clay at echo-distance. Small, visible, and consented to. We do not repeat it for spectacle."

A palace advocate could still deny. Denial would now require explaining matching codes, bodily marks, named dates, and physical tests.

Each person chose what to record. Caun wrote bodily changes and source institutions. Tavia copied route locations. Oren translated assignment hooks into beneficiary classes without exposing patients' names unless the witness requested it.

Choice divided families. One canal father wanted his children's names hidden to protect them from detention. His eldest daughter wanted hers printed because hidden names had made the ward possible. They argued until both voices shook.

"Separate sheets," Merra said. "Her name on hers. No names for the younger two. Same channel code on all three."

The father disliked the answer. He accepted his daughter's right to her page.

A former debt prisoner named Hale wanted the ministerial source named but refused to describe the illness transferred into his groin. Caun recorded chronic pain and organ damage, sufficient to establish bodily cost. Accuracy did not require stripping privacy.

Two witnesses could not write. They dictated to Sevi, then asked three listeners to read the text back. Thumbprints marked consent. One woman withdrew her entire account after hearing it. Caun burned that sheet over the lamp and mixed the ash into ordinary mud. No copy remained.

They used no stillwater to reveal most marks. Warm spring water and Nhal's lowest pressure note served only where witnesses agreed. Silver dust stayed in the wash basins afterward. Clay bowls took the abrasive residue and would be buried away from channels. Witness bodies paid only the effort and discomfort they consented to.

Oren proposed carrying the original assignment strip to Orra. Perrin objected.

"One hook through your coat and they own all of it again."

"Copies can be called forged."

"Then split the original."

The suggestion offended every keeper habit Oren possessed. An intact Crown record carried authority through completeness. Perrin took Caun's knife and cut between assignment rows, preserving the header seal on one strip and the date key on another. Each bundle received several original rows, copied keys, and witness accounts held elsewhere.

No captor could erase the evidence by seizing one person. No witness carried everyone's danger.

By afternoon, the chamber held forty-three names and twelve pages of proof.

Not all ninety-six residents had escaped. Not all escapees had come west. Missing names remained listed as unknown rather than dead.

Oren wrote Enna's line last.

Beneficiary: Kest-Eleven. Illness: marrow fever. Counterweight: Perrin Doss, prepared age seven, current age twelve. Renewals: thirty-seven. Known transferred changes: marrow heat, bleeding risk, fatigue; palace overflow additional. Consent: neither child informed of the other.

His hand cramped. He did not ask someone else to finish.

"What will you tell her?" Tavia asked.

"The truth."

"Which part?"

That question had acquired sharp edges in the last days. Truth could be cut down until it fit the sender's comfort.

Oren took a separate sheet.

Enna,

Your stilling has been paid by another child's body. The Crown told us objects carried the change. That stopped being true before your first month ended. I did not ask, because I feared any answer that might end your treatment. The child lives and has permanent injuries. I will not write the name until they choose how you learn it. I refused an offer to renew your stilling through the eclipse because it did not name who would pay. This may bring your fever back sooner. House of Last Change keeps an ordinary treatment record, with survivors and deaths both named. You have a right to know before anyone chooses for you again.

He stopped there.

No request for forgiveness. No declaration that he had done it all for her. No instruction to be brave. He signed his name rather than Father because the role could not command her answer.

Caun read the message at Oren's request. Perrin read it too.

"Don't write my name yet," Perrin said. "I want to tell her if I can."

"You may never reach the hospice."

"Then someone tells her after I choose the way."

Oren folded the message around the hospice token. A House herb seller at the Hush shaft agreed to carry it east through ordinary roads, hidden among fever-bark invoices. Delivery could not be guaranteed. They recorded the messenger's name and route.

The proof needed to travel in more than one direction. Caun proposed copies for Houses and clinics. Tavia wanted sheets at lock approaches where evacuation leaders gathered. Merra chose Bellhaven's western districts. Several residents chose east, back toward families.

Perrin chose west.

"People near Orra trust Crown seals," he said. "They think weathering wards belong to stories made by angry canal workers. I know the assignment marks. I can show mine. Oren can certify the keeper notation."

"I am charged with desertion," Oren said.

"That makes you interesting, not trustworthy. Your old seal still reads."

"Travel will worsen your spine."

Perrin's expression closed.

Oren heard his own error before Tavia spoke. He had turned bodily fact into an order.

"What help would make the journey possible?" he asked instead.

"A low cart, two people who don't mind lifting, and medicine that doesn't steal tomorrow from someone else."

Caun listed all three. Merra volunteered for the cart team. A ward physician named Sevi offered to travel with them. Perrin pressed his thumb beside his testimony, leaving the beneficiary mark visible under spring water.

They wrapped duplicate pages in waxed cloth and divided them among carriers. Destroying one bundle would not erase the names. Oren kept no sole copy.

Caun inspected the low cart brought through the burial shaft. Its axle could bear Perrin if baggage traveled elsewhere. Merra shortened one crutch to use as a brake on descents. Sevi packed willow bark, clean bandages, and two sealed jars of broth concentrate. Every provision named an ordinary source and a person responsible for replacing it.

Oren drew the next three surface routes from memory. Perrin crossed out the Crown road and chose canal villages where the proof could be read aloud at weighing yards. A slower route offered more witnesses and fewer mounted posts. They marked rest points no farther apart than Perrin could travel without his back locking.

"If I say stop," Perrin told Merra, "we stop. Not after one more hill."

"If I say the axle cracks, you walk ten paces while we brace it," she answered.

They clasped wrists on those terms.

At dusk, the western root delivered a heavy pulse from White Root Lock. Nhal lifted their head toward it with sudden hunger. Beyond the cavern wall, decades of stored change waited in a sealed reservoir.

Perrin secured the proof bundle against his chest. "I will take this west," he said. "Let them tell me to my marked face that the Crown would never do such a thing."

Chapter 17 — The Mooncalf's Hunger

Nhal bit the silver seam in the reservoir door and cracked a tooth.

Tavia caught their jaw before they struck again. The mooncalf's body hung thin in the channel under White Root Lock, scales dulled to smoke. Pearling had reached halfway around the gill fans. They twisted against her hands with little strength and enormous need.

"No," she said. "That door holds more than you can carry."

Stored change pulsed behind the stone. Decades of it. Heat moved through the seam without warming the water: rot suspended from grain stores, strain lifted out of lock foundations, fevers and wounds diverted from clinics, age routed out of official households. Nhal sensed all of it as food.

Their broken tooth bled a ribbon of black-silver into the channel.

Brother Caun opened his medicine roll on a dry root shelf. "Can the tooth wait?"

"It must." Tavia ran her thumb along the jaw hinge. "Their pulse has slowed again. If they sleep now, I may not wake them."

Oren stood at the old lock-control wall with his bandaged arm held close. The chamber surrounded them in white roots and Crown masonry. Bellhaven engineers had built a reservoir into the forest's western throat, then hidden the service doors behind carved panels showing roots bowing to Saint Orra.

"The main store feeds White Root district," he said. "There should be an inventory house above."

Caun found a brass frame under mineral scale. Inside, slate tabs named the connected channels. The Crown had preserved meticulous accounts of sources while disguising human recipients behind classes.

Foundation strain, eastern lock housing: twenty-one years.

Grain aging, western reserve: nine harvests.

Timber rot, upper spillway braces: thirty-four years.

Clinical bleeding, six district houses: active.

Marrow heat, fever, joint decay: active.

Palace overflow reserve: continuous.

Tavia read the last line twice. "Bellhaven still routes through here."

"White Root accepts excess when Ward Seven channels rise," Oren said. "The forest puts the reservoir within echo-distance of the palace main line."

Nhal lunged at the door.

Their gills closed after the effort. Tavia lifted them until water crossed the openings. One breath. A second, weaker.

"We give them some," Caun said.

"Some has bodies attached."

"Doing nothing has one body attached."

Nhal's weight dragged against Tavia's bruised shoulder. The answer could not become no cost merely because she loved the patient she held.

Oren traced the channel diagram. "The store has branch valves. Grain, timber, foundations, clinics, palace. We can isolate them."

"Can we?"

"If the valves still match the slate."

"And if they don't?"

"Then we close the main gate before Nhal drinks beyond the basin."

Tavia looked at the cradle-boat folded along the wall. Ila had built three sections to fit a funeral shed and carry one unborn creature. Its center basin held nearly four bath buckets when braced level. A known volume. Not safety, but a limit her hands could measure.

"Unfold it," she said.

They carried Nhal into the adjacent spring while they worked. Caun supported the jaw. Tavia drove the cracked braces into their slots one-handed. Oren tied the blue measuring cord at four depth marks inside the central section. Each mark represented one bucket if the basin sat level.

The first branch they tested led to grain aging. Oren turned its handwheel a quarter circle. Old silver groaned under the wall. Tavia held a single note, activating residue along the route without stilling anything new.

Water entered the measuring basin through a clay spout. It looked clear until Nhal approached. Then nine harvests of suspended age clouded it brown.

"Original source?" Tavia asked.

Oren checked the slate. "Western reserve houses above the second flood mark. Grain from three canal districts."

"People nearby?"

"Workers. The return spoils grain, not bodies, unless mold fever follows."

Caun tied cloth over his mouth and nose. "We warn through the roots first."

Tavia sent three notes, then the long wait signal. Oren added the keeper code for spoiled stores. Caun climbed the nearest surface shaft with a written warning while the basin filled to its first mark.

Nhal shook in the spring.

Waiting cost breath. Tavia kept one palm under their throat and counted. At ninety breaths, the root answered with two short beats. Someone above had heard and cleared the storehouse workers.

They slid the basin into the channel.

Nhal drank.

Brown water vanished between their teeth. Light opened under the throat scales. Far above, a deep sigh passed through masonry as nine harvests found their original grain.

The smell reached the shaft first. Rye aged, warmed, sprouted, molded, and collapsed into meal within minutes. Stored food paid the debt it had been spared. No orchard elsewhere rotted for it. No ward body took its years.

Nhal lifted their head and searched for more.

Tavia blocked the clay spout. "One mark. Breathe."

The mooncalf struck her chest. Their fin claws tore her coat but missed skin. Hunger had moved beyond trust.

Caun returned coughing. "Upper crews clear. Grain lost. No trapped workers."

"Next material line," Tavia said.

They chose spillway timber. Oren opened the branch while Tavia sent warning. The answer came sooner. Water filled to the second cord mark, carrying thirty-four years of held rot. Nhal swallowed before she gave permission.

Above them, braces split. The reservoir ceiling shifted a finger. White roots took some falling weight through direct contact, not silver transfer. One root snapped with a sound like a wet mast.

"Close it," Oren said.

The handwheel jammed.

He put both hands on it. His left forearm dressing darkened as the stitches pulled. Tavia left Nhal with Caun and added her weight. The wheel turned. Flow stopped below the second mark.

They did not open another branch immediately. Measuring volume without measuring consequence would turn the cradle-boat into another polished instrument for hiding cost.

Caun climbed the maintenance stair with two warning sheets. Tavia stayed beside Nhal while Oren inspected the newly loaded channel teeth. Fresh pressure could have driven old silver toward the wrong outlet. He found the timber line still connected to a row marked lodging stock.

"Worker barracks," he said. "The braces carried strain taken from the roofs as well as the spillway."

"How many roofs?"

"Slate gives eleven."

Tavia sent the wait pattern west and east. The white roots returned no bodily alarm, but absence carried little comfort. If a roof had fallen cleanly, nobody beneath it could send pain.

Caun returned with a keeper from above, a woman gray with grain dust. She had heard the root warning and cleared the reserve workers before rot reached the sacks. Her crew had also moved six families from the old barracks when the braces began splitting.

"One roof dropped," she said. "Empty. Another leaned into the cookhouse. We braced it with unstilled alder. The grain cannot be saved."

"Anyone hurt?" Tavia asked.

"A porter burned his hands when ferment heat came out of a meal bin. Cool water took the heat from his skin into itself. We changed the basin until it stayed cool. No silver."

The porter paid in burns. Grain paid in rot. Crews paid in labor and lost stores. Those costs remained grave without becoming a death count.

The keeper looked at Nhal with fear sharpened by practical questions. "If you open more, tell us which slate line. Half the inventory labels above don't match these. Palace crews renumbered after the north reservoir fire."

Oren compared her copied numbers to his frame. Two branch labels had indeed been reversed. What they believed carried abandoned mill strain actually reached the lower quarry clinic. A blind turn of that valve could have reopened illnesses without warning.

They corrected both slates in charcoal and scratched the new numbers into stone where water could not wash them away. Tavia made the keeper repeat the change aloud. The woman took a copy above for surface crews.

Only then did they return to Nhal.

The mooncalf had gained strength. Their tail struck the channel floor and knocked Tavia sideways. Her stiff knee folded. She caught the basin rail instead of falling under them.

A pressure signal came through the east roots.

Not their three notes. Keeper alarm: breach, armed entry, lower shaft.

Oren drew his short blade with the right hand. "Vennick found another way."

Boots hit stone beyond the eastern passage. Crown troops had followed the reopened Bell burial route, then tracked root marks west. Voices ordered the party away from the reservoir.

"How long?" Tavia asked.

"A minute. Less."

Nhal turned toward the clinical branches. Those carried living heat. A drink from them would reopen wounds and illness across White Root district. Gradual release might be survivable under care. Sudden return could kill patients before a messenger reached them.

The palace overflow line pulsed beside those branches, stronger than all others.

Tavia seized Nhal's jaw. "No."

They twisted free.

The first hook-staff entered the chamber. Oren struck its head against the wall and stepped inside the soldier's reach. His wound prevented a two-handed bind. He used the narrow passage, forcing one opponent at a time.

Caun kicked the clay spout off its bracket. Reservoir water spilled across the floor before reaching Nhal. Without the living moonbrood drinking, stored change remained suspended in it. Silver-brown water pooled around the roots.

"That won't hold," he said.

Tavia looked at the branch slate. Clinical lines divided by source house. Six districts. She could not make release painless. She could choose volume, sequence, and warning.

"Open the smallest clinic line," she told Caun. "First mark only."

"Which one?"

"The slate says lower quarry. Twelve active sources. Send medical warning."

He sang the House rhythm through a root. Oren fell back one step as two soldiers pressed him. The measuring basin filled with water carrying suspended bleeding, fever, and joint pain from twelve patients.

No answer came from the surface.

Nhal climbed into the basin.

Tavia wrapped the blue cord twice around their chest and anchored it to the funeral-boat ring. Ila's old timber bent. Tavia put her feet against the wall.

"First mark," she said. "Not a mouthful more."

The mooncalf drank. Their body surged forward. The cord cut across Tavia's bandaged palms. Caun seized the second loop. Together they held Nhal's head above the clay inlet once water dropped to the measured line.

Twelve original bodies received their changes.

Through the root network came scattered impacts: a fevered heartbeat quickening, one healed incision pulling open, old joint pain returning, a quarry worker's nose beginning to bleed. None of the sensations stopped at the root. The pain remained with those bodies. The forest only carried evidence.

Caun sent treatment instructions immediately: pressure on wounds, cooling water, clean cloth, willow bark, call names at the quarry clinic. Ordinary care could answer some harm. It could not undo the choice.

Tavia kept the clinic branch shut while they waited for a reply. Nhal scraped their broken tooth against the basin rim and reached toward the inlet. She placed her wrapped palms between mouth and silver. The mooncalf bit hard enough to bruise her hand. Hunger did not become malice because it injured her.

At last, the roots returned the House medical rhythm. A quarry healer spoke

through taps translated by Caun: twelve source patients located, nine inside the clinic, three at home. Of the nine, one reopened abdominal wound required stitching. Two fevers had returned and could be cooled. Four joints swelled. A man's nosebleed had stopped under pressure. One patient showed no visible change yet.

The three at home required runners. Tavia refused another clinic measure until all three answered.

Boots drew closer in the eastern passage. Oren watched the bend and counted the seconds between reflected sounds. "We may not get those answers before troops enter."

"Then that branch stays closed."

"Nhal may not survive on material debt alone."

"The first measure already spent twelve bodies. They get counted before we spend twelve more."

A messenger tap returned for the first home: old surgical bleeding, controlled. The second carried fever and had reached a neighbor with a cooling cistern. No answer came from the third.

Caun named the missing source from the slate, Jori An, treated for a crushed foot six months earlier. The Crown store had held swelling and bone pain after the clinic discharged him. Release might have dropped him wherever he worked.

Tavia sent his name through every surface shaft in reach. The roots could not search minds or find a person. Human runners above would have to knock on doors and quarry sheds.

Nhal lunged again. The basin ring began pulling free of funeral wood.

"Material branch next," Tavia said. "Foundation strain. Not the clinics."

Nhal brightened enough to tear one cord loop.

Crown troops broke past Oren.

Tavia opened the foundation branch.

"What are you doing?" he shouted.

"Giving the lock its own debt."

She filled the measuring basin to the third mark with twenty-one years of structural strain suspended from White Root Lock's eastern housing. Nhal drank. Masonry above them cracked along old repair seams. The floor tilted west.

Soldiers lost footing. One fell into the stored-water pool. Caun caught his collar before his face went under. The man stared at him, shocked that an enemy had not allowed the reservoir to take him.

"Climb," Caun said, and shoved him toward a root shelf.

The eastern lock housing groaned. Its deferred motion and strain returned to source stone, not to the soldiers. A gate beam shifted. Water began pressing

through seams under the main door.

Oren reached the master branch valve. "We can close the clinic lines, but the lock store will open if this wall moves another hand."

"Then we leave west."

Nhal faced east.

They did not face the attacking soldiers. Their whole body aligned toward Bellhaven, where the palace stores glowed through silver channels beyond human sight. Hunger recognized the largest concentration of stored change.

Tavia climbed into the basin beside them. The mooncalf's scales burned cold against her legs.

"Sea," she said, though the word meant nothing to them. She gave the three-note song and pushed westward pressure through water and bone.

First note: breath.

Second: opening.

Third: passage.

White roots carried the pattern toward Orra and Sea Gate. Clean springs answered from the west. Nhal's head turned a fraction.

Behind them, the palace line pulsed again. The mooncalf swung east.

Tavia changed what she offered. Not command. She opened the center basin's western drain so fresh Nightcourse water crossed Nhal's gills and continued toward the sea. The flow carried no stored change, only mineral cold and the pressure of an open direction.

Nhal followed the current.

Oren and Caun pushed the folded side sections into the west passage. Tavia guided the center as a measuring basin, keeping Nhal inside while the last controlled volume left through the drain. Crown soldiers regrouped on the tilting floor.

Their captain raised a horn.

Oren answered with his own Crown horn, one long keeper blast for structural failure. Training overrode pursuit. The soldiers looked up at the cracking reservoir roof and began evacuating the eastern chamber.

Tavia's party entered the west channel.

Behind them, White Root Lock shifted on returned foundation strain. Lower water found the old breathing mouths marked in the ledger. Surface crews, warned through the roots, had cleared two. The third remained blocked, and pressure broke its stone cover outward.

A reply chased them down the roots before the main arm moved. Surface runners had found Jori An beneath a quarry cart, conscious and unable to stand on the foot whose pain had returned. The cart had not struck him. Swelling had

dropped him beside it. Neighbors splinted the leg and carried him toward the clinic.

Tavia stopped waist-deep in the west channel to hear Caun translate every tap. One source body found. Alive did not make unharmed. She added Jori's name and condition to the reservoir slate copy.

Another signal reported the grain-store loss. Two hundred families would need replacement measures from unstilled reserves. The gray-haired keeper had opened an ordinary seed vault and posted guards chosen from the workers. Spoiled grain would be burned only after mold crews dug a trench downwind of houses.

"Our drink reaches tomorrow's meals," Caun said.

"Then tomorrow's meals go on the cost sheet."

Oren sent the House rhythm toward Perrin's westbound group, followed by the keeper code for partial structural release. Public proof would arrive alongside evidence that release itself harmed people. Tavia insisted on both. Hiding the ruined stores would rebuild Sere's logic with different hands.

The Crown captain appeared at the rear channel but did not follow. Cracks moved across the arch above him. He ordered his soldiers uphill, away from the gate housing. One man carried the trooper Caun had pulled from the stored-water pool. Their retreat cleared bodies from the first surge.

Nhal strained toward the palace line once more. Fresh western current crossed their gills, and Tavia sang the passage notes until their tail aligned downstream. Hunger remained. Guidance had not cured it.

The lock did not shatter. One gate arm lifted by the width of Tavia's hand, then another. Water entered the Nightcourse in a rising sheet. Loose roots bent west without breaking, showing the first surge had found room rather than a wall.

White Root Lock began to open behind them.

Chapter 18 — Every Gate Shut Westward

Sere held her left hand inside a bowl of stillwater while six couriers contradicted one another.

The youngest swore White Root Lock had shattered. The oldest had seen its eastern arm lift less than a hand. A quarry rider reported hundreds dead from returned illness. A House runner carried twelve names, all alive when he left. Two Crown soldiers insisted the mooncalf had swallowed the reservoir. Their captain's written report described measured releases and a structural retreat.

Sere kept her hand submerged until the tremor stopped.

Paleshell water drew joint age, skin change, and fatigue into the palace channel beneath the table. Silver needles on the recipient board swung toward Ward Seven, found broken routes, and diverted part of the load west through the overflow reservoir that Tavia's party had just opened.

The bowl clouded.

A brown spot appeared near Sere's thumbnail. It vanished, returned, and spread to the knuckle before Stiller Anset raised the held note.

"No higher," she said.

"Regent, the route will not maintain suspension at this pressure."

"Then let the hand change. Do not open another ward assignment."

Anset lowered the note. Age settled into her fingers. Veins rose beneath skin that had looked thirty-two for thirty-five years. Pain entered the thumb and remained. Her face held for the moment.

The couriers watched with the disciplined blindness of people who had learned which royal facts endangered witnesses.

"Again," Sere said. "One at a time. Separate sight from report."

She questioned them until contradiction took usable shapes. White Root had not shattered. Stored grain and timber had spoiled. Buildings cracked along old suspended strain. Twelve clinic patients received returned conditions; none had been reported dead before Crown forces withdrew. The mooncalf had survived and moved west in the Nightcourse.

More dangerous than any casualty number, surface crews had obeyed warnings carried through white roots. They had cleared storehouses, opened breathing mouths, and treated source patients without palace instruction.

"Who commanded them?" asked Minister Edran.

"Several people," the quarry rider said.

"Names."

He gave a keeper, a clinic healer, two store workers, Brother Caun, Tavia Sorn,

and a man he knew only as Jori's neighbor.

Authority had divided without disappearing.

Sere removed her hand from the bowl. Water clung to aged knuckles. "Council chamber. Bring the western charts."

The palace had lost several stilling lines during Bellhaven's rebound. Servants scraped fermented plaster from ceilings. A corridor arch stood on ordinary timber shores after its deferred cracks returned. Workers moved palace records away from damp with their own backs because motion stilling could no longer be trusted.

Sere passed each repair without comment. Every visible failure argued that the kingdom had lived inside borrowed time. Visible failure could also kill the clerk beneath an arch. Moral revelation did not hold up stone.

The Council assembled around an east-west map of Avelune. Colored pins marked refugee concentrations, lock pressure, grain reserves, ward witnesses, and known positions of Tavia's party. The map ended at Sea Gate. Beyond it, blue paint represented a cold sea that no minister governed.

"Every gate after Veyl closes westward," Sere said. "Hush, Red Step, Bell, White Root, Orra, Sea Gate. No trade craft, refugee column, House party, or animal passes west without a Crown seal issued today."

Closure traveled by different means. Hush received a copper-wire signal along the lock road. Red Step took a mounted copy because Bellhaven's broken channels distorted sound. Bell's order went downstairs to Captain Letha. White Root received drum code through a quarry shaft. Orra and Sea Gate heard by speaking pipe and relay bell.

Answers returned while the Council watched the map.

Hush obeyed and asked where to place three hundred east-basin families already on its western bridge. Red Step closed the gate but reported market carts blocking its north high road. Bell acknowledged receipt without the customary phrase under royal authority. White Root's keeper said one arm had begun lifting and could not close without crushing workers clearing a breathing mouth. Orra sealed pilgrim landings. Sea Gate stopped salt barges and warned that a hard west closure would strand fishing crews outside the night tide.

"Bring fishing crews east before full closure," Sere said. "White Root withdraws workers before lowering any arm. Hush opens the school heights. Red Step burns no spoiled goods until roads clear."

The secretary wrote each exception. An order that began as a single line acquired bodies, weather, and local limits as it traveled.

An Orra voice came through the pipe, faint with distance. "Does westward closure include burial craft?"

"Bodies may pass east for registered burial. None west."

"Saint Orra custom sends sea dead west."

"Suspend the custom. Keep names with bodies."

Sere heard what closure meant beyond strategy. A family could not finish its dead. A fisher outside Sea Gate could see home and lack a legal route to it. A clinic cart might wait while a guard judged papers. She added medical discretion and public logs, tools against cruelty that remained tools inside a cruel order.

The harbor minister stared. "Regent, shutting every gate against westward movement traps the east-basin refugees inside Bellhaven."

"High roads remain open north and south."

"Those roads cannot carry grain carts after rain."

"Then carts stay and grain feeds the basin."

"Or crowds take it."

Sere moved the grain pins to public yards. "Double open distribution. Keep posted weights. Place ward-chosen clerks beside Crown assessors. Hunger makes gates weaker than crowds do."

Her competence relieved them. She disliked how easily relief could hide the brutality of the first order.

Captain Letha did not attend. She had sent a written objection from the lower watch, citing people still trapped beneath the palace gates after the drill. Sere had not removed her. Bellhaven needed a commander whom the lower wards obeyed, even if that commander had begun treating royal orders as arguments.

"What of eastbound movement?" Edran asked.

"Open for evacuation, medical supply, and burial parties. Search for proof bundles. Seize records. Do not block food."

"Witnesses will travel as patients."

"Then inspect without delaying care."

"You ask guards to distinguish rebellion from fever on a roadside."

"I ask guards to exercise judgment. We have spent too long treating that as treason."

Several ministers looked at one another. Sere heard the contradiction. She wanted initiative from workers when it upheld her system and obedience when it threatened it. Every ruler called the boundary necessity.

The intelligence keeper unrolled copied testimony seized near Hush. Forty-three names. Assignment codes. Treatment sources. A charcoal key teaching any reader how to connect beneficiary cuts to ward rows.

At the bottom, Perrin Doss had pressed a marked thumb.

"Forgery?" Sere asked.

"Some pages, perhaps. Not the original strips distributed among them. We

verified three Crown paper stocks and one authentic ward header."

"How widely copied?"

"Unknown. Bellhaven walls carried six versions by dawn. Red Step market criers have read the names."

Edran leaned forward. "The wards must be contained before this becomes a pretext for seizure."

"Contained how?"

"Known witnesses removed from routes. Permanently, where public custody cannot become theater."

Nobody used kill.

Sere made him.

"You propose murder."

His face remained composed. "I propose preventing a basin war that will kill more."

"By killing children who document what we did to them."

"By acting before crowds turn every stiller, physician, and beneficiary into a target."

The risk existed. Already two clinic windows had been broken in Bellhaven. A hospice porter had been beaten because someone mistook his blue apron for a ward keeper's coat. Public truth did not guarantee discriminating anger.

"No witness dies by Crown order," Sere said. "Detain those carrying stolen records. Hold them separately in ordinary facilities above flood marks. No stilling, no hidden channels, no interrogation injury. Record every name and location for public inspection."

"They will speak from custody."

"Yes."

"Indefinite detention gives them martyrs without ending the proof."

"Then propose something that is not murder."

Edran sat back.

Sere knew indefinite could consume a life as thoroughly as a blade. The distinction mattered and did not absolve her. A visible prison allowed challenge, witnesses, release. It also preserved coercive control while she searched for a solution she no longer possessed.

She signed the detention order.

Before allowing patrols to use it, Sere inspected the proposed holding site. Edran had chosen a former salt warehouse above the second flood mark. Its walls carried no visible silver, but a channel finder rang near the north floor.

Workers lifted the bricks. A prepared line ran toward the palace laundry.

"Remove it," Sere said.

An engineer reached for cutters.

"Drain it first. Name the change."

The laundry register identified fabric aging suspended from ceremonial cloth. Attendants brought the original hangings into the warehouse yard and wet them with the channel water. Silk yellowed, split, and fell from its frames. The cloth paid its own deferred age. Only after the route went dull did engineers remove silver.

Sere ordered sleeping pallets off stone, open cooking hearths, three daily public name rolls, outside physicians chosen by House and Crown together, and written charges within one day. Edran objected to House physicians.

"Then do not call this protection from hidden wards," she said.

The first detainees arrived before the inspection ended: two printers carrying testimony sheets, an escaped ward clerk, and a grandmother whose cart held original assignment rows. Guards had tied their wrists. Sere ordered the cords removed inside the locked yard.

The grandmother recognized her. "Which name pays for your hand today?"

Sere looked at the aged knuckles she had failed to hide.

"Three assignment codes paid this morning. I stopped the route when White Root failed. I did not ask their names."

"You had thirty-five years to ask."

"Yes."

The woman's anger found no argument and did not need one. She held out both hands for the public register. "Write Vessa Orl. Detained carrying proof from Ward Seven. No charge given."

The clerk wrote it. Sere signed beneath the entry, placing royal authority where later challenge could find it.

Vessa looked at the signature. "A visible cage still has a lock."

"Yes."

Sere left guards at every door. Murder had been refused. Freedom had also been refused. She carried both facts back to the Council without asking either to cancel the other.

Next came the locks.

Hush had sufficient keeper strength but vulnerable drinking reservoirs. Red Step's western road remained clogged by ruined market goods. Bell's eastern housing had cracked; Captain Letha controlled lower approaches. White Root's gate had begun moving under released strain. Orra retained the strongest harvesting frame and the only active paleshell grinder. Sea Gate held the final salt pressure.

"Reinforce Orra," Sere said. "Move the grinder from its public reliquary chamber

to the lower lock works."

The chief stiller hesitated. "Saint Orra's mechanism has not been operated on living shell in eighty-one years."

"Can it be?"

"The teeth remain aligned. The guide relief complicates access. Later walls covered part of the maintenance route."

Tavia knew of the guide-channel. Sere had read Caun's seized route fragments. The old drawing showed Orra's open hand against a moonbrood jaw where palace iconography now displayed a spear.

"Seal the hollow relief passage," she said. "Do not damage the original until engineers record it."

Preserving evidence while preparing the machine it disproved. The contradiction no longer surprised her.

A palace physician entered without waiting for summons. He carried a mirror under cloth.

"Regent, your facial suspension has begun cycling."

"I have noticed my hand."

"The overflow route took a pressure reversal at White Root. Age may return by regions. We need to reassign the main channel."

"To whom?"

"Unregistered capacity remains in the prison infirmary."

"No."

"Object stores cannot accept continuous human age."

"Then reduce the suspension."

The physician uncovered the mirror.

Sere's reflection flickered. One breath showed the familiar smooth jaw, black hair untouched by gray, skin fixed near thirty-two. The next laid seventy years across the left side of her face. Her eyelid sagged. Brown spots spread over the cheek. Then stillwater pulled the changes away and youth returned.

Pain followed neither image consistently. Her body had become an argument between source and recipients.

She sent the Council out except Anset and the physician.

"How long if I end it now?" she asked.

"Unknown. Thirty-five years accumulated. Hours, perhaps minutes. Heart and vessels may take change before skin."

"And if we maintain current pressure?"

"Ward routes continue failing. Overflow will seek prepared living channels. It

may jump assignments."

"Meaning people we did not register."

"Yes."

Sere looked again. Her elder sister had died with a face older than this returned half, though she had lived twelve fewer years. After the assassination and wasting fever, advisers had called Sere's preservation a temporary continuity measure. One season became a year. Famine came. Succession threatened. Every crisis made ending the treatment irresponsible. Stability acquired a body count elsewhere.

She could release the stilling now and die before Orra. Another minister would inherit closed gates, a panicked city, and no authority broad enough to move keepers. That truth served her desire to live too neatly.

"Route no new bodies," she said. "Let failures return to me. Maintain only enough pressure to slow the accumulation."

Anset bowed. "You may not remain functional."

"Then report changes accurately."

The first reduced note aged a stripe of hair above Sere's left ear to white. Her right knee stiffened. Fatigue entered her chest like wet cloth. She remained standing.

A western courier arrived before sunset. Perrin's proof had reached an Orra weighing yard. Dockworkers refused to load paleshell stock. Pilgrims had scraped plaster from one of the saint's reliefs and exposed the curve of a hidden water passage.

Minister Edran advised sending a general.

Sere looked at the map. No subordinate could defend the grinder, close Orra, negotiate with pilgrimage keepers, and decide whether to destroy the last guide evidence without sending questions back to Bellhaven. Distance had become delay. White roots carried the rebels' signals faster than Crown horses carried command.

"Prepare my west barge," she said. "Archive charts, the mobile stilling basin, thirty engineers, two physician teams, and a hundred lower-lock guards. Move Saint Orra's grinder under my seal."

"Your condition makes travel dangerous," the physician said.

"Remaining here makes command fictitious."

She wrote the journey order herself. At the bottom she added two words that removed the chain of delegated discretion.

Personal command.

Preparation exposed what command meant in matter. Engineers loaded hand drills, timber braces, pumps, and blank pressure slates. Physicians rejected half the

mobile stillwater stock because no declared counterweights could travel within echo-distance. Sere ordered those vials left in the observatory under public seal.

The remaining vials named their uses and costs: emergency bleeding transferred into slaughterhouse cloth already saturated for disposal; brief fire arrest routed into soaked demolition beams; structural pause accepted by quarried stone loaded on the same barge. No human assignment traveled by her order. Existing channels could still seek one if the material stores failed, and Anset wrote that danger on each crate.

A hundred lower-lock guards assembled with arrest hooks, shields, rope, and six bows. Sere removed the bows from the front ranks.

"The mooncalf moves in water among civilians," she told their commander. "A missed arrow enters a pilgrim. Hooks only under direct order."

"If Tavia Sorn reaches the grinder?"

"Detain her. Keep her hands visible. Do not injure the animal unless it breaches the lock chamber."

The order preserved her option to grind Nhal while avoiding panic killing. It did not make the intended machine humane.

Her right cheek aged while she inspected the final manifest. A clerk tried not to stare. Sere handed him the page and waited until he checked every line rather than accepting a royal total.

"Two physician teams," he said. "Manifest names only one fever surgeon."

A second surgeon had been diverted to the lower wards. Sere left her there and reduced the traveling team. Personal command did not entitle Saint Orra to a healer Bellhaven needed more.

The west barge could not pass Bell Lock under full sail because returned strain had twisted one gate arm. Canal crews warped it through using ropes. Sere boarded at dusk with one side of her hair white and her face shifting between ages whenever the held note faltered.

On the lower quay, detention patrols tried to remove testimony sheets from walls. Crowds replaced each one. Grain kitchens remained open. Refugees slept beneath archive awnings while black-hulled record carriers waited under palace guard.

The first song rose near the exposed ward.

Three notes. Poorly matched, sung by people rather than carried through water.

A second group answered from a mill bridge. Then the east grain yard. Pressure entered the canal through thousands of throats and traveled along Bellhaven's damaged silver and ordinary stone alike.

Anset raised the basin note to still vibration around the barge. The crowd's song faltered for half a breath as motion moved into prepared rope counterweights. Fibers snapped under the load. The sound returned louder.

Sere ordered him to stop. More stilling would only send the song's motion into workers, buildings, or ward bodies. An ordinary echo crossed the water after the last rope snapped, and no register could assign the sound elsewhere.

Bellhaven crowds began singing three notes she could not still.

Chapter 19 — The Weathered Rise

Oren put his boot between the hostel door and its frame before the keeper could shut Perrin outside.

"No ward bodies," the man said. "My cistern serves families."

Rain ran from the eaves onto the narrow rise above Orra canal. Behind Oren, twenty-three escaped residents, Perrin among them, waited beside two low carts. Merra stood on her crutches. Sevi held the hand of a feverish boy. Perrin sat with his back against a wheel, conserving strength after the climb from White Roots.

"Weathering does not spread through drinking water," Oren said.

"Silver burns do."

"Only prepared channels carry change. Show me your silver."

The hostel keeper glanced toward the crowded weighing yard. Word of the ward convoy had reached Kell Rise before the bodies did. Townspeople watched from awnings with scarves over their mouths.

"No rooms," the keeper repeated.

Oren leaned into the door. His stitched left forearm sent pain to the wrist. "You accepted a Crown shelter payment this morning. That buys floor space for flood travelers."

"Not contagion."

Perrin spoke from the cart. "You have a silver pipe under the third rain barrel. It carries roof rot into the old tannery posts. That's more dangerous than I am."

The keeper went pale.

Merra turned to the watching yard. "Anyone here sleep in the tannery row?"

Five hands rose.

Fear changed direction.

Oren did not want it turned into a weapon against one man. "We inspect before anyone touches the channel. Open the flood hall. Keep the cistern separate until Sevi checks every patient."

The keeper yielded because the crowd had heard. The ward residents entered a broad room above the second white flood mark. Windows opened toward the canal. No silver ran in its walls. Sevi assigned one corner for fevers and another for people with open channel burns. Ordinary boiled water, cloth, and rest supplied care.

Merra posted the residents' names by the door so no one could call them a hidden ward again.

Oren inspected the rain-barrel pipe. It did carry roof rot toward tannery posts already soft with years of deferred decay. He tied a red warning cord around the

valve and wrote do not cut until roofs clear. Exposure without procedure could bring the building down on the people they meant to protect.

"Kell Rise closes westward at noon," the hostel keeper said behind him. "Regent's order."

"Where are the lower sluice crews?"

"Gate house."

"And flood stair leads?"

"Council says no flood expected if Orra holds."

White Root water had begun moving west under their feet. Orra might hold until it failed. Sere's closure had trapped trade carts, pilgrims, and refugee families on the wrong side of Kell Rise's canal gate.

Oren took his Crown horn from his pack.

The old brass looked out of place against his mud-dark coat. His insignia remained on the band. He climbed the weighing platform while merchants pulled their scales out of the rain.

One long note summoned lock keepers for structural failure.

Two short notes called lower-channel crews.

A descending third phrase ordered every mounted rider to report on foot.

The sound crossed Kell Rise. People who had ignored a deserter's voice recognized the work codes built into their days. Blue-coated keepers emerged from the gate house. Canal laborers left shutter crews. Three Crown riders dismounted with expressions balanced between obedience and arrest.

Keeper-Major Soll reached the platform first. "Kest, you have no authority to signal."

"The horn works. Water doesn't inspect my commission."

"Regent Valec ordered every gate closed westward."

"Then keep the west gate shut until the lower channels clear. If Orra pressure reaches you first, stone makes the opening for us."

Soll looked toward the road where proof sheets had begun appearing on walls. "You brought ward agitators."

"Ward residents. Their bodies carried your roof repairs and my daughter's treatment."

"That claim has no sealed proof."

Perrin rose from the cart.

It cost him. Sevi offered an arm; he accepted after choosing where she stood. Merra carried the waxed bundle. Together they climbed the weighing platform.

Perrin rolled back his sleeves.

Assignment marks ran from both wrists toward the elbows, pale branching scars dusted with silver. He pressed Enna's copied beneficiary pattern beside his thirty-seventh renewal cuts. Merra hung the Crown ward header where the crowd could see its seal.

"Perrin Doss," he said. "Ward Seven, North Twelve. Five years carrying marrow fever from a palace hospice. Thirty-seven renewals. Extra palace age when the channels overflowed."

Soll examined the strip without touching Perrin's arm. "Paper can be stolen."

"It was," Perrin said. "From the people who stole years from us."

A laugh moved through the crowd and died quickly.

Other residents came forward. Dasa showed the channel scar linked to palace wound closure. Merra named the ministerial house whose deferred structure killed her leg. Hale described organ damage without surrendering private details. Copies of the code key passed hand to hand among clerks, boat workers, and market weighers.

A Crown rider read one row and sat down on the platform edge.

"My mother had scar stilling after the quay fire," she said. "This date. This beneficiary class."

Dasa looked at her. "Then find the source name. Do not guess which of us paid."

The rider nodded.

A baker in a flour hood pushed to the platform. "My boy's burn stopped bleeding under stillwater. Are you saying I should have let him die?"

Perrin lowered his sleeves halfway, then changed his mind and left the marks visible. "I'm saying you should have been told whose bleeding started."

"I didn't choose you."

"Neither did I."

The baker looked toward Oren as if an adult in a former Crown coat might restore a simpler argument.

"Some stilling uses timber, cloth, fruit, or animals prepared for the cost," Oren said. "Your son's record names the channel. Find it before you decide what happened."

Archive clerks had not yet opened the gate house. The crowd could only speculate. Perrin refused to become a vessel for every accusation. He asked Merra for a shallow bowl and poured ordinary rainwater over one assignment mark. Silver dust rose but traveled nowhere because no held note activated it.

"This proves prepared silver entered me," he said. "The strip proves which route. My body proves damage. None of that tells you your child's source until we read the ledger."

The baker took off his flour hood. "If the source names someone here?"

"Then you listen before asking them to make you feel better."

A lock widow shouted that ward residents should be paid from palace grain. A merchant objected that compensation would empty public stores. Merra struck her crutch against the platform.

"We asked for shelter ten minutes ago. Start there."

The dispute narrowed into tasks. Two hostel owners offered upper rooms. A kitchen crew brought broth. Sevi requested clean bedding and received six bundles. Nobody settled compensation, guilt, or future law in the rain. They made bodies less cold while keeping the harder questions open.

Proof did not turn the crowd clean. Someone threw a stone at the hostel keeper. Oren caught the thrower's sleeve before a second stone left his hand.

"Records," Oren said. "Not heads."

"He hid a channel under families."

"Then seize the channel ledger. If you break the pipe, every roof year comes down now."

Keeper-Major Soll raised his voice. "The lock archives remain Crown property."

"They record change taken from this town," Merra answered. "People carrying it have a claim."

The crowd moved toward the gate house.

Oren climbed onto the rail. His left hand could not grip, so he hooked the elbow around a post.

"Listen," he shouted. "Sere's order closes west. I served orders like it because I called the danger above my rank. That did not move responsibility above me. If this gate stays shut without cleared channels, Kell Rise floods when Orra pushes back. If you smash it now, Kell Rise floods before people move."

Faces turned up through rain.

"Do not take weapons," he continued. "Take the ledgers. Copy source and counterweight routes. Put names on each sluice. Clear patients, prisoners, and workers from below the second mark. Leave a person at every mechanism with authority to stop. The Crown horn called you here. I am using it to speak against the Crown's order."

The declaration felt smaller than he had once imagined defection would. No rank fell from his shoulders. He had already carried out the acts. Words only made concealment impossible.

Soll removed the gate-house key from his belt.

"I cannot give you the arsenal," he said.

"Keep it locked. Open the archive room."

"They may destroy records."

Perrin held up the divided original strip. "We have learned not to."

Soll handed the archive key to the Crown rider whose mother had received scar stilling. "You and three market clerks witness every removal."

People entered the gate house without taking staves or blades. They carried out ledgers, channel diagrams, worker rosters, and detention lists. Copy tables formed under the weighing awnings. One clerk read sources aloud. Another marked buildings at risk if channels released. Weathered residents corrected codes.

The arsenal stayed locked. Soll posted two keepers at its door, one Crown veteran and one canal worker chosen by the yard. When three young men demanded hook-staves for defense against Sere's patrols, Perrin placed a copied ward ledger in their hands instead.

"Read North Twelve aloud," he said.

They stumbled over the code. Dasa taught them. By the end, none had taken a weapon, and three more voices could explain where wound closure traveled.

A mounted patrol arrived from the east while the first copies dried. Its sergeant ordered Soll to restore Crown custody. Soll showed him Sere's closure order, then the pressure level under Kell Rise and the blocked-mouth diagram.

"Arresting the copy tables does not clear that," he said.

The sergeant looked at Oren. "You are still a fugitive."

"Yes."

"Will you resist arrest?"

"Until the lower mouth opens. After that, ask again."

Rain struck the silence between them. The sergeant dismounted, handed his reins to a child at the high-route line, and told his patrol to move stalled carts. He had not pardoned Oren or renounced Sere. He chose the pressure under his boots over the paper in his pocket.

The uprising began with ink on wet boards, then acquired shovels.

A horn answered from the eastern road.

Oren knew the first phrase before the wagon appeared: Dunmere flood crew, free passage requested.

Ila Venn stood on the driver's board with rain pasted across her cropped hair. Six carts followed, carrying rolled skiff frames, lime tubs, pry bars, rope, and people from towns east of Bellhaven. Beside Ila sat Salo, broad as a flour bin, guarding sacks of hard bread.

She drove through the weighing yard until the crowd forced her to stop.

"I leave you alone for ten days," she called to Tavia, then looked around. "Where is Tavia?"

"Nightcourse below us," Oren said. "West with Nhal and Caun."

Ila climbed down. "And you kept your horn. I owe Caun a copper."

"You wagered on it?"

"He said guilt would make you throw it in a river. I said tools deserve better owners."

Her gaze dropped to his bandaged arm. She did not ask before checking whether his fingers moved. Tavia had told her enough over the root messages.

"I brought a safe sluice sheet for every lock district we crossed," Ila said. "And names."

She unrolled an oilskin packet on the weighing platform. Dunmere had assigned Senn at Veyl's mill race, healer Luss for immobile residents, and two fisher crews for burial recovery. Hush named a reservoir keeper, a school-height lead, and three boat families. Red Step chose dye-canal crews and Merra's House contact. Bellhaven listed Captain Letha for the lower gates, though no royal seal confirmed her acceptance.

"Letha sent this," Salo said.

He produced a small watch tablet bearing her scratched initials: Lower wards moving. Grain boats contested. Bell stop authority accepted.

Oren added it to the Bell sheet.

White Root crews had supplied their own names after the reservoir release. Orra and Sea Gate remained thin. Ila had contacts rather than accepted leaders.

"Then Kell Rise fills one gap," she said. "Who knows the lower mouths?"

Seven people raised hands. Ila questioned each until three admitted they had only seen the public grates. An old canal dredger named Vos Pell knew the buried fourth mouth under a salt shed. A laundress named Kedda organized the high route. Sevi accepted clinic and immobile-patient lead. Soll kept mechanism authority but agreed any of the three could stop opening.

They wrote the names on the lock wall.

Work divided outward. Crews shifted stalled trade carts off flood stairs. Children painted lime arrows toward high storage roofs. Boatwrights unfolded Ila's light skiffs near the western canal. Archive readers found two silver channels routed into lodging posts and one into a debtor workhouse outside town.

Nobody cut them.

Oren sent teams to warn every source building. Timber counterweights would receive accumulated strain only after rooms cleared. Living assignments required physicians and consent before any controlled release. Where consent could not be obtained, the lines stayed marked and connected until a safer plan existed. That choice left some people carrying stolen change longer. Immediate purity could injure them more.

At the buried fourth mouth, silt reached Oren's hip. His left arm could not shovel.

He used the horn to coordinate bucket timing while others dug. Ila worked beside Vos Pell with her adze, swearing at whoever had built a salt shed over flood infrastructure.

"Crown lease," Soll said.

"Then the Crown can come move it."

They moved it themselves.

The salt shed had no wheels. Crews unloaded forty barrels by hand, rolling each uphill to chalk marks outside the expected flood line. Every barrel carried a storage claim, and merchants arrived waving permits. Ila assigned two weighers to record ownership without letting paper halt the work.

Under the floor, builders had capped the fourth mouth with lime brick and routed a silver roof-strain channel across it. Cutting the cap immediately would release years from three boardinghouses.

Oren sent readers back to the seized ledgers. They identified the buildings, their occupants, and the counterweight posts in a debtor workhouse. Kedda took a door team through the lodging row. Sevi sent carts for two people unable to climb. Soll evacuated the workhouse under his own seal and left the gates open behind the last debtor.

Only after names returned did Ila score the lime around the cap.

"No grand swing," she told the shovel crews. "Take the mortar in cups. We want a mouth, not a grave."

Vos Pell, the old dredger, lay flat with one ear against the floor. He called the water level after each layer. Oren timed bucket lines with short horn notes. Children carried empty pails downhill and adults returned them full of silt, a reversal every person could understand without a proclamation.

The exposed silver route began humming as pressure changed. Soll wanted a stiller to hold it.

"No time," Oren said. "Can we put the roof years back into the roofs slowly?"

Ila examined the channel teeth. "Three branches. We open one after each building clears, let the timber settle, brace what moves."

At the first boardinghouse, shingles curled and two rafters sagged when their deferred strain returned. Fresh alder shores held them. The second lost a stair, already empty. The third remained standing but shed roof tile into the evacuated yard. Counterweight posts at the workhouse stopped accepting strain as each route drained.

Residents saw what controlled return looked like: damage, labor, lost rooms, no miracle. They also saw the weathered debtors walk free before the posts failed.

When the silver dulled, Ila cut it away from the cap. Crews removed the final bricks. Silt-water coughed through the opening, weak at first, then steady. The buried mouth carried ordinary canal pressure toward the lower channel.

Oren wrote all three damaged buildings on the public board. A merchant suggested omitting them until after evacuation to prevent panic.

"No," Kedda said. "People sheltering under the next roof need to know what opening costs."

Her answer went up beside the water level.

By dusk, brown water threaded through the reopened channel. Kell Rise's basin level dropped a thumb. Not enough to declare safety. Enough to make the next surge less sudden.

Perrin read assignment names in the weighing yard while copies traveled west on foot and east by Ila's carts. Townspeople offered the ward residents rooms without being ordered. Some offers came from shame, some conviction, some fear of public notice. Sevi inspected each room for silver before accepting.

Oren stood at the canal wall and listened to keeper signals multiply along the road. No single commander controlled them. Each lock reported local levels, cleared mouths, people remaining below marks, and names of those authorized to stop.

A runner climbed from the western root shaft after dark. She carried no Crown coat, only a quarry lamp and Caun's red cord around one wrist.

"Message from the Nightcourse," she said. "Nhal passed the deep fork. Surface watchers saw light under the Orra pilgrim road."

The yard quieted.

Oren asked the distance.

"Less than half a day. Crown barges reached Saint Orra first."

News moved across Kell Rise that Nhal had been sighted approaching Saint Orra.

Chapter 20 — The Taking at Saint Orra

Tavia had one hand beneath Nhal's jaw when the pilgrimage bells began.

The mooncalf rolled in the cradle-boat, too weak to dive and too restless to lie quiet. Their gills worked against Tavia's palm in a broken rhythm. With every third breath, a tremor passed down the four fin-limbs and shook silver light across the flooded quarry. The water around them smelled of lime and old rain.

"Not hunger," Brother Caun said from the stern. He held a strip of linen against the water and watched its fibers curl. "Fear."

"I know fear when it breathes on my hand."

Tavia shifted her stiff knee against the boat's frame. The bells beyond the quarry wall sounded bright, numerous, and deliberately cheerful. Saint Orra had twelve public bells. She had counted fourteen notes.

Oren heard it too. He crouched on the broken loading stair with his Crown horn under his coat and studied the road above. "Two field bells added at the north landing. Festival summons."

"On Day Seventeen?" Caun asked.

"On any day the Regent needs enough bodies in one place to make a witness look like consent."

Along the quarry rim, white ribbons snapped in the sea wind. Pilgrims moved between them carrying bowls, candles, and blue-glazed saint figures. Their procession filled the causeway to Saint Orra, an island city built across the Nightcourse's sixth lock. Beyond the tiled roofs, the lock towers stood like pale fingers around a sheet of water that did not stir.

Tavia lifted her palm from Nhal's throat. Cold light remained in the old rope scars. "We cannot take them under the island without seeing what has been changed."

Oren's attention stayed on the road. "Every visible way in has keepers."

"Then we enter visibly."

Caun looked at the mooncalf, then at the festival crowd. "That sounds like faith."

"It is triage. A hidden patient can be cut where no one has to admit seeing blood."

She folded the wet linen around Nhal's neck ridges, spoke the low note that asked for stillness without commanding it, and felt the answer travel through water and bone. No spell left her mouth. The pressure-song came from Nhal's body; their slowing muscles changed the boat's wake, while the effort drew heat from their own blood. Tavia named that cost silently because no one else could carry it for them.

They pushed out of the quarry channel among grain scows dressed as

pilgrimage barges.

Saint Orra rose around them in layers. Flood stairs descended from limewashed houses to the sacred basin. Blue tiles showed the saint standing over a coiled black creature, one heel planted upon its neck. Vendors sold small cakes shaped like broken eggs. Crown cloth covered the lock machinery, transforming capstans and guide rails into festival columns. Above all of it, on a temporary platform at the western landing, Regent Sere Valec waited beneath a white canopy.

Her face looked thirty-two. Tavia knew the bodies that paid for every smooth year.

The crowd noticed Nhal by degrees. A child pointed. A candle dropped into water. Then heads turned along the embankment, and the turning passed through thousands like wind through rushes. Some pilgrims knelt. Others backed toward the houses. A woman began the first note of the old birthing song and stopped when a keeper seized her wrist.

Tavia guided the cradle-boat toward the public landing. Ila had built its three folding sections to survive bad currents, not reverence. One gunwale carried a split from Red Step. Linen patches covered teeth marks Nhal had made during the Bellhaven convulsion. Among polished saint barges, it looked honest enough to offend.

A keeper skiff crossed their bow and forced them toward the procession lane. Its pilot wore festival white over working leathers. He never looked at Nhal directly; his eyes stayed on the iron frame beneath the cradle-boat, measuring where a hook might catch. Two old women in the skiff carried baskets of paper moons. Their wrists bore the ridged silver burns Tavia had seen on weathered bodies.

One woman leaned close as the hulls passed. "They told us the lower shelter opened at noon."

"Has it?" Tavia asked.

"Door has. Road to it has soldiers." The woman dropped a paper moon into the water. Instead of softening, it skated over the perfectly flat surface. "My son keeps the east capstan. He says no one has tested the spillway since winter."

The pilot struck his tiller with one knuckle. Warning, not disagreement.

"Tell him to clear the spillway by hand if the holding fails," Tavia said. "Start at the lowest weed rack. Keep every person uphill of the markers."

"Markers got plastered over for the saint's day."

"Then find the old damp line on the brick. Water remembers where officials prefer not to."

The skiff fell behind. Tavia watched the woman pass the instruction to a boy on the landing, who ran without waiting for a Crown seal. One body, one task, one named risk. Enough repetitions of that might become an evacuation without turning anyone into arithmetic.

Near the city's south flank, pilgrims had tied offerings to the lock rail. Baby shirts hung beside fishermen's gloves and strips of burial cloth. Each represented a change the giver wished Orra to prevent: a child growing ill, a hand losing strength, a dead person leaving memory. Crown priests walked the rail with bowls of stillwater, touching a drop to every knot. The petitions looked harmless until Tavia followed the fine silver wire woven through the rope. It led under the platform and out toward the sheds.

A young father held his infant over a bowl while a priest sounded a note. The baby's reddened birthmark faded. Across the basin, one of the shackled laborers flinched and raised a hand to the same side of her neck, where fresh discoloration spread.

"Stop," Tavia called.

The priest startled. His note broke, and color returned at once to the child's skin. It returned naturally because only a breath of change had been displaced. The woman across the water kept the transferred ache until the silver circuit discharged.

The father clutched his baby. "The mark might grow."

"So might the child," Tavia said. "Ask which one you mean to prevent."

He stared from her to the laborer. No answer could fit inside the festival blessing he had purchased.

Caun lifted the paper moon from the water with his paddle. It had not absorbed a drop. "Paleshell in the whole basin."

"Enough for how long?"

"Given fresh counterweights, an afternoon. Given those sheds, less. Given people, Sere can keep buying minutes until someone cuts the channels."

Oren tracked the wire toward three valve boxes built into the north stair. "Boxes have paired locks. Palace key and local keeper key."

"Can you open the palace side?"

"Not since I declined to remain a useful man." He touched the horn beneath his coat. "I can make them think an officer has arrived."

"Save it. The people who need that horn have not chosen us yet."

He accepted the answer with a shallow nod. Tavia valued that more than obedience. Once he would have spent authority first and asked whose trust it consumed after.

They passed under a rope arch where children sang the approved saint's hymn. Its melody had taken the old three notes and bent the final one upward, turning guidance into triumph. Nhal shivered at the false interval. Tavia laid a wet cloth across their eyes until the pressure in the boat eased.

"Bad song?" Caun asked.

“Wrong instruction. It asks a birthing body to close.”

At the arch’s base, masons had set new tiles over older stone. One tile had come loose. Behind it, Tavia glimpsed the curved tip of a carved finger pointing downriver. The city had needed constant repair to maintain its lie. That meant seams remained everywhere.

Oren stood forward with both hands visible. His left forearm remained bound beneath his sleeve. He had kept his sword but tied the grip with white cord, a declaration that he would not draw first.

“North parapet,” he murmured. “Six hooks under canvas. West stair, eight riders without horses. More behind the shrine.”

Tavia saw the canvas but not the hooks. “Water?”

“Too flat.”

Stillwater, then. Paleshell ground into the sacred basin and activated by a held note. It suspended motion by sending every stolen current through silver channels into a chosen counterweight. The Crown banners concealed fresh lines running uphill. At their far ends, cheap brick sheds trembled under the strain. Whatever movement the basin refused would enter those walls until the walls cracked or the stored debt came home.

Caun touched her shoulder. “The western arch.”

Beneath the platform, an old stone relief ran along the landing wall. Orra’s carved body faced east, arms raised. The moonbrood beneath her had been chipped into a posture of submission, but one section near the tail showed older lines: parallel ripples passing behind the saint’s left hand. New plaster filled a descending groove.

A guide-channel. Not a road for conquerors. A midwife’s passage around the grinding works.

Tavia’s grandmother had drawn the same shape in flour when teaching her how to turn a shoulder-stuck infant. Make room before asking the body to pass.

The cradle-boat touched the landing posts. No keeper reached for the rope.

Sere came to the platform edge. She wore no crown, only a dark coat clasped at the throat with a crescent of paleshell. The lack of ceremony carried its own calculation.

“Tavia Sorn,” she said. The bells ceased behind her. “You have brought the creature farther than anyone believed possible.”

“Your people believed it possible. You put gates in its road.”

Murmurs spread along the lower stairs. Sere let them run until each person had heard the sharpness and the Regent’s patience in receiving it.

“Bellhaven has begun evacuation,” she said. “At my order, the lower canals can carry twenty thousand before the eclipse ends. Saint Orra can open its eastern

shelters. The western grain road can remain clear.”

Oren breathed once through his nose. Tavia heard the numbers as he did: places chosen, bodies omitted.

“What do you require?” she asked.

“Place the mooncalf in the sanctuary pool. You and your companions will receive safe conduct. The ward residents already outside Crown custody may remain free.”

Caun made a small sound of disgust.

Tavia kept her gaze on Sere. “And those still inside?”

“They require care.”

“They require release.”

“Release returns every illness, year, and wound suspended on their behalf. You know that.”

“I know what ordinary treatment looks like. I know how to tell a patient the truth before touching them.”

Sere’s expression changed by less than a breath. “You would trade immediate lives for a principle.”

“No. I refuse to trade hidden lives for your appearance of mercy.”

The crowd heard that. Several people looked directly at Sere’s face, at its unlined skin under a white strand of hair. Keepers tightened around the platform.

Sere descended one stair. “I have barges loading in Bellhaven. I have field kitchens on the heights. I have opened stores that your uprising would have left locked while it argued about guilt. Surrender the animal, and I will extend evacuation west of the Bell. Refuse, and the uncontrolled break will take every lower ward before your messengers clear a tenth of it.”

Tavia looked beyond her to the sacred basin. “Open Orra Lock. Clear the lower spillways. Let Nhal pass.”

“The other gates remain shut.”

“Then send the order.”

“A sequence improvised by village keepers cannot hold a kingdom.”

“It has held this road for two days without you.”

That landed harder than accusation. The pilgrimage crowd included lock families. Tavia saw recognition move among them: muddy sleeves, raw hands, sleepless faces. Sere saw it too.

Nhal struck the cradle-boat with their tail.

Water lifted over the gunwales. Tavia dropped to both knees, caught the mooncalf behind the forward fins, and felt stored change burning beneath the basin. The sacred water held years of arrested wear from Orra’s machinery: gear teeth that had not thinned, foundation piles that had not rotted, saint mosaics that

had never loosened. Silver channels had carried that decay into hillside counterweight sheds and living ward bodies. Nhal sensed the debt as food.

“Easy,” Tavia whispered. “Not here. Not all of it.”

Their heartbeat battered her wrists.

Sere raised two fingers.

Oren shouted, “Down.”

Canvas snapped away from the north parapet. Six hooked lines flew. Tavia dragged Nhal sideways as iron teeth struck the boat. One hook lodged through the folding hinge. Another grazed scales and flashed white. Caun cut at a line with his herb knife.

The crowd broke in three directions. Festival bowls shattered underfoot. Keepers on the west stair drove people uphill while hidden soldiers emerged from the shrine.

Tavia sang the first note.

Pressure burst from Nhal. Ordinary basin water rose in a ring, driven by muscle and song. At once, Sere’s paleshell clasp answered. A keeper behind the platform held a pure high tone through a silver throat pipe. Stillwater flattened the ring before it reached the parapet. The arrested motion leapt into the prepared channels. Uphill, a counterweight shed buckled so violently that roof tiles flew.

“Brick!” Tavia shouted. “They’re paying with the sheds!”

“Not only brick,” Caun said.

A line of shackled laborers stood behind the western banners, each person wearing a silver ankle loop. The diverted force bent their bodies toward the basin. One man’s shoulder dislocated with a dry jump. A woman’s knee folded. Movement denied in water had crossed echo-distance and entered joints instead.

Tavia stopped singing.

Sere had built the trap around her refusal to spend strangers.

Hooks came again. Oren caught one line around his bound forearm, turned with it, and pulled a soldier from the stair. His tied sword stayed sheathed. Caun freed the cradle hinge and shoved the boat toward open water.

“East channel!” Oren called.

“No.” Tavia pointed to the altered relief. “Under the platform.”

A keeper lunged from the landing. She struck his wrist with her recovery hook, caught his coat, and used his weight to send him into the shallows. Her left knee flared. Someone seized her braid; she drove her head backward and heard teeth meet.

Nhal twisted between the boat’s braces. Their translucent scales darkened until moving constellations vanished. Hunger and fear had turned them toward the stillwater under the saint’s landing.

Tavia pressed both burned palms to their flank. "Three notes. With me."

She gave the first low tone, the second rising through the sternum, then the third dropped almost below hearing. The song changed pressure in the cradle-boat. Nhal answered, spending body heat to thrust water through the submerged groove. Plaster cracked along the relief. A dark seam appeared behind Orra's carved hand.

The old guide-channel remained there, sealed but not destroyed.

"Again," she said.

Before she could breathe, a hook punched through the water.

It entered Nhal below the left forward fin.

Their whole body bowed. No cry came in air, only a pressure blow that struck Tavia's ribs and threw her against the gunwale. Blood streamed from the wound in luminous black cords. Wherever it touched the basin, old silver markings shone beneath stone and plaster. The hidden channel flared from the landing wall westward, around the grinder foundations, and down toward Orra Lock's lower throat.

The crowd saw it. The saint did not stand upon the creature in the newly lit design. She knelt beside it, one arm pointing toward the open passage.

"Pull slack!" Tavia yelled.

Oren wrapped the hook line around a mooring post. A soldier on the parapet worked the winch. Between them, Nhal's flesh tore another finger's width.

Caun climbed onto the landing and cut the silver ankle line joining the laborers. The held note from the throat pipe faltered as one freed woman kicked the musician behind the knee. Water surged waist-high over the stair.

Oren hauled once. The mooring post cracked.

A Crown rider struck him from the side with a hook pole. He fell across the cradle-boat. The pole's iron butt landed under his right arm, and Tavia heard a rib give before his breath vanished. His face went gray, but his hands kept the line pinned.

"Let go," she said.

"No." The word came without air.

"Your right rib is cracked."

"Later."

Tavia reached beneath the water for the hook shaft. Its barbs had opened inside muscle. Pulling backward would enlarge the wound. She needed to push through, cut the head, then withdraw the smooth end. Her recovery kit hung at her hip. She found bone nippers by touch.

Nhal thrashed. Each motion fed the cage-lines being thrown from the landing. Silver cords settled across the basin, drank movement, and sent its burden into the

remaining counterweights. Stone split uphill. Shackled workers screamed as their tendons jerked.

"Name it!" Tavia shouted at Sere. "Tell them what pays!"

The Regent stood knee-deep on the lower stair, coat dragging in black water. "Open the object channels."

An officer hesitated. "They are saturated."

"Open them."

Valves turned beneath the platform. The next stolen surge left the workers and ran into timber stacks, fruit bins, and sacrificial ice stored in vaults under the shrine. Beams aged to punk. Pears collapsed into sour mash. Ice fractured and melted. Sere had changed the counterweight when forced to witness its human shape, but she had not ended the trap.

Tavia braced the hook shaft against her forearm. "Hold their shoulder."

Caun splashed back into the boat and fixed both hands above Nhal's fin. Oren, barely breathing, kept the line slack. Tavia pushed. The barb emerged through scales beside the entry wound.

Nhal's tail struck the landing.

Stone gave way along the revealed guide-channel. A wedge of old masonry slid into the basin. Water found the opening and began to turn west.

Tavia snapped one barb with the nippers. She reached for the second.

The throat pipe sounded again.

This note came from three keepers at once. Paleshell clouded the basin, pale as ground teeth. Stillwater caught the moving wedge of water and held it in a glassy curve. The source change, motion from Nhal and the opening channel, traveled into fresh silver cables that ran not uphill but down through the lock foundation.

"What pays now?" Caun asked.

Oren looked toward the cloth-covered capstans. "The gate."

Orra Lock took the burden. Iron pins groaned as stored movement entered them. The mechanism could contain minutes, perhaps an hour, before every arrested surge returned through its own metal.

Sere had converted the sixth lock into a cage with a delayed execution inside it.

Crown nets dropped from the platform. Tavia cut the second barb and pulled the hook's broken stem free, but a weighted edge struck her shoulders. She went under. Net cord pinned her elbows. Black blood and paleshell dust obscured the water.

Her scarred palms found Nhal's side through the mesh. Their heartbeat raced against hers. She tried the first note, swallowed water, and coughed it out.

Hands dragged her toward the landing. She hooked one boot around the cradle brace. Oren clung to the other side, his right arm locked against his ribs. Soldiers

pulled until the folding boat twisted at its middle hinge.

"Don't break it," Tavia gasped.

Oren's mouth shaped something she could not hear.

A keeper brought the butt of a pole down toward his head. Tavia released her boot and caught the blow across her bruised right shoulder. Pain whitened the landing. Her fingers opened.

The net took her.

Across the basin, lock workers rolled out a structure hidden behind the shrine: a cage of silver hoops nested around a shallow iron cart. Water within its rings remained perfectly flat despite the struggle. The lines from Nhal's net fed directly into it.

Every movement the mooncalf made entered the cage as suspended change. Silver carried that motion into Orra Lock's pins, into saturated timber, into crumbling fruit, and into any living counterweight the officers chose to reconnect. Nothing disappeared. The debt gathered for later.

Caun tried to reach the valve platform. Three soldiers forced him down. Oren rose once, failed for lack of breath, and knelt in the water with one hand pressed to his right side.

Tavia saw Sere watching him. Not cruelly. That made the Regent harder to forgive.

"Stop this," Tavia said.

"Tell the animal to be still."

"They cannot understand your bargain."

"They understand pain."

"So do you."

For the first time, age crossed Sere's face while Tavia watched. Fine lines appeared beside her mouth. One eyelid sagged, then smoothed as the silver clasp at her throat brightened. Somewhere along a prepared channel, another body received the hours she had refused.

The sight sickened Tavia more than a threat would have.

Sere signaled. Winches drew Nhal from the cradle-boat.

The mooncalf's weight came onto the net. Their wound opened around the left forward fin, and black light ran down their belly. As they crossed above the glowing relief, blood filled the last carved grooves. Orra's complete posture emerged: one hand guiding the creature, the other opening seven fingers toward the west. Below, a narrow maintenance route bent behind the saint's island and entered the lockworks under the grinding room.

Tavia fixed its turns in her memory. Down three steps. Left beside the split crescent. Follow the old drain beneath the plastered tail.

A soldier clamped iron around her wrists.

"Leave her hands in front," Sere said. "A midwife without hands becomes reckless."

"Kind of you."

"Practical."

The cage closed around Nhal. They struck once against the silver hoops. Nothing moved outside them. The force traveled away in a blue-white pulse. Under the island, Orra Lock answered with a sound like a tooth breaking.

The crowd had fallen silent. Pilgrims packed the stairs and roof walks, no longer fleeing. They had seen the old relief. They had seen the counterweights fall. Sere possessed the mooncalf, but she had failed to preserve the shape of her story.

Tavia looked for Oren. Soldiers held him upright between them. His tied sword remained in its sheath. Caun knelt nearby with blood on his mouth. Both lived. For now, that had to enter the count.

A hood came down over Tavia's face.

They took her through wet corridors where gears shuddered behind stone. Her left knee struck stairs. The silver cuffs warmed whenever Nhal moved somewhere ahead, sharing the cage's stored movement through a secondary line. She felt each panicked turn as pressure in her finger bones. The change came from Nhal's trapped body; the cuffs sent a fraction into her joints; she paid in swelling and pain so the cage could appear motionless.

At one landing, the hidden guide-channel sounded beyond the wall. Ordinary water ran there, thin but persistent, following the route Nhal's blood had revealed.

Tavia counted the turns before someone struck the back of her head.

She woke on cold tile with her wrists chained to a floor ring.

The hood had been removed. A round chamber rose around her, half shrine and half workshop. Paleshell dust whitened the drains. Through iron bars opposite, Nhal lay inside the stillwater cage. Their gills barely disturbed the water. Silver cords ran from every hoop into the wall, carrying each attempted movement toward waiting counterweights.

Tavia tested the chain once. The floor ring held.

Beyond the door, a grinder began its empty morning trial. Stone turned against stone, slow enough to count.

Nhal's dark eye found her. Their tail tried to move. Blue light entered the cage lines instead.

Tavia put both palms flat on the tile and listened for the thin water behind the wall.

Chapter 21 — A Cage Made of Tomorrows

Sere set two fingers against the cage's nearest hoop and felt tomorrow trying to break her hand.

The silver looked still. Beneath her skin, however, Nhal's arrested motion struck in quick, irregular blows. A tail sweep entered the hoop, traveled through the floor channels, and reached Orra Lock as stored movement. The mechanism's iron pins accepted the force for now. Whatever exceeded their capacity passed into timber vaults, fruit stores, sacrificial ice, and six human bodies whom the officers had not yet disconnected.

"Remove the living line," Sere said.

Master Keeper Jol stared at the gauges. "Regent, the object stores are above nine marks."

"Then brace the lock."

"We would have to open the eastern spillway."

"Open it by one hand."

"The festival landings sit below that line."

"They are already clear."

Jol glanced toward the shrine wall, as though a painted saint might relieve him of choosing which order to fear. He closed the copper valve feeding the human circuit. In the adjoining room, six sets of chains stopped rattling. A second gauge jumped hard enough to bend its needle.

Sere withdrew her fingers. Pain lingered in each joint. Thirty-five years ago, before physicians had refined palace stilling, she had thought pain always conveyed useful information. Since then she had learned that pain could arrive too late, too widely, or inside a person with no authority to answer it.

That lesson had justified too much.

Across the circular chamber, Tavia Sorn sat chained to a floor ring. Wet hair dried in uneven points around her face. Her wrists had swollen around the irons, yet she held her palms to the tile as if taking a pulse through stone. She had watched Sere order the living counterweights disconnected and showed no gratitude.

"Does that improve my character?" Sere asked.

"No."

"Your judgment comes quickly."

"I've had practice with bodies. A person who stops pressing after the bone breaks did not prevent the break."

The cage stood between them. Nhal lay in shallow water inside seven nested

hoops. Black blood clouded the bandage below their left forward fin. Every gill movement tightened a thread of blue light along the silver. The apparatus suspended the movement rather than removing it. Orra's foundation absorbed part of the transferred change; the remaining debt waited in objects already close to failure.

On the wall, a counterweight slate listed what the cage had consumed since noon. Forty-three roof beams had taken seven years of rot each. Two cellars of winter apples had received a season's spoilage and collapsed into vinegar froth. The ice house had melted so quickly that three workers suffered scald-like cold burns. Orra Lock itself held the force of nine hundred tail strokes in pins designed for ordinary water pressure. Beside those entries, a clerk had written six human names and then crossed them out at Sere's order.

Crossing out the names did not undo the hours before disconnection. One laborer had absorbed the wrench of Nhal's trapped spine into her own. Another had taken fin-strain through both ankles. Palace physicians could set the injuries, but any stillwater used in treatment would only choose fresh recipients. Sere sent a written order for ordinary splints, poppy broth, and passage out of Saint Orra under their own names. It cost little. She had once believed inexpensive mercy proved the larger system merciful too.

A second slate carried the future loads. Grinding would stop Nhal's living movement, release the cage debt into the stone, and break the shell into paleshell powder. Mixing that powder into the western reservoirs could still bleeding in the evacuation hospitals and hold Sea Gate during reinforcement. Each use required a counterweight. The projected column named condemned warehouses, harvested orchards, winter ice, and livestock. A sealed appendix held the living assignments needed after those objects saturated.

Tavia followed her gaze. "How many pages in the appendix?"

"Fewer than last year."

"Because you needed fewer people?"

"Because the wards have been disrupted."

"Then your answer depends on running out of prisoners."

"My answer depends on getting through the flood."

"You keep speaking as if there will be a clean afterward."

Sere looked at the hairline crack. "Afterward never arrives clean. It arrives governed or it arrives hungry."

The phrase sounded like one of her sister's council lessons. She regretted it as soon as it entered the room. Tavia did not challenge the rhetoric. She only touched two fingers to the tile and counted another delayed beat from the cage.

Sere had commissioned the design for an egg. No engineer had promised it could contain a living mooncalf for more than half a day.

"Treat the wound," she told the palace physician.

The man beside the drain bowed without moving. "The hoops cannot open while it is active."

"Reach through."

"It bites."

Tavia lifted her head. "So do I. Come closer if that decides your courage."

Sere almost smiled. Almost did many things, these days, before remembering how witnesses priced them.

"Give her the instruments," she said.

Jol protested. "She can cut the cage lines."

"Not through iron bars and three paces of open floor."

A guard unlocked one wrist from the floor ring, kept the other chained, and passed Tavia a shallow copper tray. She examined the needle, boiled linen, fish-oil salve, and curved forceps with the offended concentration of a tradeswoman handed ceremonial tools.

"This thread has stillwater in it," she said.

"For bleeding," the physician replied.

"Whose bleeding?"

"Standard hospice supply."

Tavia laid the thread aside. "Then it closes one wound by opening another through a silver channel. Bring plain gut."

The physician flushed. Sere sent him for it.

While they waited, she walked the cage circumference. A hairline crack had appeared in the tile beneath the western hoop. Lime dust rose with every attempted turn of Nhal's body. Tomorrow did not sit patiently inside silver. It accumulated pressure, found flaws, and waited without mercy.

"What did you call it in your plans?" Tavia asked. "The breaking point."

"The tolerance."

"Cleaner word."

"More exact."

"Exact about iron. Not about who stands beside it."

Sere stopped opposite her. "You speak as though naming a body prevents its death."

"No. Naming prevents us from pretending no one chose it."

Outside, crews hauled braces through the grinding corridor. Their boots beat a rhythm across the floor, then went quiet whenever the cage drank too much motion. Saint Orra had been designed to harvest stillness from a dead shell. Now

every wall carried the trapped effort of a living animal.

The physician returned with untreated gut. Tavia threaded the needle using one hand and her teeth.

"How?" she asked.

Sere understood. "A service port in the lower hoop. Jol will hold it open for six breaths."

"That gives me one pass through the wound."

"Then make one pass sufficient."

Tavia's gaze sharpened. "You think competence turns lack into enough. That may be how palaces count."

"It is how famine kitchens count."

Jol opened the port. At once, a slice of Nhal's unsuspended motion reached the chamber. Water slapped the bars. The mooncalf convulsed. Tavia thrust both arms through, caught the torn flesh, washed out iron grit, and closed the worst edge with four fast stitches. Sere counted six breaths and ordered the port shut.

One tail stroke escaped before the hoop sealed. It traveled as ordinary force, struck the chamber wall, and knocked a saint mosaic loose. Tiles fell where Sere had stood moments before.

Tavia drew back with blood to her elbows. "Their body supplied the movement. Your cage diverted it into Orra Lock. Opening the port returned one stroke here. That names the magic plainly. Now tell me where you intend to send the rest."

"Into the grinder."

Nhal's paleshell could accept movement until the body died. Ground shell would carry stalling west for another generation, if mixed into sufficient reservoirs and routed through renewed channels. The thought came with all the old columns attached: grain saved from rot, mothers spared fatal bleeding, bridge piles held through winter, Enna Kest granted another week. No column showed the faces in Ward Seven unless someone forced the page open.

The ledger called it movement debt. Beneath every figure waited one named body, whether the page admitted the name or not.

Sere had ordered the grinder prepared in Bellhaven and called it contingency rather than authorization. She had kept the order from her council as though secrecy and conditional language made the machine less hers. Now its teeth waited one floor below.

"The grinder kills them," Tavia said.

"Yes."

No euphemism earned Sere a brief silence.

"Then the cage does not preserve life," the midwife said. "It preserves your option to take it later."

"The cage preserves the time in which I may move sixty-three thousand people out of a basin."

"Your soldiers blocked the shelter road today."

"To keep a festival panic from crushing the stairs."

"They blocked it before we arrived."

Sere had not ordered that. Local officers anticipated royal preferences because anticipation advanced careers. Central authority produced speed precisely by making every minor cruelty unnecessary to specify.

She turned toward Jol. "Who closed the shelter approach?"

"Provost Dain."

"Remove him from command."

"Now, Regent?"

"Before he has time to interpret me again."

The master keeper left. Tavia watched him go.

"You prune one branch," she said.

"And you would burn the orchard."

"I would stop watering it with people."

Sere crossed to the narrow table where maps of the western basin lay pinned beneath glass. Blue lines marked flood depth after one simultaneous break. The lowest districts vanished. Red lines showed the sequential model from palace engineers. Even under favorable timing, the river claimed streets, bridges, hospitals, and grain yards. Weather from the sea could make either projection worthless.

She unpinned the first casualty sheet and laid it near Tavia.

"Read."

"My hands are occupied."

Sere read aloud. "An immediate Orra failure sends a crest east into White Root and west against Sea Gate. Bellhaven's lower basin receives rebound within seven hours. Expected dead range from nine thousand to twenty-eight thousand before evacuation."

"Expected by whom?"

"Engineers who know the channels."

"Engineers who left the guide-channel out of their saint."

"The guide-channel can carry a mooncalf. It cannot carry a city's flood."

"Then clear the lower sluices in sequence."

"With what labor? Your organizers have lock keepers, sick ward residents, town reeves, and untrained crowds."

"With people who know where they live."

Sere spread the second sheet. "A kingdom cannot rest on every person doing the needed thing at the needed hour."

"It already does. You hide the fact under uniforms."

The answer irritated her because it approached truth through insolence. Sere's stores opened only when clerks counted sacks, boat crews accepted orders, bakers stretched flour, street wardens marked doors, and mothers carried children uphill. A command coordinated hands; it never replaced them. Yet hands divided by fear could destroy what cooperation built.

"I saw the Northern Hunger," she said. "Not in a ledger. I stood at the river stairs while people tore grain from a barge before it could unload. Six drowned in flour paste and bilge. A boy lost his arm under a wheel because everyone believed someone else would stop pushing. By the third week, villages barred their roads against families who had walked four days. We restored ration lines with soldiers."

Tavia's expression did not soften. "And afterward?"

"We built the canal reserves."

"You built wards."

"We built both."

That distinction had once seemed decisive. A harmful instrument could serve a necessary system if authority limited its use. Then limits became emergency exceptions, exceptions became precedent, and precedent acquired offices. Sere had signed each expansion. No dead predecessor occupied her hand.

"The weathering wards distribute what would otherwise fall in one place," she said. "Aging across ninety-six residents instead of a collapsed hospital. Fever in assigned bodies instead of plague through a district. Structural strain in condemned houses instead of inhabited streets."

"Children received those assignments."

"Children also live in the streets the locks protect."

"Perrin Doss pays whenever Enna Kest receives another still hour."

Sere knew both names. Hearing them joined changed the chamber. A system preferred beneficiary marks and resident numbers because personal grammar made transfer sound like an act committed by one body against another.

"Enna would die without suspension," she said.

"Perhaps. Perrin has been dying in pieces to prevent her from choosing."

"The child cannot understand that choice."

"She is eleven."

"Exactly."

"Old enough to understand an ordinary morning."

A crack sounded beneath the table. One glass corner lifted. Blue light traveled through the floor toward the lock foundation.

A runner entered without waiting for permission. Mud covered his white festival coat to the waist.

“Regent. The eastern spillway opened past one hand.”

“Who ordered it?”

“No one. Local keepers broke the paired box.”

Tavia looked down, hiding nothing resembling triumph. “The woman’s son.”

Sere went to the door. Water now ran along the grinding corridor in a shallow sheet. The spillway had reduced basin pressure, but a fresh crack climbed the opposite wall. By releasing one portion of flow, the keepers had shifted load into an unbraced foundation. Collective competence could still make lethal mistakes.

“Close it by half,” Sere told the runner. “Brace the south pier first. Use dry wedges, no stillwater.”

“They may refuse.”

“Tell them why.”

The words left her before she considered their novelty. Not command alone. Reason.

A second messenger arrived behind the first, this one carrying a palace dispatch tube. The wax seal had broken and been tied closed with kitchen string.

Sere read standing in the wet corridor.

Bellhaven’s lower wards had begun evacuating without permission. Captain Letha Marr had opened three flood stairs. Grain crews used empty barges for children and patients. Ward Seven residents, free or aided by palace servants, marked silver-channel houses so occupants could leave before stored age returned. Ila Venn’s eastern instructions had reached the Bell. Brother Caun’s people established treatment stations on the heights.

No royal coordination appeared on the page. Neither did mass panic.

“How many moved?” Sere asked.

The messenger swallowed. “The report estimates eleven thousand since dawn.”

“Impossible.”

“Barge masters count hull places, Regent.”

“Then they have emptied the grain docks and stranded the reserve.”

“Captain Marr redirected six property barges.”

“Property?”

“Palace archives.”

Sere read the dispatch again. The lower wards had done in one day what her

council claimed required six, though no one yet knew whether the roads above could receive those people. The action might save thousands and starve them later. Competence did not remove consequence. Still, it existed outside her permission, and the fact pressed harder than accusation.

Tavia had come as far as her chain allowed. "Who pays for their movement?"

"They do," Sere said.

"Yes."

Such a small word. No forgiveness in it.

Another tremor passed through Saint Orra. This one shifted the door in its frame. Dust descended from the ceiling, and the cage hoops shone bright enough to cast shadows. Nhal moved inside their trapped water. Orra Lock took the force, but its oldest western pin had begun to shear. When that pin failed, all stored movement would return to the mechanism at once. The gate could leap open or crush itself shut.

Jol returned at a run. "Nine marks and climbing. We need a fresh counterweight."

"No people."

"The grinder stone can take rotational debt before it is engaged."

"Route it."

Copper valves slammed open. Silver lines carried Nhal's arrested turns into the idle paleshell grinder. Its upper stone twitched against the brake. Change moved from living muscle into an instrument built to destroy that muscle. The circle contained an elegance Sere despised.

"How long?" she asked.

"Until dawn, if the animal weakens."

Tavia's head came up. "If they weaken, their gills harden."

"Then dawn remains the limit."

The midwife rose, chain dragging. "Open this room and let me take them west."

"No."

"Your own message proves the lower wards can move."

"It proves they have begun. It does not prove they can finish before the basin breaks."

"So you need more time."

"I need control of the sequence."

"Killing Nhal ends the sequence. It does not end the debt."

Sere knew. Dead paleshell could extend stillwater, but the object stores had saturated across Avelune. Living assignments had become harder to conceal and impossible to expand without open seizure. Grinding Nhal bought years, perhaps

fewer. Those years might build new spillways, ordinary hospitals, redesigned canals. Or they might merely allow another ruler to postpone the same decision.

A ruler did not get to govern only when certainty favored her.

Sere returned to the chamber. "Prepare for grinding at dawn."

Tavia gripped the chain until her knuckles lost color. "Give me until the first bell."

"You have until the grinders turn."

"I'm asking for treatment time."

"You have done what you can for the wound."

"The wound is not my only patient."

Sere understood that the midwife meant the city, the river, perhaps the Regent herself. She refused the invitation.

"Move the other prisoners to the east holding rooms," she told Jol. "Keep Kest sitting upright. A cracked right rib can pierce the lung if he lies badly. Do not still his pain."

Tavia's eyes followed her. "You remember every body when it helps your argument."

"I remember them when it helps keep them alive."

"You should try remembering after they oppose you."

Sere left before anger could choose a poorer answer.

At the upper stair, a mirror caught her face. Returned age flickered across it: hollow cheek, loose jaw, sunken lid. The change lasted two heartbeats before the channel at her throat drew it away. Silver carried those seconds east through the prepared route. With Ward Seven disrupted, no gauge told her which object or body received them.

She unclasped the crescent.

Pain and years pressed near, a weather front against skin. Her hand shook. She imagined appearing before Saint Orra's crowd at sixty-seven, imagined weakness mistaken for surrender, imagined command fracturing while the river gathered. Then she fastened the clasp again.

A choice delayed remained a choice.

Below, the grinder took another fraction of Nhal's stored movement and turned half a finger against its brake.

Sere descended one step and stopped. Through the stone came a rhythm too slow for machinery. Nhal's heartbeat traveled through cage water and foundation. Tavia had bent until her ear touched the wet tile, counting the widening spaces beneath the enforced silence.

One beat came.

The next took longer.

Part IV

Chapter 22 — Enna Chooses Morning

Oren reached the hospice stair while Perrin was teaching a palace guard how to carry him.

“Under the knees,” Perrin said through clenched teeth. “Not under my arms. My spine has had enough royal assistance.”

The guard shifted his grip. Perrin’s boots cleared the third step without scraping. He weighed little, but pain made his narrow body rigid as seasoned wood.

Oren climbed behind them with one hand braced against the wall and the other locked over his right side. Each breath moved the cracked rib. Saint Orra lay two days west under dirty cloud, yet its hook pole still seemed lodged beneath his arm. Local keepers had opened his holding room when the eastern spillway cracked their station. Brother Caun had stayed to find Tavia. Oren had taken the first grain cart toward Bellhaven because Perrin’s message said Enna would receive the truth today, with or without him.

The hospice occupied the palace’s northern channel house, above flood level and below the audience courts. Its glazed blue tiles had begun slipping from returned age. Servants carried mattresses down one stair while physicians hauled medicine up another. No one stopped Oren at the door. Crown authority had thinned into useful work.

Perrin tapped the guard’s shoulder. “Set me by the window. If you drop me in front of her, she’ll think I came for drama.”

“You came across half the city in an evacuation cart,” Oren said.

“That looked like transport until you made it about yourself.”

The dryness in Perrin’s voice eased something Oren had no right to call hope.

Enna sat at a narrow table inside the weekly room, sorting seeds into a wooden tray. She wore a white sleeping coat and had braided her own hair badly. At eleven, her face still carried the rounded softness Oren remembered, though he had accumulated months between each of her waking hours. Behind her, a silver pipe entered the wall through a padded collar. Stillwater in the glass reservoir beside the bed kept marrow fever from advancing by transferring its heat and blood-making strain through that pipe into Perrin’s bones.

The source change had a name. So did the counterweight. Oren could no longer pretend medicine became clean because a clerk recorded the transfer.

Enna looked first at his coat, then his bound forearm, then the way he guarded his right ribs.

“You look terrible,” she said.

"I have looked better."

"Not during visiting hours."

Her attention moved to Perrin. The guard lowered him into the window chair as instructed. Perrin gave him a solemn nod.

"You may tell everyone I weighed nothing."

"I was going to tell them you gave orders."

"That also works."

When the guard left, no adult spoke. Oren had imagined this meeting during every mile from Saint Orra. He had prepared facts in the order a field report required: identification, mechanism, injury, decision. Enna's steady gaze made the order feel cowardly.

"This is Perrin Doss," he said. "Ward Seven assigned his body to your hospice line before your treatment began. The renewals moved marrow strain into his bones."

Enna looked at Perrin, not at Oren. "Did you choose to come?"

"Yes," Perrin said.

Only then did she point to his hands. His knuckles looked enlarged, his fingers bent by premature bone aging. "Those came from me?"

"From the stilling attached to your treatment," Oren said.

"That means yes."

"Yes."

Perrin adjusted a cushion behind his back. "Some of it. Ward Seven sent other things through me too. Stair strain. A councilor's old knee for three months. Once, an entire silver cupboard that did not want to tarnish. Your renewals had a beneficiary mark I learned to recognize."

Enna's mouth tightened. "Did you know my name?"

"Not until Oren brought the assignment strip."

"And he knew?"

"Not until White Root."

She looked at her father. "You told me the treatment used orchard wood."

"That is what the hospice told me."

"You believed them."

"I chose to."

The distinction hurt more to say and gave her more truth.

Enna swept the sorted seeds back into one pile. "Why?"

"Because if the treatment remained lawful, I could obey the people who continued it. If I obeyed, I believed I could keep you here until someone found a

cure.”

“You mean keep me asleep.”

“Mostly asleep.”

“Those words do not improve it.”

“No.”

She separated one black seed from the heap and rolled it under her fingertip. “Do you know why I sort these?”

Oren looked at the tray. “The attendants said it helped your hands.”

“They say many things about my hands. These came from pears Nurse Amma ate in spring. I put one in soil each waking day. Then I sleep seven days and find out what happened without me.”

On the sill stood five clay cups. Two held thin green stems. One showed only cracked soil. Another had been overturned and reset. The last contained a seed furred with mold.

“The first plant grew too tall while I slept,” Enna continued. “They tied it to a stick before I woke, so I never saw it fall. The second dried because an attendant changed shifts. With the third, they used a drop from my reservoir to stop rot.”

Perrin’s bent fingers tightened on the chair arm.

“I made them throw that one away,” she said. “They told me I had become morbid.”

“You were asking where the rot went,” Oren said.

“I was asking what happened while I slept. No one likes that question here.” She pushed the moldy seed toward him. “An ordinary morning has spoiled food and plants that lean. It has people who forget water. If you fix all of that before I wake, I do not get a morning. I get a room prepared for inspection.”

Oren had inspected hundreds of keeper stations. A clean room proved compliance only when he ignored the hurried broom, the hidden ledger, and the worker sent away before his arrival. He had accepted the hospice version because love made the staged room easier to inhabit.

“Did you ever ask them not to prepare it?” he said.

“Every week. They call it agitation from interrupted stilling.”

Master Halve had written those words in reports Oren signed. He remembered the neat script and his relief that Enna’s dissatisfaction had a medical name.

“I read the reports,” he said. “I should have asked you.”

“You should ask now.”

“What do you want me to see?”

Enna pointed to the cups. “All of it. Even the dead one.”

Outside the window, bells rang from the lower basin. Not alarm bells. Barge

calls, uneven and overlapping, as crews moved evacuees toward the heights. Oren counted three channels active by their tones. Captain Letha had opened routes the palace once reserved for stores.

Enna turned to Perrin. "Do you hate me?"

He considered the question without rushing to protect her. "I hated a princess for a while."

"I'm not a princess."

"I know. That made it less convenient."

"What do you hate now?"

"Stairs."

She waited.

"The people who wrote my number beside yours," he said. "The ones who knew my back bent whenever your fever stayed quiet. I hated Oren when he first came into the ward wearing a Crown coat. Then he opened a rear door. Now I find him tiring."

"Everyone finds him tiring."

Oren accepted the verdict.

A physician entered carrying a brass timing clock and stopped when she saw Perrin. Master Halve had overseen Enna's suspension since the second month. Her gray sleeves remained spotless despite the palace disorder.

"This room permits family only," she said.

"Perrin Doss is part of the treatment," Enna replied. "That makes him more than family for this conversation."

"It makes him a counterweight resident. He cannot remain within the active echo-distance."

Perrin's smile lacked warmth. "You found the concern late."

Oren stood away from the wall. His rib punished the movement, but Halve remembered his uniform even without the coat.

"The House of Last Change sent a release protocol," he said. "You received it yesterday."

"I received an unsigned copy carried by kitchen staff."

"Brother Caun signed the original."

"Brother Caun has no palace license."

"He has treated marrow fever without stillwater."

Halve set down the clock. "Three survivals in nine cases. None began after years of suspension. Release could return all deferred fever at once."

Perrin looked toward the silver pipe. "It has not been deferred. It has been

happening in me.”

The physician’s face changed. She had known the mechanism in abstract form. Perhaps she had never sat with one of its assigned bodies.

Enna touched the seed tray. “Tell me what happens if we do nothing.”

Halve answered quickly. “Your blood remains stable. You wake four hours each seventh day. We renew the reservoir monthly.”

“And Perrin?”

No one answered until Perrin did. “My bones keep receiving the fever’s work. The last renewal cracked two vertebrae.”

Enna’s fingers stopped moving. “How many more?”

“Master Halve cannot know,” Oren said.

“I asked him.”

Perrin flexed one hand. “One could put me in bed. Two might stop me walking. More becomes a silly way to count.”

“Why did you come?”

“To show you the person.”

“Not to ask me to release?”

“I have had enough choices made with my pain. I won’t use it to make yours.”

Enna leaned back. The silver pipe gave a faint singing noise as stillwater circulated. Every quiet second in her marrow entered Perrin through prepared channels. Here, within echo-distance, the transfer happened with almost no delay.

Oren wanted to tell her she did not have to decide today. That desire came from love and from the old lie in equal measure. Delay had kept her eleven while he turned forty-two. Delay had bent Perrin’s spine.

“What does release involve?” Enna asked.

Halve reached for the timing clock. “We reduce the held note in stages. The House protocol uses four breaks, each followed by ordinary treatment. Fever heat returns to your body. Your marrow may begin failing within the first hour. We have willow-bark tea, cooled cloth, clean transfusion needles, and donor blood matched during your last waking period.”

“Whose blood?”

“Three volunteer attendants. No magic. Nothing transfers beyond what their bodies give and replace naturally.”

“Pain?”

“Yes.”

“Chance I die?”

Halve looked at Oren.

"Answer her," he said.

"Higher than half," the physician said. "We do not know how years of suspension changed that chance."

Enna breathed out slowly. "Chance Perrin keeps walking if I stay stilled?"

"Low."

"Chance some other person gets assigned after him?"

Halve's silence supplied the number.

Enna pushed the tray away. "I want an ordinary morning."

Oren knelt because standing had become impossible. The motion put his face level with hers.

"You can have more time to think."

"I have had years of time. I was asleep for it."

"I mean waking time."

"You mean enough time for you to find a reason I shouldn't."

He took that without defense.

She reached toward him, stopped before touching his injured side, and set her hand on his shoulder. "You rode away every week and told yourself I stayed safe here. I told myself you kept the world going while I waited. Neither one happened the way we said."

"No."

"If I die, you do not get to turn it into permission to obey someone else."

His throat closed.

"Say it," she demanded.

"I will not make your death serve an order."

"If I live, you do not get to lock me up because ordinary things are dangerous."

"I will try."

"That is not the same promise."

"It is the honest one."

Enna considered him, then nodded. "Good."

She turned to Halve. "Begin."

They moved Perrin beyond the inner silver circuit but kept the door open. Enna refused the bed until the first break. She sat upright while Halve, two hospice nurses, and an attendant from the House of Last Change assembled ordinary medicines on clean cloth.

The reservoir's held note came from a small reed organ worked by a foot

bellows. Halve closed the first pipe.

Color entered Enna's cheeks too quickly. Her breathing doubled. Across the doorway, Perrin gasped and pressed both hands to his spine.

"Transfer lag," the House attendant said. "The channel is discharging what already entered him."

The magic named itself in their bodies. Suppressed fever returned toward Enna's marrow. Residual bone strain finished crossing into Perrin. When the silver pipe emptied, no new change would move between them.

Halve waited six minutes, then closed the second pipe.

Enna vomited into a basin. Oren held it without touching her neck, because she had told him not to steady her unless she asked. Sweat soaked her sleeping coat. A nurse replaced it with dry linen and gave measured willow tea.

Perrin's hands trembled less.

At the third break, blood ran from Enna's nose. Halve packed it with plain cloth. No stillwater touched the bleeding. The first donor lay on a neighboring cot while a glass line carried warm blood by gravity into Enna's arm. The donor paid with fatigue and a meal's worth of bodily work, chosen openly and recoverable through rest and food.

Oren watched the level fall. He had spent years demanding certainty from a treatment constructed out of hidden damage. Ordinary care offered no certainty. It offered named risks, consenting hands, and work that might fail.

"Talk," Enna whispered.

"What about?"

"What happens outside."

He described the grain barges. Captain Letha had ordered archive crates unloaded onto the high court. Children rode west stair ferries with their names written in charcoal on their sleeves. Ward residents marked unsafe silver houses. Ila's people cleared silt from lower channels. He did not call any of it safe.

"Mooncalf?"

"Captured at Saint Orra."

"Tavia?"

"Alive when I left."

"You left her."

"Caun stayed. Perrin's message came. I chose to reach you."

Enna's eyes opened. Fever had made them too bright. "Now you choose to go back."

"I am not leaving while you are in danger."

"That means never."

The fourth pipe waited.

Halve laid her hand on its stop. "Once this closes, renewal requires a new living circuit. Ward Seven no longer functions. There may be no reversal."

Enna looked at Perrin. He had managed to stand in the corridor with both arms braced on a wheeled chair.

"Ready?" she asked.

"No," he said. "Do it anyway."

Halve closed the pipe.

The held note ceased.

For one instant, every silver line in the room shone. Years of marrow fever had not waited in some separate reservoir; much had already been transferred into Perrin and prior counterweights. What remained suspended at Enna's source returned at natural speed sharpened by accumulated delay. Her body arched. Blood darkened beneath her fingernails. The reed organ split along one seam as unused stillwater released its held vibration into the wood.

Perrin cried out once. Then the pressure left his bones.

He sagged over the chair but did not fall. The rapid aging stopped. Existing damage remained: curved fingers, compressed spine, brittle hips. Release did not heal what transfer had done.

Enna convulsed. Halve turned her on her side. Oren counted breaths, lost count, and started again. The second donor line opened. Cool cloths went under Enna's arms and behind her knees. The House attendant named every change aloud for the record: fever returned; marrow failing; pulse irregular; bleeding present; no silver transfer active.

After forty minutes, Enna opened her eyes.

"Is it morning?"

"Near noon," Oren said.

"Poor planning."

Perrin laughed from the corridor, then winced at his own ribs.

Halve did not promise survival. She adjusted the blood line and told Enna her pulse had steadied for five consecutive minutes.

An ordinary morning would not arrive by magic. If it came, attendants would bring broth, measure heat, change damp linen, clean needles, and ask three donors to return. The work looked small after a kingdom's machinery. Oren understood its scale better now.

Enna slept for an hour and woke when evacuation bells changed cadence. The fever remained high but no longer climbed. Halve called that a useful sign, nothing more.

Perrin came to the bedside in the wheeled chair. Enna held out her hand. He

inspected it before taking it.

"Any silver?" he asked.

"Only bad nails."

"Acceptable."

Oren stood slowly. His rib caught halfway. Enna noticed.

"You need strapping."

"I have it."

"You need sense."

"That has been mentioned."

From beneath her pillow, she drew a small oval of blue ceramic drilled through with silver. The current week's hospice token carried the channel-house mark, Oren's beneficiary seal, and a date cut into the rim. The hospice issued a fresh token each week. Enna had kept the expired ones under her blanket instead of letting the clerks grind them blank, while Oren delivered every replacement without asking where its line ended.

"The palace channel doors read this," she said. "Master Halve used it when they moved me during the drill."

Oren did not reach for it. "What do you want opened?"

"All of them."

"That may release stored age into the palace."

"Then get people out first. Tell them what returns."

"Enna."

"Tavia's at Saint Orra. Nhal has until tomorrow. Captain Letha needs someone who knows the lock roads. Perrin came here because he thought I should choose. You came because you thought you had to watch me survive it."

"I do."

"No. You have to let me try."

She pressed the current token into his palm. Its edge carried a shallow notch from Master Halve testing the channel door during the drill.

Perrin raised one bent finger. "For the record, I will stay and be irritating."

"Qualified care," Enna said.

Oren closed his hand around the token. He bent and touched his forehead to hers, careful of the blood line, careful not to ask absolution.

Her skin burned with marrow fever. The heat belonged to her body now. No child beneath the city received it in secret.

When he straightened, Enna had already turned toward Halve to ask when the next donor should eat. Oren stepped into the corridor. Behind him, ordinary

treatment continued without silence or silver.

He took the hospice token toward the channel doors.

Chapter 23 — The Palace Learns to Change

Captain Letha held the palace channel door while Oren forced Enna's hospice token into a lock made for a gentler hand.

The blue ceramic oval caught halfway. His left forearm had stiffened during the climb from the hospice, and each twist pulled his cracked right rib. Behind him, water slapped the service stair. Bellhaven's lower canals had risen above the first flood mark.

"Turn left, press, then right," Perrin said from the wheeled chair.

"You could have said that before he tried strength," Letha replied.

"I wanted to confirm the educational method still failed."

Oren followed the sequence. Silver pins withdrew inside the wall. The channel door opened inward on darkness and the smell of wet brick.

Enna's token had been cut to grant physicians access between the hospice, Ward Seven, and the palace's hidden treatment rooms. No one had expected a patient to choose where it traveled.

Letha raised a hooded lamp. At fifty-one, she had the squared stance of someone who had spent years being blamed for doors other people ordered shut. She wore her lower-gate coat without rank braid. Two dozen watch officers waited on the stair below, mixed with ward residents, servants, grain crews, and three House of Last Change attendants.

"No weapons out unless I call for them," she said. "We take keys, valves, and routes. Anyone surrendering keeps skin."

A grain worker lifted a boat hook. "What if they do not surrender?"

"Use the hook to open something useful."

Perrin tapped the chair's wheel. "I can walk the flat corridor."

"You can direct us from there," Oren said.

"I did not survive your daughter's treatment to become cargo."

"You survived the release three hours ago."

"And she told me to stop hovering. Apparently we share a problem."

Enna remained feverish but stable under Master Halve's ordinary care. Perrin had kept his promise to stay until the second donor arrived. Then he had taken the service lift down because he knew Ward Seven's channels better than any free person.

Oren stepped through the door. "Show us."

The corridor descended inside the old dye quarter wall. Silver pipes ran waist-high along both sides, each stamped with a palace seal and a beneficiary number. Condensation trembled on them despite the still air. Change moved

within: Sere's refused age, court wounds, unstained tapestries, unrotted beams, quiet fevers. Crown stillwater had distributed all of it toward bodies below.

Perrin pointed to a thick pipe marked with seven cuts. "Main palace line. Close it too fast, everything returns at once."

"What order?" Letha asked.

"Objects first. Then residents who can be moved to the House tents. Child-assignment lines last, because their routes cross three times."

Oren had expected fear in his voice. Perrin sounded like a keeper who knew a dangerous mechanism and hated it enough to respect its force.

They moved.

At the first junction, two palace guards lowered pikes. Letha gave them one chance.

"Lower wards are evacuating. Regent Valec is at Saint Orra. This channel house has assigned illness to children. Step aside and help disconnect it."

"Our order holds," the older guard said.

"From whom?"

"Palace Continuity."

Letha took the paper he offered, read it, and passed it to Oren. The seal authorized force against sabotage. No named official had signed.

"A clean order," Oren said. "No hand to answer for it."

The guard recognized his old dam-rider coat. Recognition moved into doubt.

Perrin rolled up his sleeve. Silver burns branched from wrist to elbow. "This came through your wall while you kept it orderly."

The younger guard put down her pike. After a moment, the older one did the same.

"Good," Letha said. "You know the object vault?"

They nodded.

"Take six people and open it."

No cheer followed. Authority changed hands through a task.

Ward Seven occupied a brick chamber beneath the former dye vats. Ninety-six registered residents had lived at its Red Step site; eighteen were children. Four adults died during the transfer failures. All eighteen children escaped through Bellhaven's western spillway, while some adults had slipped through Oren's rear door weeks earlier and others had joined Perrin's public march. Fifty-one adults remained when Letha's group entered, too sick or too closely connected to palace channels to move safely.

Rows of narrow cots faced walls laced with silver. No restraints held most residents. Their bodies served as restraints enough.

A woman with hair aged white on one side sat up. "Are you opening us?"

"We are disconnecting in stages," Oren said.

"What comes back?"

Perrin answered. "Change returns toward its source. What already entered us stays. Fresh transfer stops. Palace beams may rot. Old court injuries may reopen. The Regent's age may return if her personal line breaks. No one here gets younger."

"Then do it."

House attendants spread lists across a dye table. Residents gave names, assignment marks, present injuries, and any symptoms that appeared after a specific palace ceremony. Oren recognized the funeral clarity Tavia demanded: no softened terms, no vanished cost.

Perrin led him to a bank of child-assignment lines, routes first opened against residents who had been children at assignment. Some recipients had since reached adulthood. The lines of the eighteen children who escaped Bellhaven still ran west through buried silver. "These three carry fever. Two carry bleeding. That one takes growth from the palace orchard."

"Growth?"

"Trees stay decorative. Assigned bodies lengthen wrong."

A young man on the nearest cot had one leg longer than the other. Weathering had done that before he reached adulthood. He watched Oren touch the valve.

"What happens when you turn it?" the young man asked.

"The orchard starts growing at its own speed. Your leg does not change back."

"Will it hurt them?"

"The trees?"

He nodded.

"Some branches may split if years return too quickly. Gardeners can cut and bind them."

"Do they know?"

"Not yet."

"Tell them first."

Oren looked at Letha. She sent a runner upstairs.

The message took twelve minutes to return. Gardeners had cleared the paths and braced the oldest pear trees. Only then did the young man tell Oren to turn the valve.

Silver light diminished along the pipe. In the palace orchard above, held growth returned to trunk and branch. A root lifted paving. Two limbs cracked despite the braces. The young man on the cot felt no new pull through his bones.

They worked line by line.

A set of three channels ended at an elderly man named Sorren, whose skin bore a different weathering pattern on each limb. His right arm shook with a court musician's suppressed palsy. The left had swollen under a magistrate's gout. One leg carried the slow failure of a palace waterwheel axle, because an engineer had decided living muscle tolerated cyclic strain longer than timber.

"Which first?" Oren asked.

"The wheel," Sorren said. "It has been turning all night."

A servant ran to the old pumping gallery and found two crews still drawing hospice water from that wheel. Disconnecting at once would return twelve years of wear to the axle. If it shattered, the northern cisterns would stop filling during evacuation.

Letha sent grain workers to rig a hand pump. They complained that every able person already loaded barges. Sorren listened from his cot and said, "Put me on the pump."

"Your leg cannot hold," Oren said.

"My arms know enough."

They carried him upstairs on a door. He took a seat at the pump handle beside two archive clerks whose robes had never met grease. Only when clear water ran from their strokes did Oren close the axle channel.

Far above, old iron shed rust in flakes. A bearing split. The waterwheel stopped, and Sorren's leg ceased its borrowed turning. His tremor and swollen hand remained.

"Next?" Oren asked when he returned.

"The musician," Sorren said. "She plays on the evacuation stair. Better a shaking hand than no signal."

A runner found the woman and explained the return. She finished one barge call, tied the bell rope around her waist so both hands could guide it, and gave consent. Oren closed that circuit. Her palsy returned. The bell rhythm faltered, then settled into a slower pattern that crews could still follow.

Last came the magistrate. He refused. Letha listened to his messenger and folded the refusal into a square.

"Sorren never consented to receive the gout," she said. "The magistrate has no right to continue the transfer."

They broke the line. Somewhere in the upper court, a man cried out as pain and swelling returned to his own joints. House attendants had sent ordinary anti-inflammatory herbs and instructions ahead of the release. Mercy did not require Sorren's continued use.

Court tapestries took back stains and faded in patches. A ceremonial stair

received twenty years of wear in a minute; servants had cleared it, so the treads collapsed empty. When an old stilling on the west kitchen broke, three ovens released stored heat and ignited flour cloths. Grain workers smothered the fire with damp sacks. Each release named its source, its route, and the matter paying for delay.

Living changes required harder choices. A palace clerk had suspended a blood disease into a woman called Mera. Disconnecting stopped future transfer but returned the current illness to the clerk. A runner found him on the upper evacuation desk. He came down pale and furious.

"You cannot break a licensed treatment without consent."

Mera showed him the assignment mark burned beneath her collarbone. "Mine?"

He could not look at it.

"Consent works both ways," Letha said.

They disconnected him. His nose began bleeding before he reached the stair. House attendants treated both patients with plain cloth, iron broth, and named risk.

By the seventh bank, the silver walls had gone dark in sections. Perrin stood between chair and valve table, gripping both for balance. No fresh aging entered his spine. Existing pain sharpened as exhaustion stripped away anger's support.

"Sit," Oren told him.

"After the child-assignment lines."

"You cannot hold the table and turn a wheel."

"I can tell you which wheel."

That compromise carried them through the last cross-routed lines.

When the last child-assignment circuit closed, Ward Seven did not transform. Bent bodies stayed bent. Weathered faces remained old. The room smelled of blood, medicine, and wet lime. Freedom arrived as the absence of the next injury.

A woman began to laugh. Another told her to save breath for the stairs.

Letha assigned watch officers to carry cots toward the House tents. Palace servants brought doors off hinges for stretchers. No one waited for a formal release seal.

Perrin pointed to the main pipe. "That goes to the audience chamber."

Oren looked at Enna's token. "Then we show them where it began."

The palace court had filled with people who came uphill ahead of the flood and found the gates open. Lower-ward families stood beside archive clerks, bakers, wounded guards, and residents from the first Ward Seven escape. Rain entered through a roof crack and spotted the mosaic floor.

At the far end, Sere's ceremonial chair sat empty.

Beside it, on a narrow stone stand, rested the unchanged bowl.

Its water had not rippled during the crowd's entry. Dust falling from the cracked roof hovered above its surface. A fine silver tube left the bowl, entered the stand, and joined the main palace line beneath the floor.

Perrin asked to stand. Oren and a kitchen servant supported him without lifting his weight away from his feet.

"This pipe runs to Ward Seven," he told the crowd. "It carries more than bowl water. It carries the Regent's age."

An archive clerk shook her head. "She survived the wasting fever."

"Thirty-five years ago," Perrin said. "She kept surviving it in other bodies."

Oren placed Enna's hospice token against the access plate in the stand. A panel opened. Inside, seven silver routes were engraved with assignment numbers. Sere's personal line ran thickest.

A ward woman came forward and matched the first number to the scar on her wrist. Others found theirs. The proof needed no speech.

"Break it," someone called.

"No," Oren said.

Anger turned toward him.

"We clear the source room first. Returned age may strike her body at Saint Orra, but stored strain may also enter these foundations. Children are still leaving the north stair."

Captain Letha climbed onto the first dais step. "Evacuation continues. Four groups: north stair, archive court, grain dock, channel valves. If you want the palace changed, keep it from falling on the people under it."

Tasks cut through the crowd's appetite for spectacle. Boat crews carried benches outside for ramps. Clerks emptied lower rooms. Ward residents marked live silver routes with charcoal. Guards who surrendered their keys joined the work under watch.

A man in court livery tried to stab the main pipe with a ceremonial spear. Letha caught the shaft.

"You open that now, you age every beam above us at once."

"He deserves it."

"The roof does not know who deserves what."

She took the spear and sent him to the stretcher line.

Oren followed the main route below the chair. Its stop valve required two keys. Enna's token released one side. The second belonged to Palace Continuity.

The older guard from the channel corridor arrived carrying a ring of confiscated

keys. "Director fled through the west gallery."

"Did you pursue?" Oren asked.

"No. We opened the object vault."

He handed over the proper key.

Before Oren turned it, Letha's runners confirmed the audience roof, orchard, kitchens, and western stair had been cleared. Grain crews waited with sand and braces. House attendants prepared for injuries whose suspension would return to court residents.

"Now," Letha said.

Oren and Perrin turned the keys together.

The bowl moved.

One raindrop struck its surface. Ripples crossed the water and touched the rim. Such ordinary motion drew a sound from the crowd more powerful than a cheer.

Silver beneath the stand flared. Sere's suspended aging sought its original body along the western channel toward Saint Orra. Thirty-five years could not cross instantly through a damaged network. Some change struck saturated junctions and escaped into palace matter. Lime fell from columns. Blue tiles slid from the roof. The ceremonial chair split along a seam hidden since Sere's accession.

Elsewhere in the court, stored age returned in bursts. A councilor's hair whitened. A guard's old ankle injury reopened and dropped him to one knee. The west mosaic darkened under years of damp. No counterweight received these changes now; they returned to the sources that had refused them.

Perrin clung to the key wheel. His body did not weather further.

"Enough?" Oren asked.

"Ask me tomorrow."

A deep crack ran under the audience floor. Everyone froze.

"Out of the center!" Letha shouted. "Weight to the walls."

The crowd moved. Not perfectly. Two people fell and were lifted. A child screamed for a missing shoe until someone carried both child and shoe to the arch. The floor settled without opening.

From the western window, Oren saw grain barges leaving the palace dock. Archive crates lay stacked in rain along the high terrace. Families crowded the decks under sailcloth. Captain Letha had redirected every usable hull toward the lower wards.

A palace quartermaster rushed in. "Those six barges carry the winter charter collection."

"They carried it," Letha said. "Now they carry people."

"The Regent reserved them."

"The Regent is absent."

"By whose authority?"

Letha looked over the court. "The people loading them."

It did not create a tidy government. Arguments broke out over routes, food allotments, and which patients moved first. A dock crew refused an archive clerk's tally. Ward residents demanded the names of every beneficiary. Three guards tried to leave with stillwater vials and were stopped without being beaten. Control passed through negotiation, leverage, anger, and physical work.

Oren had served commands because they promised a clean line. This looked tangled. It also moved eleven thousand people.

A young boatwright found him beside the emptied archive court. "Ila Venn sent this from the east store."

Three curved hull sections leaned on a handcart, nested and tied with familiar knots. The folded cradle-boat carried repairs from half the kingdom. Its iron hinges had survived Saint Orra's trap.

"How did it get here?"

"Local keeper hid it under festival cloth. Sent it on a grain scow after they took you."

Oren laid a hand on the middle brace. Tavia had worried about the boat while a pole broke his rib. She would need it in the grinding room, though he did not yet know how to reach her.

Perrin rolled beside him. "The old Orra relief has a maintenance channel behind the guide figure. I saw Caun's copy at White Root."

"Can you draw it?"

"Better than I can ride to it."

He marked the route on a scrap of palace charter: down three steps, left at the split crescent, old drain beneath the plastered tail. Oren folded the map into his sleeve.

Captain Letha approached with two keepers and a road horse already saddled. "Your rib?"

"Still cracked."

"That question expected a useful answer."

"I can ride if someone ties the boat behind rather than across."

She ordered the sections packed on a narrow grain cart. "I leave for Sea Gate after the last lower barge clears. Ila holds the eastern sluice lists. Caun's messengers hold White Root. You get Tavia and Nhal out of Orra."

"No promise."

"Good. Promises waste time."

Oren looked back at Perrin. "Enna."

"I return to the hospice now. She will complain that I left. I will report that she sent us."

"Tell her I used the token."

Perrin glanced at the moving water in Sere's bowl. "She'll ask what it opened."

"Tell her the truth."

Rain intensified over the court. Servants set the unchanged bowl on the floor because its stone stand had cracked. Water slopped over the rim and spread among muddy footprints.

Oren took the Orra road with the folded cradle-boat knocking behind him.

Chapter 24 — The Grinding Room

Two soldiers dragged Tavia to the paleshell grinder by the chain between her wrists.

She let her left knee fail on the last stair. Both men cursed and took her weight, which gave her three breaths to study the floor.

Black blood marked the drain seam.

Nhal had passed overhead in the cage. Drops from the wound below their left forward fin had fallen through the cart slats and entered hairline cracks in the lime. Wherever the blood touched old silver, a dim constellation shone. The line ran under fresh plaster toward the western wall, bent at a split crescent carved near the floor, and vanished behind the grinder's catch basin.

Down three steps. Left beside the split crescent. Follow the old drain beneath the plastered tail.

She had counted the route while hooded. Now Nhal's blood confirmed it.

The soldiers paused while a work crew rolled a bin of sacrificial timber across the passage. Each beam had been stamped with its forest, harvest year, and intended burden. One would receive axle wear. Two had been assigned the grinder's heat. The last six waited for structural strain from the lock. Ethical accounting written on wood, Tavia thought, until the wood saturated and an officer reached for a person.

A girl among the workers recognized her. She had carried paper moons in the festival skiff. A silver burn marked one wrist, but no ankle loop held her now.

"My mother got out," the girl said quickly. "The east sheds opened after the spillway."

"Your brother at the capstan?"

"Still there. Says the western pin has a crack through the head."

"Tell him not to stand behind it. When it shears, it will kick east."

One soldier shoved Tavia forward. The girl seized a timber tag as though checking its ink and repeated the instruction under her breath to the next worker. The message moved away faster than any official order could have traveled.

At the corridor bend, Crown plaster covered another section of the old relief. Moisture had loosened its lower edge. Tavia dragged one cuff across it as she passed. A hand-sized piece fell.

Older carving showed Orra kneeling beside a three-part boat. One section supported the moonbrood's chest. A second held their hind fins clear of a stone lip. The third floated loose behind, ready to be carried through a narrowing. Beside Orra stood six figures with ropes and poles. No single saint performed the passage. A crew did.

Fresh paint had changed the six helpers into kneeling worshipers. The

restoration was clumsy once someone saw the buried boat.

"Stop damaging the shrine," the taller soldier said.

"You have a grinder in it."

"It preserves the kingdom."

"What has it preserved for you?"

His mouth tightened. He had weather lines around both eyes and a scar through one eyebrow, changes his service had not suspended. The younger soldier looked away.

The work crew rolled the bin onward. One beam already gave off a sweet rotten smell. It had absorbed years from Saint Orra's roof before reaching the grinder. The stamped ledger still called it fresh.

Tavia planted her heel beside the exposed relief. "When that beam takes heat, it will ignite. Wet it or move it outside the axle room."

"We have orders."

"You have kindling."

The younger soldier tested the beam with his knife. The blade entered to the hilt. He called the crew back and ordered the bin separated, accepting his companion's glare.

One prevented fire would not open the cage. It would leave a corridor standing long enough for people to escape. Tavia added it to the count.

"Stand," the taller soldier said.

"Give me a better knee."

He hauled her upright. Tavia used his shoulder without thanking him and entered the room on her own feet.

The grinder filled the chamber. Its lower stone had been cut from dark basalt, broad as a burial raft. The upper wheel held grooves for breaking shell into powder. Copper teeth lined the feed throat. A channel of stillwater surrounded the axle and kept the stone from wearing; its abrasion traveled through silver lines into Orra Lock, the shrine foundations, and whatever living assignments Master Keeper Jol could still reach.

Nhal's cage waited on rails above the feed ramp.

They lay curled within seven silver hoops. Their bandage had come loose. Four plain-gut stitches remained, but the wound leaked luminous black around them. Gills moved slowly. Each attempted breath entered the cage as stored movement and made the grinder twitch against its brake.

Regent Sere stood beside the release wheel.

Age had begun to find her. One side of her face looked as Tavia remembered from the basin. The other carried a deeper mouth line and gray hollows under the eye. Her paleshell clasp flashed irregularly. Bellhaven had disrupted the personal

channel; returned years reached her in fragments and spilled into Saint Orra's machinery when the route failed.

"You should have ground the cage empty," Tavia said.

Sere watched the soldiers fasten her chain to a wall ring. "The shell must remain alive through the first turn. Dead shell does not take the held note evenly."

"So you learned from the last one."

"From records."

"Written by people who heard it die."

The Regent's gaze moved to the grinder. No defense came.

Brother Caun knelt near the south wall with his hands tied behind him. Dried blood darkened his collar. He had one eye swollen shut and a strip of plaster dust in his hair. When he saw Tavia studying the drain, he looked away too deliberately.

He knew the route.

Master Jol entered with four keepers and a silver throat pipe. "Western pin has reached fracture. We must begin before the third bell."

"Object lines?" Sere asked.

"Saturated. The palace line reopened an hour ago, then went dark."

Bellhaven's release had cut her supply of hidden bodies. Tavia thought of ward doors opening, not as triumph but as fifty-one injured people facing stairs.

"What pays when you hold the grinder?" she asked.

Jol refused to answer her.

Sere did. "Orra's Crown house and the lock mechanism."

"People inside?"

"Evacuated."

"Pilgrims?"

"Above the old flood line."

"You finally learned to clear a room before returning its age."

"I have always understood evacuation."

"You understood ordering it. Different trade."

A tremor shook dust from the ceiling. Nhal's tail had moved half an inch inside the cage. That motion transferred into the grinder stone. Copper teeth clicked forward.

Tavia leaned against her chain and felt the wall answer. Behind it, ordinary water ran through the guide-channel. The flow had increased since yesterday. Local keepers must have opened the eastern spillway farther. Thin water pressed toward the Nightcourse, seeking the lower route Orra's carved hand once showed.

"Let me dress the wound before you begin," she said.

"The animal will die in minutes," Jol said.

"All the more reason not to feed iron grit through their blood."

Sere considered, then unlocked one end of Tavia's chain. "Six breaths at the service port."

"You have worn that number thin."

"It remains what the cage tolerates."

Tavia took boiled cloth and plain salve from the tray. She knelt beside the lowest hoop. Jol turned the service key.

The port opened. Nhal's unsuspended breath struck her hands as moving water. She reached through and found heat where scales should have felt cold. The wound edges had swollen around a fragment of hook barb.

"There is iron inside."

"Remove it," Sere said.

"In six breaths?"

"Take twelve."

Jol looked appalled.

Tavia inserted the curved forceps. Nhal convulsed at the touch. Released motion slapped water across the feed ramp. On the seventh breath, a crack climbed the Crown house wall. By the ninth, the lock foundation groaned. At eleven, Tavia caught metal.

The barb came out black with tissue. She flung it into the drain and packed the wound with salve and folded linen.

"Close," Sere ordered.

Jol sealed the port. Blue light carried the next gill stroke toward the grinder.

Tavia held up the iron fragment. "Your hook. Your wound. No creature in a story did this to themselves."

"Prepare the held note," Sere said.

Keepers took positions around the axle. Caun shifted his knees. His bound hands had found a broken tile behind him, and he worked its edge against the rope.

The first bell rang over Saint Orra.

From behind the western wall came three soft knocks.

Tavia coughed to cover them.

Jol raised the throat pipe. Its note would activate paleshell in the axle water, suspending the grinder's resistance and transferring that wear into the empty Crown house and Orra Lock. Once the upper stone reached speed, the cage floor would open. Nhal's shell and body would enter the copper teeth.

Three knocks came again. Then two.

Oren knew keeper tunnel signals. Three for obstruction, two for ready.

The folded cradle-boat could fit the guide-channel only in sections. He had brought it.

Tavia looked toward Caun. His rope parted. He kept his hands behind him.

"What do you need?" he asked without moving his lips.

"Throat pipe."

Sere stood too near the release wheel. Jol had the pipe. Four keepers guarded the cage. The soldiers at Tavia's chain watched her hands.

She saw no clean sequence.

That no longer meant no sequence existed.

The held note began.

Stillwater around the axle turned white. The grinder brake released its stored friction into silver. Across the courtyard, the evacuated Crown house aged by decades. Roof beams rotted. Window lead sagged. Orra Lock took rotational strain into its western pin, which bent closer to fracture.

Caun rose and drove his shoulder into Jol.

The throat pipe struck the floor. Its note broke. Tavia wrapped her loose chain around the nearest soldier's ankle and pulled. He fell against the feed ramp. The second reached for her hair. She caught his thumb, bent it to the wrist, and took his key ring.

Keepers rushed Caun. He kicked the throat pipe into the grinder's catch basin.

The western wall opened along the blood-lit seam.

Not dramatically. One plaster panel tipped inward, pushed by the blunt prow of the cradle-boat's middle section. Oren came through behind it on hands and one knee, soaked to the chest. His face had gone white with pain. A narrow grain cart could not enter the drain, so he had tied the three hull sections with rope and floated them ahead of him.

"Took longer," he said.

"Your route drawing lacked water depth."

"Perrin's complaint."

A keeper swung a bar at his right side. Oren turned too slowly. Tavia threw the key ring. It struck the keeper's eye and changed the blow enough that the bar hit Oren's shoulder rather than his rib.

He still folded over with no breath.

Tavia crossed the chain around the wall ring, used both feet against the stone, and pulled until the open cuff end slid through. She reached Oren before the keeper struck again. Her recovery hook caught the man behind the knee. Caun shoved him onto the wet floor.

“Boat,” Oren managed.

Caun and Tavia dragged the three sections from the guide-channel. Ila’s hinge pins had been tied inside a linen packet. They assembled the cradle-boat beneath the cage ramp while water rose around their ankles.

Sere had not fled. She gripped the release wheel with both hands.

“Stop,” she said.

No one obeyed.

She pulled the paleshell clasp from her throat and dropped it into the axle channel.

The stillwater brightened. Thirty-five years of suspended age no longer traveled from her body through a controlled personal line. The clasp’s stored charge entered the grinder circuit instead, taking resistance from the brake and sending it into Saint Orra’s Crown house. The house roof collapsed in the courtyard. No people paid there, but the lock pin screamed under the excess.

Sere aged visibly. Skin loosened at her jaw. White spread through her hair. Her hands developed dark veins and swollen joints. Not all years returned; damaged channels still held portions. Enough came to bend her over the wheel.

“Regent,” Jol shouted.

“Engage,” she said.

The upper stone began to turn.

Tavia reached the cage control. Seven levers corresponded to seven hoops. Opening them together would release every stored movement into the room. The grinder, walls, and people would take the first force. Keeping them closed meant Nhal reached the teeth.

“Clear the ramp!” she shouted.

Caun pushed the assembled cradle-boat under the cage and cut its restraint rope. Oren crawled to the guide-channel entrance and pulled loose stones from the water path. His right arm stayed locked against his rib.

Keepers chose around them. Two held their posts. One ran. Another began evacuating the north stair. Jol tried to recover the throat pipe from the catch basin.

Tavia put both hands on the levers.

“Not all at once,” Oren said.

The Veyl lesson. Lower flow before main gate. Make room before asking the body to pass.

She opened the lowest hoop.

Stored movement returned from its silver line. Nhal’s accumulated gill strokes burst into cage water and drove it down the ramp. The cradle-boat filled. Orra’s Crown house lost another wall as transferred strain came home through the grinder circuit.

Second hoop. Fin twitches struck the feed rails and bent them outward.

Third. Tail strokes hammered the axle. The upper stone jumped, missed its copper teeth, and cracked along one groove.

A keeper lunged for Tavia. Sere stopped him with one raised hand.

"You cannot control the release," she said.

"No," Tavia answered. "I can give it a direction."

Fourth hoop. Water found the old guide-channel behind the wall. The cradle-boat surged toward it, caught on the ramp lip, and held.

Caun threw his weight against the stern. His feet slid.

Fifth hoop. Nhal's body uncurled. Their wounded fin moved, tore two stitches, and sent blood across the boat. The returning force lifted the bow over the lip.

Sixth. The grinder brake shattered. Stored rotation traveled back into the stone, which spun once at violent speed and cast paleshell dust across the chamber. Tavia covered her mouth. Dust entering water could activate under a held note, so Caun kicked the throat pipe farther down the drain.

One hoop remained around Nhal's throat.

The cage had stored their heartbeat there.

Releasing it might restore every arrested beat at once. A human heart could not survive that. Moonbrood bodies followed pressures Tavia only partly understood. She put her palm against the silver and felt a rapid sequence waiting inside, tomorrow's beats packed into a ring.

"Nhal," she said. "Listen."

She sang the first note softly.

White roots far below answered through the water. The pressure returned as a broad pulse, not magic without source: Nhal's own earlier song had traveled through root and mineral, losing force across distance. The roots carried it back now. Their living fibers paid in small tears that clouded the channel with white sap.

Tavia gave the second note. Nhal's gills opened.

On the third, she lowered the final lever one notch at a time.

Heartbeats returned into Nhal's body. Three came too fast. Tavia held the lever. Two more settled. She lowered it again. The cage released the rest in a sequence their flesh could carry.

The seventh hoop opened.

Nhal dropped into the cradle-boat.

Their weight drove it through the plaster breach. Oren caught the side rope with his left hand and let the current pull him into the guide-channel. Caun pushed from behind. Tavia climbed onto the stern as the grinder room split along the blood-lit drain.

Sere came after them.

She did not call guards. With one aged hand on the wall, she followed the rising water toward the breach. Her body had lost decades in minutes, but calculation remained in her eyes.

“Sea Gate is shut,” she said. “Six gates stand between that animal and saltwater.”

“Then open them.”

“Your release has started Orra’s failure.”

“Your cage stored the movement.”

“And now the city pays.”

“The Crown house paid. Your people cleared it.”

“Not every channel ends in an empty room.”

Tavia knew. The broken grinder had sent movement east through saturated lines. Bellhaven’s palace, already emptied in sections, would crack. Some old injuries would return to their sources. Object stores would fail. No victory could keep every body outside the consequence.

Behind Sere, Master Jol shouted that the western pin had split.

Orra Lock moved.

The guide-channel became a river. Water lifted the cradle-boat and hurled it into darkness. Oren’s shoulder struck stone. Tavia landed across Nhal’s flank and felt the mooncalf’s ragged heartbeat under her ribs.

They emerged below the pilgrimage island, where the old channel joined the Nightcourse west of the grinding works. Dawn had begun as a gray line above the lock towers. Crowds on the high embankment sang three notes while local keepers cut weed racks from the lower spillways.

Nhal slid from the cradle-boat into deep water. Their left forward fin trailed, but the other three limbs worked. The stored movement released from the cage strengthened each stroke and punished the damaged lock behind them.

Oren clung to the boat, breathing shallowly. Caun came through the channel on a broken plank. Tavia counted all three, then counted Nhal.

Across the upper bridge, Sere mounted a keeper horse. Age had bowed her shoulders. She turned west toward Sea Gate instead of yielding Saint Orra.

Under the island, Orra Lock gave another iron crack.

The Nightcourse rose against six closed gates.

Chapter 25 — Before the River Stood Up

Tavia cut the last cage thread from Nhal's wound while quarry water climbed over her boots.

The mooncalf lay in the deepest part of the abandoned stone pit west of Saint Orra. Their body curved around the assembled cradle-boat, scales dim beneath silt and black blood. Three fins worked. The injured left forward fin rested against their side under a clean wrap. Each breath sent a pressure ring through flooded ledges and into the white roots breaking from the quarry wall.

Messages trembled in those roots.

Brother Caun knelt with his ear against the largest strand. White sap stained his cheek where the living fiber split under repeated song. The roots carried pressure by bending and tearing their own small cells. Nothing traveled without a body paying.

"Hush reports both lower sluices clear," he said. "East bank families above the third mark. Keeper wants sequence time."

"Name," Tavia said.

Caun listened again. "Reeve Mara Pell."

Oren sat on an overturned stone trough while Tavia rewrapped his ribs. His Crown horn lay across his knees. Breathing had become a deliberate craft for him: shallow draw, pause, careful release. The knife cut on his left forearm had closed badly but showed no fever.

"Red Step?" he asked.

"Waiting on the dye quarter," Caun said. "Sela Rusk leads the west rack. They found three houses still occupied below the line."

"No opening until she clears them," Tavia said.

A quarry worker scratched the decision onto a slate. Nine slates stood around the water, each assigned to a lock, route, treatment station, or uncertain report. Tavia had refused one grand map. Grand maps made bodies small enough to lose. Here every mark required a person to speak it aloud.

At Veyl, Ila Venn held the first gate crew with Dunmere fishers and lock keepers who had removed their Crown braid. Hush belonged to Mara Pell and two reed villages. Red Step waited on Sela Rusk. Oren's old lieutenant, Hara Dey, had taken the Bell east capstan after helping clear the lower basin. Brother Caun's House crews worked White Root. At Orra, the festival skiff pilot called himself Davi An and reported through his mother, Eret, whose silver-burned wrists Tavia remembered. Captain Letha rode toward Sea Gate with lower-gate officers and grain crews.

Seven gates. No saint at any one of them.

The route slate demanded equally specific hands. Veyl's people would take the

basalt ridge, not the Crown road that had flooded during the first break. Hush had two reed ferries for anyone trapped on the islands. Red Step's dye canals could drain west if workers broke three temporary walls. Bellhaven needed every stair above the blue tile line kept one-way uphill. White Root's cave exits admitted only stretchers carried lengthwise. Orra's pilgrims had to leave their carts or block the causeway. Beyond Sea Gate, salt workers marked ground firm enough for wagons.

A miller from the quarry pointed to Bellhaven's south silt quarter. "My sister lives there. The slate says tannery bridge open."

Oren shook his head. "That bridge took a crack during the stilling drill."

"No one sent word."

"Because the western watch still lists it passable."

Tavia moved the route marker. "Who can reach the approach?"

The miller volunteered, then admitted he had never crossed the flood stairs. A former palace laundress knew them and agreed to guide him. Together they left with a red cloth to close the bridge and charcoal to mark a detour through the soap yard.

Another worker asked whether the House tents could receive weathering residents unable to climb. Caun counted six mule litters, twelve doors usable as stretchers, and one cart with a sound axle. They assigned the cart to the people with damaged spines. Those able to sit took doors. Walking residents would travel last beside attendants who knew their assignment injuries.

"Why last?" a young House brother asked.

"Because officers will see them and clear roads," Caun said.

"Because they matter least?"

"No. Because they can speak while the stretcher patients cannot. If the road closes, they decide whether to turn. We do not decide for them from here."

Tavia watched him amend the slate. Even care could hide command inside efficiency. Naming the choice did not slow them as much as authority always claimed.

A fisher brought a basket of white flags cut from burial cloth. "For houses checked empty."

"Use black for someone inside who refuses," Tavia said. "White must mean seen and cleared, not silent."

"What if they will not give a name?"

"Mark the number of bodies. Return with a second person to witness."

The fisher distributed cloth among the runners. Each took a wax tablet for names, injuries, destination, and time last seen. Tavia knew floodwater would erase some records. She also knew that writing a name changed how a rescuer searched.

At the western slate, Sea Gate still showed no leader present. Captain Letha's name stood beside an unfinished route. Sere had the mechanism and remaining Crown keepers. The plan depended on a confrontation no chalk could solve.

Tavia wrote two alternatives beneath it: Gate opens: salt stair and north flats. Gate shut: quarry crews hold western spill, all roads above iron marker. Neither promised enough time for Nhal.

Oren read both. "You left out forcing the gate."

"With what?"

"People will assume we have a way."

"Then tell them we do not."

He took the chalk and wrote: No means known to overpower Regent's stilling. Do not mass below Sea Gate.

The honesty made the western slate frightening. It also kept desperate crews from gathering in the deadliest place.

Tavia tightened the rib binding.

Oren grunted. "That is worse."

"It is meant to keep the bone from moving."

"It also keeps the man from moving."

"Useful coincidence."

She tied the knot on his left side where he could reach it. He tested one breath and stopped arguing.

Nhal stirred in the quarry. Water rose another finger against the ledge. Their escape from the cage had returned stored movement into the Nightcourse, and Orra's splitting pin had sent a pressure crest both east and west. Six closed gates held that force. Veyl had broken its harvesting frame on Day Two, but its main passage still required controlled opening. Every lower sluice had to take flow before the gate lifted.

The quarry slate keeper cleared his throat. "Captain Marr's first estimate."

Tavia looked up.

"Bellhaven lower basin: evacuation could reach four-fifths if roads hold. Projected loss after sequential opening, two hundred. Maybe four. Simultaneous failure, she says over eight thousand."

"Projected from what?"

"Door counts and barge loads."

"Which wards remain?"

"South silt, tannery bend, two hospice courts."

"Then write those. Do not write two hundred as if we chose which two hundred."

The worker erased the number.

Oren watched her. "Letha still needs a range to place crews."

"She can have a range beside the names of the places. No number alone."

"The river will not wait for complete lists."

"I did not ask it to."

She had spent most of her life believing any decision larger than one body turned cruelty into arithmetic. Now she sat beside a river capable of killing thousands and demanded arithmetic with bodies left visible inside it. The difference felt insufficient. It also carried more honesty than refusal.

Caun raised one hand. "White Root reports a jam below the eastern gate. Dead timber. They can burn it or cut underwater."

"Fire releases stored heat into the cave," Tavia said. "No."

"Cutters need an hour."

"They have half."

Oren lifted the Crown horn. "Who commands the old maintenance crew there?"

"Keeper Solun."

"He served under me." Oren put the horn to his mouth and sounded two low calls followed by one short. The official signal meant clear obstruction, prepare partial draw. Its note traveled through quarry air to a listening bowl, entered the water, and reached the white roots as vibration. The roots spent more sap carrying it east.

Caun listened. "Solun answers. He has axle saws."

"Tell him cut the trunk in three places. Let each section turn lengthwise through the rack."

Tavia looked at Oren. "You kept that horn because you thought command might still be useful."

"I kept it because breaking it would have made me feel clean."

"And now?"

"Now it makes a sound people recognize. Whether they obey depends on what I ask."

Replies came in broken waves.

Veyl's lowest spillway ran clear. Hush had moved livestock from the island pens. Red Step found the three houses empty after a grandmother refused to leave without her stove door and six neighbors carried both. Bell's east capstan had lost one tooth; Hara Dey rigged rope around the remaining drum. White Root's axle saws entered the jam. Orra's Crown house had collapsed, but Eret's crew braced the west stair. Sea Gate sent no reply.

Sere had reached it first.

Nhal lifted their head. The eclipse darkened the daylight to pewter. By tomorrow the pale interval would close, hardening their gills if saltwater had not changed them. Tavia placed a palm below their jaw and felt heat gathered from the cage, the White Root reservoir, and every stillwater current they had drunk. Hunger had become a hard knot along the belly.

"No more stores," she told them, though they knew pressure, not language. "Living water now."

Their eye reflected her as a moving point among darker stars.

A messenger arrived from the eastern road on a lathered mule. She carried no Crown seal. A different, week-dated hospice token hung from the message cord, one of the expired ovals Enna had refused to surrender for grinding.

Oren stood too quickly and caught the trough edge.

Tavia took the paper because his right hand had gone to his rib.

Enna's writing leaned hard against the fibers.

Fever stays high. I stay with it. Lower wards moving. Perrin says the palace bowl spilled and you will understand. Master Halve says ordinary treatment requires another morning, so make one possible. Do not come back before the road opens.

Below, Perrin had added: She dictated the last sentence twice.

Oren read the note without touching it. His face moved through fear, relief, and the knowledge that neither deserved final authority over Enna's choice.

"She is alive," Tavia said.

"Today."

"Yes."

He sat again. "I thought accepting her decision would feel like release."

"It is work."

"That appears to be your answer to everything."

"Not drowning. That requires a hook."

A corner of his mouth shifted. No confession followed. The quarry had too many listeners and the river no interest in completed tenderness.

Tavia folded Enna's message around the hospice token and gave it to him. "I trusted you to reach her."

"You had no choice. You were chained."

"I trusted you before that."

He studied the token. "At Saint Orra?"

"When you held the hook line after your rib broke."

"That was poor judgment."

"It often accompanies trust."

"I trust you to stop me when command becomes easier than listening."

"Do not make that my permanent trade."

"No." He looked toward Nhal. "Then I trust you to tell me what your hands cannot hold."

The answer reached an old fear. Tavia could hold a newborn, a drowned body, a rope under load. She could not hold seven locks, sixty-three thousand people, and a mooncalf's dying clock. Naming that limit no longer felt like surrender.

"My hands cannot hold the timing," she said. "That belongs to everyone at the sluices."

Oren raised the horn. "Then ask if they are ready."

He sounded each lock call in order. One for Veyl. Two for Hush. The clipped pattern for Red Step. Bell's long return. White Root's rising pair. Orra's broken cadence. Seven clear notes for Sea Gate.

Answers traveled through white roots, keeper bowls, road horns, and human runners. None came perfectly. Red Step delayed while the stove door reached high ground. Bell needed another brace. White Root freed the first timber section and lost an axle saw. Orra reported water above the second mark. Sea Gate remained silent.

Tavia assigned ten more minutes to Bell, eight to White Root, and no imaginary certainty to the western gate.

"If Sea Gate stays shut?" Caun asked.

"We open through Orra and hold the western crest in the salt flats as long as we can," she said. "Letha clears the road. Oren and I go to the gate."

"The flood may reach before you."

"Yes."

"Nhal may not survive the hold."

"Yes."

Quarry workers listened. Tavia let both risks remain in the air.

At last, White Root answered clear. Bell's brace held. Red Step's three houses stood empty. Captain Letha's horn sounded faintly from the west road, not at Sea Gate yet but close enough to carry a promise of labor.

Tavia waded into the quarry until water reached her waist. Her stiff knee dragged. She put both palms on Nhal's sides, one behind the good forward fin and one clear of the wound.

"The three-note song begins here," she said. "Roots carry it east first. Each gate opens only on its own answer. No one anticipates."

Caun relayed the instruction. Oren gave the horn pattern. Around the quarry, people took up positions at listening bowls.

Tavia drew breath.

The first note settled low in her chest. Nhal answered with pressure through the water. The source lay in their muscles and breath; the change moved into quarry water, stone, and white roots. Tiny root fibers split as counterweight to the distance.

Far to the east, the note reached Lake Veyl.

For a moment nothing returned.

Then the oldest root under Tavia's palm bent westward. Through water and bone came a vast iron sound.

On the first note, Veyl's distant answering gate opened.

Chapter 26 — The Breaking of Seven Locks

Veyl opened through Tavia's bones.

The first gate's answer traveled beneath half a kingdom in water and white root, a pressure so deep that the quarry surface dimpled without wind. Nhal lifted their wounded head. Around the flooded ledges, people stopped speaking and held the sequence in their bodies.

Far east, Ila's crew had cleared the lowest sluice before taking the capstan. The root message came in pieces: basalt tremor, wheel strain, one snapped rope, another rope taking load. Lake water entered the old birthing shaft and the Nightcourse together. The main gate rose one hand, stuck on a warped tooth, then rose again when Dunmere fishers put their shoulders to the auxiliary bar.

No stillwater held it. Iron accepted wear as iron. Rope stretched. Six people tore skin from their palms. The source change came from a lake descending toward its buried road; stone and gate took the force, while the crews paid in ordinary strain.

Tavia sang the second note.

Nhal answered. The note entered water through their throat and moved east along torn roots. White sap clouded the quarry at every transmission. Tavia kept one palm against the mooncalf's jaw and the other on the root that carried Ila's reply.

Veyl's gate reached its marked height.

"First holds," Brother Caun said.

Oren sounded one call on the Crown horn. Not command. Confirmation.

The returned pressure shifted west to the next barrier.

Hush answered with reed bells.

Mara Pell's people had opened both island sluices, but flood grass packed the northern rack as the main water arrived. Through the roots, Tavia felt poles strike weed, felt a ferry rope pull taut, felt the next mass of water leaning against wood and bodies. Messages carried sensation rather than words. Caun translated the signal code spoken by the listening bowls.

"North rack blocked. Six people still on goat island."

"Ferry?" Tavia asked.

"Last crossing started."

Oren held the horn ready. "If they lift now, the backflow takes the ferry sideways."

"Tell Mara to wait."

He sounded the hold pattern. Root fibers bent. Somewhere under the reed country, a listening bowl cracked from the pressure.

Nhal tried to turn west. Their injured left forward fin dragged, opening a dark thread in the water. Tavia tightened the support wrap and shifted the cradle-boat beneath their chest. The quarry current wanted them toward the sea. Every delay hardened their gill edges a little more.

"You wait," she told them. "They are making room."

The mooncalf struck the boat once with their tail. That movement entered ordinary water and rocked Caun knee-deep. No cage diverted it. No distant body received the blow.

A root pulse brought the ferry's arrival. Five people climbed the high bank. The sixth, an old herder, went back for a child who had hidden under wet fleece. Mara's crew could see both figures. Floodwater reached the island pen.

"We cannot hold the sequence for one body forever," a quarry keeper said.

Tavia knew. She also knew what a clean decision would call that child.

"How long before the rack fails by itself?"

Oren judged the tremor under his boot. "Four minutes. Perhaps less."

"Give them two."

The quarry keeper stared at the rising ledge. "That costs everyone west two minutes."

"Yes."

Tavia did not say the cost would be worth it. No one knew.

Mara's final reed bell came after one minute and forty breaths. The herder reached the ferry with the child under his coat. Crews cut the clogged rack rather than clear it. Flood grass and broken wood shot through first. Then the gate lifted.

Hush released in a long, low surge. One empty ferry overturned. Two goat pens vanished. The north keeper house lost its downstream wall after years of stolen rot returned from a broken object line. Everyone in that house had moved uphill.

"Second holds," Caun said.

Oren gave two calls.

Tavia took the third note higher. Nhal's answer shook loose stones from the quarry rim.

Red Step received the combined water.

Sela Rusk had cleared the three houses and broken two temporary dye walls. The third wall belonged to a guild warehouse whose owners locked the tools inside before fleeing. Workers attacked it with boat hooks, mallets, and a timber beam. Behind them, saturated cloth released borrowed stains in clouds of blue and orange. Fruit stored under the market awnings collapsed into rot as Nhal's pressure-song disturbed old channels.

The change debt followed rightful sources. Orchard decay returned westward to trees already harvested, killing some roots. Suspended dye seeped from cloth into

the canal. Beams took back age and sagged. People paid only where Crown assignments remained connected.

A sharp pulse entered the quarry root.

Caun flinched. "Ward line under the west depot. Still active."

"How many?"

"Four assignment marks."

"Can Sela reach the valve?"

The reply took twenty heartbeats. "Depot cellar flooding. One volunteer going."

"No," Oren said. "Valve box sits under the north lintel. If the third wall goes, the lintel drops."

Tavia listened to the confused rhythm arriving through root and water. Sela could wait for a safer approach and risk transferring the gate surge into four people. She could send someone into the cellar and risk that person under the wall. No choice removed a body.

"Break the silver line from outside," Tavia said. "Not the valve. Use the guild beam as a ram against the channel where it crosses the drain."

Oren put the instruction into three horn patterns. At the eastern listening stations, people relayed it by bowls and runners.

The guild wall fell before the answer returned.

Water struck the warehouse. A woman on the ram crew disappeared under blue foam. Two others found her against a grain post and pulled her out with a broken leg. The timber beam hit the drain channel on its second swing. Silver snapped.

Stored strain returned toward the depot. Its roof dropped into an empty counting room. The four ward residents stopped receiving gate pressure. Existing injuries remained.

Sela's crew opened the third dye cut.

Red Step lifted. Water spread through canals in three colored streams instead of one destructive crest. One market row washed away. The three occupied houses stood empty with white cloth tied at their doors. A fourth building, missed on the slate because it served as an illegal sleeping room, collapsed with two people inside.

The root carried no names.

"Get them," Tavia said.

"Sequence," the quarry keeper warned.

"Rescue crew only. Gate crew stays."

Sela sent six people. They recovered one survivor and one body before the east canal rose too high.

Tavia asked the slate keeper to leave two blank lines. Names would come later.

The dead did not become less specific because the living had not yet learned who they were.

"Third holds," Caun said.

Oren sounded the clipped pattern.

The river reached Bell.

Its arrival carried Bellhaven into the roots as a thousand overlapping impacts. Barge hulls struck steps. Capstans jumped. Blue roof tiles slid into floodwater. Hara Dey's east crew held one drum with rope because a tooth had broken. Below them, the lower basin still moved uphill.

Tavia could not see the capital, but reports built its physical shape. South silt remained half occupied. The tannery bridge had been marked closed; people diverted through the soap yard until a warehouse wall blocked the lane. Six grain barges loaded patients from the hospice courts. Captain Letha had left for the western gate, so dock crews chose priorities by names written on charcoal boards.

The first three openings had raised the Bell approach faster than engineers projected. A return wave from Hush arrived behind the main crest. Simultaneously, palace channels released years of structural debt into the audience hill. Part of the western retaining wall split and dropped stone into the lock race.

"Main gate cannot lift," Caun said. "Debris against the lower leaf."

"East spill?" Oren asked.

"Clear."

"West mill race?"

"Blocked by evacuation barges."

Oren's right hand tightened around the horn. Pain made his face shine. "They must move the barges."

"They are loading the last hospice court," Tavia said.

"If the race stays blocked, the gate force goes under south silt."

"How long to load?"

"Message says nine minutes."

They did not possess nine.

Nhal's gills opened and failed to close fully. A hard translucent edge had formed along each slit. Tavia put two fingers beneath one and felt the eclipse changing cartilage into shell. Saltwater could reverse it. Quarry water could not.

"Give the hospice three minutes," she said. "Then move every hull, loaded or not. Leave two shore crews with doors and rope."

The slate keeper wrote the choice. Tavia made him add: South silt at risk if delayed.

Oren sent the pattern.

During the wait, white roots relayed the three-note song into Bellhaven. Crowds on flood stairs took it up. Human voices lacked Nhal's pressure, but sound coordinated hands. On the first note, crews cleared the east spill. The second moved barges from the race. The third told Hara to lift.

Three minutes passed.

Five hospice barges entered the canal. The sixth remained half loaded when the mill-race bell sounded. Its master cut the mooring and let current swing the bow out. Twelve patients waited on doors above the flood stair. Two House attendants stayed with them.

Hara Dey's crew heaved on the capstan.

The broken tooth skipped. Rope snapped backward and killed a keeper before anyone could duck. Another crew took his place because stopping would send the crest under the city.

Bell's gate rose unevenly.

Water punched through the lower race. Prepared canals took much of it. The rest entered south silt below the blue tile mark. Buildings there had been emptied incompletely. People climbed roofs and limewashed flood stairs. Rescue skiffs launched from the soap yard. One struck hidden masonry and overturned. Neighbors on a roof threw laundry lines, pulling three people out while a fourth vanished beneath brown water.

At the palace hill, years of held settlement returned to foundations. The empty west gallery collapsed. A north kitchen still held six workers; four escaped before the ceiling came down. No report came for the other two.

The gate continued rising.

Tavia felt every urge to stop the sequence and send all hands back. Stopping now would trap the accumulated crest at the capital and kill more people in the same streets. Continuing meant accepting water already among them.

"Fourth holds," Caun said, voice rough.

Oren lowered the horn. "Say the name."

"Keeper Den Ro. Capstan rope."

The slate keeper wrote it.

Tavia sang again.

White Root answered beneath her feet.

The fifth barrier stood inside the cavern forest where pale roots webbed gate, stone, and reservoir. Solun's crew had cut the dead timber jam into three sections. Two had turned through the rack. The third lodged crosswise under the main leaf.

The combined river reached it before the axle saws could finish.

Roots bowed in the cavern. Their fibers stored pressure naturally, not through paleshell, but too much bending would uproot the entire forest and collapse the

listening network. Sap poured into mineral pools. Brother Caun touched the quarry strand and went pale.

"The roots cannot hold another full note."

"What happens if they fail?"

"Messages stop. Cave roof may come down where the largest trunks tear."

"People?"

"Treatment crew at the north pool. Gate crew on the west ledge."

Tavia closed her eyes and mapped bodies rather than symbols. The treatment crew could use the surface exit Caun marked on Day Eleven. West-ledge keepers had to remain for the gate.

"Evacuate north pool. Cut every small listening root except the west strand."

Caun recoiled. "Those trees took centuries."

"They pay or people do."

He transmitted the order with his own low song. House workers cut roots that had carried prayers, pain, and messages longer than the Crown's locks had stood. White sap flooded the cave. Severed fibers released pressure into water and mineral, sparing the roof by sacrificing the communication web.

One west strand remained.

Solun's crew could not dislodge the third timber. Oren gave them an old lock-rider command: lower the gate one finger before lifting, using the reverse current to turn debris.

"It may crush the rack," Caun said.

"It will," Oren replied. "Tell them to stand above the axle."

Iron lowered. The timber rolled. The rack crushed flat and vanished downstream. White Root opened.

Water took years of mineral stain from the cave walls. Blind trees bent west, lost branches, and remained rooted. The north treatment pool emptied into the Nightcourse after every patient reached the surface path. One saw operator lost three fingers when the reverse wheel caught his glove. No stillwater stopped his bleeding; Caun's people bound the hand and carried him uphill.

"Fifth holds," Tavia said.

The white-root network had gone nearly silent. Only the final west strand carried a weak reply from the sixth barrier.

Orra had begun breaking before its turn.

The western pin split during the grinding-room escape. Eret and Davi An had braced the pilgrimage stairs, cleared the Crown house, and opened the lowest spillway. Their main capstan, however, moved under returned cage debt. Every stored tail stroke and gill beat had entered the mechanism through Sere's trap.

Now the force came home.

"Do not touch the capstan," Tavia told the root. "Cut the brake cable from the upper platform. Let movement lift the gate."

A reply arrived as three taps: people still below.

"Where?"

"Grinding corridor. Two keepers searching cells."

Caun looked at her. His swollen eye had closed completely. "They may be looking for prisoners."

"They have four minutes."

"Or less."

Tavia sent the time without softening it.

Nhal rolled from the cradle-boat into the quarry current. Their body pointed west. They could feel the open water beyond the sixth barrier. Holding them now required rope across the chest, Tavia's weight on the boat brace, and their own dwindling willingness to wait.

The root brought one keeper out. Then the second emerged carrying a prisoner over his shoulder. A third figure followed, someone no slate had listed. The Crown physician from the cage room had gone back for his instrument boy.

"Clear," Caun said.

Eret cut the brake.

Stored movement turned Orra's capstan without human hands. The gate leapt its first foot and shattered the upper guide. Water threw empty saint barges into the pilgrimage wall. The altered relief split along old plaster lines, exposing Orra's carved crew from stair to stair.

Davi's mother lost her footing on the platform. Her son caught one wrist. The silver-burned joint dislocated, but she held the knife until the last brake line parted.

The sixth lock opened.

The accumulated river entered the quarry.

Tavia had one breath to release Nhal's support rope. Water stood up from the eastern ledge, black and vertical. It took the cradle-boat, slate tables, tools, and people who had not reached the marked shelf.

Oren sounded the evacuation call before the wave struck. Caun caught a root with both arms. Tavia threw herself across Nhal's neck.

The river broke over them.

Cold erased direction. Her stiff left knee hit stone. One burned palm tore open on a scale ridge. She kept the good forward fin clear, protected the wounded left side with her body, and let Nhal's stronger limbs choose the current.

They rose west of the quarry in the main Nightcourse.

Oren surfaced beside an overturned trough. His Crown horn remained looped around his chest. Caun came up farther back with the slate keeper. Three workers clung to the last white root. One person did not surface.

Nhal swam.

The released current strengthened them but pulled blood from the hook wound. Tavia climbed onto the broken forward section of the cradle-boat and used its rope as a guide line. Oren joined her, unable to paddle on his injured side. Behind them, the sequential openings converted six reservoirs into one moving river.

Ahead waited Sea Gate.

For the first time since the song began, no root message could reach them. The cut network ended at the quarry. They followed water west through a channel widening toward daylight.

Salt entered the air before they saw the flats. Nhal tasted it and accelerated. Their hardened gill edges softened by a fraction, then tightened again. The eclipse had narrowed to a dark bite over the drowned moon.

The Nightcourse emerged into a basin of iron-colored mud and low stone walls. Sea Gate spanned the western mouth. Its twin leaves remained shut. Above them, Regent Sere stood on the central mechanism platform with her gray hair loose and a silver throat pipe in both hands.

Captain Letha's people occupied the north stair. Salt workers held the south. Neither could cross the stillwater sheet covering the platform.

Sere sounded the held note.

Paleshell clouded the gate pool. The river's forward motion stopped so abruptly that Tavia left the boat and struck the water as if striking floor. Nhal slammed sideways. Oren caught the guide rope with his left hand and nearly lost it when his cracked right rib folded him.

The stopped change had to move somewhere.

Silver channels blazed from Sea Gate eastward. Object stores along the flats saturated at once. Salt sheds took structural strain and collapsed empty. Sacrificial ice flashed to water. When those counterweights failed, the force traveled into remaining weathering wards outside Bellhaven and along the western road. Through exposed channels, Tavia saw distant human assignment lamps ignite.

"People pay for every second!" she shouted.

Sere's older face tightened around the throat pipe. "If I release it now, the crest takes the gate and everyone below."

"Open the leaves in sequence."

"The western screw has fused."

Oren dragged himself onto the north stair. "I can reach it."

"You cannot turn it with one arm," Letha called.

"Then bring more."

Her crews formed a line along the mechanism rail. Stillwater prevented the screw from moving; every attempt merely sent their force through silver into ward bodies. Tavia saw a channel lamp brighten with each push.

"Stop!"

They released the bar.

Nhal lay on held water, gills barely moving. The left forward fin leaked black into the pale pool. Tavia crawled toward them. Sere's magic stopped the river, not Tavia's body, until her hands touched the moving edge around Nhal. There, suspended current pressed like glass.

She could not overpower it. No song could safely release that much debt while the gate stayed shut.

"Sere," she said. "Look east."

"I have seen the projections."

"Not paper. Look."

From the platform, the Regent could see beyond the flats to Bellhaven's distant heights. Rain had cleared. Signal mirrors flashed from the upper courts. Grain barges moved along the ridge canal, black with evacuees. Lower-basin streets lay underwater, but rescue skiffs crossed between blue-tiled roofs. The city moved without royal permission and without becoming orderly enough to flatter anyone.

Captain Letha climbed as far as the stillwater boundary allowed. "South silt lost three streets. North hospice cleared. Ward Seven cleared. Archive court holds kitchens. We need the gate open."

"How many remain below the marks?" Sere asked.

"We do not know."

"You ask me to act without knowing."

"We have acted for two days without knowing."

The Regent looked at Tavia. "If I release the hold, years return through every broken route. My body cannot take them gradually now."

"No."

"The gate may still fail."

"Yes."

"Nhal may die short of the sea."

"Yes."

Sere lowered the pipe by one inch. "You offer no mercy."

"I offer no lie."

A lower-ward signal rose in the distance: three notes sung by people too far

away to hear individually. Other stair crews answered. The sound crossed open air where roots had failed.

Sere watched a grain barge turn around a drowned audience roof. Its pilot avoided wreckage without waiting for command. On the western ridge, people opened a storehouse and passed sacks hand to hand. No one preserved the palace archives. No one killed the clerks who had tried.

The Regent removed the paleshell clasp from her throat.

This time she did not drop it into another circuit.

She crushed its thin shell against the platform rail.

Her personal stilling broke. Thirty-five years of age returned toward their source. Some remained lost in dead residents and ruined objects, damage that could never be reclaimed as justice. The rest entered Sere's body at accumulated speed.

Her spine curved. Skin loosened across her face and hands. The wasting fever she had survived returned as weakness in her limbs, not because magic created illness, but because stillwater had postponed its bodily aftermath along with age. She fell against the release wheel.

The held note ceased.

River motion returned. Sea Gate shook from foundation to tower. Letha's crews took the northern screw. Oren wedged his shoulder under the bar, left arm pulling while his right side failed. Salt workers seized the southern wheel.

Sere rose once by gripping the central lever.

Tavia reached the platform through knee-deep moving water. She could have dragged the Regent away from the mechanism. Doing so would leave the central catch engaged.

"Which order?" she asked.

Sere's eyes had clouded, but calculation remained. "North leaf. South two breaths later. Central catch last."

Letha called the sequence.

North opened.

Water struck the salt-flat channel and tore out its eastern bank. Two workers vanished from the wheel. Ropes went after them; one came back alive.

South opened after two breaths.

The balanced flow kept the central pier standing. Bellhaven's flood rose below the prepared marks on the heights, not above them. Lower districts filled. Houses collapsed. Barges rode over streets where people had lived that morning.

Sere pulled the catch.

The central mechanism engaged with a grinding shock. Returned age took the strength from her hands. Tavia caught her before she fell beneath the wheel.

"Is it open?" Sere asked.

"Yes."

"Do not tell them I saved them."

"You opened what you closed."

A breath moved through the Regent and did not return. Her body weighed sixty-seven years and thirty-five years of debt without any ward receiving the next hour.

Tavia laid her above the gear path. There would be names later, including hers, with no clean line through them.

Nhal passed under the gate.

The mooncalf entered the western salt flats on the flood crest. Their wounded fin dragged. Three others pushed against shallowing water. Tavia took the guide rope; Oren, Letha, and salt workers joined it. No single pair of hands carried the weight.

Behind them, Bellhaven flooded to the chalked blue lines. Some routes held. Others failed. Rescue bells continued.

Ahead, the sea had withdrawn beyond a mile of wet salt.

The eclipse closed over the drowned moon.

Nhal swam until water thinned beneath their belly, then pulled forward on three fins. Black blood marked the flats. People pushed the cradle-boat behind them as a moving basin, pouring water over hardening gills.

The surf sounded in darkness, close enough to promise and too far to touch.

Nhal collapsed short of it.

Chapter 27 — A Night With Weight

Oren pulled until the guide rope cut through his left palm.

Ahead, Nhal lay across the wet salt with three fins spread and the wounded left forward fin bound against their body. Behind, the released river poured through the broken gate and spread in branching sheets. The sea remained a dark line beyond the flats, retreating almost as quickly as the survivors dragged the mooncalf toward it.

“Again,” Tavia said.

She walked beside Nhal’s head with both hands under the jaw. Blood ran from one palm where stone had opened an old rope burn. Her stiff left knee shortened every fourth step, yet she did not surrender that side to anyone else.

Oren leaned backward. His cracked right rib shifted beneath the binding. Captain Letha and twelve salt workers took the rope behind him. Others pushed the three sections of the cradle-boat under Nhal in turn, making a road of shallow basins. Water poured from each section before they carried it forward again.

No hidden body paid for this movement. Their muscles supplied it. Salt cut their feet. Rope took skin. Nhal’s weight pressed grooves into mud.

The eclipse had closed. Full darkness rested over Avelune for the first time in generations, but cloud hid the stars and moon alike. Rescue bells sounded east through rain.

“Surf should meet us at the second iron stake,” a salt worker said.

The second stake stood a hundred paces ahead. Its tide rings shone pale.

“The sea is late,” Letha answered.

“The moon has been late for a hundred sixty-two years.”

Nhal’s gills opened against air. The edges had hardened into thin black shell. Tavia tipped a bucket from the cradle-boat over them. Quarry water ran off too warm and too fresh.

Oren looked behind. The river had erased the path to the gate. People on the broken stair were lowering doors as rafts. A roof beam spun in the current. Sere’s body had been carried to the upper platform and covered with her coat. No guard stood around it.

The river carried the first survivors past them on a door raft. A woman held a boy whose lower leg bent where no joint belonged. Two salt workers waded out, took the raft, and asked before touching him. Tavia released Nhal’s jaw long enough to check the break.

“Closed fracture,” she said. “Splint above and below. No stillwater.”

The woman clutched the boy tighter. “He cannot bear that pain.”

"He already bears it. Paleshell would make someone else bear the bone's change."

"Give it to me."

Tavia met her eyes. "That would leave two patients and no one able to carry him. Hold his hand. Tell him what happens next."

They cut two strips from the broken cradle brace, padded them with wet cloth, and bound the leg. The boy screamed until his voice failed. His mother named each step and did not promise it would stop hurting. When the raft moved toward the treatment ridge, she held his weight without taking the injury into her own body.

Another current branch brought household things: a painted door, three grain chits in a wax pouch, a child's shoe, a weathering-ward register swollen with water. Oren caught the register before it passed. Ink had bled, but assignment numbers remained. He put it under his coat.

"Records later," Letha called. "Rope now."

He obeyed because the rope task stood in front of him, not because her rank removed his responsibility.

At the salt ridge, crews marked four lanes with lanterns. Red received people needing immediate treatment. White took those able to walk. Black cloth designated bodies whose names needed recording before removal. The fourth lane led east for anyone searching relatives, though workers warned them not to enter the current alone.

A man arrived carrying a locked archive box above his head. Behind him, an injured kitchen servant struggled without help.

"Drop it," Letha ordered.

"Royal flood maps," he protested.

"Then they have already served their purpose."

He set the box in mud and went back for the servant. Water entered its seams. Paper became pulp. Oren felt no satisfaction. Some records could not be recovered, and future councils would need to admit what they no longer knew.

Farther east, a roof collapsed with people signaling from it. Letha sent one rope crew and refused a second because the treatment ridge needed carriers. The decision left no one content. That did not make it wrong or clean.

Tavia pointed toward the next iron stake. "Pull."

They pulled.

At the first iron stake, a return wave struck from behind. It lifted the cradle sections and knocked six workers off their feet. Oren lost the rope with his right hand, caught it again with his left, and felt pain tear from rib to spine.

Nhal slid sideways.

Tavia planted herself against their jaw. "Keep the wound above salt grit."

"There is no saltwater yet," Oren said.

"Grit does not care."

He moved to the injured side. Together they rolled the mooncalf enough for Caun to replace the blood-soaked wrap. The House brother's swollen eye had opened to a narrow red slit. He used plain linen. Any stillwater thread would have displaced Nhal's bleeding into another body along the surviving channels.

From the east came a line of lanterns.

Evacuation barges had grounded where the flood met the flats. People climbed down into knee-deep water and carried children, bundles, and injured neighbors toward the salt ridge. Among them moved a narrow hospice litter with blue ceramic tokens tied to its poles.

Oren stopped pulling.

Enna sat upright beneath a sailcloth hood.

Master Halve walked on one side, holding a blood line high. Perrin came beside the litter in a wheeled chair mounted on a barge plank. Two ward residents pushed him through mud. His hands remained bent; his spine forced him forward. He looked twelve and older than Oren's father had at death.

Enna saw Oren and raised a weak hand. Fever had thinned her face in one day. Blood marked the corner of her mouth.

"You left the road open," she said.

"You should be on the heights."

"Those are east."

Halve gave Oren an exhausted look. "The north hospice stair failed. Western evacuation offered the smoothest route."

"Smooth?" Perrin asked as his front wheel sank.

"Relative term."

Oren knelt beside Enna's litter and immediately regretted the pressure on his rib. She touched the bandage at his right side.

"Still terrible," she said.

"You are feverish."

"We both observe well."

"How long stable?"

"Pulse has held since afternoon," Halve said. "Fever remains dangerous. Donor blood continues. No silver transfer."

Perrin held up his hands. "No new aging. Before you ask."

Existing harm remained visible in both children. Enna had chosen illness

returned to her own marrow. Perrin had stopped paying, but freedom did not straighten bone.

Nhal moved behind Oren. A pressure tremor crossed the salt and shook water from the litter hood.

Enna leaned to see. "That is them?"

"Yes."

"They look smaller than the flood."

"Most bodies do."

She pulled the oldest expired hospice token from beneath her blanket, its week-mark worn pale. "Do they need it?"

"No more doors."

"Good." She let it fall onto the wet salt. "I am tired of keys."

Perrin watched the blue oval sink halfway into mud. "Someone will put that in a museum."

"Then push it deeper."

He directed one of the ward residents to roll over it.

The chair wheel exposed a silver line under the mud. It had once carried Sea Gate's arrested wear toward a western counterweight house. Now the line ended in a torn coupling. A faint light still pulsed inside it.

Perrin bent as far as his spine allowed. "Residual charge."

Halve caught his shoulder. "Do not touch."

"Was not planning to. I have become particular about what enters me."

A former ward resident named Asha followed the line to the treatment ridge. Its far end had been tied into a field splint where a gate officer's broken arm lay perfectly still. The fracture's swelling and pain traveled back along silver toward the abandoned counterweight house. With the house flooded, the change searched the severed route and leaked into wet salt.

Asha explained the transfer to the officer. "Your arm stays quiet by sending its injury into whatever the line finds. Right now that may be no person, but the circuit is open."

"Cut it," he said.

Halve replaced the silver splint with wood and plain linen. Pain returned to his arm. He cried out and kept his consent. Asha used insulated cutters on the coupling. The residual light died without finding another body.

Perrin looked at Enna. "One less museum piece."

"Bad museum," she said.

The small act changed no flood count. It prevented one hidden transfer from surviving inside the rescue work, which Oren had learned deserved its own place in

the count.

Tavia came to the litter. She assessed Enna before speaking to Oren: skin color, breath rate, blood line, awareness. Trade before reassurance.

"You chose release," she said.

Enna nodded.

"Any stillwater since?"

"No."

"Good. The fever belongs in your body. The care belongs in many hands."

"That sounds unfair."

"It is ordinary."

A sound crossed the flats, lower than a bell.

The tide turned.

Black water advanced from the western dark, not as a wave but as a broad shining edge. It reached the second iron stake, climbed its lowest ring, and continued.

Nhal felt it. Their tail struck wet salt. The pressure threw Perrin's chair backward and made Enna's blood line sway.

"Move the patients to the ridge," Oren said.

"I stay until they reach it," Enna replied.

"You cannot help pull."

"I can sing."

Tavia looked from her to the incoming tide. "Save breath. Give the first note when the water reaches Nhal's gills."

Salt workers repositioned the cradle-boat. Letha sent half her crew east to guide evacuees away from the river branches. Caun assigned litter carriers. No one gathered merely to witness.

Oren took the rope again.

They hauled Nhal toward living surf while tide came to meet them. Wet salt softened under every step. The first incoming tongue reached the mooncalf's tail and ran along translucent scales. Constellations inside their body brightened.

"Not enough," Tavia said. "Gills."

Another pull.

Water covered the hind fins. Nhal convulsed. Their stored hunger released into the tide, not as stillwater transfer but as bodily change. Heat moved from their blood into saltwater. The water warmed around them. Hardened gill edges began dissolving.

At the second stake, Oren's rib failed him. His knees hit mud. The rope slid

through his hands.

Letha caught his section. "Breathe."

"I am."

"Badly."

He crawled forward and took the rope lower. He could pull with his legs while keeping the right side still.

Tide reached Nhal's throat.

Enna sang the first note from her litter. Fever weakened it, but people around her joined. Perrin carried the second. His voice cracked. Ward residents, salt workers, palace servants, keepers, and people who had lost homes found the third.

Nhal answered beneath them.

Pressure entered the sea. Unlike white roots or silver channels, saltwater spread the change through its own moving mass. No distant counterweight weathered. Nhal's muscles spent their remaining strength. The tide took the song outward and returned with a deeper pulse.

Their gills opened.

Black shell dissolved from the edges. Saltwater flushed iron and blood from the wound below the left forward fin. The injury did not vanish. Its scar contracted around torn muscle and limited that limb.

Nhal moved under their own weight.

The rope went slack.

They slid into surf, three fins driving. Tavia followed waist-deep. Oren saw the incoming breaker before she did.

"Tavia!"

Water struck.

Nhal disappeared beneath black foam. Tavia vanished with them. The cradle-boat sections collided. One hit Oren's shoulder and spun him onto his back. Salt filled his mouth.

He found bottom, stood, and saw no one where Tavia had been.

Then the sea rose.

A long dark body broke the surface beyond the first breakers. Nhal's scales no longer held small constellations. They held moving fields of night. Along both sides, the rear fin-limbs opened and lengthened. Membrane spread between silver bones, broad enough to catch the sea wind.

Sail-wings.

The wounded forward fin stayed folded near the body. A scar shone beneath it.

Nhal climbed one wave and left the water.

Not easily. The first lift failed, and their belly struck foam. The second carried them the height of a person before the damaged side tilted. On the third, the sail-wings filled. Wind changed around the flats. Cloud tore open in a widening path.

People stopped singing.

Nhal crossed above them, shedding saltwater in bright sheets. Their pressure-song passed through chest bones and loosened dreams that had gone thin for generations. Oren remembered Enna at four asleep against his coat, not as an accusation or proof, only as a child's real weight.

The moonbrood circled once toward the drowned moon.

Night thickened. Tide rhythms shifted underfoot. These changes came from Nhal's completed body meeting sea and sky. Their metamorphosis spent shell, heat, and enormous muscular work; no ward child aged for it.

Then they flew west into dark cloud.

Oren searched the surf for Tavia.

Her recovery hook washed against his boot. He picked it up. The rope had snapped near the grip.

"Tavia!"

Letha organized the search before he could turn panic into useless motion. Four lines entered the water at measured intervals. Salt workers watched the current. Caun checked each person pulled out. Oren took the northern line despite his rib.

Bodies came in.

A Sea Gate worker breathed after Caun cleared mud from her mouth. One of Letha's officers did not. Two pilgrims clung to a door. A child from south silt arrived alone with a charcoal name on his sleeve and could not say where his family had gone.

No Tavia.

The fully dark sky did not make the flooded basin merciful. Bellhaven burned in three places where returned heat had reached old kitchens. Rescue bells marked roofs. Families called names from the salt ridge. The opened river carried grain sacks, roof tile, animal carcasses, and household bowls through the gate.

Oren returned to work because searching one stretch repeatedly would not create her.

At the casualty tables, clerks refused to write a final number. Reports changed by the hour. Hush had lost ferry workers. Red Step had two confirmed dead and more missing. Bellhaven's south silt and tannery bend carried the greatest loss. White Root reported one crushed keeper and three severe injuries. Saint Orra still searched the grinding cells. Sea Gate crews counted their own.

Hundreds had died across the basin.

Not tens of thousands. Evacuation had mattered. Grain barges, cleared stairs, named leaders, and ordinary disobedience had kept whole districts alive. That truth did not reduce hundreds into an acceptable price.

Oren read names as they arrived. Keeper Den Ro. Mira Sel, market sleeper. Tovan Sel, her brother. Two unnamed people recovered below the soap yard. A House attendant called Rinn. A salt worker whose crew knew only the name Avo. Blank lines remained for bodies not found and names not carried west.

"South silt estimate?" a clerk asked.

"Do not turn it into one number yet," Oren said. "List streets cleared, streets lost, people found, people missing."

"Tavia taught you that," Letha said from behind him.

"I learned slowly."

"Learn while walking. North rescue needs rope."

He took a coil with his left arm.

Enna and Perrin worked at the treatment station despite orders to rest. Enna sorted clean cloth from used while Halve watched her pulse. Perrin recorded residents' assignment injuries so no one later called flood damage responsible for years of weathering. Both tired quickly. Neither allowed useful work to erase bodily limits.

At the north channel, a collapsed grain-barge mast pinned three people against a roof section. Oren directed the lift. His experience with gates supplied leverage points; four civilians supplied force. They freed two alive. The third had drowned before the mast arrived.

Near dawn, though no pale light returned yet, a salt child ran to him.

"Woman under the east fish stair. Black hair. Keeps trying to stand."

Oren left the rope where another person could take it and followed.

The old fish stair had broken from the gate wall and lodged half a mile west. Beneath it, in water up to her shoulders, Tavia supported an unconscious boy against the stone. Her jaw-length hair had dried in salt points. Blood covered one side of her face from a scalp cut.

"You took your time," she said.

Relief struck him so hard that his rib seemed a minor thing.

"Can you move?"

"My knee will not bear. The boy inhaled water and has a pulse."

Oren called the litter crew rather than trying to carry both. He entered the water and took the boy's weight while Tavia kept the head aligned.

"Did you see Nhal?" he asked.

"From underneath."

"They flew."

"I heard the lift." Her hand found the recovery hook at his belt. "You found this."

"It found me."

She examined his face as if checking for a concussion. "Enna?"

"Alive. Fever high. Perrin alive. No new aging."

"Losses?"

"Hundreds. Count not finished. Lower districts ruined. Most evacuation routes held. Some did not."

Tavia closed her eyes once. Saltwater ran from the lashes. "Names?"

"Lists started."

"Good."

The litter crew arrived. They lifted the boy first at her insistence, then strapped Tavia to a door because her left knee had swollen twice its normal size. Oren walked beside her rather than take a handle he could not safely carry.

At the treatment ridge, Enna reached from her own litter and touched Tavia's wet hand. Perrin offered a dry blanket that smelled of palace archives.

Cloud moved over the flats.

The drowned moon remained hidden, but holes opened above it. Points of light appeared where Avelune's pale nights had concealed them for generations. They did not form an instruction. No pattern selected a savior or promised repair.

Ordinary stars became visible over the ruined lower city, the treatment fires, and the living people still calling names.

Chapter 28 — The Midwife at the Sea

Tavia put two fingers against the child's scalp and told Neri not to push.

"I have been told to push since midnight," Neri said through her teeth.

"People have been wrong since before midnight. Pant now."

The rebuilt coastal house held every sound. Wind pressed the woven reed walls. Surf struck the new spillway beyond the birth room. Six trainees stood where Tavia had placed them, close enough to work and far enough to leave the laboring woman air.

Neri knelt over a low birthing rail with her partner, Esen, supporting her weight from the front. One shoulder had failed to turn. The scalp showed dark hair and no further movement. If the child remained caught, breath would fail before strength did.

"Position?" Tavia asked.

A trainee named Jori swallowed. "Hands and knees. Lift the right leg."

"Why right?"

"The child's back faces left. It gives the trapped shoulder room."

"Do it."

They moved Neri between contractions. No stillwater quieted pain or held tissue unchanged. Neri's body supplied each effort. Esen paid through bruised forearms and a bitten lip. The trainees paid in work, not transferred injury.

Tavia's left knee no longer bent fully after the salt-flat surge. She used a padded block rather than kneeling. The change made her slower to reach low angles and better at telling another pair of hands what mattered.

"Next contraction," she said, "push toward Jori's hand. Not the floor."

Neri gave her a murderous look. "Jori did not put me here."

"No. The child did."

The contraction came. Neri bore down. Jori kept one palm above the pubic bone and pressed the shoulder sideways. Tavia guided the head down and toward the mother's thigh.

Nothing moved.

Esen began the first note of the old lake song.

"Stop," Tavia said.

The note broke.

"We use that for moonbrood pressure and for people who choose it during ordinary labor. Not to make a stuck shoulder sacred."

"I thought it helped."

"It may help breath. It does not change bone."

Neri panted. "I liked it."

"Then sing for her, not at the child."

Esen started again, softer. The three notes belonged to comfort now, carrying no paleshell and activating no transfer. Sound moved through air. Breath paid for breath.

Tavia assessed the child's position. The forward shoulder remained wedged. She could reach one arm, perhaps sweep it across the chest. The maneuver risked fracture. Waiting risked death.

She looked at Neri. "The shoulder is stuck behind your front bone. I can turn the child by bringing one arm across. The arm may break. If I wait, the child may not breathe. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Which do you choose?"

"Turn."

Tavia named the choice for the trainees. Jori recorded it on a wax tablet. No consent vanished simply because time had narrowed.

"Esen, hold her. Jori, pressure where I showed you. Mave, clean cloth ready. Senn, watch the mother's bleeding, not my hands."

The next contraction gathered.

Tavia inserted her broad hand along the child's back, found the elbow, and pressed it toward the chest. Neri cried out and nearly came off the rail. Esen held without pinning. Jori pushed above the bone.

The arm shifted.

"Now," Tavia said.

Neri pushed. One shoulder turned. The body followed in a wet rush into Tavia's hands.

For one breath, the child did nothing.

Mave reached with the cloth.

"Wait."

Tavia lowered the newborn below the mother's hips, cleared mucus with her smallest finger, and rubbed the back. No silver line brightened. No moonbrood song moved through bone. No hidden body took a breath on the child's behalf.

The newborn coughed.

A cry filled the room.

Neri sagged against Esen. Tavia set the child skin to skin and checked the swept arm. The collarbone held. Fingers curled around nothing.

"Child breathes," Jori said, voice shaking.

"Write the time. Then watch the mother."

Blood flowed more quickly than it should.

Senn had seen it. "Heavy bleeding."

"How heavy?"

"One soaked cloth and filling another."

"Good. Named, not merely heavy."

Tavia placed a hand on Neri's abdomen. The womb remained soft. She guided Jori's fingers to the same place.

"Massage until it firms. Mave, measure the blood. Esen, keep Neri awake. Ask before you give the bitterroot."

Neri opened one eye. "Give it."

Bitterroot contracted the womb through ordinary plant chemistry. It could cause vomiting and dangerous pressure; Jori named both before holding the cup. Neri drank, spat half onto Esen's shirt, and kept the rest.

The trainees worked. Blood slowed. The womb tightened under Jori's palm.

Tavia checked the birth passage for tears and found one requiring stitches. Plain gut, boiled needle, willow-bark tincture. No stilling thread. Pain stayed where the wound occurred; care gathered around it.

By dawn, Neri slept with the newborn tucked under one arm. Esen sat on the floor, still singing two notes because exhaustion had lost the third. The trainees washed cloth, measured the final blood loss, and wrote every intervention in the public ledger.

"Why public?" Senn asked.

"So someone can tell us where we were wrong," Tavia said.

"What if the family wants privacy?"

"Names belong to them. Methods belong to the trade. We record the body without turning it into property."

She corrected Jori's entry from difficult birth to right forward shoulder caught; arm swept after consent; bleeding measured; bitterroot given after risks named. Euphemism made poor instruction.

The placenta had not yet come. Tavia set the ledger aside and returned to Neri's pulse. Too fast. Blood had slowed, but a retained placenta could start it again after everyone relaxed.

"What next?" she asked Senn.

"Wait another quarter hour."

"While doing what?"

“Watch bleeding.”

“Also empty the bladder, put the child to breast, and prepare for manual removal. Waiting is work when done honestly.”

Neri woke enough to consent to a reed catheter. Jori warmed it in boiled water, cooled it, and completed the task under Tavia’s hand. The newborn rooted against skin but did not latch. Mave adjusted the child’s lower lip instead of pushing the head. A swallow came, then another.

The womb tightened. Placenta separated with a small renewed flow.

Tavia received it in a basin and spread it under the window light. One edge looked torn.

“Missing piece?” Jori asked.

“Perhaps folded.”

They checked every lobe. A thin section had doubled under itself. When opened, the organ proved complete.

“Do not write complete until you look,” Tavia said. “Do not write missing because you fear it might be. Record what your hands find.”

She showed Neri and Esen the placenta before burial, naming the torn-looking fold and why they would watch for fever or renewed bleeding. In Dunmere, families once considered such detail part of a proper funeral but improper after a living birth. The restored trade taught that survival did not make bodily evidence shameful.

The newborn finally latched. Neri winced.

“That also hurts?” Esen asked.

“Everything apparently does,” Neri said.

Tavia checked the nipple position and found no injury. “Pain should ease after the first pulls. If it sharpens, call us. Ordinary does not mean ignored.”

At the wash table, Senn found a blue hospice thread tangled among donated cloth. He held it up by one end.

“Stillwater,” he said.

“Source?”

“Unknown.”

“Counterweight?”

“Unknown.”

“Then it does not enter a patient.”

They sealed it in a marked jar for the records advocate. The thread might carry an old circuit even months after the wards closed. Public practice required suspicion to become a documented object, not a whispered fear.

Only when Neri’s pulse slowed and the newborn maintained warmth did Tavia

allow the room to settle.

Outside, morning light changed on moving water.

The coastal house stood where the old Sea Gate watch barracks had been. Its foundation kept the high stone but opened the lower walls into broad channels. During spring tides, water passed under treatment rooms and out through reed beds. No mechanism could trap it. The great gate leaves had been cut into bridge plates and stretcher ramps.

Along the former Nightcourse, four locks had been dismantled completely. The remaining three served as open spillways with no paleshell in their basins. Water levels rose and fell. Mills now stopped during low flow. Grain farmers argued about irrigation every week.

Nothing stayed convenient enough to hide the cost.

Tavia carried the bloody wash water to a marked drain. An apprentice took the heavier bucket from her because of the knee. Months earlier, she would have refused. Now she let him carry it and watched whether he lifted correctly.

Across the yard, a council hearing occupied the covered boat platform. Representatives from ward houses, lock towns, grain crews, House clinics, and road workers sat around a map weighted with ordinary stones. They disagreed about who would repair the western bridge.

Bellhaven governed through ward and lock councils after Sere's death. The arrangement had no crown and no innocence. Wealthy heights sent polished speakers. South silt sent people missing homes and work hours. Dunmere complained that eastern water had been released for western rebuilding without sufficient notice. Two former palace clerks tried to preserve sealed records rules and were shouted down, then invited back when no one else understood the grain permits.

Captain Letha chaired only until the first planting. She struck a hand bell when speeches stopped naming material work.

"The south spillway killed a mason last week," she said now. "His name: Varo Pell. Cause: west parapet lacked rope anchors. Question: who installs anchors before the next crew enters?"

Three districts argued over iron. Ila Venn, visiting with a Dunmere boatwright delegation, offered recovered hinge stock if Bellhaven sent lime east. No one called the bargain unity. It moved iron toward the wall.

Tavia did not leave before the next claim. A former orchard owner named Bes brought a crate of dead roots to the platform. When Nhal released market rot toward its source, his eastern trees had blackened even though their fruit had already fed western towns.

"I never assigned a child," he said. "Why should my land pay?"

Perrin's deputy opened a route ledger. "Your cooperative sold saturated fruit through the Spoiled Hours contract. The Crown paid above ordinary price."

"We were told the wood took the change."

"Some did. Records show overflow entered Red Step residents after the third year."

Bes looked at the ward delegates. "I did not know."

A woman with weathered hands answered, "Now you do."

The council could not restore trees or hands. It proposed seed stock, shared labor, and a levy on surviving contract profits. Bes objected to the levy and offered grafting wood instead. Ward delegates rejected an offer controlled entirely by him. The argument lasted past the meal bell.

At last they wrote a provisional agreement: independent assessors would count viable roots; Bes would supply grafting stock now; the cooperative books would remain open; compensation would change after evidence. No one called the paper justice. It prevented ignorance from becoming a permanent defense.

Tavia left them to it.

At the treatment veranda, Enna Kest sorted pear seeds into clay cups.

She had turned twelve during the second month after the flood. Marrow fever still thinned her blood and brought weeks when walking across a room exhausted her. Ordinary treatment had given her no miracle. It had given her donor schedules, bitter medicines, boiled needles, friends who visited while she was awake, and mornings she sometimes hated.

"Two molded," Enna said. "I am documenting negligence."

"You forgot to water them," Master Halve replied from the medicine table.

"I am documenting personal negligence."

Oren sat beside her winding clean bandage onto a reed spool. His right rib had knitted with a painful ridge. The cut on his left forearm had scarred. He spent most weeks on the open roads between former lock towns, carrying council decisions, missing-person lists, and flood repair disputes. He no longer wore Crown black. His horn hung in the coastal records room with a label naming every signal it had sounded during the opening.

"You arrived after the birth," Tavia said.

"I was told labor began yesterday."

"Children ignore road reports."

"Road reports are often wrong."

Enna held up one seed. "This one has a root."

Tavia examined the thin white thread. "Plant it before you admire it to death."

Perrin rolled onto the veranda in a chair redesigned by Ila. Wide front wheels

handled mud. A strap supported his spine without forcing it straight. He carried three ledger packets on his lap.

"Council wants the latest ward claims," he said. "Council also wants the claims to become smaller."

"Do they?" Enna asked.

"They used the phrase manageable scope."

"What did you tell them?"

"That bones do not respond to scope."

Perrin had trained as a records advocate with the House and former archive clerks. He helped weathering residents match assignment marks to beneficiaries, file treatment claims, and challenge families who called inherited palace care innocent. Some beneficiaries had lost health or property when stilling ended. Several refused liability. The councils had not settled whether restitution belonged to individuals, guilds, the former palace estate, or every district that profited from preserved canals.

Tavia doubted one answer could carry all of it. She insisted every claim retain the payer's name.

"New birth record," she told Perrin. "No assignment mark. No stillwater. Shoulder turn and measured bleeding."

"I will attempt not to make it manageable."

A group of apprentices crossed the yard carrying recovery hooks, rope, birthing cloth, and tide charts. Lake midwifery had become a public trade again. Training lasted three years and included human birth, drowning recovery, flood evacuation, counterweight ethics, old song use, and moonbrood guidance. Half the first class came from weathering families. Two were former Crown keepers. One had failed the knots examination twice.

Tavia taught them that no bloodline conferred authority. Ossa's songs had reached her because her grandmother remembered them, not because ancestry chose her. Anyone who learned the work and accepted correction could guide the next passage.

"When will there be another egg?" an apprentice asked as they passed.

"Eighty-one years if the old intervals hold."

"So none of us."

"Some of you may still be alive."

"Not if you keep giving us night recoveries."

"Then tie faster."

They groaned and continued toward the tide pools.

Deaths from the flood remained posted in the records hall. The list had grown for six weeks as bodies were found and names matched. It never became perfectly

complete. Hundreds of entries filled wall panels. Below them, another set named the missing. No plaque thanked those deaths for purchasing a future.

Sere Valec's entry recorded chronological age, years stilled, offices held, orders signed, wards expanded, final gate action, and cause of death. Someone had left flowers once. Someone else removed them. The record stayed.

Nhal's passage changed more than governance. Nights lengthened. People dreamed and sometimes disliked what returned. Sleepwalking violence declined slowly rather than ending. Tides reached marks no living salt worker remembered. Fruit ripened unevenly. A warm month arrived too soon, then broke under cold rain.

Mortal society had not become gentle. It had lost one machine for exporting harm invisibly.

Tavia found Oren by the open spillway after the council recessed. He stood on a bridge plate cut from the old gate and watched water carry alder leaves toward the sea.

"Letha says the north road needs a second survey," he said.

"Then survey it."

"She also says Dunmere requests a midwife instructor before winter."

"Ila requests many things after offering hinge iron."

"Will you go?"

"For a month. The apprentices can keep this house."

He nodded. Their trust had not arranged itself into a household or promise. Oren traveled. Tavia belonged to work that moved between lake and coast. On some roads they met. On others they sent notes about bodies, gates, and Enna's pear trees. Tenderness survived without being named into ownership.

"How is the knee?" he asked.

"Attached."

"An exact medical report."

"It hurts in cold rain. I use the block for births. Jori can reach the floor faster."

"You let him?"

"After checking his hands."

A bell sounded from the birthing room.

Tavia turned at once. Neri had woken. The newborn needed to be weighed, and the mother's bleeding checked again.

Inside, Esen stood beside the open window holding the child. Afternoon had cleared the cloud. The drowned moon rose faint over the sea, no longer bleaching the entire sky around it.

"May we take them outside?" Neri asked from the bed.

Tavia assessed both patients. Neri's pulse held. The newborn breathed evenly and kept warmth under two layers of cloth.

"Yes. To the yard and back."

She showed Jori how to support the head and injured-side shoulder despite no fracture. Esen carried Neri to a chair. The trainees brought the public ledger only after asking whether the family wanted names included. They declined; the methods remained.

People in the council yard looked up.

Shadows crossed the moon.

Three mature moonbrood moved high above the coast. Their sail-wings caught silver along the bones and darkness through the membranes. One carried a bright scar below the left forward limb.

Nhal did not descend. No human voice called them back. The moonbrood crossed east toward the mountain lakes, changing tide pressure as their wings passed. Water rose half an inch through the open spillways and fell again. That motion belonged to sea, moon, and living bodies, with no hidden counterweight.

The newborn stirred at the shift in light.

Tavia took the child from Jori, checked Neri's consent with a glance, and walked beyond the roof shadow. The baby's face tightened against cool air. Behind her, trainees named the mother's pulse, the time outside, and the warmth of the child's feet.

She carried the newborn to open air and let changing moonlight touch their face.